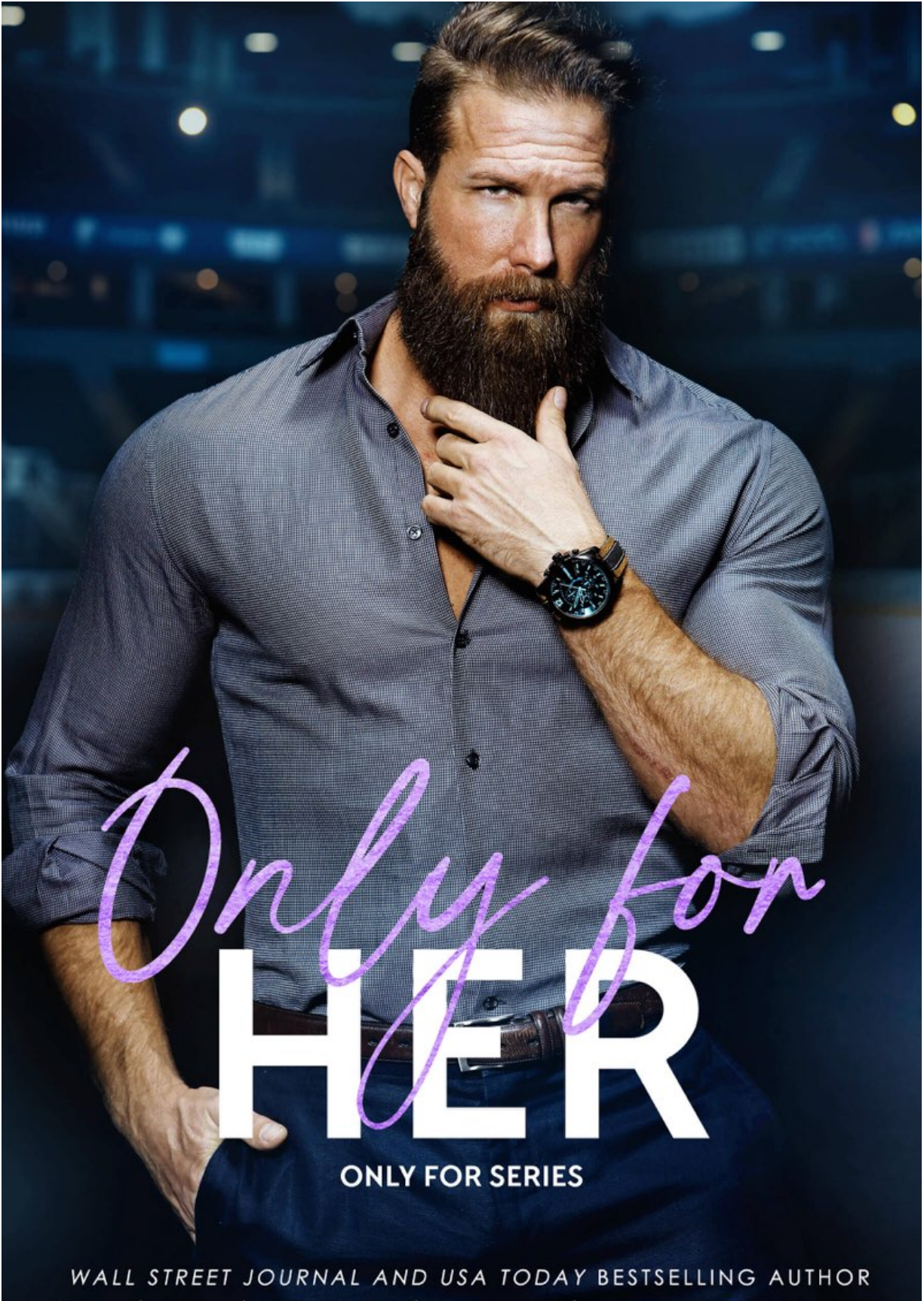




Only for
HER

ONLY FOR SERIES

WALL STREET JOURNAL AND USA TODAY BESTSELLING AUTHOR
NATASHA MADISON



Only for
HER

ONLY FOR SERIES

WALL STREET JOURNAL AND USA TODAY BESTSELLING AUTHOR

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only for her

Only For #4

natasha madison

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about only for her

He's the youngest coach in the league, and she's your captain's younger sister.

Victoria

Being offered a job in a brand-new city wasn't something I was planning on.

Neither was meeting him at a random hotel bar that same night.

We shared a drink, flirted, and then one thing led to another. We exchanged first names, and I escaped the next morning with a quick goodbye.

I never expected to see him again.

I especially never expected him to come face-to-face with him at my brother's house.

As the new coach of the team.

Zane

I was the youngest coach in the NHL.

I had to focus on one thing and one thing only.

My job.

It's the only thing I had time for.

Until I came face-to-face with the stranger I thought I would never see again.

She's off-limits in every sense of the word.

Not just because she's younger than me.

She's the sister to my star player.

content warning

Please be aware, Only For Her contains some difficult topics that could be upsetting for some readers.

Topics that take place on page are: (false) allegations of grooming between main characters, mentions of domestic violence (not between the main characters), and a brief mention of gun violence/death.

Your mental health matters, please take care when reading.

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dedication

. . .

To Shauna without you there is no Zane.

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family tree

Hockey Series

SOMETHING SO SERIES

Something So Right

Parker & Cooper Stone

Matthew (**Something So Perfect**)

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Zara (**This Is Crazy**)

Zoe (**This Is Wild**)

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Frances (**Only One Love**)

Vivienne (**Made For You**)

Chase (**Made For Me**)

Something So Irresistible

Allison (Grant) & Max Horton

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Jack

Joshua

Elizabeth (**Holiday Unscripted**)

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This Is Crazy

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This Is Wild

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Zara (Meant For Gabriel)

Lexi (Only For Love)

This Is Love

Vivienne (Paradis) & Markos Dimitris

Karrie

Stefano (Mine to Promise)

Angelica

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Christopher (Meant For Her)

Gabriella (Made For Romeo)

Abigail (Made For Us)

ONLY ONE SERIES

Only One Kiss

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Ariella (**Only For Tonight**)

Brookes

Callie

Only One Chance

Layla (Paterson) & Miller Adams

Clarke

Only One Night

Evelyn & Manning Stevenson

Jaxon (**Only For Tonight**)

Victoria (**Only For Her**)

Kiera

Only One Touch

Becca & Nico Harrison

Phoenix

Dallas

Only One Regret

Erika (Robinson) & Cooper Grant

Emma

Mia

Parker

Felicia

Leo

Matthew

Only One Mistake

Jillian (Williams) & Michael Horton

Jamieson

Bianca

Bailey

Only One Love

Frances (Grant) & Brad Wilson

Stella

Lawson

Only One Forever

Alexandria (Horton) & Dylan Woods Stone

Maddox ~~Smith~~

Maverick

Maya

James

MADE FOR SERIES

Made For Me

Julia (Williams) Grant & Chase Grant

Made For You

Vivienne (Grant) & Xavier Montgomery

Trevor

Made For Us

Abigail (Stone) & Tristan Weise

Penelope

Payton

Made For Romeo

Gabriella (Stone) & Romeo Beckett

MEANT FOR SERIES

Meant For Stone

Ryleigh (Beckett) & Stone Richards

Aspyn

Dalia

Declan

Meant For Her

Dakota & Christopher Stone

Luna

Rain

Lochlan

Meant For Love

Zoey (Richards) & Nash Griffin

Easton

Evander

Ella

Meant For Gabriel

Zara (Petrov) & Gabriel McIntyre

Colson

Callum

Cecilia

ONLY FOR SERIES

Only For Tonight

Ariella (Weber) & Jaxon Stevenson

Jagger Stevenson

Only For Love

Lexi (Petrov) & Kirby Materson

Only For Him

Kylie (Hayes/Materson) & Knox Taylor

Westley

Vincent

Nora

Only For Her

Victoria (Stevenson) & Zane Gilmore

SOUTHERN WEDDING

Mine To Have

Harlow (Barnes) & Travis Baker

Charlotte

Theo

Mine To Hold

Shelby (Baker) & Weston ‘Ace’

Arya

Mine To Cherish

Clarabella (Baker) & Luke

Zander

Mine To Love

Presley (Baker) & Bennett

Cadence

Charleigh

Violet

Mine To Take

Sofia (Barnes) & Matthew Petrov

Reed Cooper (R.C.)

Ruby

Mine To Promise

Addison (Laurier) & Stefano Dimitris

Avery

Mine To Honor

Evangeline (Meyers) & Levi Mathison

Selena 'Cici' James ~~Crinke~~ Mathison

Mine To Keep

Grace (Barnes) & Caine Griffin

Meadow

Morgan

SOUTHERN TREE

Southern Family Tree

Billy Barnes and Charlotte Barnes

(Mother and father to Kallie and Casey)

Southern Chance

Kallie (Barnes) & Jacob McIntyre

Ethan (**Southern Sunrise**)

Amelia (**Southern Secrets**)

Travis

Southern Comfort

Olivia (Young) & Casey Barnes

Quinn(**Southern Heat**)

Reed (**Southern Sunshine**)

Harlow (**Mine to Have**)

Southern Storm

Savannah (Harris) & Beau Huntington

Ethan (**Southern Sunrise**)

Chelsea (**Southern Heart**)

Toby

Keith

Southern Sunrise

Emily & Ethan McIntyre

Gabriel (**Meant For Gabriel**)

Aubrey McIntyre

Southern Heart

Chelsea (Huntington) & Mayson ‘Braxton Michaels’ Carey

Tucker

Kasey

Southern Heat

Willow (Davis) & Quinn Barnes

Grace (**Mine To Keep**)
Charlie (**Shattered Dreams**)

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Hollywood Prince

Erin (Crest) & Carter Johnson
Annabella
Axel

FALLING FOR SERIES

Falling For You

Collins (Henderson) & Theo Williams

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one

. . .

Victoria

“WHO IS YOUR FAVORITE AUNTIE?” I LOOK OVER AT MY NEPHEW WHO knows about three words. “Can you say Auntie Tori?” I ask him as he yaps away with nonsense sounds followed by a big glob of drool pouring out of his mouth. “So we have to work on that,” I tell him as he smiles at me. “Do you think we can do that? You can do it.” I clap my hands. “Auntie Tori,” I repeat.

“Dadadadadadada,” Jagger says, clapping his hands and smiling like he just said what I said.

“Don’t tell him this, but your dad is super annoying. He’s not as cool as you think he is. I know he tries to pretend he’s cool, but he’s not,” I tell him, as he stares at me, interested in everything I’m saying. “You look like him.” I tap his little nose with my finger. “It might be a curse.”

“What are you teaching my child?” My brother, Jaxon, walks into the living room, tossing his suit jacket on the back of the couch as he sidesteps some of Jagger’s toys that are all over the place. Jagger is standing wearing a pair of black pants and a white T-shirt. He’s holding a plastic golf club in his hand as he looks over to where my brother is making his way to us.

“Dadadadadada.” He drops the plastic golf club and runs toward Jaxon, who squats down and grabs him, tossing him in the air. His laughing squeal fills the room, and I just smile at the two of them. Jaxon buries his face in

Jagger's neck and his head flies back, soft brown hair moving side to side as his chubby fists wrap around Jaxon's neck.

"Hello, my boy," he greets him as he settles Jagger on his hip. "How is my Jagger doing?"

"Dadadad."

"Yeah, that's the only thing this kid knows how to say," I mumble. Jaxon walks to the side of the couch and sits down on the floor in front of me as Jagger gets up and goes back to his plastic golf club. "Jagger," I call his name and he looks at me. "Who is your favorite Auntie?" I ask him and he walks over to the red plastic golf ball like I'm not talking to him. "Auntie TT," I tell him.

"That's not even your name." Jaxon laughs.

"It's easier to say TT than it is to say Tori," I snap at him. "Jagger, Auntie TT."

"Debada debada," he chatters, and I shake my head.

"It sounds like he's a late bloomer, just like you." I goad, trying not to laugh when Jaxon's face goes white. "I'm kidding," I say, getting up from the floor. "He is your son after all, it makes sense," I tease him like any little sister would. Makes up for all the times he teased me growing up. "You don't like that, huh? Payback is a bitch." I point at him.

"Tori," he hisses, and I laugh.

"I'm kidding," I repeat, walking to the kitchen that is right off the family room, "it's a joke."

"It's not funny," he grumbles. "Jagger, what's this?" He holds up the red golf ball.

"Ball," he answers and Jaxon smiles at me.

"I'd be a little more impressed if he said red ball." I lean on the counter as Ariella comes into the room.

"Okay," she says, "you can go and take your shower now." She walks toward the living room wearing a pair of jeans and a Warriors T-shirt tucked

into the waistband. Her eyes light up when she sees Jaxon. "I thought you were gone."

"I'm about to head out," he says and tilts his head so she can bend to kiss his lips. The two of them hooked up one night, almost two years ago, and in a very surprising twist for both of them, out came Jagger. They were not the only ones that were surprised. It was a shock to all of us, especially our fathers who were retired hockey teammates and best friends. Now it feels like they've always been together. "My sister is being kicked out of our home."

Ariella looks over at me, shock on her face. "I'm trying to teach Jagger something and all he does is say dadad and debada."

"He says Mama." Ariella defends her son. "Jagger," she calls his name and he looks over at her.

"What's that?" She points to the ball on the floor.

"Okay, I get it, the kid can say ball." I roll my eyes. "Jagger." I walk to him and squat in front of him. "Auntie TT," I say and he smiles at me, scrunching his nose. "See?" I shrug. "It's okay," I tell Ariella, "from what my father said, Jaxon started talking late too."

"I did not." Jaxon picks up the ball and throws it at me, making Jagger laugh. I hold my hand up to deflect the ball before it hits me.

"I'm going to shower," I announce then look at Jagger. "Who is your favorite auntie?" I ask him and he walks over to the ball Jaxon just threw at me and tries to hit it with the stick.

"His favorite auntie," Jaxon says, "is Lexi." He mentions Ariella's best friend. I flip him the bird before I walk out of the room. Lexi and Ariella are best friends and when she was going through her divorce she moved in with her and Jaxon. If I'm being honest, besides my brother and Ariella, Lexi is Jagger's favorite person in the world.

"Maybe I'll move in with you guys for a while then."

“That would be so much fun!” Ariella exclaims at the same time Jaxon says, “Fuck no.”

“What did I say about swearing in front of Jagger?” Ariella snaps at Jaxon.

“Ari, he can’t even say TT, you think he’s going to say fuck?”

“See?” I say, pointing to Jaxon. “Step one is admitting there is a problem.”

“And that is why you are sleeping at a hotel tonight,” he declares and I laugh as I make my way up to the spare bedroom I’ve been staying in for the last couple of days. After my long hot shower, I put on a pair of black jeans with a black sweater. It has the same Warriors logo in the middle of it like Ariella’s T-shirt.

When I walk down the stairs, I hear Ariella singing “The Itsy-Bitsy Spider....the spout again,” she sings, her voice animated as Jagger claps his hands.

“Yay,” I say, walking in and seeing Jagger in front of Ariella. He is wearing the same pants but now has on his baby hockey jersey. The logo is in the middle of his chest and has Jaxon’s number thirteen on the back with the name Daddy above it. I know this because I bought it for him when he was first born. I knew it would be too big for him, but he’s been slowly growing into it.

“Look at how snazzy you look.” I smile at him. “Who is your favorite auntie?” I ask him and he looks at me and smiles, scrunching his nose. “No, not what is that stinky smell.” I shake my head. “Auntie TT.” I point to myself and he copies, pointing to me and I take his finger, kissing it. “TT.”

“Okay, let’s go,” Ariella urges. “You can teach him to say your name on the way to the game.” She grabs her big bag as she puts in a sweater and a pair of pjs for Jagger before we step into the garage, and I put him in his car seat. I get into the front seat next to Ariella as we chat about going to the farmers market tomorrow.

We drive into the underground parking reserved for families and she gets out, smiling at the valet there. “How is our big man?” he asks her as I walk around the SUV.

“He’s doing good, Clive,” she replies. “This is Jaxon’s sister, Victoria.” She points to me.

“Hi.” I reach out my hand. “Nice to meet you.” I smile at him, and he takes my hand as Ariella grabs Jagger out of his car seat. We walk over to the elevator, making our way up to the suites.

Ariella steps into the suite before me and I swear I think I hear my name as I look around.

My eyes go to Lexi. “Is that Victoria?” I hear Lexi ask.

Ariella gets to Lexi before I do, Jagger throwing himself out of her arms to get to Lexi. “It is I.” I point to myself as I try to give her a hug, but I’m pushed away by Jagger. “Dude, you literally slept with me last night. Have you no loyalty?” I ask him and he just lays his head on her shoulder, and I think the bugger even takes a huge sigh.

“It’s Lexi or no one,” Ariella huffs out. “Which means I can relax and enjoy myself for a bit before he wants me again.” She smiles and the girls are all around us. “Guys, this is Jaxon’s sister, Victoria, she is visiting us for a week.”

“Oh, that sounds like so much fun. Hi, I’m Kylie, Lexi’s soon to be sister-in-law extraordinaire, and also Kirby’s favorite sister.” The girl beside Lexi extends her hand as Lexi laughs at her introduction.

“You’re his only sister,” she points out to Kylie, who just shrugs.

“I’m still the favorite. It’s so nice to meet you.”

“Thank you.” I extend my hand to her. “Coming to visit was a graduation present to myself.” I smile big. “I just graduated less than two weeks ago and, sadly, the first thing I decided to do was come to California to see my brother.”

“Fun,” Kylie says. “I backpacked in Europe for mine and Kirby paid for it.” She mentions her brother who is Jaxon’s teammate.

“I wish!” I shriek. “I freaking wish.” I look at Ariella, who is talking to one of the girls. “Think Jaxon will pay for me to go backpacking in Europe?”

“Yeah, sure,” she nods her head, “and he’ll hire five guys to go with you.”

“Yeah, I’m afraid of that.” I look up at the ceiling. “He’s such a buzzkill ever since he became a father.” I fold my arms over my chest. “Thanks for that.” I side-eye Ariella.

“You’re welcome, I think.” She sounds confused.

“Look at her shirt,” Lexi urges Ariella. Kylie proudly turns around to show her the back of her shirt. All I can see is the number and a glimpse of the name.

Her gasp out loud is very similar to Lexi’s. “That’s bold.”

“It is not bold,” Kylie defends. “There are literally other girls out there,” she points to the seats, “who are wearing his name too.”

“Yes, but you wearing it means”—Ariella holds up her hands—“like you’re taken by him.”

“Well, I am,” she admits and everyone’s eyes go big, except mine.

“We’re dating,” she announces and I guess this must be a big deal, but I don’t really get it.

“Oh fuck,” Lexi whines, “admitting it out loud is—”

“Well, considering I went toe to toe with the ex-wife last night,” Kylie says, and I swear this is better than the soap operas my grandmother used to watch. I wait for the next update as if my life depends on it. “And met his parents who, by the way, are assholes.” She takes a sip of the wine and I have so many questions. “So, she literally put her hands on him to stop him from moving. I swear to everything, I was this close,” she puts her thumb and forefinger together, “to fucking throat punching her.”

“The tea is piping hot!” I squeal with glee. “Wait, so she put her hands on him,” I finally ask cocking my hip, “and you were going to throat punch her?”

“Well, not throat punch her, per se,” Kylie admits. “I would never do it with the kids there, but I did use a firm voice.”

“Got it.” I nod. “I don’t know if I would be as mature. I’d be like ‘Bitch, you want a piece of this?’” I puff out my chest like I’m going to chest bump her. ““You are going to get a piece of this.””

“And this is why no one is paying for you to go to Europe,” Ariella retorts to me as the girls laugh and I roll my eyes.

The roar of the crowd goes nuts and we know the guys have taken the ice. I smile as the memories of my father skating into the arena when I was younger come back to me. Those were the best nights, and some of my best memories. “I forgot how loud it can get,” I say.

“It gets louder.” Kylie’s voice goes louder. “So what are you doing now that you have graduated?” I see the girls starting to walk out of the suite toward the seats and I have no doubt they are going to stand by the boards. It’s where all the fun things happen before the games. I still remember I had a whole duffel bag of pucks I collected one year, and I used hockey tape to write down who gave them to me. It’s still in my closet at home, in the corner collecting dust. I refuse to throw them out.

“I don’t know yet,” I answer her honestly. “I have a couple of options, but nothing has jumped out at me just yet.”

“What’s your degree in?”

“Marketing,” I reply. “I worked with an ad agency back in Dallas, but it’s not really my thing.”

“Well, what are you looking for?”

“Obviously I’m good at social media,” I tell her and she laughs at me, “but then I love doing market research. Finding out the trends before they

happen. Helping create the brand and then driving brand awareness is what I love most about marketing.”

“Well, if you want.” Kylie starts, taking a drink of her wine, “we could use the help with the foundation we are running. You could take over the social media, which has been put on the back burner since I don’t want to do it, and Lexi is too busy doing other stuff. We also were looking at starting an after-school program, which could really be huge if we had the right marketing behind us.”

Lexi comes back without Jagger and walks to us. “This meeting looks like it’s secretive.” She sticks her head in. “What are we talking about?”

“I was offering Victoria the social media job we talked about having someone take over,” Kylie fills her in and Lexi nods her head. “Why don’t you come by the office this week when you are free and we can talk it over?”

I smile at both of them, and I don’t know why I say it, but I do, “I’m pretty much free as a bird.” I shock even myself. “Why don’t we exchange numbers so we can schedule it?”

They share a look that screams excitement. “I can’t wait,” Lexi says. “I think you’ll be perfect for the job.”

I smile at them while my head screams, *What the hell are you doing?* “I look forward to hearing about it.”

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two

. . .

Zane

I LACE UP MY SKATES BEFORE I GET UP AND SNATCH MY HELMET THEN WALK out to the ice, grabbing my stick along the way. I slide onto the ice, going over to the coaches who are in a huddle at the side.

“Okay, we’re going to get this going,” Martin, the head coach of the LA Warriors, declares. “We will work on the same plays we talked about yesterday.” He looks at the five of us. “You two,” he points to Cam and me, “work with the defense.”

I nod at him, turning and skating toward the other side of the ice. “Defense.” My voice booms out and the defensemen come my way. Jaxon, who is the team captain, is the first one to me.

“What’s up, Coach?” He gives me a chin lift.

I look over at Cam. “You want to lead this?” I ask him because he’s been here longer than I have. He’s also older than me. I mean, at forty years old, I’m the youngest on the coaching staff and everyone likes to remind me of this constantly. They call me the rookie and even though it’s annoying, it just makes me want to do better.

“Nah.” He shakes his head and puts his arms on his stick as he watches me. “You can do it; you’re the young one.” I roll my eyes, waiting for the rest of the defensemen to join us.

“Are we missing anyone?” I ask the group and then look over to see two more guys coming onto the ice and heading toward us. “We don’t have all fucking day,” I snap at them. “When it says practice at ten,” I tell the guys who just showed up, “it means be on the fucking ice at ten.” I see them look down. “Not five after ten.” I shake my head. “Next time, you’ll make the whole squad do suicides for fifteen minutes.”

“Sorry, Coach,” they both say, and I accept it.

We work hard and do the drills that Martin set up. I’m the only coach skating side by side with the defensemen. Pushing them when I think they can do better, playing the puck with them, and frustrating them when they think it’s going to be easy. Jaxon is heaving by the time practice ends and he looks over at me. “Next time, go work with the forward line,” he wheezes between pants. “Knox needs someone to push him.” He motions with his chin toward the forward players, who are all huddled around Martin, and not one of them looks like they are going to vomit.

“But then what fun will you have?” I ask him as we skate off the ice. He shakes his head, and I take off my gloves and put my stick on the other wall, away from the players’ sticks. I then make it into the coaches’ dressing room. Taking off my gloves and handing them to the equipment managers so they can put them on the drying rack.

I grab a bottle of water and sit down on the bench, drinking it as Martin comes in. “I need to see a couple of you guys in my office when you finish taking off your skates.” He looks at me and my eyebrows pinch together at his tone. “Zane.” He looks at me. “When you are done here,” he says, “meet me in my office.”

“Sure thing, Coach,” I reply to him as he turns and walks out of the room.

I untie my skates as Cam sits down beside me. “I wonder what the fuck that is all about,” he says as he unties his own skates. I look over at him. “He sounded serious.”

“Maybe I’m getting fired,” I quip, trying to make a joke about it, but my stomach rolls. “Might as well happen now, right before the season ends, and not during the summer. That would suck, me being away and then boom I have to come back to pack up my shit.”

“Nah,” he replies, running his hands through his salt-and-pepper hair. “You’ve been working too hard with the defensive line, and they are up twelve percent since last year.”

“Yeah.” I ignore the rest of what he says. I get up after putting on my sneakers and head toward Martin’s corner office. I knock on the closed door, the whole time I’m trying to calm the fuck out of my beating heart and tell myself it’ll be okay.

“Come in!” I hear Martin shout and open the door. My eyes go to him behind his desk, with his hands folded on top of it, and then he looks over to one of the chairs in front of his desk where Ken, the general manager, sits. *Yup, definitely getting fired*, I think to myself. “Sit down,” he states, pointing to the empty chair beside Ken.

I step in and try not to yack all over the carpeted floor as I sit down in the chair and rub my hands on my track pants. “Nervous?” Ken asks me.

“A little.” I put my hands on the armrests and try to act calm and collected, when inside it’s like a tsunami about to hit land. “Feels like I’m a junior again, and I’m about to be cut from the team.”

They both laugh. “You aren’t getting cut from the team,” Martin reassures me softly and then looks at me. “It’s actually the opposite.” He stops talking and then looks over at Ken to take the lead.

“Martin and I have been talking,” he starts, “or better yet, Martin has let me know this will be his last year with us.” My eyes go from Ken to Martin, who shrugs. “He came to me at the beginning of the year and told me he was ready to retire, and I told him to hold off and see how he would feel.” My mouth opens in shock. “Needless to say, he is still on the road to

retirement.” Ken looks at Martin. “Fishing and doing nothing sounds boring as hell.”

“Sounds magical to me,” Martin retorts.

“Anyway,” Ken continues, “we’ve been watching you for the last year.” I look back at Ken, not sure where the fuck this is going.

“You’re fucking good,” Martin praises. “You have a great handle on plays. You’re proactive and sense what is going to go down on the ice and call some fantastic plays.”

“Thank you,” I reply. “That means a lot coming from you.”

He smiles. “I want you to take over for me.” The minute he says the words my back sinks even deeper into the chair.

“I’m sorry, what?” I shake my head, not sure I heard the correct words.

“You’re going to be the new coach for the Warriors next season,” Ken clarifies, slapping me on the shoulder. “We’re about to make history with you being the youngest head coach.”

“I don’t know.” I shake my head, the disbelief filling my thoughts. “I don’t think I can.”

“You can,” Martin assures me. “We think you’re the coach that can build something amazing here and continue the legacy for a long time to come. You won’t need my help, but I’ll be a phone call away.”

“This is...” I try to think of the words. “It’s like a dream come true.”

“We’d like to announce it to the team today,” Martin says. “Some of the sports reporters have been sniffing around, since they know my contract is up at the end of this year.”

“Are you sure about this?” I look over at Martin, who leans back in his chair.

“It’s time. My daughter just gave birth to her second kid, so it’ll be nice to help take the first one to school. I can tell you one thing; it’ll be a fucking joy to not travel so fucking much.”

I laugh at him. "I don't know what to say," I respond honestly. "I'm fucking honored to be taking over the team." I look at Ken, *I just hope I don't fucking suck at it*. I want to say but instead I say, "I won't let you down."

"Trust me, if you aren't up to par," he replies, laughing, "you'll know."

"It's a learning curve," Martin notes. "There are going to be some hiccups because, let's face it, you can't win them all. The wins will be big, but the losses..." He points at me. "No one is going to remember the wins when you lose." I nod at him. "I wanted to tell you first and then slowly work down with the other assistant. I am going to break the news to Cam," he tells me. "You want to be here when we do?"

"He should be," Ken advises. "We have to be united in this."

"I don't want him to feel blindsided," I tell the room, "by having me in here. Like I knew things were going to happen and didn't tell him."

"Okay, we'll tell him and then call you back in here after we've broken the news to him. That way we still stand united," Martin says. I think he says this because he probably knows Cam isn't going to take this well. If anyone should be taking over for Martin it should be Cam. He has many more years of experience than I do.

"We break it to the team in fifteen," Martin states, "be ready."

"Got it," I confirm, getting up and walking out of the room at the same time Cam is coming out of the coaches' locker room.

"Did they fire you?" he asks me, and the door behind me opens and Ken steps out.

"Cam," he says, "you're up."

I move to the side and head back to the locker room, my head spinning at this news. At forty, I'm going to be the youngest coach in NHL history. I close my eyes and put my head back on the cement wall. I stare into space until I hear Martin shout my name from the hallway. Getting up, I walk out, seeing him standing there with Ken behind him. Cam is looking at me with

almost a glare, which is quickly covered up. “Congrats,” he says when he gets beside me, “going to be a fun year.”

“Yeah,” I say to him as I follow Martin into the locker room. I stand here and then Cam moves to the side so I’m standing next to Martin. “Hey, guys,” Martin starts, and his voice is somber. The whole room must sense something is up because the room suddenly goes silent and all eyes are on him. “I have some news for you.” The room is so quiet you could hear a pin drop. “This season will be my last with the Warriors.” I see Jaxon look over at Knox and then Kirby, the oldest ones on the team who lead the young ones. “It wasn’t an easy decision to make, but one I knew it was time for.” He takes a deep inhale. “We aren’t going to be sharing this information with the media just yet, but I wanted you guys to be the first to hear it and to hear it from me.” He looks over to me and nods his head. “I’m happy to say that I’ll be passing the torch to Zane.”

A gasp fills the room as I step up beside him, and he slaps my shoulder and then squeezes it, so I know it’s time for me to say a little something. I start off right away. “I know I have big skates to fill.” I chuckle nervously as I try to look around the room, but I just look at Coach. “But I’m going to try my fucking hardest.” I’m sure the whole room is thinking what everyone else is going to be thinking when it’s finally announced. “I just hope you guys give me a chance.”

Jaxon is the first one to speak. “Martin handing you the torch,” he looks at the guys in the room, making sure everyone is looking at him while he says this, “means something.” He looks back at me. “Looking forward to seeing how you’re going to lead us.”

“Thank you,” I say to him and then he looks at Martin, who looks at Jaxon once more before he turns and leaves the room. I follow them and can hear the whispers that are going on behind me.

“We tell the press tomorrow afternoon,” Ken states. “I’ll let you know when we are going to schedule the press conference.” I nod at them and

then look at Martin.

“Twenty-four hours to change your mind,” I tell him, and he shakes his head.

“Not a chance in hell,” he retorts. “I was more nervous about breaking it to the boys than I will be breaking it to the media.” He slaps my arm. “Dress nice.”

“I’ll take out my best suit.” I try not to sound as nervous as I feel.

“Go home, rest. Tomorrow is going to be one of the biggest days of your life.”

I nod, turning and heading to my truck. The whole ride home I feel like I’m outside of my body, in a daze. I step into the house and I hear water dripping. I walk over to the kitchen and see a leak coming from the ceiling. Running up the steps to the upstairs bathroom, I see all faucets are off. I pick up my phone and search for emergency plumbers. It takes two hours for him to come by after telling me to turn off the main line. They break open the ceiling in the kitchen, seeing one of the pipes from my bathroom has a leak and the whole ceiling is actually wet.

“It’s not safe for you to be on the top floor,” he states, looking at the destruction, “at least until we get a contractor in here.”

“Great.” I exhale and then make my way upstairs to just pack a suit and a couple of other things to tide me over. When I walk back downstairs, he’s waiting at the door.

“We have a contractor who can pass by tomorrow late morning, early afternoon,” he tells me. “We’ll get a clear picture then.”

“Sounds good,” I say, grabbing my bag and heading out with him. I sit in my driveway and pull up the closest hotel to me and see if I can book a room. The only available room I can find is right near the airport. I book the room and check in online, bypassing the whole front desk. When I get inside, I dump my bag on the bed and then turn back around and head down to the hotel bar.

The whole place is packed when I step in, and the hostess looks at me. “Welcome.”

“For one,” I say, putting my hands in my pockets and she looks around.

“I don’t have any tables available,” she states as she does something on the iPad. “But there is a place at the bar,” she says. “You can order food there too.”

“That’s fine,” I reply as I follow her through the restaurant and pull out the tall barstool. I sit down and the bartender comes over.

“What can I get you?” he asks me and puts his hand on the bar top.

“I’ll have a whiskey on the rocks,” I order and he turns to walk away. I look down at the menu when the empty stool beside me is pulled out.

“Is this seat taken?” I hear a sweet voice and I look over and see a woman’s side profile. Her black hair is pinned back in a loose updo, a soft curl escaping the clip at the back of her head. When she turns completely, facing me, I swear I stop breathing. Her blue-gray eyes look into mine and I can say, without a doubt, she is the most beautiful woman I’ve ever met. “Is it taken?” she asks me again.

I shake my head. “No,” I tell her, “not by me anyway.” She looks at the girl on the other side of the stool.

“Is this seat taken?” The girl shakes her head and turns back to the conversation she’s having with the person next to her.

“Perfect,” she says, sitting on the stool and putting her purse down on her side. She puts her hand on the bar and crosses her legs. I turn to face the menu and try not to think of the woman who is beside me. The bartender comes over and places my drink on a coaster then turns his smile toward the beauty beside me.

“Hi,” he greets her.

“Hi,” she says breathlessly as she puts her phone down. “Can I get something to eat at the bar?” she asks him.

“For you,” he says, “we’ll make it happen.” I about roll my eyes and watch him flirt with her.

“Aren’t you the sweetest?” She laughs. “Can I have a menu?”

“Coming right up,” he says to her and then instead of minding my own business like I should be, I hand her mine.

“You can have mine,” I tell her. “I already know what I’m having.”

“Thank you.” She takes the menu from me and then looks down at it while her phone buzzes on the bar. She ignores it as she reads the menu, and it goes off about fifteen more times.

The bartender comes back with a menu, and I see he even undid another button on his black shirt and rolled up his sleeves. “Here you go, gorgeous.” He hands her the menu, and she takes it and turns her smile toward me.

“It’s only right,” she tells me, “that you take this one.”

I grab it from her and then she turns her face back to the bartender. “Can I have a glass of wine, please? A pinot.” She puts the menu in her hand on her lap and leans in. “A big one.”

“Of course.” He nods and turns to walk away from her.

“That kind of day?” I ask her, instead of shutting the fuck up and minding my own fucking business.

“Considering I just spent the last four hours sitting on a plane on the runway, with no air-conditioning, and then being told the flight is cancelled until tomorrow.” She shrugs. “It’s the least I deserve.” I nod at her and take a sip of my own drink. “Was your flight cancelled also?”

“No.” I shake my head. “Came home to a busted pipe and a flooded house.”

“Okay, fine.” She rolls her eyes. “Your day is suckier than my day.” I can’t help but laugh when she says that. “But if you think about it,” she turns to face me and her oversized sweater falls off her shoulder and to the middle of her arm, showing me her white tank top that swoops low in the front and molds to her chest, “I bet tomorrow will be better.”

“Yeah,” I agree, putting the glass on the coaster, thinking about how the news of me taking over as head coach will be everywhere tomorrow.

“I mean, it should be, but it could also suck even more.” The minute she says it, I can’t help but bark out a laugh. “I mean, think about it. A flood today, termites tomorrow.” She holds out her two hands, palms up, as she moves them up and down like she’s weighing the options.

“Can we not put that thought out there?” I turn to look at her. She takes in the way my shirt is tight against my chest, and I see her giving me a very approving once up and down. “Let’s think good thoughts.”

The bartender comes back and puts her drink on her coaster. “There you are, beautiful,” he flirts and I side-eye him. “Have you decided on what you are going to have?”

“I’ll take a cheeseburger with bacon, hold the tomatoes,” she orders. He gives her a grin and then starts to walk away as I hold up my finger. “And my friend here,” she adds and puts her hand on my arm, “will have,” she looks at me, “the same thing.”

“Sure,” I agree, “that works.” He nods at me and walks toward the system to put in the order.

“Thanks,” I mumble as she picks up her drink, holding it up in her hand.

“I aim to please.” She smiles at me and it’s not a fake smile. Not one that someone who is being polite gives you. No, this is a smile that fills her face and goes straight to her eyes.

“Well, to a better tomorrow.” She holds up her glass and I take an extra second looking at her, not sure what to do. “This is where you pick up your glass and we toast to a better tomorrow,” she tells me, and I reach for my glass. “For a smooth flight home for me and no termites for you.” The smile on her face is never-ending. “And hopefully good fries; it would suck after the day we had if the French fries are meh.” I can’t help but chuckle as I clink my glass with hers. “You have to say it,” she informs me. “You have

to repeat what I just said or else it doesn't work. And then we're cursing tomorrow. Do you want that? I don't!"

"I've never heard that before in my life," I tell her and the smile fades from her face.

"Do you want to be the one who tempts fate?" she questions dramatically. "Wow, I guess you don't care about termites in your house, but I care about a safe flight. So can we maybe not throw bad juju into the universe?"

"I would hate for bad juju to go into the universe," I reply when I know she isn't going to take a sip of her wine until I repeat what she says. "To a safe flight and no termites."

"I mean, it's not the same since you didn't say it with feeling, but I've already had a long day, and it sounds like it's going to be longer if I don't take this sip of wine." She clinks her glass with mine and takes a big sip before putting it down. "If those fries are floppy," she looks over at me, "that is going to be an indication as to how tomorrow goes." She holds up her hands beside her and crosses her fingers. "Please be good."

"That excited to get home?" I ask her and she looks back over at me.

"Yeah, it's been a week, and my bed is probably wondering where I am."

"You didn't tell the bed where you were going when you left?"

"No." She shakes her head. "I should have. I did hug my pillows a little bit more than I usually would though." She takes another sip. "That should have been my first clue this trip would turn out the way it did."

"Well, like you said, it'll be all better tomorrow," I assure her as the bartender comes over and sets the plates in front of us. "I can't bear to look," she tells me. "I'm going to need you to take one for the team and tell me how the fries are." I turn my head toward the plate and see the burger on the side and the fries beside it.

She watches me as I pick up the fry and hold it up. “Crisp,” I confirm. “No flop.” I then bite into it. “Hot,” I tell her and her whole face lights up.

“I see the tides turning for us.” She points to me.

“Zane,” I tell her my name and she smiles at me.

“I’m Victoria.” I smile at her. “It’s a pleasure to meet you, Zane.”

I stare into her eyes that have changed five times since she sat down, going from a blue-gray to a gray and then to a blue, and now they’re like a crystal blue. Her hair is pushed to the side, away from her forehead, leaving her neck exposed. “The pleasure is all mine.”

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three

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Victoria

AN ALARM STARTS TO RING, AND I OPEN MY EYES. SOFT LIGHT IS TRYING TO come in from the closed curtains, and I close my eyes again before I open them when I feel the bed beside me move. I can't help the smile that fills my face when I feel the covers being pulled away from me. "It must be yours." I hear Zane's thick voice and hold the cover to my chest as I sit up in bed.

My hair feels like it's sticking up from all sides. "Do you want me to get it for you?" he asks, and I look over at him. His side is to me as he looks over his shoulder and his hair that was perfectly combed last night when I met him at the bar now looks like I spent the night pulling at it. And I did. The last time was in the small fucking shower and tub he placed me in, with my back to the wall. He put one of my feet on the rim of the bathtub and then got on his knees and feasted on me. I swear, I think I saw stars. Then he got up while I was coming down from my orgasm and literally picked me up around my waist and plunked me down on the counter as he sheathed himself in a condom, then planted himself in me.

"Yeah," I reply, clearing my throat.

"You want me to get it for you so you can check out my ass," he accuses, tossing the covers off himself and standing up. My eyes travel from his thick legs to his half-mast cock that manages to be bigger than

anyone else I've ever been with. His chest is perfectly sculpted. If I'm going to guess, I'm going to say he's a personal trainer because there is no way someone who doesn't work in the gym looks like him. I mean, I guess he could have another job, but I'm going with personal trainer, or maybe gym owner. "You're staring," he says, and I let my eyes roam to his face. The beard is a bit overgrown but neat, and his green eyes look almost brown without the light on him. My heart starts to speed up as I take him in. My mouth starts to water and certain parts of me start to melt. He has to be the sexiest man I've ever laid eyes on in my twenty-five years of life.

"I am staring," I retort. "It's all out there for me to look at." I motion with my hand. "If you don't want me to stare, perhaps you should cover it." I hold out my hand, my palm facing him and blocking the second-best thing on his body. My eyes go to the tattoo on one side of his chest. An abstract blend of shapes and lines flow over his pec and shoulder, that if I cared enough I would have asked him about, but I had other more important things to ask him about, like him having protection.

He turns to walk out of the room, and I think about the conversation that threw cold water on us for at least twenty minutes.

I was pushed up against the door to his room when his mouth left mine and the only thing I wanted was to be fucked against the door; something I've never done before but I've always wanted to do, and he seemed like the perfect person to do it with. "You have protection, right?"

"No." He stopped kissing me right away.

"What do you mean no?" I stared into his eyes, my hand going from his shoulder to his hair. "How do you not have any protection?"

"Do you?"

"No!" I shrieked. "I will next time."

He let me go and walked over to the phone by the bed. As I watched him, he picked up the phone. "Yeah, do you guys have condoms?" I gasped.

“How about, ‘Good evening, how are you doing?’” I whispered and he just looked back at me.

“Okay, I’ll dash it, thanks.” He put the phone down and took his cell phone out of his pocket.

“Do you want to dash it or do I?” He looked over at me.

“I’m not going to dash condoms.” I put a hand to my chest. “That stays in your history. When you pull up the store again, it’ll say ordered this before.”

“Fine,” he said, uncaring about this being in his history. “I’ll order.” Totally unfazed that this will be in his history. “You need anything else?” he asked as if he was ordering me a burger.

“I think condoms is all,” I replied and then tilted my head to the side. “Might have to get some lube, you feel really big.” He smirked at me.

“I’ll get you warmed up.” He winked at me and then tossed the phone to the side. “I’ve got twenty minutes to get you ready.”

I tilted my head to the side. “Well then, get to work.”

It was the first time I was so open about sex and not shy about anything. It was very refreshing. Knowing I wouldn’t see him after the night made me freer than I normally would be.

He walks back into the bedroom and tosses the purse onto the bed at the same time his phone rings. “Time to rise and shine, Zane.” I open my purse and take out my phone, turning off the alarm. “Present me is happy that past me set an alarm, or else I’d be missing my flight.” I toss the sheets to the side and get up. “Um, is it okay if I use the bathroom before I leave?” I ask him awkwardly and he nods his head.

“Do you think you can turn around and not watch?” I ask him.

“No.” His snarky answer makes me snort. “Victoria,” he says my name and my whole body shivers. “I could lie to you and say sure and turn around, then I would turn back and watch you and that ass walking to the

bathroom.” His eyes bore down on me. “But I’m not a liar, never was... never will be.”

“Fair enough.” I snatch up my panties and jeans from the floor. “Stare away,” I invite, grabbing my shirt and then my bra, holding them to my chest. “It’s the best sight you’ll ever see in your life, so I might as well give it to you.” He laughs. “That is not the right answer, Zane,” I snap at him. When I walk past him, he reaches out for me and pulls me to him.

“What’s the right answer, Victoria?” His eyes are light green now. “Tell me and I’ll say it.”

“No,” I retort, “then what good will it be?” I roll my eyes at him as his hand cups my ass.

“You are the best sight I’ve ever seen in my life,” he compliments, bending and kissing my lips. “Better?”

“I mean, it’s after the fact,” I say and he lets me go, “but it’ll do.”

I walk away from him and when I look over my shoulder, I see him staring at me. “Now that,” I point to him, “is the answer; you drooling as I walk by.” I close the door as he barks out a laugh. “I’m taking a shower,” I tell the closed door and turn the shower on.

I quickly shower and get dressed, pulling my hair on the top of my head in a messy bun. I wish I’d had a chance to grab my purse so I could put on some lip gloss or something. Walking out of the room, I see him sitting on the side of the bed, wearing his black boxers, his phone in his hand. “I tried to order you coffee, but they said the wait was an hour.” He looks up from his phone at me.

“That’s okay. I have to head out anyway.”

“He also asked me if I got the condoms I needed.” I gawk at him and my eyes literally feel like they are going to come out of my sockets. “I’m kidding.”

“That is not funny.” I point to him, grabbing my purse from the bed and then the sweater. “I have enough time to get to my room and then change

before I have to meet my car downstairs.”

He nods as he gets up. “What are you doing?” I ask him as he takes a step closer to me.

“Walking you out,” he explains. “It’s called being a gentleman.”

“Well, I’ve seen what you can do with your fingers, your mouth, and that thing,” I point to his covered cock and he just shakes his head and smirks, “and you are no gentleman. I don’t think you should come to the door,” I tell him, stopping in the living room. “What if someone sees me leaving and then sees you? It’s like news flash; I just had sex.”

“Or you could be going to work,” he offers and I just look at him.

“That is not what anyone is going to think. If the housekeeper is out there, she’s going to see the wrappers in the garbage, and the wet stain on the bed, along with all the wet towels, and she’s going to know we did so many nasty things that this room should be decontaminated.” I look around the room. “We should have thought about that last night when you got me naked on that couch.” I point to the couch, putting my hand to my stomach. “How many asses do you think have been on that couch?”

“Only yours,” he tells me, and I roll my eyes. “Was that not a good answer?”

“Okay, you stay here.” I hold up my hand to him. “I’m going to go and, well, you watch me leave,” I tell him. He comes to me, puts his hand on my hip, and grips it, pulling me to him. “We literally don’t have time for this.”

“You’ll be fine,” he assures me, as if he knows what time my flight is. “You don’t have to change.”

“These clothes are twenty-four-hour-old clothes. I’ve been to the airport with them.” I start to say more when he bends his head and his mouth stops me from talking. I let my purse and sweater fall to the floor. I put my hands on his chest as I close my eyes and take in the kiss. His tongue plays with mine and his hand grips my hip tighter, pulling me flush to him.

He lets me go after a minute. “Thank you for last night.” I look up at him and he just smirks at me.

“No,” he says, his hand coming up to play with the hairs that fell out of the bun by the side of my face, “thank *you* for last night.”

“Pretty sure you did most of the work.” He laughs and I get on my tippy-toes and even that doesn’t get me close to his lips, but he gets what I’m going for and kisses me again. I look into his eyes before glancing back to his chest. I make a mental note of his tattoo, my finger moving to trace a couple of lines. “Thank you for the most memorable”—I hold up my finger—“first-time one-night stand.” He throws his head back and laughs and I have to wonder how many of these he’s had. *Don’t do that*, I immediately tell myself, *don’t go there*. “You are at the top of the leaderboard,” I quickly say something to make him laugh and then his laughter stops abruptly when the phone rings from my purse. “That’s my ride,” I tell him.

“Thank you,” he says to me, “for—” He doesn’t say the words and I smirk.

“For that thing I did with my mouth.” I wink at him, and he smiles, the creases around his eyes showing me it’s a true smile. “You’re welcome, Zane.” I turn and then walk to the door. I look over my shoulder as I pull open the door and find him watching me. “I hope your house doesn’t have termites.” I roll my lips as the phone stops ringing, and I give him one last smile before I walk out of the room.

My heart speeds up in my chest and my stomach feels like I’m going to be sick as I exhale and walk to the elevator. I press the button, looking back at the empty hallway as my phone rings again. I fish it out of my purse, seeing that it’s not my driver but Ariella. “Hey,” I answer, watching the empty hallway the whole time, “what’s up?”

“Just checking in on you. What time is your flight?” she asks me as the elevator gets here, and I inhale before getting into the elevator and pressing the number of my floor.

“I’m heading out now,” I reply as the elevator door stops and I push away the feeling that I’m sad he didn’t come running after me. “Hey, question. After you had a one-night stand with my brother, did you feel sad he didn’t chase after you when you left the room?”

“Oh my God,” she squeaks and then her voice goes low, “you had a one-night stand?”

“Yup,” I confirm, pulling the key card out of my purse and opening my door, seeing the bags I dumped at the door when I got in and rushed down to the bar to get something to eat.

“With who?”

“No clue, met him at the bar last night. Drank a glass of wine, flirted with him, and he didn’t flirt back. Which was annoying. He paid for my meal and when we went into the elevator, I said, ‘Is this when you ask me to go back to your room?’”

“What?”

“I know, I was as shocked as anyone,” I say. “He said yes and, well, the rest is history.” I grab my bags and head to the bed. “Anyway, I have to change before I leave to go to the airport,” I tell her.

“Was he good?”

“Oh yeah, my vagina is well-used.” I laugh as I pull off my sweater. “I have to run. I need to rush. I’ll call you later.”

“You better,” she snaps. “I want all the details.”

“No.” I shake my head. “Those are mine,” I tell her. “It’s one night and it’s all mine.”

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four

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Zane

Five months later....

I PULL UP TO THE BLACK, STAINLESS-STEEL GARAGE DOOR AND TAKE OUT MY pass, scanning it at the magnetic square, and the door slowly starts to creak open. I wait for the door to completely open before I drive down the ramp to the underground parking.

The valet office in the corner sits empty, since Clive only gets here after eight during the week and two when we have a Saturday game. Pulling into my parking space, I look at the center console to see it's four minutes after seven. I turn off the car, grabbing my phone from the console and the leather binder on the passenger seat.

Looking down to see my father texted me.

DAD:

Have the best first day. Send us a first day on the job picture.

I smile and shake my head but do it anyways with me scowling and holing up a thumb.

Getting out of the SUV, I head over to the silver stainless-steel door that you need a pass to go through.

I take my pass out and scan it, watching the red light turn to green before the door unlocks and I step in. The office space is eerily quiet, which

is normal since we start at nine today, but I came in to hit the gym for an hour before I head to my desk and start reading the notes from yesterday. We started training camp two weeks ago but today everyone is back, including the players who have official contracts with the club. I've made it clear to the GM two weeks ago that regardless of if they have a contract or not, if they are going to half-ass training camp they'll be shipped to the farm team. He was not thrilled with this news, since he has a budget to account for, but I couldn't give a fuck less. I want to win games and I'm not going to do it with people who aren't going to give it their all. I walk down the black carpeted hallway to my office in the corner, which was Martin's office until his last day here three months ago. He was half out by the time the draft came, and I was officially in the head coach position.

The office is bare, with a desk in the corner so I can have space for a couch that I don't even use, but Martin had it in here, so I kept it. I don't even think anyone has ever sat on this couch, to be honest. There is a small mini fridge in the corner of the room behind my desk, fully stocked, even though I haven't touched a drink in there. I leave it stocked for when people come into my office. I toss my binder on the top of the desk before walking back out. The rest of the office doors are closed and the lights are off. As I head toward the gym, I spot the people in the kitchen setting up. "Morning!" I holler as I walk by and a couple of them look over at me confused that someone is here so early.

I walk into the gym, taking off my sweater and tossing it to the side before walking over to the television in the corner and turning it on to *Sports Center*. Once that is on, I get on the bike to warm up for ten minutes, watching what is going on with other teams. I do cardio for about fifteen minutes before moving to my weight training.

I'm heaving when I grab my sweater and walk out of the gym. The lights are now on everywhere since it's after eight. I stop in the kitchen and start making my protein shake, taking out some frozen fruit and then

blending it. “Hey, Coach.” I look over my shoulder to see Eric, my second assistant coach, walking in. “You’re here early.”

“Yeah, I was in the gym,” I tell him and he nods. “I’m heading to my office now to go over the notes from yesterday’s practice if you want to join me.”

“Will do,” he confirms, and I walk back to my office and toss my sweater onto the couch before pulling the black office chair out and sitting down. Grabbing the leather binder and unzipping it, I take out the notes from yesterday that I collected from Cam and Eric, along with a couple of the hockey development coaches. I also grab the printout sheet that was given to all of us with the players’ names, position, and the rest of their stats, including weight and height.

I hear more people arriving as Cam sticks his head into my office. “I’m here. I have things to do.” I look up at him and nod my head, keeping the comment that he should be in here going over the notes with me since he’s my assistant. But if he doesn’t see that, I’m not going to point it out to him.

Eric comes in a couple of minutes later. “Where is Cam?”

“No clue, he said he had things to do,” I reply and watch Eric’s face turn confused. The cup of coffee in his hand goes to his lips as he mumbles something.

“Okay, let’s go over these names,” I suggest as he sits in the same seat I sat in when my life changed five months ago. “We have fifty-five players trying out,” I tell him and he huffs out. “Thirty-five forwards, seventeen defensemen, and three goalies. Lucky for us the goalies are not our job. I’ll leave that up to Andrew.” I mention the goalie coach. “He’s been doing this for the past ten years; he knows more than me.” Eric nods at me. “We have to be on the ice from ten,” I tell him, “until four, rotating every hour and a half.” He nods at me. “I want you on the ice with me. I am going to have Cam go over the plays with the guys before they get on there, so we aren’t wasting time.”

“Sounds good,” he says as we go down the roster and make a plan of attack on who to watch out for. “We are going to have to cut five defensemen and ten forwards.” I get up from my chair, grabbing the list and putting my notes back in my binder and closing it shut. As I head toward the locker room, I see the first round of players getting ready for their time on the ice, while the second-round ice players are getting ready to hit the gym, and the third round are getting ready to do off-ice training, which focuses more on balance and coordination, agility and strength training.

“Hey,” I say to Jaxon when I see him walking down the hallway. His face goes into a smile.

“What’s up, Coach Man?” he says, holding out his hand to me.

I shake his hand. “What’s up, C Man,” I call him since he’s the captain. “How we doing?”

“Good.” He nods at me. “Good to be back but sad to leave the summer behind.”

“Did you have a nice vacation?” I ask him.

“Nice enough, spent time with the family. What about you?” He looks around and gives a couple of chin-ups to some of the guys he sees.

“Good, busy. Spent the summer going over everything that I needed to go over. Got ready for this year,” I answer. “We’ve been at it for the last month, going over rookies and prospects.”

“I heard,” he says as Kirby and Knox both arrive behind him.

“Hey, Coach,” Knox greets first, and then Kirby holds up two fingers to say hello as he drinks some light-pink drink from his water bottle.

“What time are you guys on the ice?” I ask them.

“Next round,” Jaxon says for them. “We are doing video training.” I nod at them.

“I’ll see you out there.” I turn. “You guys better fucking bring your A game.” I look at them. “Show the young kids what it’s all about.”

“Yes, Coach,” they snap out at the same time.

“On it, Coach,” Kirby adds.

“You got it, Coach,” Knox states next. “I’m in tip-top shape this year,” he says, making fun of himself two years ago when he came back to training camp twenty pounds heavier and a fuck ton slower. Then last year he came back after learning his wife was fucking his sister’s husband.

“You look lighter,” I joke with him as I head to the locker room to change into my skates.

Cam is already there lacing up, while Eric sits down with his bottle of water in his hand. “What’s going on?”

“Cam wants to go out on the ice,” Eric replies. I look over at Cam then back to Eric, who gives me a look like “it’s fine.” I just nod my head as I lace up my own skates, grabbing the nylon track jacket that is hanging on the hook with my name on it. I push my hair back on top of my head before grabbing my helmet and heading to the ice. “You forgot the whistle.” Cam chuckles and I turn back to see Cam grab it and put it around his own neck.

“I got it,” he announces, walking past me and heading to the ice.

“This is going to be fun,” Eric deadpans, doing a chin lift toward the door.

“It’s a learning curve.” I give Cam the benefit of the doubt. “He’s been at it longer than I have.”

“Which means he would have gotten the job, *if* he was qualified enough,” Eric states, getting up. “I’ll go and talk to the guys about the plays on the ice.”

“Thanks,” I reply quietly as I walk out and grab my stick before making my way to the ice. Cam is there on the side, chatting it up with some of the guys.

“Coach,” a couple of them call out.

“Why aren’t you on the ice?” I ask them, my tone tight, and a couple of them look down and head to the ice. I look up and see we are supposed to start in two minutes. “Whoever isn’t on this ice by the time I start will not

be allowed to practice, and your practice will be over!” I shout down the hall, knowing the word will get around. It takes a full minute before everyone who is supposed to be on the ice is on the ice.

“Gentlemen,” I look at the guys in front of me, “you have one hour and a half to impress the shit out of me. Make every single minute count,” I urge. I would blow my whistle at this point, but instead, I bang my stick on the ice. “Positions.” I skate to the side and watch them break up into pairs like we did the past couple of days.

I stand to the side with Cam beside me, and when I see a play that isn’t being played right, I look at him. “Are you going to use that whistle or just watch them fuck up things?” I ask him. He smirks before he blows the whistle, and I skate to show them what I want on the ice.

We only get off the ice for lunch and then we are back again for the other two sessions. I get off the ice at the end of the third round, seeing Andrew still on the ice with his goaltenders.

Cam is already out of his skates and out the door heading home by the time I make it to the locker room. Jaxon sticks his head in. “Hey, Coach.”

“Sup?” I ask him, putting my skates under the bench.

“I’m going to head out, but I wanted to see if you wanted to come over for dinner.” He looks over his shoulder. “Something less formal for us to maybe talk about this year. I was thinking maybe around six, six thirty?”

I nod at him, knowing this is an olive branch he’s extending to me. “Sounds good,” I tell him. “Do me a favor and send me your address. I’ll bring dessert.”

“Awesome,” he replies, walking out. By the time I quickly go over the notes from today’s practice, make it home and order dessert, it’s six when I’m on my way over to Jaxon’s, who lives about twenty minutes away from me.

I pull up to the house, parking on the street, grabbing the white box of desserts that I got, and heading to the front door. Pressing the doorbell, I

wait for Jaxon to answer. He pulls open the door, and he stands there with jeans and a black Warriors T-shirt on, with his son on his hip. "Come in." He moves away and I step in.

"Hey," I say to Jagger, "what's up, little man?" I hold up my hand. "High-five." He holds up his hand and gives me a high-five. Then he smiles big at me and looks at Jaxon.

"I was just going to change him," Jaxon states as we walk into the house. "Please make yourself at home." He points to the kitchen that leads into the family room. "I'll be right back."

I walk over to the kitchen, placing the box on the counter before I look around and step into the family room. I head over to the built-in shelves where there are photos of Jaxon and his wife, Ariella, a couple of pictures of Jagger when he was a newborn and then, I swear, I think time fucking stops. Or at least that is what it feels like when I see the face of the girl who has been fucking haunting my dreams for the past five months.

It's a picture of them on a beach somewhere. She's standing at the side, her face straight, looking at the camera. Her eyes are not as bright as they were the last time I saw her. Her hair is loose with those soft waves I can't get out of my head. She looks just as beautiful as I remember. My heart feels like it's about to come out of my throat when I see a picture of her and Jagger with a #1 Auntie on the top of the frame. It can't fucking be.

"Hey." I look over at Jaxon, who has come back into the room without Jagger. "Sorry about that. Ariella was in the shower. She now has him."

"No worries." I try to not freak out just yet. "I was just looking at some pictures." I point directly at the picture of Victoria and Jagger, hoping he says she's a family friend, maybe Ariella's sister. I hope she is anyone but his sister.

"Yeah, Tori got him that last month," he explains. "She's been trying to get him to say that she's his number one aunt."

I swallow down the lump in my throat as the back of my neck starts to burn, and everything feels like it's coming crashing down when the front door slams shut. "Honey, I'm home." Victoria's voice rips through me, going straight to my cock, and then at her little giggle afterward. I have to blink once, twice, three times. "It's Jagger's favorite person."

I stand as if my feet are in cement boots as she walks into the house, and I try not to freak the fuck out. "Oh good, you guys didn't eat. I'm starving," she says, looking at Jaxon and not seeing that I'm here. I look at her, taking in her hair which is almost like it was the first time I met her, pinned back by a clip at the back of her head. Soft tendrils fall to the sides of her face. Her cheeks are pink and not because she just came from my cock or my tongue but because of the makeup she has on. Her eyes are blue today but when she finally looks at me, I see them change before my eyes and widen in surprise. "Um," she hesitates then looks at Jaxon, "I didn't know you were having someone over."

"Well, you didn't call, so how would I be able to tell you?" He teases her as he wraps an arm around her neck and pulls her close to him. "Coach, meet my baby sister, Victoria."

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Victoria

I TURN MY HEAD TO THE SIDE, AND I SWEAR I HAVE TO BLINK ABOUT A hundred times to make sure what I'm seeing is real, and not that I'm daydreaming Zane is fucking standing here in the middle of my brother's living room. Like Cupid literally picked him up and delivered him straight to my door with a bow around him. "Um," I hesitate, looking back at Jaxon and trying to hide the fact I'm silently freaking the fuck out. "I didn't know you were having someone over," I say, hoping my voice doesn't crack with the nervousness that shoots through me. I swear, I feel like you would be able to see how fast my heart is beating because it feels like it's coming out of my chest.

"Well, you didn't call, so how would I be able to tell you?" he teases me and wraps an arm around my neck. At any given time, I would push him off me and call him a dick, but I'm thrown right now. "Coach," he says, and it takes everything inside me not to gasp; this is his fucking hockey coach, "meet my baby sister, Victoria." Jaxon looks at me. "Tori, this is my coach, Zane."

"Victoria," Zane says my name and I'm transported back to five months ago as he groaned my name when my mouth was attached to a certain part of him. He comes over to me and my eyes go to that special place I liked,

but the black jeans he's wearing don't give anything away. He extends his hand to me and Jaxon lets me go.

I hold out my own hand for him and just like the first time we met, electricity passes through me. For the past five months I've tried to find that same feeling with every new guy I've met. I would shake their hands immediately to see if the spark was there, and then wait for it. It never fucking happened, but now with him, in front of my brother, it feels like I just got electrocuted. "Zane," I say his name, as if it's the first time I've ever said it and not that I've moaned it out numerous times in the past five months without him, "it's a pleasure to meet you."

"Likewise," he replies, his broodiness back. I take in his green eyes and note the differences in his appearance. His hair is cut shorter on the top than it was before, and it looks like he ran his fingers through it to the side. But his beard is longer, and I think I shiver as I remember what it felt like between my legs.

"I thought I heard you," Ariella says, and I walk over to her, making sure I swing my hips a little bit more than I should. I'm also really happy I wore these jeans today since they show off my ass. Jagger is on her hip in his pjs, squirming to get down. His hair is combed over to one side, still wet from his bath that he was probably in not too long ago.

"Hi," I say to her, trying not to freak the fuck out and run out the front door, slamming the door shut behind me. "I was in the neighborhood." I bend down, pointing my ass in Zane's direction. "How is my handsome boy?" I pick him up and kiss his neck. He takes it for one second before fighting to get down.

"How were you in the neighborhood when you live on the other side of the city?" Jaxon questions, laughing,

"Leave her alone," Ariella scolds Jaxon. "Also, hi, Zane." She walks around me and heads to Zane and kisses his cheek. He smiles down at her

and if she wasn't madly in love with my brother I might, perhaps, maybe, by accident, pull her head away from him. "Welcome."

"Thanks for having me," he says. His voice rumbles and I look over my shoulder at him. "I brought dessert."

"I love dessert," I interject, and his eyes come to mine. "It might be my favorite meal." I see the memory flash into his eyes when we ordered cake in the middle of the night, and he grabbed the whip cream and smeared it on my nipple so he could lick it off me.

Jagger walks over to Ariella and pulls at her legs to be picked up. "I'll set the table," I tell them.

"So you are staying for dinner," Jaxon says, "even though you weren't invited, got it."

"You're welcome," I retort as I reach for the plates. "Zane, you don't mind if I stay, do you?" I smile at him then look at Zane, who just watches me, not saying a word.

"It's fine with me," he answers and gives me a little smirk before I walk back to the table and set it.

"Do you want something to drink, Zane?" Ariella asks him as Jaxon takes the tray out of the oven.

"He looks like a whiskey man," I state and see his eyes flicker, but he gives away nothing.

"I'm good with water," he says, walking into the kitchen and I can feel his eyes on me as I set the table. "Is there anything I can do to help?" he asks.

I'm about to mumble out, "You can take me in the bathroom and do me against the door," but I bite my tongue before I actually say it out loud.

"We're all good," Ariella says, grabbing water bottles out of the fridge and placing them on the counter. Ten minutes later, we are sitting down at the table. I pull out the chair next to Zane and sit down, smiling at him. His

hand is resting on the top of the table and the pull to slide my hand in his is so fucking strong.

Jaxon picks up the tray that has grilled chicken on it as he takes a piece and then hands it to Zane, who then hands it to me. "Thank you," I tell him and his eyes light up a touch. "So you're the brand-new coach?" I ask him and he nods his head, not saying anything. "That's exciting."

"It is," he replies, not giving me anything more as Jaxon hands him the plate that has the potatoes and veggies.

"I heard that you are the youngest coach in the NHL," I mention, and he just nods his head awkwardly.

"Tori," Jaxon says my name, "this isn't an inquisition. Let him chill."

"I'm just making conversation," I respond. "Your family must be really proud of you," I blurt out as he looks up at me as he cuts his piece of chicken. "Are you a single child?"

"They are." He looks at me, "I'm not I have an older sister."

"Do they live near here?" I ask trying to lead up to the most important question that I want to ask him.

"No, they are all on the east coast."

"Are you married?" I finally ask him the loaded question and the only question that really matters.

"Tori," Jaxon hisses.

"What? I'm trying to make conversation and get to know your guest." I grab a string bean and put it in my mouth.

"I'm not married," he answers, not giving me anything more.

"Kids?" I ask him and I see Jaxon share a look with Ariella.

"No to that also," he replies.

"So how long have you been the head guy in charge?" I ask him and he looks over at me.

"Five months now," he says, and I nod my head.

“Have you always lived here?” I ask him since he’s not going to do any of the talking during this time.

“I moved here three years ago, when I got the assistant job,” he tells me.

“I just moved here myself for a job. Right after graduation,” I state, smiling at him. “I came to visit my brother five months ago.” I make sure to add in that little piece of information for him, his face looking like he’s seen a ghost. “And I was offered a job. Thought, why not?”

“I don’t think he cares,” Jaxon mumbles as he eats his food.

“Well, it’s a good thing I’m here or he would be asleep in his plate since you haven’t said a word.” I smirk at him. “So do you live near here?”

“Yeah,” he says, and I look over at him, “not too far, a house on the beach.”

“Oh nice, that sounds like fun.”

“So where are you from originally?”

“Sorry, Coach,” Jaxon apologizes.

“What is your problem?” Ariella asks him. “She’s making conversation. There is nothing wrong with her questions. It’s not like she’s asking him anything private.”

“Yeah, Jaxon,” I add, tilting my head to the side, “it’s not like I’m asking him about his dating life.”

“I mean, it looks like it’s headed that way!” he snaps, making me laugh and then I hear a chuckle come from Zane.

“Oh, he can laugh,” I tease Zane and he looks at me. “You’ve been pretty dry, and a little bit rude.”

His back goes up. “Tori,” Jaxon hisses.

“What?” I ask. “He hasn’t asked me one question.”

“That’s because he’s minding his own business.” Jaxon sticks up for Zane and I just shrug. “So, Zane, how do you like coaching?”

“It’s different,” he answers me. “Got some things to get used to but it’s coming along.”

“The guys are loving the new blood,” Jaxon interjects. I lift my eyebrows and smile proudly at him, especially when I see his eyes light up with the acknowledgment.

“See how great this conversation is?” I pretend to flip my hair by my ear. “Again, you’re welcome.”

“We see things differently,” Jaxon refutes as he bites his chicken, and Jagger starts to get fussy in his highchair.

“I’ll take him,” I offer, reaching for him and he turns away from me.

“I will have you know, young man,” I say as I pull him out and he whines, “there are men out there who would love to have my hands on them.” I swear I hear Zane start to cough, and I look over at him and see his glass of water at his mouth. “You okay there, Coach?” I ask him, using his title.

“Yes,” he replies, his jaw getting tight.

“Don’t you have to go?” Jaxon asks me as he puts his fork down.

“Nope, this is fun,” I chirp, getting up with Jagger on my lap. “Isn’t this fun?” I ask Jagger, who puts his finger in his mouth. “I think he wants a bottle,” I suggest, walking over to the kitchen and spotting Jaxon’s phone. I put it in my back pocket as I make Jagger a bottle and then hand him back to Ariella. “I’ll be back, I have to use the ladies’ room.” I turn and hope Jaxon doesn’t see his phone is missing. Getting into the bathroom, I open up his contacts and head down to Zane’s name, repeating the number to myself four times before going and texting it to myself. Once it goes through, I delete the text thread from the phone and then head out.

“Okay, as much fun as this is,” I say, slipping his phone back onto the counter, “I’m going to head out. I have a busy day tomorrow.”

“Finally,” Jaxon exhales. “Goodbye.”

“Zane,” I say his name and he looks over at me. I see his short sleeves are tight around his biceps. “It was so nice meeting you.” I smile at him. “I’m sure I’ll be seeing you around.” I tilt my head to the side and he just

nods at me. “A man of few words,” I mumble to myself. I turn to kiss Jagger on the cheek. “Good night, my sweet boy,” I say as Ariella gets up with him.

“I’m going to go and put him to bed.” She looks at the guys. “Leave the plates, I’ll clean up when I come down.”

She walks me out as I grab my bag I tossed at the door. “The coach looks like he’s a barrel of laughs,” I say to her, and she rolls her lips.

“He’s very, very serious,” she whispers. “It’s like his whole world is his job from what Jaxon says.”

“That’s sad.” I look back at the hallway. “He looks like he needs a fun night.” *While we fuck over and over again*, I think to myself but don’t say it. “I’ll see you Saturday night,” I tell her. “My parents are coming down for a spot visit, sort of like a wellness check, which should be so much fun.”

“I thought they were saving the trip this weekend for three weeks from now when it’s the opening game,” she says.

“Well, either way, I’ll be here Saturday because I have no life,” I joke as I walk out and head to my car. For the second time since I’ve met him, I look over my shoulder, waiting for him to chase after me, and again, I’m left with him not fucking chasing after me.

I get into the car and pull out of the driveway, looking over at the SUV that is parked by the sidewalk. I’m tempted to leave a note on his car to call me, but I think my original plan is going to work better.

When I get home, I unlock the door and step in, taking off my heels. Then I walk into the kitchen, dumping my purse on the little counter before heading over to my bedroom. The two-bedroom house is perfect for me, and it was just my luck that Lexi was renting it out after she moved in with Kirby. It’s directly on the beach and comes fully furnished. I couldn’t ask for anything else.

I take a shower and after my hair is wrapped in a towel and I’m wearing my cotton robe, I put the gold eye patches under my eyes as I take out my

phone and go into my text messages.

I press on the phone number I sent to myself, wondering if he's even going to answer. It rings three times before he answers, and it sounds like he's out of breath. "Hello."

"Zane," I say his name, curling my legs under myself as I sit on the couch.

"How did you get my number?" he quickly asks.

"Does it matter?"

"Victoria," he says my full name.

"I got it from Jaxon's phone," I tell him, knowing he's probably freaking out.

He gasps. "What if you got the wrong number?"

"How many Coach Zanes are there in the world that my brother has stored in his phone, do you think?" I don't wait for him to answer. "Now that we know it is the right number, it was indeed a good idea," he sighs and my nipples pebble.

"This can't be happening," he says, and I hide my disappointment.

"Relax there, Coach," I reply, not willing to use his name. "It's fine, it was just sex between two consenting adults."

"How old are you?" I roll my eyes at that question.

"Does it matter?" I shake my head.

"Yes," he quickly hisses out.

"Okay, fine," I say, "eighty-four. Does that make you feel better?"

"Victoria," he says my name in a frustrated voice, "seriously."

"Nope." I will not give him this. "All that matters is we make sure that night is our secret, and we are both on the same page, so no one finds out about it."

"I agree," he says quietly. "That night needs to stay between us." I want to ask him why, but I refrain from it.

“Your wish is my command. Have a great night, Coach.” I hang up the phone on him. I look down. “It’s a sad day because he had a magical cock.” I shake my head, silently wishing he calls me back but getting up, knowing that he won’t.

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Zane

I SLIP THE BLACK JACKET OFF THE HANGER AND PUT IT ON, BEFORE PULLING my cuffs out of the sleeves. The nerves in my stomach almost make me feel sick. It's our first home game of the season. I take a deep inhale and look at myself once more before I head out. I'm in a black tailored suit with a charcoal button-up shirt, my hand goes to the knot at the neck. "Game fucking day," I say before running my hand through the top of my hair and then down over my beard. I think I should really cut it off, but I like the way it looks.

The phone rings and I look down to see it's my dad, "Hey," I say putting him on speaker.

"Hey yourself." His voice is gruff, "Whatcha doing?"

"About to head to the rink."

"You nervous?" He asks me and I give a little chuckle, "You got this son. We'll be staying up to watch the game."

"Thanks. I want you to call me tomorrow and tell me how you think I did." I say and he laughs.

"I'll take notes." He chuckles at me, "talk to you tomorrow. Love you."

"Love you too dad." I say and hang up.

I turn off the lights in my bathroom and head for the stairs, going up to the top floor where the kitchen, living room, and the front door and garage

are. I've been in this house since my house had to be completely gutted and then rebuilt. I bought this one in the meantime, but as time goes by, I think this is the house I'm going to be living in, and I'll sell the other one. I walk to the garage, getting into the car, and pressing the remote to open the door before starting the SUV. Once the door is up, I pull out of the garage and make my way down the road. The ocean is on my right and mountains on my left. The house is on a cliff, which I love since it's on the beach, but not directly on the beach, which gives it more privacy.

My drive to the arena doesn't lessen my nerves and as I pull up to the entrance, I know immediately it's going to be a different type of insanity today. The media is already set up to take pictures of the guys arriving. They have not made a secret of it; they are watching my every fucking move. I pull up and stop my car when I see Clive walking out of his office, a big smile on his face. "Hey, Coach," he greets and slaps my arm, "you excited about tonight?"

"I'm not the one on the ice," I tell him, hitting his arm. As I walk into the building, I hear a couple of the reporters calling my name and I just ignore them, walking in.

I head to my office, taking off my jacket and loosening my tie before I head over to the coaches' room. There is a long table in the middle of the room, one wall has three screens on it, and the other two beside it to show us replays. Then there is the whiteboard with the players' name written on it with what line they are on.

I take a second to stare at it. "Hey." I look over my shoulder at Jaxon, who walks into the room. I have to say, for the last month, I've been waiting for him to walk into the room and deck me for sleeping with his younger sister. It feels like I'm standing in the middle of the room with a ticking time bomb in my hand, and it's about to explode every single time. That night, after she called me and she refused to tell me how old she was, I lay in bed trying to think of how old she could be. Did I know she was

younger than me? Of course, but did I know she was just fucking graduated young? No, I thought for sure she was in her mid-to-late-twenties. I did not think she had just fucking graduated university. I closed my eyes and even called myself an old pervert for sleeping with her to begin with. I know I need to focus on one thing and one thing only – winning this game. Victoria Stevenson should be the farthest thing from my mind.

“How you doing?” Jaxon asks me, bringing me back to reality, as I look at the door and then back at him. He is usually the first one who gets here, going to work out before everyone else.

“Like I’m going to yack all over the fucking place.” I turn back to look at him. “If it’s not too much pressure, I’d really like to win tonight,” I tell him and he laughs.

“I’ll see what I can do. How’s this, we win, you join us at the bar tonight?”

I groan, “I didn’t even like going to the bar when I was your age. You think I want to go to the bar at my age?”

“You’re about six years older than me, so you can relax with the whole when I was your age,” he states, making me chuckle. “What do you say?”

Cam heads into the room, holding a coffee cup in his hand, wearing a light gray suit, even though the coaching staff talked about it and we decided to be unified with wearing black suits. “What do you say about what?”

“We win, Coach is joining us at the bar,” Jaxon says, slapping my shoulder and squeezing it. “I’m going to go and hit the gym.” He walks out of the room and leaves me with Cam.

“You think that’s a good idea?” he asks me, and I just look at him.

“Bonding with the team?” I ask him. “Yeah, I think it’s a good idea.” He raises his eyebrows, not saying a word. “What’s up with your suit choice?”

“What do you mean?” he asks me when Eric comes in and he’s wearing a dark-blue suit.

“Was I the only one who got the memo to wear a black fucking suit?” I ask, putting my hands on my hips.

“Wait, what?” Eric questions. “Cam said—” My eyes go to Cam.

“I thought you were joking,” he says, avoiding looking at me as he looks at the board. “It doesn’t matter anyway.”

“It matters,” I mumble to him and then I call his name, “Cam.” He looks up at me. “Don’t do that shit again.”

“What shit?” he replies defensively. “I thought you were joking about it, my mistake.”

I don’t say anything else because he turns to walk out of the room. “Sorry, Coach,” Eric says, “I should have checked with you.”

“No big deal. What do you think?” I ask Eric, looking at the board. “Think we have the lines worked out?”

He looks at the board, seeing the names of the roster split up. “Yeah, I think we start with this and rework it once we see what happens on the ice. It worked for preseason.”

“Now is when it counts,” I remind him, and then he walks out of the room. I stand here looking at the names as if willing the board to tell me if it’s right or not. I walk out when I hear the roar of the crowd, knowing the players are taking the ice for the pregame skate. I walk down the hallway to the tunnel and stand here looking out, seeing the fans lined up at the ice with their signs. I see a couple of the players going to see their family, and I force myself to not look and see if she’s here. Instead, I turn around and head to my office.

Ken is there waiting beside my door, talking to Brad, the VP of hockey operations for the team. He’s basically everyone’s boss. “Hey, Coach,” Brad says, stepping forward, “just coming to wish you luck. All eyes are going to be on you tonight.”

“I don’t know why,” I retort, “all eyes should be on the team.”

“You would be wrong,” Brad replies, turning and walking away.

“He’s a tough nut to crack,” I say as he stops and chats with Cam, who shakes his hand and the two of them chuckle. “Apparently not to everyone, maybe it’s just a me thing.” My stomach gets tight.

“He’s been on the fence about you,” Ken admits. “He thought it would be better to have someone with more experience in there, but Martin was firm on choosing you and handing the team over to you.”

“Good to know,” I mumble as the guys come back in off the ice. “Time to announce the lines,” I say to Ken. “See you out there.”

He nods at me as I walk into my office, grabbing my jacket and putting it back on before I grab the paper with the lines, even though I know I have them memorized like the back of my hand.

I step into the room and then shut the door, not wanting the media to hear what I have to say. “Boys,” I start, clearing my throat as the room looks up at me. “We got the lines.” I hold up the paper. “Nothing changes from the last pre-season game,” I tell the room. “We are going to start with Knox, Lane, and Nick.” I look at the three of them. “With Kirby and Jaxon on the D.” I look at Kirby and Jaxon, who just nod at me. “Between the pipes,” I look over at our goalie, “we’ve got Sammy.”

I look over at Cam and Eric. “Listen, they are saying that all eyes are on me tonight.” I smirk and then chuckle. “I don’t know why, I’m not the one on the ice.” The joke makes them laugh. “I won’t be called out after the game if I don’t skate good; you guys are.” I point to them. “In all seriousness, there is a lot of noise out there.” I point to the door. “They are looking at us, wondering if we are going to go down. You look at the guy on the right, you look to the guy on the left, and you know that when you go out there, you play for him. You play for yourself. You can’t win a game with one person. This is a team. I might be biased,” I hold my head high and my shoulders back, “but I think this is the best fucking team on the ice. Now let’s go out there and fucking do it, so I don’t have to have a sad press

conference after,” I say and they laugh. “Warriors on three.” It’s something I started at the first preseason game. “One, Two, Three.”

“Warriors!” they roar. I clap my hands and open the door, heading out and then going straight for the bench. I walk behind the bench with Cam right beside me, as the lights go down and they start introducing the staff members. I take a deep inhale when they start introducing the coaches. When they get to Eric and then Cam, I wait to hear my name.

“Your head coach for the season,” the announcer says, “Zane Gilmore.” The crowd cheers loudly and the only thing I do is give them a nod.

The team is introduced, one at a time taking the ice: Kirby, Knox, and Jaxon the last three. When it’s over, everyone comes to the bench and the first line takes their positions. “Here we go,” I say, watching center ice for the puck drop. I think I hold my breath the whole fucking game. The whole game. Until the last fucking second. I finally let it out when the siren goes off and I put my hand in a fist and hold it up.

“One down,” Eric states, “the whole season to go.” I shake his hand then go to Cam.

“Nice game,” I tell him, and he smiles at me.

We walk back to the dressing room as I stop at the beginning of the tunnel, Cam looks back at me. “What are you doing?” he asks.

“I’m the first guy who is going to be there to congratulate them or greet them when they lose,” I tell him as the guys start coming back through the tunnel. “Good game.” I hold up my hand and, one by one, I congratulate the boys.

Jaxon is the last one off the ice, doing his own thing with the boys and making his way to me. “You know what this means, Coach,” he reminds me, taking off his gloves. “See you at the bar.”

“A deal’s a deal,” I tell him and then walk into the room with him.

“Okay, let’s do this; a new thing we are starting this year.” I look over at Cam and Eric, who come in with a helmet and a hammer. “They call me

Coach Viking.” I laugh at the nickname the press gave me. “Not sure if it’s my beard, but,” I run my hand over it, “we’re going to do Viking of the game, win or lose, there has to be someone chosen. I’m going to start it off. I really wish I could give it to each and every one of you because there was not a battle out there that you guys didn’t fight to win.” I look at the guys. “Whether it was in the corner or on the open ice, you guys fought hard. I have to give it to the C Man,” I tell Jaxon. “Two goals, one assist.” I walk over to him and hand him the hammer and the helmet.

He takes the helmet, putting it on his head and then shakes my hand and comes in for a hug. “Thanks, Coach.”

“Okay, the press is about to come in, and I have to go and do my own and take credit for all your hard work,” I tell them, turning and walking out of the room and heading straight for the media room where they are waiting to ask me questions.

Media lasts a full thirty minutes and I am finally free of them. I head to my office, Cam and Eric having already checked out and left. Jaxon comes out of the changing room, and I look at him. “Ready to go?”

“I’m not getting out of this, am I?” I ask him and he smirks.

“Nope, good news though, it’s not too far from here.”

“Oh good,” I reply.

“Can you give me a lift? My wife is going to meet me there with my ride.” I nod at him as we walk out.

Heading to my SUV, I pull open the door and get in. It takes under ten minutes to get to the bar and by the time I park and get out, I’m already dreading this. The music can be heard from the parking lot. “Ugh,” I groan, walking with him to the door and walking in after Jaxon.

He quickly goes off to the side as the rookies see me, and they all holler at me. I turn to walk toward them, but my vision catches on Victoria. She’s holding a glass of wine in her hand as she talks to one of the equipment managers – Robert. The smile she is giving him is fake and then she shakes

her head. I swear, I only have eyes for her, and then I'm stupidly making my way to her. "No, I think I'm good," I hear her say, "but thanks."

He grasps her arm and I have to stop myself from grabbing the nape of his neck when she looks shocked that he's touching her. "Come on, just give me your number."

"Robert," I snap out his name and his eyes come to me. "Leave Ms. Stevenson alone," I demand, my voice tight. He nods his head and turns to walk to the other side. His eyes going big at her last name and he finally gets that she's off-limits.

"Thanks for that," she says as she steps toward me and I again, for the second time tonight, I mistakenly look at her up and down. She's wearing black jeans that hug her every curve and a black shirt with a blue jean jacket. Her white sneakers make it sporty.

"No worries," I reply, and then I get a whiff of her perfume. My cock again springs into fucking action. The minute I saw her, he was ready, but now knowing she's close to me, knowing what she tastes like, what she feels like, he wants nothing more than to end this night with her. I nod at her and turn away, heading straight for the rookies, knowing whatever she wants or needs, I can't give it to her.

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seven

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Victoria

I WATCH HIM WALK AWAY FROM ME FOR THE FIRST TIME. THE FIRST COUPLE of times it was me walking away from him, wishing he would chase me, but coming to the conclusion that it was never going to happen.

I should just tuck it away as the best night of my life and end it there. The whole game my eyes were on him behind the bench. Yelling at guys to *skate harder* or *let's fucking go we got this*. Either way, my eyes could never leave him. Never.

Was I expecting to see him here tonight? No. I didn't think he would come, to be honest. Did my breathing stop the minute he barked out that guy's name? Yes, it did and then I was shaking from the inside out.

He was dressed the same way he was during the game, minus the tie. The top two buttons of his shirt were open and when he turned, even just a bit, I saw a hint of his ink and my mouth watered to taste him again. My hands itched to touch him, my body that for the past five months has been dormant was now wide awake, as if it knew he was near.

I look down at my white sneakers and turn away from him. The minute I start to get farther away from him, the back of my neck burns as if someone is staring at me. I can feel eyes on me and when I look back over my shoulder, I catch his for just a second before he turns away. He leans his arms on the bar as two guys are around him, the three of them talking about

something. I'm not even watching where I'm going when I bump into a hard body.

Looking up, I see one of my brother's teammates, Woods. "Oh my gosh," I say. "I'm so sorry."

A smile fills his face. "If I get run over by a beautiful woman," he leans in, "I'll take the hit."

I can't help but laugh at him. "I've never heard that one before," I joke with him, and he puts his hands in his suit pockets.

"I just made that up on the spot."

"Somehow," I chuckle, "I don't believe you."

He puts his hand to his heart. "I'm wounded."

"No, he's not," Jaxon booms into the conversation. "He's not any of that." He pushes his shoulder. "He doesn't get wounded." He side-eyes him. "You know this is my sister, right?" The guy's mouth drops open. "Yeah, exactly. So take all that fake shit away from her."

"I'm—" He extends his hand for me to shake and Jaxon slaps it away.

"She's *touch her and die*," Jaxon warns and Woods just laughs at him.

"I'm also known as Tori," I tell him. "It's nice to meet you."

"Don't engage with him," Jaxon groans. "He's going to think you're interested in him and then he'll be all over me, asking about you. My team is not your personal dating app," he says, holding out his hand in a circle. My eyes roam, following his hand when I see those green-brown eyes looking my way again. The breath hitches in my chest, but I quickly look away from Zane and pretend I'm really into this conversation with Woods when not ten seconds ago, I was. I mean, I wasn't really buying the shit he was saying, but it did make me laugh that he made so much of an effort.

"Tori," he says my name and I wait for my body to react to it the way it did when Zane said my name. I'm waiting and waiting and waiting and nothing. Not a fucking thing is happening. "I look forward to seeing you

again sometime soon.” I roll my lips when he looks directly at Jaxon as he says it. “When this Neanderthal isn’t around.”

“You don’t even know what that word means.” Jaxon laughs. “Now go away.” He grabs my hand and turns, dragging me with him. I hold up my other hand, waving at Woods, who just shakes his head and laughs at him before he turns and walks away.

“Why are you dragging me?” I rip my hand from his. “I wasn’t going to do anything with him.”

“Well, I was making sure,” Jaxon mumbles, getting to the table where Ariella is sitting with Lexi and Kylie. “I told you that she would be trouble,” he grumbles, pulling out the empty chair beside Ariella.

“What trouble? I accidentally bumped into him,” I tell Jaxon and take the seat beside him, where I have a side view of the bar and where Zane is. “I was being polite.”

“With who?” Ariella asks, her eyes going big.

“Woods,” Jaxon snaps and she does a weird face.

“He’s so nice, but such a whore.” I roll my eyes when she says that. “He’s literally making sure he gets it all out of his system before he meets the one.” She holds up her hands when I’m about to say something. “That is literally what he told me to my face.” She points to herself.

“Well, I wish him well in his endeavors,” I deadpan and then reach for one of the bottles of water that are in the middle of the table. “Jaxon, I’m not interested in dating anyone you work with.” I unscrew the cap of the bottle while my head yells *liar*. I mean, technically, I don’t think they actually work with each other. “It’s like I’m on vacation and just checking out the view.” Ariella closes her eyes and tries not to laugh, and so do Lexi and Kylie, who just nod.

“Except you aren’t on vacation and the view is not as good without a good margarita in your hand,” Kylie advises and then smiles big when she looks over at the door, seeing Knox come in, followed by Kirby.

“Everything is always better on vacation,” Lexi states, “until reality hits you.”

“I don’t even know what we are talking about right now,” I admit, holding up my hands. “I bumped into a guy, I said sorry, and then this one went all *Kung Fu Panda* on the poor guy.” I look at Jaxon, who rolls his eyes at my description of him. “I would like to get my footing under me in LA before I start to date.” I swallow down and push away from the table. “Now, if it’s okay with you,” I glare at Jaxon, “I’m going to go to the bathroom.” Ariella bites her lower lip, trying not to laugh. “Is that okay? Should you escort me there also?”

“Don’t have to,” he says, crossing his hands in front of him. “Woods now knows you are my sister, and he’ll pass along the message.” He grabs his own water bottle from the middle of the table. “My work here is done.”

“How am I supposed to be living my best life if you are there with a fire hose?” I cock my hip to the side.

“Who has a hose?” Kirby asks, pulling up an empty chair and sitting next to Lexi. He leans over and kisses her neck.

“Woods was coming onto my sister,” Jaxon explains, and I shake my head.

“He was, in fact, not coming onto me.” I then look at Knox, who pulls out the chair beside me, and then moves it closer to Kylie. “How did you feel when you found out Knox was dating your sister?” I look at Kirby.

“He isn’t Woods, so I don’t think we are comparing apples to apples here,” Kirby reasons, putting his hands on the arms of the chair. “If he was, I would kick his ass.”

“I would take that ass-kicking,” Knox declares, “every day of the week and twice on Sunday if it ends with me going home with Kylie.”

“Well, this is fun,” I say sarcastically. “I’ll be back. I’m going to go off and elope with Woods.” I put my hand on my heart. “Sorry you can’t be there.” I laugh as I walk to the back of the restaurant and spot the

bathrooms, with a door that leads to an exit. I shake my head and exhale before pushing out of the door and stepping out into the cool air. The metal door slams behind me. I look up at the sky then look around to see that there is a gate that lets me out, I think, to the parking lot. I'm walking to it when the door opens and Zane steps out.

"Victoria," he says my name.

"Don't let the door close," I warn and he turns around to stop the door from slamming shut, but he doesn't catch it in time.

"What the hell are you doing out here?" He stares at me as I walk back to the door.

"I needed some air," I tell him, "and thought this would be a good idea and it was, at the time." I fold my arms over my chest. "Now it's not such a great idea," I mumble as he looks down at me. "Don't look at me like that." His eyebrows shoot up.

"Like what?" he asks as he turns me until my back is against the outside brick wall.

"Yeah, like that," I say when he steps into my space. I can't even say what I want to say because all words have evaporated from my mouth.

His scent rushes all over me, the musk from his cologne—or maybe it's his body wash—brings back memories of me pinned under him, my limbs wrapped around him, no space between us. "You shouldn't be out here by yourself, Victoria." His hand grips my hip. "I shouldn't be out here."

"We'll agree on that one." I look up at him as his eyes stare into mine. "Zane," I say his name in a whisper and my hands go up to touch his chest.

"Don't say my name like that, Victoria." His teeth are clenched as he says it.

"Like what?" I ask him, and that is the last thing I say because his lips are on mine. My mouth opens for his tongue. His hand on my hip moves up to my side, and he picks me up, my legs wrapping around him as my arms encircle his neck. My hand now cups the top of his head, anchoring him to

me, as his tongue slides into my mouth and my back arches into him. The kiss is just how I remembered it was but, no that's not right; it's fucking better than I remembered. He pushes my back into the wall as he kisses the ever-loving shit out of me. His beard stings my lips, but it just makes me want to kiss him longer.

"Fuck," he growls after a couple of minutes, pulling away from me, but I bring his lips back to mine, making sure the kiss lasts longer. My tongue slides back into his mouth, dancing with his. I want to rip his clothes off him right here in this alley. I want him to rip my clothes off me, and then I want him to fuck me against this wall. Both of us are lost in the kiss until we hear voices and a car alarm. The sounds make him rip his lips away from mine. We both look to the side where the gate is, as he moves to put his back toward the gate and shield me from anyone's view.

"We can't do this," he states, holding my sides as my legs unwrap from his waist and he sets me down on my feet. My hands grip the lapels of his jacket until I feel like my knees won't give out on me. "We shouldn't have done that."

I put my hand on the side of my lips, still feeling his kiss lingering on me. "Why not?" I ask him, my stomach getting tight.

"For a whole fucking bunch of reasons." He steps away from me and runs his hands into his hair, moving it to the side.

"Okay," I fold my arms over my chest, "name one."

"Okay." He puts his hands on his hips, and it just makes the buttons of his shirt look like they are holding on by a thread, getting ready to pop off. "Our age."

"Hard pass, next." I shake my head. "We did things that night and your age wasn't a factor in it. Unless you took a pill to do all those things to me."

His eyes go into slits. "You fucking know I didn't," he hisses. "I'm not talking about my age. I'm talking about your age and me being old enough—"

“If you say my father, I’m going to vomit on your shoes.” I hold up my hand to stop him from saying another fucking word.

“How old are you?” he asks me and I look up at him, into his eyes.

“One hundred.” I don’t skip a beat. “Does that make you feel better?”

“Victoria,” he hisses out my name and unlike when anyone else says my name, with him, it sends warmth through my body, regardless of the tone of this conversation.

I step into him, my hands moving up his chest and resting on his pecs. “Yes?” I whisper.

“We can’t do this,” he repeats and takes a step back, my hands falling from his chest. “I’m sorry.”

“Me too,” I tell him, my heart sinking as I nod at him, “more than you will ever know.” I look down once more and then I walk toward the gate that leads to the parking lot. I don’t bother looking over at him to see if he’s looking at me, because I can feel his eyes on me.

I walk around the building and I’m about to head back into the restaurant when I see a cab driving down the street. I hold up my hand and the driver pulls over at the curb. I get in and give him my address before I pull out my phone, texting Jaxon and Ariella.

ME:

Feeling a bit queasy, just got into a cab. Sorry for leaving.

Ariella answers me right away, no doubt she has her phone right next to her, in case her parents text her about Jagger.

ARIELLA:

Oh no, hope you feel better. Text me when you get home.

I look out the window and into the darkness of the night as the car zigzags its way through the Saturday night traffic. I take out my credit card, tapping it on the reader, before I step out and head to the front door.

ME:

I'm home.

I send out the text and step into the house, thinking to myself that for the third time, he's let me walk away from him.

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eight

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Zane

“ZANE,” SHE GROANED MY NAME AS SHE SLID DOWN MY COCK, MY HANDS AT her waist as I helped her ride me. My back was to the headboard, her hands on my shoulders. “It’s so good.” If only she fucking knew how good it actually was.

“Show me,” I egged her on. “Show me how much you love my cock in your pussy.” Her back arched as she used her knees to help her move up and down. Her head fell back. The ends of her hair swished over my thighs. She moved one hand from my shoulder to the back of my head and then put the other one on my knee. “That’s it,” I said, looking between us, seeing her move up to the tip and then slide back down. “You’re taking me so well.” One of my hands moved to her clit as I used my thumb to rub it in circles, her pussy tightening on my cock. I leaned forward and took one of her nipples into my mouth and she slammed down on me. “You like that, baby?”

“I like anything you have to give me,” she said breathlessly, my eyes staring into hers. “I’ll take whatever you want to give me.”

My eyes flutter open and I look over to the side, seeing that my bed is empty and I’m all by myself. My heart hammers in my chest, wishing she was fucking here. Knowing if things were different, I would have taken her

home with me last night. And that isn't something I ever do. It's been five months since I last had her and every single day feels longer than the last.

I toss the covers off me and get out of the bed, my cock as hard as granite as I walk to the bathroom and start the shower. I step in and let the cold water hit me until it warms up. I hold up one hand, putting it on the shower wall as I think about kissing her last night. My other goes to my cock as I think about the last time I had her in the small fucking shower in the hotel room. Fucking her into the wall as she took my cock and begged me to fuck her harder. I close my eyes, picturing her fucking perfect face. Everything about her is perfect from her eyes to her lips to her fucking body; everything. I grip my cock tighter as I moan out her name and come on the shower floor. I hang my head, letting my cock go and holding up myself up against the wall.

Last night, I couldn't take my eyes off her, even knowing I shouldn't be fucking looking over at her table every two seconds, but my eyes and my head were not on the same page. I saw her get up and I was suddenly making my way toward the back. I kept telling myself I was doing it to make sure no one bothered her. I heard the door slam shut when I turned the corner. I thought someone had dragged her out there. By the time I could stop myself, I already had her pinned against the brick wall with my mouth on hers in the exact way I'd been trying to fight all night long.

I spend the rest of the day surfing to forget about her, which doesn't work. When I wake up the next morning, it's again from another dream about her. Waking up to the reality where I know I can't have her, I decide to get dressed and get to work before everyone else so I can hit the gym.

I spend time on the bike and then run on the treadmill for about an hour before I hear some of the guys coming in. Needing to make a protein shake to get through the day, I turn off the treadmill, and say hello to a couple of people before my meetings officially start. Eric is the first one in. "Hey, Coach," he greets as soon as I turn on the blender.

“Hey. Been thinking,” I tell him, “I’m going to do some one-on-one meetings with some of the team today.”

His eyebrows shoot up. “Something wrong?”

“No.” I shake my head. “I just want to touch base with them, see what they have to say about how the season has started. I think it’s important that everyone is on the same page, to show them I’m invested in them and their wellbeing.”

“You want to do this with Cam and me or just yourself?”

“You think Cam is going to want to sit in with some of the guys if they have complaints about anything?” I ask him, putting a straw in my shake.

“Good point.” He leans against the counter and crosses his feet and his arms.

“I want to have an open-door policy. Which isn’t normal, I know. You are just opening yourself up to all the shit and playing babysitter. But I want them to know they can come to me. To know I have their backs.”

“I think that’s a good thing to have. They don’t really know you or me at this point, so it’s going to be difficult for them to come to us with an issue. This is just you giving them access to you.” I nod at him, knowing he would be the one to get it. “I’m going to hit the gym before we take the ice.”

I walk out of the kitchen and head to the locker room, seeing a couple of the rookies in there shooting the shit. “Hey.” I stick my head in. “One of you come with me.” They all share a look with each other, like they are in trouble. “Relax,” I snap, “I’m meeting with everyone one-on-one so you might as well get it over with.”

I turn and head back to my office, not sure which one is going to come into my office first, but I’m not surprised when it’s Owen. He’s been the leader of the rookies this year, on and off the ice, and when he comes into my office, I bark out, “Close the door.”

“You said I wasn’t in trouble,” he groans and then I laugh.

“You aren’t, but I also want this to be a private conversation,” I tell him, pulling out my chair. “You want something to drink?” I ask him, motioning my head toward the fridge.

“You have beer in there?” he asks me and the look I shoot him is more of a “watch it” look than a glare, and he holds up his hands. “I was joking.”

“Me too,” I assure him, sitting down in my chair. “Listen, I’m going to be talking to everyone. Making sure everyone is on the same page as I am and checking in.” He sits down in the chair in front of me, putting his ankle on his knee. “I know that I’m new in this role, and I don’t have much time under my belt as someone who played in the NHL.” I chuckle, folding my hands together. “I was on the ice for one year and then knew I was better behind the bench.” His eyebrows shoot up at that confession. “Just want you to know I’m here for you if you need anything.” He nods his head. “And if at any time during the season you want to talk to me about anything or anyone, my door is open. My main focus apart from winning is making sure that you guys are in the right headspace for dealing with all the things that come with being a professional athlete. Lots of coaches don’t worry about the mental health of players, but I’m not one of them. Will I get pissed off at some point in this season? You bet your ass I will, but if at any time you think you can’t handle something, I want you to come to me and we’ll get you the help that you need.”

“Thanks, Coach.” He nods his head.

“Now, that’s not to say I’m going to be the fucking teacher if things don’t go your way on the ice. I’m not a babysitter either.” He laughs at that. “So I’m not going to sit down with you if you and your friends are not sharing your toy.”

“Got it,” he states, getting up. “It’s pretty cool that you’re doing this. Not many coaches give a shit about what their players are going through.”

“Thanks, Owen,” I tell him. “Send in Kaiden, but pretend I chewed your ass out so he’s scared,” I joke with him and he laughs as he walks out of my

office. I meet with about ten players by the time it's lunch.

I walk out and head to the kitchen to eat before I join a couple of the guys on the ice. I step foot into the room and then grab a plate, filling it with chicken and then pasta before looking over to see Jaxon, Kirby, and Knox sitting at a table. "This taken?" I ask of the empty chair, and they all shake their heads. I pull out the chair, sitting down. "What's going on?"

"What's going on with you?" Knox asks me and I look at him.

"Nothing, why?"

"Heard you are having a one-on-one with everyone," Jaxon mentions, taking a bite of his food. "We were just insulted that we weren't any of them."

"You guys are the next round," I inform him. "I hit the young kids first."

"Wow," Knox says, "are you saying we aren't the young kids?"

"That's one-thousand percent what I'm saying," I look at the three of them. "You three have to lead on the ice and in that room. I don't even know if the open-door policy thing is going to work. They might just talk shit behind my back. But I want them to feel like I have their back."

"They are one-thousand percent talking behind your back," Jaxon shocks me by saying, "but it's better than them not talking about you at all."

"That is not better," Knox states. "Who told you that?"

"Tori," Jaxon replies, and even the mention of her name has my ears perking up. "She said when someone talks about you, it means you are living rent-free in their head and you are their Roman Empire." He holds up his hand. "I don't even know what that means, but I think it's good."

Kirby shakes his head. "I can see it," he says. "Speaking of her, I have to swing by her place after work to take care of a couple of things she wants done. She's in the house you almost took over," he informs me, and I did think of staying there when I had to look for emergency housing. It was right on the beach, exactly like I like it, but it just wasn't for me.

“Why the fuck are you going to her house?” I blurt and all three sets of eyes come back to me. “Aren’t you taken, and isn’t that your sister?”

“Thanks for having my back,” Jaxon says, laughing, “but it’s probably because she’s living in Lexi’s old house.”

“Like I would cheat on my wife.” Kirby glares at me.

“That came out—” I try to think of words to not make it sound like I’m a fucking lunatic and just accused him of cheating on his wife. “I was just shocked.”

Jaxon slaps my shoulder. “I thought you were going to deck him.” He squeezes my shoulder.

“I didn’t mean anything, it was just—” I hold up my hands and Kirby just glares at me and leans back in the chair. “I guess you guys are going to talk about me when I leave now.”

“Most definitely,” Knox assures me, trying not to laugh, “and it’s not going to be good.” I can’t help but laugh at him and then Jaxon and Kirby join in.

“Okay, well, I guess I’ll leave you guys to it.” I grab my plate. “But seriously, when you have a minute, I’d like you guys to come to my office. I don’t want them to think I’m playing favorites.”

“Coach,” Jaxon declares, “everyone knows I’m your favorite.”

“I can tell you I’m not his favorite,” Kirby assures him, “but it’s okay, he’s not mine either.” I can’t help but snort when he says that.

“I said I was sorry,” I tell him, and he just nods his head as he side-eyes me, Jaxon and Knox snicker at him.

I head back to my office and see Cam coming down the hallway, looking at me and I can tell right away he’s not happy. Eric comes out of his office at the exact moment and catches Cam, stopping in front of me. “What the fuck are you doing?” he hisses at me as I move the conversation to my office so there is no gossip about us clashing.

“I don’t know what you are talking about,” I reply, and Eric follows him into my office and closes the door.

“You had meetings with all the rookies,” he says, putting his hands on his hips, “without me there.”

“I did it without Eric either.” I motion my chin to Eric, who is leaning against the door behind me. “I just wanted them to know my door was always open for them.”

“Well, I should have been aware of the conversation before it happened and not after the fact. I looked like a fucking idiot when I didn’t know what they were talking about.”

“You aren’t always going to know what I’m going to do,” I tell him, sitting down on the front of my desk. “I wanted it to be me and them. It had nothing to do with anything about you or coaching.”

“I think it was a dumb thing to do, and if you would have told me I would have talked you out of it.” He shakes his head. “No one cares if everyone gets along,” he mutters. “It’s a fucking joke.” He turns to walk out, and Eric moves out of the way.

“Cam,” I call his name and he looks over his shoulder, his hand on the handle. “You go out and say what you just said to my face, we’re going to have problems,” I warn him.

“We already have problems,” he responds, “and it has nothing to do with me.” He storms out.

“On a scale of one to ten,” I look at Eric, “how pissed do you think he is?”

“Zane,” Eric says my name, trying not to laugh. “The minute they named you coach instead of him, he was a one hundred on the scale.”

“I guess I’m his Roman Empire,” I tell him and he just looks at me confused. “Something I heard.” I think back to Victoria. “It’s what the kids are saying.”

“Good to know.” He turns, walking out of my office.

I take a huge exhale before I walk back out and head to the ice, the whole time plans are being made against me and I had no idea.

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Victoria

THE PHONE RINGS FROM THE COUNTER AS SOON AS I POUR THE MILK IN MY cup of coffee. Walking over to it, I see it's Ariella FaceTiming me.

I slide my finger across the screen as I walk out of the kitchen and then head outside to sit on the deck. The little white circle spins around and around as the phone connects and then I see Jagger's face. "Well, hello there, handsome man." He smiles big. "How we doing on this sunny Sunday?" He babbles. "Really?" I ask him, as if he just said something. "How is your dad doing after losing his hockey game yesterday?"

"Daddadadad," Jagger jabbles, a dollop of drool falling out of his mouth.

"Yeah, I guess he's not in a good mood, right?"

"I'm fine." I hear Jaxon speak from not too far away from him.

"He doesn't sound fine," I tell Jagger, taking a sip of my coffee. "He sounds like he's the opposite of fine. Sometimes they say they're fine and they aren't, and they want you to make a big deal about it," I explain to Jagger. "Don't fall into that trap."

"Bgabdodubabo," he replies and I nod my head.

"Exactly," I tell him, smiling at the screen. "Who is your favorite auntie?" I ask him.

“Lexi,” Jaxon interrupts and Jagger’s eyes light up as he drops the phone to the floor and I see his little feet running, probably to the door. “No, buddy, she isn’t here.”

“But your Aunt TT is here!” I shout at the phone, now being picked up by Ariella as she laughs at me. “Such a traitor,” I mumble.

“He’s the worst,” she agrees with me, “but he’s cute so we shall keep him.”

“He does have that going for him.” I take another sip of my coffee. “To what do I owe the pleasure of this lovely early morning phone call?” I ask her and she laughs.

“Your brother is leaving tomorrow,” she says with a sad face as she looks over at him, coming back into the room with Jagger on his shoulders.

“I’ll miss him,” I reply sarcastically, “so, so much.”

“We’re going to do a Sunday late lunch early dinner sort of thing today,” she shares.

“Keep talking,” I urge her and she laughs, “I like where this is going.”

“Can you pick up some dessert?” she asks and I chuckle.

“Dessert for lunch slash dinner. Sold.” I point to her. “What time do you want me to show up?”

“You can come now.”

“You can’t come now,” Jaxon reneges. “I’m putting this guy down for a nap and then I’m taking my woman to bed.”

“Sorry, you’ll have to excuse me, my ears are bleeding.” I grimace. “I’ll be by later and I’ll only come in after you tell me that you both showered.”

They both laugh. “I mean, we could shower and kill two birds with one stone.” Jaxon winks at Ariella.

“And now I have no eardrums,” I retort. “Bye, Jagger, your parents are disgusting.” I hang up the phone and look out at the ocean. Seeing the water crash onto the shore, the roaring makes it so relaxing, and my mind is brought back again to Zane. It’s like all fucking roads lead back to him, and

I'm pissed about it. Last night I avoided going to the bar after the game because I was afraid to come face-to-face with him. Which made me even angrier because I wanted to see him. "I need to forget about him," I tell myself. "He clearly has forgotten about me."

I finish my coffee, trying not to think about the fact that our night must have not meant anything to him, while I'm over here thinking about him at least once a day, usually in the morning when I wake up or at night before bed. If that one night wasn't enough for me to fixate on, him pushing me against the wall at the restaurant was another memory that is now seared into my brain. Everything with him is on a different level. The way he touches me, the way he kisses, the way I just want more of him is something I've never felt before.

My first boyfriend was during my senior year in high school. We dated for a year before I gave him my virginity. I thought he would be the one. I mean, doesn't everyone think the person she gives her virginity to is going to be the one? He was, in fact, not the one. I found out the motherfucker was cheating on me with five different girls from different schools. He had even gone as far as going into my phone sometimes and blocking the girls, just in case they messaged me. I thought about pouring sugar in his gas tank but instead, I did better. I dated his best friend and roommate and even walked into the kitchen one Sunday morning wearing his shirt. It was delightful. At least for me.

After him I had a string of boyfriends, but no one stuck. It was like there was always that one thing missing, but I couldn't exactly put my finger on it. I wanted someone who made me laugh at the same time he drove me crazy. I wanted someone who I could make lose control and pin me to a brick wall to kiss the ever-loving shit out of me. That is what I wanted, and I guess I found it, but now I need to find someone who would do that with me and not think it was a bad idea.

I spend the day cleaning up the house and putting away my laundry before I get dressed in a pair of blue jeans and a T-shirt, then heading out to the bakery Lexi showed me that has the best cinnamon buns I've ever tasted in my life. I get a box of six and then head over to Jaxon and Ariella's. I pull up in the driveway and walk up the steps to the front door, ringing the doorbell before walking in. "Honey, I'm home!" I call out and then hear small feet hitting the floor. I put the box on a hall table and squat down when Jagger comes into view. "There he is, the love of my life." I hold out my arms and he runs into them as I sweep him up and turn him around. "The most handsome boy ever." I blow kisses in his neck, and he laughs. "How is my favorite nephew?" I ask him and he just grunts out a couple of nonsense words. "Are you happy your Auntie TT came to visit you?"

"TT," he says and I swear, I about jump up and down.

I gasp. "What did you say?" I ask him. "Did you say TT?" I look over at Ariella and then at Jaxon, who rolls his eyes.

"Great," he grumbles. "Now she's going to be all 'I'm his favorite.'"

"Well, I'm not saying I'm his favorite, but who is your favorite?" I ask again.

"TT," he says.

"He's the smartest boy in the whole wide world," I tell them. "This kid is Einstein."

"Five months ago you didn't think so," Jaxon reminds me as I walk into the house and he squirms out of my arms, "and now he's a genius."

"I said what I said." I shrug. "What are we eating? I'm starving."

"We got tacos," Jaxon answers and I clap my hands.

"Chips and guacamole." I walk over to the counter, seeing the appetizer and reaching for a chip. "Yes, please." I dunk the chip in the guacamole before tossing it in my mouth. I make a plate of tacos before walking over to the table and we have dinner.

“I’m not looking forward to this road trip,” Jaxon says, leaning back in his chair. “It’s going to be brutal.” He closes his eyes. “All I know is we better win at least one out of the two, or else Zane is going to lose it.” The minute he says his name, it’s like my body is brought to life. “He’s a great fucking coach, but we’re starting to see a divide in the team.”

“How so?” I ask and, for the first time in my life, I’m interested.

“Some players don’t like his coaching style, so it’s going to be interesting to see how it plays out.” I don’t ask him any more questions because he’ll probably be wondering why I suddenly care, but I’m immediately curious and want to know if Zane’s alright. When it’s time to head home, I kiss Jaxon goodbye before hugging Jagger, right before he goes upstairs to bed.

I go home and undress as I get ready for the week ahead of me. I put on my face mask, grab my phone, and pull up Zane’s number. I know I shouldn’t call him, and I know I should leave it, but I can’t. Something in me is pulling me to him. The phone rings three times before he answers it, and by that time I’m wondering if he’s with someone. “Hello.” His voice fills my ears, and I don’t say anything as I close my eyes. “Hello.”

“Hey,” I say, swallowing the big lump in my throat, “whatcha doing?”

“Watching television,” he replies as I climb into my bed and sit in the middle. “You?”

“Nothing, I was here in my bed, and I was thinking about you,” I confess, and I can feel the tension through the phone when he says just my name.

“Victoria.” His voice is tight as he groans out my name, and I bite my lower lip, laughing.

“Yes, Zane,” I say and I wish he was here with me. “I was thinking.”

“Oh dear,” he mumbles and I can’t help the giggle that bursts out of me.

“Do you think—” I start. “Would you maybe—” I rephrase it and, for the first time in my life, I’m fucking nervous over a guy. “Perhaps want to

do it again?" I wait a split second before I add, "Maybe one more time?" Maybe a couple more times is what I really want to say.

"We shouldn't." If I thought his voice was tight before, it's nothing like it is now.

"Or maybe..." I wrap my arms around my legs, "we should and then we forget it." He doesn't say anything. "Why don't you think about it?" I swallow down and the heat suddenly fills the back of my head. "Think about me naked," I push, and I can hear his breathing start to pick up, "sitting on your face." My voice goes lower. "Or maybe blowing you." I close my eyes as I picture him naked in front of me; his perfect body like it was sculpted out of clay and then made into stone. "You seemed to like when I had your cock in my mouth."

"Victoria," he snaps out and I wait for him to say no, wait for him to tell me it's never going to happen again, "we said it was a one-time thing."

"I know what we said." I smile. "I remember saying it, but I'm just saying that since we've already done it once, there might be no harm in doing it a second time." He groans. "Okay, hear me out," I start. "Say you are going to have sex with someone and both of you decide it's going to be for that one night." I stop. "Are you listening?"

"I'm listening," he confirms, and I can see the smile on his face now.

"The two of you decide that you are going to have sex and then you have sex after midnight. It's okay for you to go until the following day, since you already went past the time you said you were going to do it. You get it?" He chuckles and my heart skips a beat. I thought I loved hearing him say my name. I know I loved hearing him moan my name, but him chuckling and laughing is a whole different ball game. "I mean, no one really has to know. It can be our little secret."

"Victoria," he says my name softer this time.

"I mean, not little," I keep talking, "we shouldn't say little when it comes to you. You are very well-endowed."

I try not to laugh when he hisses out my name, “Victoria.”

“I just keep thinking about our night together,” I admit. “Do you think about it too?” I also want to ask him if he’s had someone else after me. Obviously he has, and just the thought makes me sick to my stomach, and I push it away. “Do you?” I ask him softly.

“Yes,” he answers reluctantly.

“Often?” I hold my breath.

“More than I should.”

“You are such a buzzkill,” I groan out my own frustration at his answer.

“You are a temptation I don’t think I could stay away from.” The moment he says the words, my stomach flutters.

“Then stop staying away from me and give into the temptation, Zane.” I inhale deep. “Ball’s in your court.” I close my eyes. “I, for one, would like the balls to be hitting my chin,” I say with a moan. He doesn’t say anything, so I do what I should have done from the beginning, I close my eyes and end it. “Have a nice night, Zane.”

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Zane

ME:

Meet me in Cam's office.

I SEND ERIC THE TEXT AFTER GETTING THE EMAIL I'VE BEEN WAITING FOR. I push away from my desk and head over to Cam's office, which is supposed to be right next to mine, but he decided to take the office at the complete opposite end of the hall from me. I pass the locker room that is starting to fill up since we start practice in about half an hour. I get there and see the door to Cam's office wide open. He's sitting down behind his desk with five players, and they look like they are having a meeting. No one even looks my way before I knock on the door and see them turn to look at me, Owen's face goes white when he sees me. "Coach," he says my name.

"Hey, am I interrupting anything?" I take a step in and the guys get up nervously, shaking their heads and moving out of the room. "What was that all about?" I ask Cam, getting an uneasy feeling in my gut.

"Going over defensive plays," he replies, leaning back in his chair. "What's up?"

"Hey," Eric says, coming into the office and standing beside me, "just got your text."

"Yeah." I look back at him. "I know we are having practice today," I tell them, "but I have something planned with the guys." I look over at Cam.

“The bus gets here in thirty minutes.”

“The bus?” Cam asks me and I smile.

“The bus,” I repeat. “I’ve decided to take the boys out to do some bonding.”

“Bonding?” Cam repeats like I didn’t just say the word.

“Yeah, I think the team needs to be more in sync.” I look at Eric, who nods. “They aren’t trusting each other on the ice, and it’s starting to show.” I look over at Cam to see if he’s going to repeat these words too, but he just leans back in his chair and rocks back and forth. “So I got a hold of a place where they do team-building exercises.”

“I’m not going to that,” Cam declares without waiting for me to tell him what it is.

“Why the fuck not?” Eric snaps out, looking at Cam.

“I just don’t think it’s a necessary activity,” he says. “I’ll make up an excuse that I have an appointment or something.” He shrugs.

“You think that’s a good idea?” I ask him and he nods his head.

“I’m skipping it.” He sits back up, crossing his hands on the desk. “I’ll hold down the fort here and work on the power play and power kill plays.”

“Sounds good,” I reply, turning to Eric. “Looks like it’s me and you.” I slap his shoulder and squeeze it, telling him it’s not worth it. He nods his head, avoiding looking back at Cam before we walk out of the office.

“That guy is a piece of—” I cut him off before he says something and someone reports it.

“To be honest, this wasn’t for him, or for us, it’s for them.” I point toward the locker room. “We have a game on Saturday, and we have to win it.” He just nods at me as we walk into the locker room.

“Guys,” I call out, my voice booms as everyone stops talking. “I know we are supposed to be on the ice in about an hour, but the bus is going to be here in twenty minutes,” I tell them and I see they are all sharing a look. “It’s nothing bad. So get to the kitchen and get some grub before we leave.”

Twenty minutes later, I'm the last one on the bus and I look over to Eric, who is sitting in the back with some of the rookies. I give him a chin lift as I sit in the front next to Jaxon, who is turned in his seat talking to Kirby and Knox. "So we have to know," he says to me, "where are you taking us?"

"Disney," I side-eye him, smirking, "the most magical place on earth."

"I've been and it's, in fact, not magical. It's where parents go to die," Knox states as I look out the window. "You think it's magical until it's past a naptime and your kid has a mental breakdown in the middle of the fucking sidewalk because she can't get a Mickey Mouse ice cream," he groans. "I refuse to take the kids back until they are old enough to not have a meltdown."

"So, never," Kirby jokes with him. "I'll take them."

"I will have them packed and ready to go," Knox agrees, and I laugh. When we pull into the building, I get up from my seat.

"I know you guys are probably wondering where we are." I look at everyone. "I thought that instead of on-ice practice, we could do some team-building exercises." I clap my hands and the door to the bus opens. "Let's go, people."

We get off the bus and walk into the building where two men are there waiting for us. "Welcome." They look at us and wait for the team to get in the front door before talking. Eric comes and stands next to me. "We're excited for you guys to start." He looks at the guys. "Let's go to the first activity."

I follow him into the first room, which is set up with aluminum plates all scattered around four separate workspaces. "Okay, I want you guys divided into the lines," I tell the guys as everyone gets in their respective lines.

"This is where you are going to see if you trust your team," the associate says. "I want all the guys to put on a pair of goggles." The other guy holds out a basket as he passes them to each player. "And the guy in

charge is going to guide you through the pathway. If you step on the plates, you have to start back at the beginning.”

The guys all line up, the first line has Jaxon leading them. The second line has Owen leading them. I stand back and watch as Jaxon starts and they all line up. His team holds each other’s shoulders while the other team puts the players on their shoulders. “That’s interesting,” I say as they work their way through the playing field. Lots of laughter fills the room and lots of frustration when it takes one line over thirty-five minutes to make it through. Owen’s team is the second to last place and they hate it. Each of them points the finger to the next person.

The next activity has each team putting their feet on two planks of wood with ropes being tied to them. Each player holds the rope in each hand. “The team that gets over the finish line first wins,” he tells the group of guys. “Easiest drill.”

Jaxon’s team has him in the front. Owen’s team has him in the front, the two of them are side by side. The whistle blows and Owen shouts out for his team to go right first, which is fine because they all lift their right foot but don’t really go ahead, while Jaxon leads his team with instructions to lift the foot and move forward. They easily get to the front first with Owen behind him, and he’s pissed to be behind Jaxon.

“See the cracks in the foundation?” Eric leans over and whispers to me and I nod my head.

“A couple of them I do,” I confirm, watching Owen and the guys I found in the office with Cam stand to the side and talk amongst themselves.

By the time we get back on the bus, half the team is laughing while the other half of the team is unsure. “Might be time to rework some of those lines,” I tell Eric when we get back to the arena.

The next day I show up early, and the press is there already setting up. “Hey, Coach,” a couple of them say as I walk to my office then to the other room where the whiteboard is.

“Hey.” Cam walks into the room. “What are you doing?” he asks as I look at the board.

“Going to switch up the lines,” I reply, and he looks at the board with me.

“You think that is a wise decision?” he retorts and I look over at him.

“If you had come with us yesterday, you wouldn’t ask that question.”

“From what I heard, it was dumb and half the guys hated it.” He puts his hands in his pockets.

“Yeah, and who told you that?”

He shrugs. “Couple different people.”

“Well, you let those people know they should come to me if they have a problem, instead of adding fuel to the fire.” I turn back to the board.

He doesn’t say a word as he turns to walk back out of the office, and Eric comes in followed by Jaxon. “What’s up, Coach?” Jaxon asks when I start to erase names from different lines and switch them around.

“I’m playing with some lines,” I tell him and he looks at what I did. “Going to change just one player this game from each line and see how that goes, might change it back before the end of the game... depending.”

“Sounds good,” he says to me. “You going with us after the game?” I glare at him.

The last thing I want to do is go to the bar after the game. “It’s bonding too,” he reasons and I roll my eyes when Eric snickers.

“I don’t know why you are laughing,” I tell him, “you’re coming with.”

“Great,” he replies, “I’ll go and tell my wife.” He turns and walks out of the room with the phone in his hand.

I walk out of the room with Jaxon as Kirby and Knox get there together. “You guys carpooling again?”

“Yeah, the girls are going to be our rides home,” Knox says. “You going to be okay?” he asks Jaxon, and I look over at him, knowing I missed something.

“I don’t like it,” Jaxon declares and then looks at me. “My sister, Tori, she invited this guy to the game on Saturday.” He says her name and just like every fucking time before, my body goes on alert. It’s been almost a week since she called me. A week where every single night, I’ve looked at her number and told myself to call her. A week where I’ve thought about nothing but her when I wasn’t thinking of the game. Where I ate each meal alone, something that has never bothered me before, but now suddenly bothers me, and I don’t know if it’s because I’m thinking about having her sit with me at the end of the day. “Apparently, she met someone at a coffee shop, and he asked her out on a date.” I swallow and all I can hear is the thumping of my heart in my ears. “So she asked me for an extra ticket.”

“If she’s dating this guy,” Kirby says, “the best thing to do was to give her a ticket so you can meet him after.”

“Or you don’t and she goes out with him and you never meet him so you can’t threaten him,” Knox adds. “Either way, you have to get her a ticket.”

I look down, a rage filling my veins, and I don’t know why since this is what I wanted to begin with. “Don’t you guys need to get ready?” I snap, not sure I want to hear the rest of why it’s a good idea for her to date this guy, already fucking hating him, and I don’t even know him.

The whole game I am in a mood. The lines that I’ve changed have half-worked and half-not, and when we come out with a win by the skin of our teeth, I’m ready for the whole fucking night to be over.

I walk into the press room after the game and sit down. “Hey, Coach.” I look over to see the veteran reporter, Timothy, who has been covering the team for the past ten years, I think. “There have been whispers of personality clashes amongst the players,” he says, and I just look at him, making sure I give away nothing. “Is that why you switched up your lines tonight?”

“I like the idea that I have a team and everyone can play with everyone as a team,” I tell him. “Things happen during the year—injuries, power play, penalty kills—it’s a good time to see who works well with whom, so mixing it up is always beneficial.” I don’t even bother commenting on the first part of the question, and he must sense I’m in no mood tonight. “We have a good team. They have to trust each other.” He just nods at me. I take a couple other questions and when I walk out, Eric is there with Jaxon. “What the fuck are you doing?”

“Making sure you don’t bail on us,” Eric admits. “It’s easy to slip out.” I roll my eyes, pulling down the knot of my tie, and then tuck it in my pocket as I walk out of the arena and head to my SUV. “Shotgun.” I look over at him. “What? My kids always say that when they want to ride in the front seat.”

I shake my head as I make my way back to the same restaurant they always rent out after the game. I get out and head in. Looking around I tell myself I’m not looking for Victoria, when I see her sitting down with a man beside her, who has to be her date. Eric goes right and I know I should follow him, but instead I follow Jaxon to his table, and I see her look up and smile at Jaxon, then she looks over her shoulder at me. “Hey,” I say, pulling out the chair in front of her and right next to Knox, “nice to see you again.”

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Victoria

“THE SUITE WAS NICE. I THINK WE HAD A SIMILAR ONE WHEN WE WENT TO watch the basketball team,” Elliott says and then stops talking when he looks over and sees Jaxon coming our way.

I look over at Jaxon and I smile, seeing he’s got his ‘don’t fuck with me’ face on. I secretly want to warn Elliott, but I don’t say anything when I look over his shoulder and see him. Zane. His eyes are directly on me and my mouth goes dry. He comes to stand next to Jaxon. The light suddenly shines on him and I see his green eyes looking darker. “Hey,” he says, pulling out the chair next to Knox. “Nice to see you again.” He nods to me, and it feels like all eyes are on me.

“Um,” I say, picking up my wine glass and taking a sip before I talk, “it’s nice to see you again too.” I put the glass down. “I’m so sorry, but I forgot your name.” I make a face and look over at Jaxon. “I know he’s the coach but—” His eyes flicker and I can see his jaw get tight.

“Zane,” he supplies his name, and my nipples perk up as he extends his hand to Elliott, “I’m the Warriors’ head coach.”

Elliott reaches over and shakes his hand. “Wow, nice to meet you,” he says. “Good game tonight.”

“Thanks,” Zane’s voice is gruff, “but I wasn’t the one on the ice tonight.” He looks around at the players at the table and I see Knox move to

the side, so Jaxon grabs a chair from the other table and sits down between them.

He shakes his head. "Nice win, lucky win." I bite down on my teeth and want to tell him to just stop talking.

"A win is a win, right?" Zane's eyes don't leave him.

"This is my brother." I hold up my hand to Jaxon. "Jaxon. Jaxon, this is Elliott."

"Nice to meet you." Jaxon gives the guy a nod and then looks up at the server, who stops by the table with a tray full of drinks. "Can I get a burger," he holds up his hand, "and a salad on the side?"

"That's gross." I point to him. "You are going to eat the burger, might as well add some bacon to that and a plate of fries."

"Well, not really," Elliott says from beside me. "It's about moderation." I smile at him and turn to look at him. "He's not depriving himself of having the burger, but he's also not pushing it."

"Exactly," Jaxon agrees as I hear Zane.

"I'll take the same with bacon and fries." I try not to look at Zane, but my eyes are not in sync with my head, apparently. "So, Elliott," he looks at the guy, "what do you do?"

"I'm a lawyer," he replies and I smile a big fake smile. "Dealing with mergers and acquisitions."

"How did you two meet?" Zane asks him and I look at him, biting my tongue.

"Ran into her in the coffee shop." He looks at me and I stare into his brown eyes, waiting to feel that tug for me. And it comes up empty. Actually, the whole fucking night I've been trying to find something, anything, that excites me about him. I have to be honest, every single time I thought I felt something for him, his mouth just ruined it. Every time something happened or someone said something, he always had something to say.

“So you asked out a random stranger?” Jaxon grills him.

“Better than swiping right,” he chuckles, “if you get my drift.”

“I don’t,” Zane says, and I try not to glare at him.

“How did you like the game?” Jaxon leans back in his chair.

“It was good fun,” Elliott answers. “I’ve been to the arena often enough.” *And here we go*, I think to myself as I drain the glass of wine. “Our law office has box seats for the basketball games. We sometimes go for hockey.”

“Fun,” Zane deadpans and I think about maybe kicking him in the shin, but then I don’t even bother, because ignoring him is better than making a scene, “but you can’t compare basketball to hockey.”

“No offense,” Elliott says, and I think I hear all the girls at the table groan, because he’s been saying this fucking line all night long, “I’m more of a basketball type of guy.”

“Yeah,” Zane tosses out, “you look like it.” My mouth opens.

“You do,” Jaxon agrees next. “Hockey isn’t for everyone; you need heavy cardio for hockey.”

“I would think that isn’t the case,” Elliott disagrees.

“You would think wrong,” Zane grumbles. I hold my hands up and fold them in front of me, hiding my mouth that has my lips rolled together as I try to fight off the laugh.

“Have you ever played hockey before?” Jaxon asks him.

“I mean, how hard can it be?” Elliott quips and, I swear, I glance over and see Knox and Kirby looking like they want to say something but are biting their tongues. “It’s ice skating with a stick.”

“Yeah, it’s just ice skating with a stick,” Jaxon mimics. “You should come to one of our practices. Should be easy enough.”

“That would be dope,” he says, and I literally look the other way.

“So you said you deal with mergers and acquisitions.” Kirby tries to bring down the tone. “How do you like it?”

“It has to do a lot with contracts and negotiations,” he answers him. “Not sure how much of that you would understand.”

“I’m going to go to the bathroom,” I announce, knowing it was a dig at Kirby. Even though I want to tell him he’s an asshole, it’s much more fun watching Zane get irritated. “I’ll be back.”

I grab my purse and head to the bathroom, closing my eyes when I get inside and then hanging my head. Okay, fine, maybe accepting a date from a total stranger wasn’t the best idea I’ve had, but I was sitting down, pining for a man who didn’t even want me. It was time to get off the fucking pot and do something. This was that something. I walk over to the mirror and look into it. My hair is down and around my face, my makeup on perfectly.

Did I do my makeup thinking of Zane? Correct. Did I dress sexier than I should to go to a hockey game? Also correct. Who the fuck wears high heels to a hockey game? No one, but what is on my feet right now? Stilettos because that is the journey I am now on. My blue jeans fit tight around my hips, clinging to all the right places, and showing off my ass in the best fucking way. The black shirt is tucked in and has the sleeves rolled up to my elbows and the neckline goes off one shoulder, but you can’t tell because my hair is draped over it. Opening my purse, I pull out the lip gloss, apply it to my lips, and take a huge inhale before I close my eyes and head back out there. I shouldn’t have left Elliott alone, but I had to get away from Zane. His smell had invaded my senses, and along with him staring at me half the time even though I avoided looking in his direction, I felt his eyes on me.

I pull open the bathroom door and I take a step out and see him leaning against the wall beside the door. His feet are crossed at the ankles, his hair is pushed to the side like it always is. His beard makes my hands itch to touch it, his shirt—again open at the collar—and I want nothing more than to lick up his throat while I ride him. “Jesus.” I put my hand to my chest. “What are you doing lurking near the women’s bathroom, Zane?”

“Oh, now she knows my name,” he goads, and I can feel the tension in the hallway. It’s thick and the walls are closing in on us.

“What are you doing waiting for me in the dark hallway?” I ask as I try not to get too close to him, fearing I’m going to try to touch him and he’s going to turn me down, yet again.

“No, what are *you* doing is the question of the night,” he fires back. I fold my arms over my chest and my tits push up more.

His eyes roam down as he takes in my action. “I don’t know what you mean.” I smile at him, a fake smile just like I gave Elliott before. “Right now I’m having the best night I’ve had practically all year long.” I shrug my bare shoulder and his tongue comes out to lick his bottom lip, mine wanting to come out and touch his. “I might even end the night with Elliott and me rolling around in—”

“Victoria,” he says my name and the minute he does, my whole body starts to tingle. My stomach flutters. My heart speeds up. My nipples tighten, and a certain part of me demands to be played with.

“Yes,” I reply, pretending that him saying my name does nothing to me, “what can I do for you?” He just stares at me and his look is one where I want him to pick me up and push me against the wall, which pisses me off. “You know what, I don’t care what you have to say,” I hiss. “It’s been a week since I called you, one fucking week.” I hold up my finger and he takes a step closer to me. “And you haven’t done anything. Not a call. Not a text. Nothing.”

“So you date that guy?” He points to where the table is.

“Why shouldn’t I? What do you want me to do, stop living my life?” I roll my eyes. “I’m twenty-five, not ninety-five.”

“That guy is a fucking tool, and you deserve better,” he says softly. My eyes burn and my nose stings, knowing he’s right, but not wanting to give him the satisfaction.

“Better?” I tilt my head to the side, hoping my voice doesn’t crack. “Do you mean I should be with someone like you?” He glares at me. “Because, I believe, I made myself pretty clear to you when I called you,” I hiss, my head advancing into his space, “that you could have had me.”

“It’s not that easy,” he deflects, and I shake my head.

“But it could be,” I say and walk away from him to head back to my date.

I walk out of the darkened hallway and head to the table, seeing Elliott is there on his phone. Jaxon and Ariella are across from him, the two of them in their own conversation. Knox, Kylie, Kirby, and Lexi’s chairs are all empty. “Where did everyone go?” I ask, sitting in the chair beside him, his eyes glued to his phone.

“They called it a night,” Jaxon answers me. “The sitter just called us.” He looks at me and then back at Elliott. “We have to go. Jagger is being really fussy. We’re just waiting on the bill.”

“Oh no,” I say, sitting down.

“Yeah,” Jaxon confirms. “Do you want to come with us?” He raises his eyebrows.

I look back at Elliott and then look over toward the bar, seeing Zane come back out from the bathroom. He looks over at us and I dare him to come back. Dare him to finally come after me, and he looks to the right then toward me again, and before he can make his choice, someone comes up to him and starts to talk to him.

The server comes over and hands Jaxon one bill and then the other bill to Elliott, who takes out his credit card and hands it to him. “That one might be heavy,” he brags to the server, “it’s platinum.” He looks over at me and winks.

“So did you have fun tonight?” I ask him as we wait for the server to come back with his platinum card.

“It’s been alright,” he replies, and I throw my head back and pretend he just said something funny. Zane, always watching me, looks over at me confused.

“We’re going to go and say bye to Coach,” Jaxon announces. “Elliott, I hope to see you again,” he says and then mumbles “never” under his breath. I roll my lips and close my eyes. The server comes back and hands Elliott his card, and I get up at the same time he does. He puts his hand on the lower part of my back and ushers me out. I can feel Zane staring at me. I can feel his eyes on me, but I ignore the feeling to turn and go toward him and instead walk out with Elliott. He walks us to his brand-new BMW. He made a point to tell me that he just got this car last week. It’s the newest one on the market, they brought it in specially for him. I tried not to roll my eyes at him, since it’s actually not brand-new to the market because my uncle Nico got his seven months ago.

I wait for him to walk over to my side of the door and open it for me, but he just takes his keys out of his pocket and unlocks the door. Okay, that would be the nail in the coffin at this point. “Oh God,” I say, opening my own door, “I got this sudden headache. Wow, it’s like a pounding.”

“I had one of those last week,” he says, and I look over at him. “You need to drink lots of fluids.”

“Thanks,” I tell him, rolling my eyes, and when we pull up to my house, I look over at him. “I’m really sorry. I would invite you in, but my head.” I hold my hand to my head as I reach for the door handle. “Thank you for tonight; it was fun. Text me.” I get out of the car before he tries to lean over and kiss me, and I make my way to my front door, almost jogging. I close the door behind me and for the millionth time I wish it was Zane coming home with me.

twelve

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Zane

I WALK OUT OF THE BATHROOM AND I'M ABOUT TO HEAD TO THE TABLE, when I see her sit down and then turn to the side to talk to her fucking date. Who, by the way, is the biggest fucking tool I've ever met, and I've met plenty of fucking tools in my life. "Hey, Coach," Woods says, coming to me, "you have a minute?"

I look back over at Victoria and see her bare shoulder and my teeth bite down, wishing I could bite her right there before I mark her. I want to tell him that I'll talk to him another time, but I also want my players to know they can come to me for anything. "Sure thing," I say reluctantly and motion over to the empty table in the corner. "Should we sit?"

"Yeah," he agrees. I turn to walk over to the table, pulling out the chair that faces the restaurant and the front door. This is pure torture for me, seeing her laugh with someone else, wanting it to be me, but knowing I shouldn't fucking go there with her.

"What's on your mind?" I ask him and he looks around to make sure no one looks like they are listening to us.

"I was going to talk to you on Monday," he starts to say, and I can tell he's nervous.

"Yeah, well, no time like the present."

“I know that you are switching around the lines and stuff.” He looks down and I hate that he’s nervous to talk to me.

“Woods,” I call his name and he looks up, “whatever you say to me stays between us. My door is open, but you have to know that you can trust me.”

“It’s just that—” He leans back. “I would like the chance to play on the first line,” he starts to say, “my game has gotten better.”

“Your game has gotten a lot better.” I give him the encouragement because it has. “You went from a minus three to a plus one.” I give him his stats, even though he knows them. “And you are spending lots more time on the ice doing one-on-one with Eric. It shows and it shows how determined you are to get better for yourself and the team.” I point at him. “It is also going to help you with your confidence.”

“I am, and he’s the best.” He quickly covers that up. “I mean, obviously you too.”

“Obviously me too.” I joke with him to not have him feel bad. “I see nothing but good things for you this year.”

I laugh with him and then motion catches my eyes. I look up, seeing her get up but then my view is obstructed when Jaxon comes over to us. “We’re heading out,” he says and I look up and hold out my hand to shake his.

He shakes my hand and then looks over at Woods. “Good game out there.” He slaps his shoulder. “Coming into your own.”

“Trying to.” He laughs as he looks at me.

I look beside Jaxon at Ariella, who is standing beside him, holding his hand as I give her a nod. “Good seeing you,” I tell her, being polite. “Hope to see you again soon.”

“Come by anytime.” She smiles at me and then the two of them walk out and I can see Victoria standing with Elliott. He puts his hand on her back, and I have the sudden urge to get up and go over to her and break his hand for touching her.

“What is this little meeting?” Owen asks, pulling up a chair to the table and my eyes fly back to Woods.

“No meeting,” I say. “Just talking about the game today.”

“It was good,” Owen states. “We got fucking lucky there with the last goal.”

“It wasn’t luck. It was a rebound shot,” I tell Owen as he looks at me. “It’s what I’ve been telling you guys all along. You take the shot and then someone will take the rebound.”

“No offense, Coach,” he says and the hair on the back of my neck tingles, “but you can’t say that.”

“Why not?” I ask. “Last game, Lane took the shot off the crossbar.” He looks at me. “Went out of play. We got a face-off in the zone and then we scored. I’m saying that you have to take the shot. Don’t sit back and second-guess yourself or your team.” He doesn’t say anything. “Everyone on that ice wants to win. But you can’t win at it alone.” I don’t say anything more when a couple of the rookies come over and sit at the table.

“How did you guys think the switching of lines went tonight?” I look around the table.

“I went from the second line to the fourth line,” Owen grumbles. “I fucking hated it.”

“Thanks,” One of the rookies who is on his line says and it makes us laugh.

“No offense,” Owen says to him, no doubt feeling like a dick or maybe he doesn’t give a shit.

The rookie just looks at him and then back at me as he brings up a couple of plays that he thinks he should have been better at.

We sit around and talk about the game, and I finally get up about forty-five minutes later and look around the table. “Tonight has been fun, boys.” I look at each of them. “Monday it’s back to the grind. Maybe I’ll switch up the lines some more,” I say and Woods silently nods his head. “Rest up,” I

tell them as I look around, seeing that most of the team has left, so I walk out the door.

I start my SUV and driving home fills me with dread. Walking into the house alone, the quiet of the night is deafening this time. The light's on in the kitchen as I head toward the stairs and to my bedroom.

Walking straight to my closet as I take off the jacket, I then pull out the phone. "Don't fucking do it," I tell myself, but at the same time my fingers are on the screen and I'm calling her number. A number I should have deleted after she called. "Fuck it," I swear as I find her name and then press call.

It rings twice and then is sent to voicemail. "Hi, you've reached Tori." My cock springs to action when I hear her voice. "I'm busy or I don't want to take your call, either way, you can leave me a message or don't. I have caller ID, so if I want to talk to you, I'll call you back. If I don't, you are probably on the 'I don't want to talk to you' list." She ends the message with a chuckle and that makes me laugh.

I look down at the phone and see the numbers on the screen move up by the second and instead, I hang up. I pull out my shirt from my pants and unbutton it before heading to the shower. Bringing my phone into the bathroom with me, in case she calls, but knowing she probably won't. I slide my black boxers on before checking my phone and then grab a pair of basketball shorts.

I get into bed, putting the phone on the bedside table, checking it for what feels like the hundredth time. Reaching for the remote and turning on the television, I flip through until I get to *SportsCenter* and see a recap of all the games. I'm half listening to them recap one of the games and all I can do is think about her. Picture her here with me.

I don't even know what I'm doing as I move across the room, getting out of bed and heading back into my closet and opening the drawer to take out a T-shirt. I slip on my slides and walk over to the dresser, where I snatch

up the keys and my wallet. I give myself a chance to think deeper about I'm doing before I'm pulling out of the driveway. I make my way over to her house and see there is no car in the driveway, which means dickhead isn't there. But there are no lights on at all, which could also mean she's not fucking home and she's with him.

The thought makes me grip the steering wheel even harder before I get out and shut the door. "Are you just going to show up at her fucking door?" I ask myself as I walk up the pathway to the house. "Yes," I mumble to myself, "Yes, I fucking am." I hold up my hand and knock on the door.

I put my hands out to hold onto the side of the door and listen to hear if I can hear anything. I look down at the cement and then up when I knock again, this time a bit harder than I did before.

I take out my phone and pull up her number again, calling her. It rings once and then I'm sent straight to voicemail. I hang up the phone when I see light coming from the side of the door, and I take a step back. My heart feels like it's coming out of my chest. Half of my head is screaming at me that *this is the stupidest thing I've ever done*, while the other half is telling me *this is what I should do*.

"Who is it?" she asks.

"You know damn well who it is," I bark out, my voice a bit louder than I want it to be.

"Say your name," she demands, and I put my hands on my hips.

"Victoria," I say her name between clenched teeth.

"Is that your name?" I hear her voice through the door. "You don't sound like a Victoria."

"Open the door," I snap.

"No," she retorts. "This is very much like Little Red Riding Hood and when she opened the door to her grandmother's house the wolf was there to eat her."

“This woman is going to,” I mumble. “You know who it is, so open the door.”

“Sounds like what a wolf would say,” she singsongs, and I pull up her number on my phone and call her again. I’m expecting it to go to voicemail but then I hear her answer.

“Hello,” she practically sings it out.

“This isn’t funny.” I grip the phone in my hand. “Open the fucking door.”

“No, you would be wrong,” she snaps. “This is very, very funny.”

“Would you please open the door?” My voice is low and tight. “I’m not leaving until you open the door.” I look down at the phone when I hear the dead signal and see she hung up on me. “I’m not leaving,” I tell the door, “so you are eventually going to have to open the door.”

“Ugh,” she groans, “fine.” I hear the locks click open. “But only because I don’t want my neighbors to call the cops and then you end up in jail for disturbing the peace.” The door slowly opens and she’s standing in front of me wearing a black silk robe that is loosely tied around her waist. “Oh, it’s you. This is a surprise.” She cocks her hip. “Not a nice surprise though.”

“Are you not going to invite me in?” I ask her and she shakes her head.

“I was not going to invite you in.” She folds her arms over her chest, and when the robe opens in the front giving me a peek at her lace bra, I feel myself pulled further into her orbit. “What are you doing here?”

“I came to talk to you,” I reply and even I don’t believe what I’m doing here. Her eyebrows go up. “Are you alone?”

“No,” she snaps, and my heart sinks to my ass, “I’m throwing a party obviously.”

“Is he here?” I hiss out at her.

“No.” She glares at me. “You just missed him.”

“Did you let him touch you?” I growl out and she glares at me.

“It’s none of your business. You made it none of your business when you let me walk away from you. *Again.*” Her voice goes louder now and she’s angry. “What I do is none of your—” She stops talking but only because I storm into the house and she moves back.

“That is where you’re wrong,” I hiss. “When it comes to you, it’s my fucking business.”

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thirteen

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Victoria

I STARE BACK, TAKING ZANE IN, AS HE GLARES AT ME. HIS HAIR IS PUSHED to the side, his beard full, and the muscles on his shoulders defined in his black T-shirt. He looks like he just walked out of the shower. “That is where you’re wrong,” he hisses, and he starts to make his way into the house. I move back, my nipples going hard at the way he’s looking at me. “When it comes to you, it’s my fucking business.”

“I would agree to disagree.” It takes everything I have in me to make my voice stay strong and not whisper. He makes his way into the little entrance hallway. I thought it was small before, but with his big frame and powerful presence, he’s shrinking the space. He bends his knees so he can kiss me, and he uses his foot to slam the door shut, the sound echoing.

“Is he here?” He looks over my head toward the rest of the house.

“How the hell do you know where I live?” I ask him.

“That doesn’t answer my question, Victoria.” He stands in front of me, so close that all I would have to do is lean forward and I would be plastered to his front.

“I’m alone.” I shake my head. “I had a headache and it’s getting bigger as the seconds go by. It’s about yay high,” I say, getting on my tippy-toes and not even that is enough to reach the top of his head. “About this wide,” I add, holding my arms to his sides, “about two twenty, maybe more.”

“It’s about to get even bigger,” he assures me and I don’t have a chance to ask him what he means because his arm is around my waist, and he’s pulling me up his body.

“Zane,” I whisper his name and his eyes are just like I remembered them from that night—full of hunger, full of need, full of desire—and all aimed at me.

“I’ve never wanted anyone else to say my name as much as I’ve wanted you to say it.” He pushes the hair over my shoulder. “Every single fucking time you say my name, my cock stirs in my pants.” His mouth gets so close to mine I can feel his breath on me. “I picture you on your back with me buried inside you, and all I want you to do is scream my name.”

I wrap an arm around his shoulder and then my other hand comes up to cup his face, my fingers stinging from his beard. “Zane,” I repeat one more time and then his lips are on mine. Softly, not as hard as he wants it to be. My lips open for him as his tongue slides into my mouth, and I know this is the kiss that is unlike any I’ve gotten before in my life. It’s a kiss that everyone describes when they describe that perfect kiss. His tongue moves around and around with mine as I feel us moving through my house.

I don’t know how he knows where to go, and I’m too far gone to care, and he steps into my bedroom. He gets onto the bed on his knees and my legs unwrap from his waist as I drop down to my own knees in front of him. I hear his slides fall to the floor, first one then the other. He stares at me and my eyes bore into his as his hand comes up and he gingerly touches my cheek. He bends down, lips hovering over mine as the hand on my cheek moves down to my neck. If my eyes weren’t open, I would think I was dreaming. His touch is light as a feather as my own hands come up to touch him. I cup the back of his head with one hand, the other going to the side of his neck as his lips take mine again. I try to keep my eyes open to see the kiss, but the feeling is too much.

“Victoria,” he says my name between kisses as he holds my neck with both hands, my hands grasping his biceps. He follows his hands as he moves them from my neck to the dip of my robe as he pushes it open wider. The matching see-through black bra peeks out as he pushes it open and kisses me again. Both of his thumbs are now making circles around my nipples and I feel him everywhere. I place both hands palms down on his chest, rubbing the softness of his T-shirt, but it would feel better on his skin. I reach down and pull the bottom of his T-shirt up and then move it over his head, kissing his pecs before I lean back. My hands go to the sash around my waist. I pull out the bow, and the robe finally falls open. His hands move to my shoulders, peeling it off me and tossing it to the side. I’m in front of him, wearing the black bra with matching panties. Both leave nothing to the imagination, with little pink embroidered flowers on them and his breath stutters. I lean in to kiss his lips as his hands roam to my back before he sits back on his knees and kisses the middle of my chest. He comes back up and kisses me as his hands go to my bare ass and he squeezes. Both of our hands move over the other person, getting reacquainted, or maybe just making sure neither one of us is dreaming.

I turn around in his arms, my back to his chest, and I lean forward to my side table, grabbing the box of condoms I tossed in there two weeks ago, after I called him the first time. I place the box beside our legs as he pushes the hair off my shoulder. “Tonight,” he starts, his voice thick but soft, “I saw your shoulder and I wanted nothing more than to bite it.” He then nips my shoulder. I push back into him, his hard covered cock nestling between my ass cheeks. He grabs my hand in one of his as I look over my shoulder at him, and the other hand comes up to cup my face. “I wanted my mark on you,” he admits, biting my neck and then sucking it into his mouth; the hand on my neck going down to cup my breast.

I move my ass side to side as both of his hands knead my breasts before he pulls the cups of the bra down. My hand moves to take the strap off my

arms, as his fingers move around my pebbled nipples. My ass pushes deeper into his cock and the only sound in the room is the heavy breathing coming from both of us. "I need you." I reach around and rub my palm over his cock as the tip of his tongue licks my shoulder. His thumb and forefinger roll my nipple and my pussy gets even more wet. "Zane," I groan his name, my head falling on his shoulder. One of his hands moves down my stomach, going into my panties, and he slides his middle finger right into me. I gasp out as he moans.

"Fucking wet for me," he growls out as I try to focus on getting his cock out of his shorts. I push the side of his shorts down using his pockets and lean forward to do the other side. All the while he moves his finger out of my pussy and to my clit, moving in a circle and then sliding back into me. "Tight," he mumbles and then he hisses out my name as his cock springs free, and I fist it with my hand, moving up and down. "Victoria," he says my name and I shiver.

"Need you," I mutter as he moves his finger out of me and reaches for the box of condoms, ripping the box open and sliding one on. He moves my thong to the side, and I brace on my hands and knees for him to slide his cock into me. I'm expecting him to go slow but he doesn't. In one swift thrust, he's balls deep into me. "Yes," I pant out as he pulls out a bit then thrusts back in. My eyes roll to the back of my head. His cock is so thick, I cry out.

"Going to fuck you hard in a minute," he tells me, gripping my hips in his hands. "Just letting you get used to me." He moves me out to the tip of his cock and then pulls me back onto him with my hips. "So fucking tight, you're choking my cock."

"Harder," I urge, trying to push the orgasm away so I can last longer, "it's so good."

He puts his hands on my lower back. "Fuck yourself on my cock," he instructs, and I move forward and then back on him. "That's my girl." He

slaps my ass like he did that first time and even if I didn't want to come, that pushes me over the edge. "Soaking my cock so fast." He holds onto my shoulders as he fucks me harder than I fuck him. When I'm at the end of the orgasm, he pulls out of me and I turn onto my back, wanting him on top of me.

My hand goes to his chin and holds it there. "It took you long enough." I smirk at him before I kiss his lips. His hand cups my face and I let him go, lying on my back, my legs open for him. He grabs my thighs, pulling me to him. I get up on my elbows, watching his cock, my mouth watering to taste him. His mouth smashes down on mine.

This kiss is so different than the last one. This one is needy, it's rough, it's better than I can even describe. He lets go of my mouth, moving down and biting my nipple. "My mark." Then he bites beside it. His hands grip the sides of my panties and I'm expecting him to pull them down, but instead he snaps the sides of them and then lifts my foot, kissing the inside of my ankle gently. His beard tickles as he places my foot down. "I've dreamed of this pussy." He uses his hand to rub through my lips. "Dreamed of fucking it." His finger rubs my clit. "Dreamed of eating it," he says, and then his mouth is devouring me. "Dreamed of you coming on my face." He moves his face side to side, the prickling of his beard making me close my legs on his head.

My hands go to the top of his head, my nails gripping his scalp. "So much fucking better than I remember." I lift my head to watch him as he watches me.

"Fuck my face. Move your hips and make yourself come on my face," he commands, and my hips buck up. "That's my girl. Take what you want." I close my eyes as he bites my clit. "Needy pussy." I grip his head with both my hands and move my hips to ride his face.

"Clit," I state, wanting him to play with my clit. The friction from his beard is in a whole different zone, the pinch of it, followed by the

smoothness of his tongue. He eats my pussy like a man on a mission. His hand pushes my inner thighs even wider, as his tongue flicks my clit. He moves his face up and down my pussy. “More,” I say and he smirks at me. “Make me come on your face,” I egg him on. “I’m there,” I tell him as he moves his tongue side to side, putting pressure on my clit.

“That’s my girl.” He moves and slaps my clit with two fingers before moving them down and sliding them into me. “Going to come on my fingers and then you get my cock again.” He is relentless with his fingers. “You want my cock again?” he asks, and I gasp when he curls his fingers inside me, hitting my G-spot. “Greedy girl wants my cock.” He bends to take my nipple in his mouth and I grip his hand. “Tell me, Victoria.” He looks at me and his mouth crashes on mine as his fingers fuck me. “Did you make yourself come thinking of me?” I don’t answer him—I can’t, not with him relentlessly bringing me to the edge. “The amount of cum I wasted down the drain instead of on you or in you is a shame.” I still don’t say anything because my whole body convulses with the orgasm that rocks through me. “Dripping,” he says and I lift my hips as his fingers press up, making me try to close my legs. “No, no, pretty girl. I want to see that pussy gush all over me.”

His eyes look at his fingers. “Look at how wet you are. Now you’re really ready for my cock.”

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Zane

MY FINGERS SLIDE IN AND OUT OF HER, ONE ORGASM ROLLING INTO another and I feel her trying to close her legs. “Not just yet, Victoria,” I say, bending and sucking her clit back into my mouth. Her taste is my kryptonite. “I can feel you have another one in you.”

“I don’t.” She moves her head side to side. “I need your cock.”

“Give me one more and then I’ll give you my cock,” I urge, my fingers moving over her g-spot. Every single time I touch it, she gets wetter than she was before. “One more, Victoria,” I say, and I feel her push my fingers out as she gushes. “That’s it,” I praise as her hips lift off the bed and my fingers move her clit side to side. “That was what I was waiting for,” I tell her and before she is riding down from the high of her orgasm, I slam into her. The tightness of her pussy is one I’ve never felt before. The wetness lets me pull out easier, but then I’m back into her, over and over again. She gets wetter and wetter, and then just as tight as a fist squeezing me. The sound of flesh hitting flesh fills the room, along with her moans and my grunts as I fuck her as hard as I have ever fucked anyone before. I need her to feel me for the rest of the week. To remember tomorrow that my cock was in her, giving her this pleasure. It’s something I didn’t know I needed, something primal taking over. “Say my name,” I urge her as my balls get tight.

“Zane,” she moans out and tries to spread her legs wider.

“Remember who makes you feel this good.” I pull out and then slam into her. “Going to spend the rest of the night fucking this pussy to make sure you remember my fucking name,” I vow and she comes on my cock. I grit my teeth, pushing off my own orgasm before I pull out of her and rip the condom off. Her eyes widen, and I jerk my cock. “Squeeze those perfect tits together,” I tell her. She moves her arms, squeezing them together, as I aim my cock to come all over her tits. “That’s where it belongs,” I tell her as I spill my cum all over her. I let go of my cock. “Next time it’s down your throat.”

“Don’t threaten me with a good time.” She puts her head back, breath evening out. “Last time you fucked my mouth, you had me gagging.”

“Later,” I promise her with a quick kiss as I move to her and off her bed, my shorts still under my ass. “I’ll get a rag.”

“Okay,” she replies, not moving. “I’ll wait for you here. Save my energy for the mouth fucking I plan on getting.” I shake my head, laughing as I make my way into the bathroom.

“After,” I hear her voice once I open the cabinet and grab a face cloth, “we are going to discuss, one, how you found me.” I turn on the water. “Then two, how you know this house so well.”

I chuckle as I lean over and wash my face, wetting my beard before I wet the rag and look over to see her standing there in the doorway. “Tasted your cum on the way here,” she mentions when I stare at her tits and my eyes flare. “I have Kleenex by the bed,” she says and comes over to stand beside me, and she grabs the wet rag to finish cleaning her chest. “So are you going to tell me how you found me?” She looks up at me and I put my hand on her cheek.

Her gorgeous blue eyes look at me. “You’re beautiful,” I compliment softly, my heart hammering in my chest as I take in her beauty. I bend to kiss her lips softly as she puts one hand on my chest.

“Okay,” she says, then she looks down and walks out of the room, “I need water.” She grabs the black silk robe from the floor and puts it on before she walks out of the bedroom.

I follow her out of the bedroom, pulling up my shorts and heading to the kitchen. She opens the fridge. “You want something to eat?”

“No.” I lean against the counter as I watch her open the bottle of water and take a sip.

“What’s on your mind?” I ask her, sensing something is on her mind.

“Couple things,” she starts and the small wooden island is between us. “Why did you call me?”

“I don’t know,” I answer her honestly.

She tilts her head to the side and with the afterglow of me fucking her senseless, she takes my fucking breath away. “I think you can do better than that.”

“I honestly don’t fucking know.” I put one hand beside me on the counter. She looks at me, nodding her head before turning and opening the other side of the fridge, taking out a pint of ice cream.

“Could it be...” She walks over to the side, opening the drawer, and pulling out a spoon before coming back in front of me but with the island still between us. She pulls the top off, taking some ice cream on her spoon. “Perhaps you were jealous?” I don’t answer her but my glare, I think, is enough of an answer. “That’s a yes,” she declares, taking another spoon of ice cream.

“What would you do if you walked in tonight and I was with someone else?” I ask her, turning the tables on her.

I expect her to glare at me. What I don’t expect is for her to snort. “I’d say good fucking luck since I’m better than ninety-nine-point-nine percent of the women out there.” She points her spoon at me. “So you’re welcome.”

I shake my head and look down. “You’re too young for me,” I admit it out loud. “You don’t need to be tied down to someone my age.” The

thought of her actually with someone else makes me physically ill.

“You’re too old for me?” she asks me, leaning onto the counter as she eats her ice cream.

“Yes, you should stick to guys your own age.”

“Have you ever been married?” she asks me.

“The longest relationship I had was six months. I’m more focused on work than anything else,” I confess to her. “So no, I have never been married.”

“Strange, I have,” she replies and it’s my turn to be shocked. “I’m kidding. Age is just a fucking number. Would you feel better if I was thirty instead of twenty-five?”

“I don’t know, probably.”

“So I’ll pretend to be older than I am,” she suggests.

“It’s not just your age,” I snap. “It’s—” I run my hand through my hair. “Work is intense, and it needs all my attention. All eyes are on me.” I sigh. “I’m the youngest coach to ever coach at this level. It’s a huge deal and, right now, that has to be my main focus.”

“Who is telling you that it can’t be your main focus?” she asks me, standing up. “You are talking as if I’m asking you to run off with me and elope.” She laughs, “I’m twenty-five. I met a hot man in a bar one night and had great sex.” She shrugs one shoulder. “I mean, technically, I made it half of the great sex it was because I’m that awesome.” I laugh. “Then I met him again and he got all angry at the world and avoided talking to me.”

“I didn’t avoid talking to you,” I defend myself and she rolls her eyes.

“Can we not just take it a day at a time?” she asks me. “I mean, what if I don’t even like you out of bed?”

“What if I don’t like *you* out of bed?” I counter her question with her own question.

“That’s impossible,” she retorts. “Refer to my previous statement that I’m ninety-nine percent better than any of the women out there.” I laugh at

her now. I don't think I've ever been with someone who was so mature about things, yet carefree. "I'm twenty-five." She looks at me while she says it. "I just moved to a brand-new city. I started a brand-new job. I just got out of school. I'm not looking to run off with you and get married just because you can do me properly." I glare at her. "What? We have great sex. We can't dispute that."

"I'm not disputing that," I quickly add to the most mature conversation I've ever had with a woman.

"So why don't we just go day by day, and if it gets to be too much for either of us, we'll reevaluate," she raises her eyebrows, "because let's face it, you could be too clingy for me."

"Is that so?" I ask her.

"Zane, I'm fucking fabulous." She points to herself, and I laugh. "Now, I'm not going to say you were stalking me"—she takes some more ice cream and puts it in her mouth—"but I'm not *not* saying it. How did you know where I live?"

I walk around the island and she watches me, her hair flipped to the side, the soft waves framing her face. I pick her up by her waist and place her on the island. She opens her legs so I can step in between them. I grab the spoon from her and she snatches it back, putting some on the spoon and then feeding it to me. "See? Perfect." She points to herself once I take the ice cream off the spoon. The cold ice cream hits my tongue as she takes another spoon for herself.

"When my house had to be gutted, Kirby told me about this house," I tell her. "I came to take a look at it. I was going to take it but—"

"Too small for such a big man." She reads between the lines. "I get it."

"I guess you do," I say. "Why didn't you answer my calls?"

"Because you didn't deserve to speak to me." She doesn't let any of my actions slide. "I gave you a week and you did nothing with that week."

“I wouldn’t say I did nothing,” I state as she feeds me another spoonful. “I thought about doing something.”

“I’m thinking about doing something right now.” She tilts her head to the side. “It has to do with my mouth and your cock.” She smirks. “Oh wait, not going to do it.” We both laugh. “Maybe in a week.”

I reach up to hold her face in my hands. “If it’s any consolation,” I say softly, “I really, really wanted to do something about it.”

“If it’s any consolation,” she counters and I can just imagine the snark that she is going to come up with, “I bought three vibrators, and blew them all.” She holds up the hand without the spoon and holds up three fingers. “Deep throated all those motherfuckers.” She winks and I laugh and pick her up. “Zane,” she squeaks, laughing when I throw her over my shoulder, “the ice cream.” It drops to the floor, along with the clang of her spoon. Her robe falls from her ass as I move my hand up and slap her bare cheek. “Zane.” She laughs as I walk to the bedroom.

“Time to show me how much you practiced with those fake cocks,” I tell her, bending at my knees and tossing her on her back. I pull down my pants, my cock springing free. “Take off the robe,” I demand and she quickly tosses it to the side, unsnapping her bra and throwing it over her shoulder. “Hands and knees,” I direct her, “ass in the air so I can play with it while you take my cock.”

She grips my cock in her hand and looks at me, licking the head of my cock. “Fuck, you’re even beautiful on your knees for me.”

“I know,” she sings at me, “but now I’m more beautiful because I have your cock in my mouth.” She takes me halfway inside.

“What am I going to do with you, Victoria?” I ask her as I move my hips to fuck her mouth.

“I can think of a couple of things.” She grins as she takes my cock to the back of her throat and wiggles her ass side to side.

An hour later I'm on my back, she's collapsed on my chest, and my cock is still buried inside her after she rode me. I swear I've died and gone to heaven. "I have to get rid of this condom," I remind her, and she grumbles as I roll her to the side and her eyes barely open. I get rid of the condom, clean up, and bring out the rag. She lies on her side. "Open your legs for me, baby," I urge softly. "I'll clean you up and you can go to bed." She opens her legs and I toss the rag to the side afterward.

Sliding into bed with her and pulling her close to me, I close my eyes and drift to sleep.

The soft ping of my email sounds in the distance with the subject line.

Urgent meeting Sunday 10 a.m. at the arena.

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Victoria

SLEEP TEARS AWAY FROM ME AS I BLINK OPEN MY EYES, SEEING THE SOFT glow from outside coming into the room at the side of the curtains. I snuggle deeper into the bed and wrap the covers around me more as I close my eyes until the urge to fall back asleep passes. I open them back up and look across the room, finding the bed empty. I reach out, feeling the bed cold. I get up on my elbow. “Zane,” I call his name and listen for any noise, but the silence is almost too loud. I toss the covers off me and get up, snatching up the black silk robe before I go out into the kitchen and find it empty.

“Wow.” I stand in the middle of the living room that opens up to the entire house, finding it empty too. “This is why you shouldn’t have opened the fucking door last night.” I turn back and head toward the bedroom, the sheets in disarray show you two people definitely slept in the bed, though his side looks like he snuck out of bed like a snake. “Asshole,” I grumble and shake my head, pushing down the way my stomach sinks.

I walk to the bathroom, turning on the faucet and going to the bathroom before coming back out and washing my face. I twist my hair in the back and pin it up with a clip before I walk into the kitchen, heading straight for the coffee machine and stopping in my tracks when I see the white note right next to the machine. I take a step toward it like there is a land mine

ready to explode. Once I get to the counter, I pick up the note and try not to smile down at it.

Victoria-

Had a meeting early this morning. Sorry to sneak out.

I cleaned up the ice cream, but I didn't want to wake you.

You might want to clean it again.

Z

I turn now and look out the big glass window at the blue sky with the sun shining down. I shake my head, a small smile now playing on my lips, and place the paper back down on the counter. I go over and make my coffee when the phone rings, and I rush to my bedroom to get it, seeing it's my father FaceTiming me. "Good morning," I say once his face comes onto the screen.

"Good afternoon," he replies and I look back over my shoulder at the clock on the stove and see it's almost fucking noon. "Did you just get up?"

"I actually did," I admit, walking to the fridge to grab the milk. Going over to the milk frothing machine, I pour some in before pressing the button. "I guess I was more tired than I thought I was."

"You are pushing yourself too much at work." My father's voice is filled with worry.

"Every single time I talk to you, you are at your desk." His eyebrows pinch together.

"Who are you talking to, Manning?" I hear my mother come into the room and then her face is next to his and she smiles at me. "Hey, sweetheart." My parents met unconventionally one night when my mother

went to her best friend's bachelorette party and my father was there. They locked eyes and had a one-night thing. There was just a little problem, besides my mother sneaking out on him and not telling him her name, my dad was in a loveless marriage and had been trying to divorce his wife for years. She refused to give him a divorce and used Jaxon as a pawn against him.

"Hey, Mom," I say, pouring the milk in my cup and heading out to the balcony to have my coffee.

"You look tired, honey," she observes, and I laugh.

"Is that your way of saying, 'honey, you look like shit'?" I sit down on the outside couch, curling my feet under me, taking a sip of my coffee.

"No." She laughs.

"You could never look like shit," my father interjects and then looks at my mother. "You look exactly like your mother, and she's the most beautiful woman I've ever laid eyes on." She looks at him.

"Should I hang up now so you guys can make out, or do you think you can relax whatever it is you are telling each other via your eyeballs?" They laugh and he leans in and kisses her and then moves his head to her ear and whispers something to her. "My own eyeballs are going to need bleaching." I point to my eyes, which makes them laugh even more. He puts his arm around her and pulls her to him, kissing her head. "Did you guys call me to do this?" I ask them.

"I called to check up on you," my father replies. "We're going to be coming down to visit soon."

"Shocking," I reply, taking a sip of my coffee as I listen to the water crash onto the shore, "since you were here, what was it, two weeks ago."

"Our grandchild is there," my mother snaps and I roll my eyes. Even though Jaxon isn't her biological child, she calls him her son and treats him like it too. Their bond is sometimes stronger than my bond with her.

“And your children,” I mention of Jaxon and me. “Are you bringing my sister with you?” I ask them and they shrug. “Last time you guys came here without her, you kept getting notifications from the Ring cam that showed she had a rager.”

“It was not a rager,” my father defends her, “it was a quaint get-together.”

I snort, laughing at him. “There were fifty people, and some of them were boys,” I whisper out the last word and he glares at me.

“Stop goading your father.” My mother looks at him as he bites down and his jaw gets tight. “She’s a good kid.”

“I was a good kid.” I point to myself and they both snort and my father even pffts.

“You were a spoiled brat,” he retorts, and my mouth opens. “You literally put a padlock on your door when you moved out of here to go live in LA and still haven’t given us the code for it.” I did, in fact, have the best bedroom anyone could have asked for. I even had a sitting room, and I will be holding onto it until they pry it from my cold dead hands, and even then I would probably come back and haunt whoever was in that room.

“That is my private, personal space and I don’t want anyone going in there,” I defend myself. “It’s my room. What are you going to do with it?”

“I’ve always wanted a glam room,” my mother says and now I’m the one pffting out. “I could start to put on makeup and do the whole glam thing.” She glares at me. “Anyway, we’re coming down and we are going to have Sunday dinner, so don’t make any plans.”

“I literally work and then come home,” I tell them. “I have the saddest social life of all time. My best friend is a one-year-old kid that still pees his pants.” I laugh and take another sip of my coffee. “Now thanks for making me depressed on a Sunday. I’m going to let you go and then go take a workout class.” I blow kisses to the phone and then hang up on them. I look

out into the horizon at the calmness of the water far beyond, and then marvel at how it rolls up and hits the shore.

I get up and stretch, noting how certain parts of me are aching this morning. My legs are one of them, my vagina is another one. I turn to walk inside when I get a text from Jaxon.

JAXON:

Lunch.

I quickly type out a reply.

ME:

Are you asking me or telling me?

I press send before putting my cup in the sink and see he put the spoon in there. I smile to myself as the phone pings with a text. For whatever reason I can't explain, I think it's from him. My heart speeds up and I get suddenly nervous, but then I see Jaxon has sent me a video.

I press play, leaning back on the counter as Jagger's face comes into view. "Tell TT to get her lazy ass here for lunch."

"Jaxon." I hear Ariella scold him from a distance.

"TT," Jagger says on the phone, and I smile big.

"He's not going to say the word ass, Ari!" Jaxon shouts back at her as Jagger mumbles gibberish at the phone. As the video stops playing, the phone rings, showing me a FaceTime.

"I sure am popular today," I say when I answer the phone and see Jagger's face.

"We are going to eat in twenty-five minutes," Jaxon states from behind Jagger, who holds the phone in his hand. I'm suddenly looking at the floor and then the ceiling as he starts walking with the phone in his hand.

"Come back here," he calls to Jagger. "Twenty-five minutes or we eat without you."

“I’ll be there,” I tell them as the phone falls to the floor and all I see is black because Jagger sits on said phone. I hang up, walking to my bedroom, taking in the messy bed, the picture of it so unlike when I sleep in it alone. One side is normally never touched, but now both sides are rumpled. I walk over to make the bed, smelling Zane on the pillow I pick up to toss to the end of the bed as I smooth the sheets back. I clean up the three condom wrappers off the side table and toss them in the trash before putting the pillows back in place.

I walk toward my closet, taking out a pair of black leggings with a matching sports bra before going into the bathroom and fixing my hair. I unclip my hair, bend over, and hold it upside down, putting my hands through it before flipping it over to one side. I put on some mascara and then I see the red mark he left on my shoulder. My fingers come up to touch it and I bring the memory up to the forefront of my thoughts. It was when I was riding him and he pulled me close. It makes me close my eyes and sigh deeply before I head over and grab a sweater.

I get there in time for lunch and then we take a walk to the park, where I spend the rest of the afternoon chasing Jagger and having him chase me. I’m sliding into bed when I pick up the phone and text him.

ME:

Found your note this morning. Thanks for cleaning up the ice cream.

I press send and I’m expecting him to text me back, but instead the phone rings, and I see it’s him. “Hello,” I answer, putting the phone to my ear.

“Hey,” he says, and I sink down into the bed.

“Who is this?” I ask and roll my lips to not laugh out loud.

“The Big Bad Wolf,” he replies, and I can’t help but laugh out loud.

“Okay, you win that round.”

“Finally. Sorry for sneaking out on you,” he says softly. “I got an email about a meeting.”

“On a Sunday?” I ask him.

“Yeah.” He sounds stressed. “Management meeting.”

“That sounds like all kinds of fun.” I make a joke out of it and he chuckles.

“I am sorry for leaving that way.”

“Thank you for cleaning up the mess in the kitchen.”

“It was the least I could do since I made half the mess.”

“Half the mess?” I balk. “You made the whole mess. What are you doing?”

“Packing,” he replies. “We go on a five-day road trip.”

“I know. I work with Lexi and Kylie. They keep a calendar at the office, and I also had lunch with Jaxon today, who was dreading it.”

“Yeah, he’s not the only one dreading it,” he mumbles, taking a deep inhale. “I’ll call you when I get back.”

“So needy.” I make a joke of it and when he laughs it makes me feel a bit better. “Have a good trip,” I tell him and I hang up.

I put the phone on my bedside table, trying not to overthink things. I don’t have a good night’s sleep and when I’m walking into the office the next day, my ass is dragging.

I step into the elevator, pressing the button for the floor the office is on. Stepping out and walking to the left, there are two offices on each floor. We have the one on the left, but the management company has said the person in the other office is not renewing his lease and has asked us if we want to take it over. Since I don’t have an office and the girls feel bad, we are now taking over that office, but it won’t be ready for another two months.

I open the brown door and step into the waiting area. The side has a long green couch with two different shades of pink pillows and two single

green chairs facing the sofa. In the middle of the wall over the couch are two words.

The Choice. The 'The' is in gold and the Choice is in green. Above the words are what look like green leaves with pink flowers covering the top half of the wall, like you stepped into a garden.

"Good morning," I mumble and walk over to my desk, right next to the door. Kylie and Kirby started the foundation called Make The Choice, that helps women and children leave toxic and abusive families. It was just Kylie until Lexi came in, and the two of them have already helped different organizations with shelter and clothing for women who have taken the step to make a change in their lives.

"I know that mumble," Lexi says, coming out of her office, leaning against her door frame as I pull out the chair to my desk and put my purse on top of the desk. "Someone had a wild weekend."

"Oh please, tell me it was not with Elliott," Kylie joins in, making her way out of her office and heading straight to the couch area. "He was... something."

"It was not with Elliott," I admit and they both gasp.

"I was just shitting you, I thought for sure it was with him."

"It was not," I assure them. "It was with this guy I sort of met."

"You sort of met a guy while you were on a date with another one?" Lexi asks, her eyes are about to come out of her sockets.

"No." I shake my head. "I met him before; we were talking and then—"

"You did more talking, but with your vagina." Kylie laughs.

"It was also with my mouth." I point to her. "But anyway..."

"Avoidance," Lexi notes. "I did that when I was falling for Kirby."

"Okay, no one is falling for anyone. It's just sex," I clarify and avoid looking at them. "Anyway, are we having our Monday morning meeting?"

"Oh fuck," Lexi swears, rushing back to her office and coming out with the folder in her hand. "I'm ready."

I laugh at them as I open my laptop, ready to take notes. “What are you working on?” Lexi asks me.

“So, I was thinking.” I lean back in my chair. “The community garden you guys did was amazing.” They look at me. “But what if we did the same thing but with the church after-school program.” Lexi’s eyes light up. “They have a playground area that has seen better days,” I tell them. “The play structure is half broken. There are no benches.”

“I love that idea,” Kylie says. “I think if we start doing social media”—she points to me—“it’ll make it open to more people who need help but didn’t know they could go there.”

“Exactly,” I agree.

“Why don’t we go and visit it this afternoon and take some pictures? Then we can see what we can do,” Kylie suggests and I smile.

“Road trip.” I clap my hands. “The dream team is taking it on the road.” They shake their head at me as I open up our social media page and get to work.

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Victoria

WE PULL INTO THE PARKING LOT OF THE CHURCH. MY EYES AUTOMATICALLY go to the brown building that looks like it's seen better days. The blue side door is shut and looks like it's been kicked in a time or two. I step out and look around to the back of the church where there is the chain link fence falling down on one side and bent up on the other to give people access to get into the yard. The grass is overgrown except for the path that leads to the back of the church and the playground.

I leave Lexi and Kylie by the car as I make my way to the fenced area. The playground has one swing that isn't even level. The slide is missing the second piece in it, so they can't use it. The sandbox is filled with very little sand as the weeds have taken over and the basketball court is cracked in four different places, the rim to one basket is slanted, while the other one is not even on there. "There is all that field over there." Lexi points from beside me. "We could even do a community garden here," I nod, "and a soccer field."

"We should head inside," Kylie suggests and the three of us walk to the front of the church.

"I love old churches," I tell them as we walk up the five steps. "There is just something so peaceful about them." I look at them and they try not to laugh at me. "You'll see," I assure them as we pull open the door and step

in. Walking into the entrance, there is a bulletin board to the right that has papers all over it. We walk through the two doors that are open and see the pews on both sides of the church with the front altar empty.

“Don’t you get a sense of peace?” I ask them as we walk in. The click and clack from our heels echo into the high ceiling room.

“Where do we go?” Kylie looks at Lexi, who points to the door on the side. We head toward the door. Once we get there, we see stairs leading downstairs and an office not far off.

I follow Lexi, who walks toward one of the offices and knocks on the door. “Shauna,” she says the woman’s name. “My name is Lexi Petrov. I’m from Make The Choice Foundation.”

“Lexi,” she says, getting up and walking over to her, extending her hand, “it’s so nice to finally put a face to a voice.”

Lexi shakes her hand as she looks over at us. “Shauna,” she points to us, “this is Kylie and Victoria.” Kylie goes first and shakes her hand and then I follow.

“It’s nice to meet you.” I shake her hand, and she gives me the gentlest smile I’ve ever seen.

“Let’s get Seth,” she mentions someone we’ve yet to meet. “He’s downstairs where his office is.”

I move to the side as Shauna walks past me and we head down the stairs. We make it downstairs, and it opens to a huge space. Folded tables are against one wall and there are colored pictures taped up. A small kitchen is off to the side and there is a woman in there preparing food.

“That is one of our kitchen volunteers. She comes in a couple of times a week,” Shauna explains to us, walking to the kitchen. “Hey,” she calls out and she looks over at us. A little girl who walks around with a ball in each of her hands smiles at me, as another one is sitting on the floor playing with two spoons and a bowl. “That is Kennedy,” she says of the lady, “and her

daughters, Serafina and JJ. These are the ladies who are going to help us create a playground.”

“Oh,” she says, her eyebrows going up in anticipation, “that would be so good for the community.” Her voice is soft. “A lot of kids will be happy about that”—she looks over to her kids— “including these two.”

“We’re going to do what we can.” I smile at her as she turns back to her cutting board.

“Seth,” Shauna calls and a man comes out a door of the corner office. He’s about six foot two with blondish brown hair with black-framed glasses. “The Make The Choice Foundation is here.” She looks at us. “This is Seth, he’s the social worker who works for the church.”

His eyes lock on mine and I smile at him. “It’s nice to meet you,” he says and then looks at the rest of the girls. “I’ve heard lots of good things about your foundation.” He turns. “Do you guys want to head outside and we can take a tour?”

“That would be great,” I reply. “If possible, can I also take some pictures? I plan on pushing this on social media to get the word out so people will know about the before and after school program. We can even start a donation page that could help.” I look at Lexi and Kylie, who are off talking to Shauna. “I’d also love if you could tell me a little bit more about what the church does within the community.” He nods at me as I turn back to the girls, who are being pulled to the kitchen, as Seth leads me to the side where there are stairs leading to the back of the church.

“I guess this is why there is a path to the swing set,” I say to him, and he puts his hands in his pockets.

“It is,” he answers. “We usually have the before-school kids and the after-school kids come out here and burn off some of their energy,” he explains as I take out my phone and snap a couple of pictures.

“What ages do you usually have?” I ask him.

“The before-school program is mainly kids from four to about twelve years old. The after-school program is when the older kids come in. Then it’s up to about fifteen, maybe even sixteen.”

“How do you think they would benefit?” I ask him, turning to take a picture of the basketball court.

“It’s not even for the kids who come here during the week. It would be a safe place for them to also come to on the weekends when the services we offer are cut in half. A place where they can connect with each other and stay out of trouble,” he states.

“How many families does the church help?”

“Not enough,” he admits, and I smile at him as I take more pictures. The girls come out with Shauna, and we quickly end the meeting when we see a group of fifteen kids walking through the playground from the school that is right next door to the church.

I take one more look around before walking to the car with them. “We have to help them,” I say as soon as I buckle my seat belt. “Like, this playground is dire, and it helps so many families.” I look out the window at the building as we drive away. “We could even make it a community effort and have volunteers and the families come out and help us build it,” I speak up from the back as Lexi and Kylie look at each other. “I’m even going to reach out to a couple of garden centers to see if they are willing to donate any supplies.”

“That’s a great idea,” Kylie says.

“Do you think Kirby and Knox could ask some of the team to come out and help?” I take out my phone to start taking notes. “Jaxon for sure will be in.”

I pull up his number and call him, and he answers it after one ring. “Yeah,” he says, and I can tell he’s not really in a good mood.

“Hey, it’s your favorite sister,” I announce, and he groans.

“You mean it’s the sister who always calls me when she wants something.”

“Same thing,” I say. “Anyway, how down would you to be helping the community build a playground? Keep in mind these people don’t have a lot, and this playground is to help the kids. Unlike your child, who has a state-of-the-art playroom inside and outside.” He groans. “And these kids don’t even have food some days.”

“Laying it on a little thick there,” he accuses.

“It’s for the children,” I hiss. “I’ve already got you down on the list. Do you think you can bring a couple of your friends?”

“Like, ‘hey, guys, let’s go on a playdate,’ and I take them to do physical labor?”

“Correct. Anyway, you sound super busy. So I’ll let you go now.”

He doesn’t even say goodbye, he just hangs up. “Well, he’s not a happy camper, but he’s in.”

“They lost their hockey game six to two,” Lexi reports. “It was not a good night.”

“Yikes,” I say and look out the window. My mind suddenly goes to Zane and how he’s feeling.

“They have another game tonight in Philly, and they are probably going to lose that one,” Kylie adds.

“I mean, it’s a fifty-fifty chance,” I counter, and she looks over at me.

“I’m just putting it out there in the universe,” I say and then hold up both hands, crossing my fingers. “Please let them win.”

We get back to the office, finish up the workday, and I head home. For the first time in, I think forever, I sit and turn on the hockey game. It’s not like I haven’t seen them play this year. I go to the games, but I haven’t turned on a hockey game on my television when I’m by myself. I used to sometimes watch the game when I was living at home with my dad, but that was the extent of it.

I curl up on the couch with my feet under me as I listen to the broadcaster. “This is a very big game for them,” he states. “Right now, they are two and five and we have to say, that is the worst start record ever.” I get a bit angry as he continues talking, “All I know is Coach Z has his hands full tonight, and from when he spoke to the media this morning, his team has a lot of bumps in the road.”

The television goes to a press conference that must have been this morning. “We have a great group of guys on the ice. Skillful players. It’s finding out what skill goes with the other players’ skills,” he says. I smirk when I realize he didn’t even fucking smile, knowing how brightly he smiles when he’s with me.

I watch the game; by the end of the second period it’s three to zero, and not for us. Zane looks like he’s about to burst out of his suit as another player takes a penalty. He looks up at the Jumbotron to see the play and he just shakes his head. I watch the whole game and they end up losing four to one, and my stomach sinks for him.

I think about texting him and then close my eyes and do it before I change my mind.

ME:

Good game.

I think about sending it, and then quickly erase it. I think about how angry Jaxon used to get after he lost a game, and my father would tell him he had a good game.

Instead, I send him a text that says.

ME:

Thinking about you.

I send it and get up off the couch, looking outside and seeing that it’s almost seven thirty. I pop one of those precooked meals in the oven that Jaxon gave me since he would be out of town. I head to the shower,

washing my hair and then put a face mask on. Sliding on my plush terry robe, I head to the kitchen when my phone rings. I think it will be either Ariella, Lexi, or Kylie, since they are basically the only ones who actually call me since I've moved out west. I'm shocked when I see Zane's name on my screen.

My heart picks up a beat when I press the green button. "Well, hello there," I say, putting the phone on speaker while I grab my food out of the oven.

"Hey," he replies, and his voice sounds resigned, "got your text."

"That's how texting works these days. You send it out and, boom, it arrives at the other person's phone. Technology, man, it's a strange thing." He chuckles. "How's it going?" I ask him softly and he sighs deeply.

"Like fucking shit," he states.

"You can't win them all," I offer, sitting down at the table with the meal.

"You should tell the press that. Something is going on; I just can't put my finger on it."

"It was just an off game."

"Yeah, that's the thing. They are making stupid mistakes, and botching plays we've gone over in practice, and I have to wonder if they are making the mistakes on purpose," he wonders out loud. "I'm going to need them to get their heads out of their asses."

"Have you always wanted to be a coach?"

"Yeah," he says, "I knew I didn't have what I needed in order to go far in the NHL on ice, so I put my focus on training to be a coach. Watching the coaches made me see the type of coach I wanted to be."

"What do you mean?" I ask him, not sure what he is saying.

"I started this open-door policy with my players. To make sure that they were good mentally and physically." His voice is so calm and not at all the way one would think he spoke if you looked at him. "I was on this team before coming to the Warriors. The coach was so old school, none of the

players or the coaches could have facial hair. The players would get destroyed in the press. I'm not just talking about it's a bad game. I'm talking that they would even get death threats and this is during regular season games. The only thing the coach and management said was, 'If you get better, that won't happen,'" he hisses out. "Who the fuck says that? I want my guys to know that they fucking matter. I want them to know that I've got their back. I want them to know that it's okay to not be okay and everyone goes through it."

"That's so," I start to say and I don't know why something inside me shifts, "I think I really admire that the most about you," I admit to him. "The tenacity to admit that one, you aren't going to get far in the NHL as a player and instead of crying into your Cheerios, you put on your big boy pants and pivoted to something else while staying where your heart was."

"You're one to talk," he throws out at me.

"What are you talking about?"

"You moved across the country for a job."

"I mean it's not like I did it without having a security blanket."

"You came out here, got your own place, and did your own thing. You didn't come here and live with your brother. Give yourself some credit." I smile at his words. "Or else."

I can't help but burst out laughing. "Or else what?"

"No idea." He now chuckles and I can feel his mood changing from when we started this phone call. "Just thought as the older one that I needed to say it. Authoritative."

"Simmer down there, Grandpa." That makes him laugh even more and the sound makes me feel like a million bucks.

"What were you up to today?" His voice is soft and it doesn't take long for me to realize I like sharing this with him. Having a conversation about our day and just being there for each other.

“We went to visit a church playground and have decided we are going to use some of the funds the foundation made during the previous fundraiser to help rebuild it.”

“Where do you come in?”

I smile. “I am the social media whiz kid.” He chuckles. “So tomorrow I start doing my social media campaigns and hope that one of the reels I create goes viral. I’m going to wait until Jaxon is back in town and in a better mood before I ask him to make a video, and then post it on his social media.”

“You should touch base with the girl who does the PR for the team, Jill. They are always looking to give back to the community.” I gasp at his suggestion and can’t believe I didn’t even think of it.

“That is such a good idea. I was just going to ask Jaxon, Kirby, and Knox to drag some of the guys with them.”

“I’ll send you her number,” he offers and my phone pings with a text. “I just shared it.”

“You are pretty good with technology. Well, for someone your age anyway.” That makes him laugh and it feels good to laugh with him. “It’s going to get better,” I assure him softly.

He inhales and then exhales deeply, and I wish I was next to him. “Or worse.”

“Glass half full instead of half empty, Zane,” I say softly.

“Glass half full,” he says. “Thank you for tonight.” I lay my head down and close my eyes picturing him here with me. “For talking with me and letting me vent it out.”

“Anytime you need an ear,” I tell him, “my phone is open.”

“That’s good to know,” he sighs deeply. “That’s very good to know.”

I smile big. “I mean I’m still going to keep you on your toes.” He laughs, making me laugh out. “Night, big man.”

“Goodnight, Victoria,” he says, his voice rumbles, “Talk to you soon.”

“You bet,” I say and disconnect the call, looking at my phone and wondering when the fuck things with Zane went from casual to not or was it just me?

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seventeen

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Zane

“YOU GUYS HAVE TWENTY MORE MINUTES OUT THERE TO TURN THIS THING around,” I declare, my hand gripping the paper with the lines I made today, and then remade on the bench and then re-fucking-made during the first intermission and again the second intermission. “We are only down by two.” I look at the guys, none of them looking at me. “You guys are fucking better than this.” I point to the closed door. “Let’s get our heads out of our fucking asses and score a fucking goal for fuck’s sake.” I stand here waiting for one of them to look at me but not one fucking person does. It’s day four of the road trip and our third game. If we don’t score two goals to at least tie it, it’ll be our third consecutive loss on the road.

When none of them look at me, I turn and storm out of the room, going to the video room we set up. I walk in seeing Claire, who is in charge of our video footage through the game, with Eric going over a couple of the plays that we had on the ice. “I want to watch the second period,” I tell her. “What do you have for me?”

She nods her head as she pulls up the plays she thinks that went badly for us, but in reality the whole fucking game has gone badly. Their passes weren’t executed. They weren’t winning the battles in the corner. They weren’t even trying to shoot the fucking puck to even get a rebound. I

watch the two plays and then look at Eric. “Go get Jaxon and Kirby,” I tell him, and he nods, leaving the room as Cam comes in.

“Well, this road trip is a bust.” He sits down in the chair, putting his hands behind his head. “Horrible. They haven’t played this bad since—”

“I got it,” I snap at him as Jaxon comes in first then Kirby.

“What?” Jaxon questions, and I know I don’t even have to tell him what he did wrong. He knows, but he also knows he can’t be everywhere on the fucking ice.

“You want to watch the second period?”

“For you to point out where I fucked up?”

“You aren’t the only one fucking up out there,” I tell him, and he looks up at me, and the look isn’t a friendly one.

“I know what I have to do, and I didn’t do it.”

“I want to see,” Kirby says, and Claire plays the two goals again for us, and then they both nod their heads and walk out of the room.

“He needs to lead the team better,” Cam states to me of Jaxon, and I slowly look over at him.

“Let’s lay off at pointing fingers at the players and instead think about what we can do better instead,” I counter, turning to walk out of the room.

We start the third period, and we end up scoring two more goals, the only thing is, so does the other team, and we end up losing six to four. I walk out onto the ice and head across it to go to our locker room.

The press is there, all lined up, waiting to get into the locker room. I usually go in and give a speech, but everyone is just as pissed as I am. So instead, I look at the media, hoping they get what they want from me and don’t bother sticking around to interview any of the players. “Okay, whatcha got for me?” I ask and the first reporter comes up and sticks his phone in my face to voice record it.

“We get the sense that it was just one of those games, that the first forty minutes you couldn’t get anything going for you. No one was generating

anything.”

“I wouldn’t say no one.” I put my hands on my hips. “I think the last three lines were going well. I think when you start a game and you take the two penalties we took, um, you haven’t learned enough yet about playing on the road. It was a disastrous way to have to start the game and it feels like it was downhill after that. We just kept chasing it, instead of playing our game.”

“How do you get past that?” he asks, and I look up at him.

“You’ll know when I know.” I glare at him. “You think if I knew the answer, I wouldn’t give it to my team?” He doesn’t say anything. “The other team played a great game. They had solid sticks on the ice tonight. They took the shots and, unfortunately, it didn’t go the way we wanted. No one goes out on the ice and says tonight I’m going to lose.” I shrug. “At least no one on my team.”

“There has been some talk about a break in communication.” I look over at the veteran reporter who has had it out for me since day one. “On and off the ice.”

“Yeah.” I motion with my chin. “Who said this?” I ask him and he gives a one-shoulder shrug. “Come on, Timothy, if you are going to ask a question like that, are you going to say who said it or is this you speculating?”

“I’ve heard it from a couple of people,” he replies, goading me, and I know I shouldn’t fucking bite.

“Yeah? I’d like to meet these people.” All the other reporters look around. “If you are going to stand here in front of me and expect me to throw any of my players under the bus and point fingers, I’m going to tell you that you are wasting your fucking time, Timothy. So take that for communication,” I snap.

I turn and head into the locker room. “I want to say good game out there,” I tell the room as they are getting undressed and tossing their gear in

the bags in front of them, “but not one of you are going to think it’s true. We came back and showed a little bit more fight. We just have to remember that it’s three periods out there and not just one.”

I turn and head out while the reporters head in to talk to a couple of guys. An hour and a half later, we are gearing up to head to the plane. No one says much on the flight and even I don’t watch the fucking replays. We land back in LA at 1:00 a.m. local time and everyone silently makes their way to their own vehicles.

I get home and all the lights are off. The house is dead as I wheel my luggage and my carry-on to my room. I toss my shit on the floor of my closet before sliding into bed. Setting my alarm for eight, even though it’s an off day tomorrow, I want to head into the office.

I wake up the next morning, opting to not even check my phone before getting dressed in my track suit and then grabbing a coffee before leaving. I’m at my desk when I open up the iPad and read the sports headline.

“LA Warriors’ Cracks Keep Widening with New Coach.”

I shake my head as I read the piece written by Timothy, making it clear my age is a disadvantage for the game since apparently I’m too young to actually do this job right.

My phone vibrates on my desk, and I look down to see Ken has sent me a message.

KEN:

Meeting today in your office at noon. Brad will be phoning in.

“Great,” I mutter, “another meeting.” Before we left on the road trip, they made it clear that all eyes were on me. There was no room for mistakes and now that we just lost three games in a row, I can bet those eyes are getting bigger and bigger.

I scroll through the text messages I didn't have the energy to look at yesterday and see father and Victoria texted me last night. I know I shouldn't text her. My life is slowly becoming a disaster, and the last thing I should be doing is getting involved with anyone, especially my player's sister.

DAD:

You can't win them all.

I look at the words trying to tell myself the same thing.

ME:

Easier said than done.

I reply then read the one from Victoria.

VICTORIA:

Thanks for the number. I spoke with Jill and she is on board with it.

My brain knows I shouldn't respond. My brain is well aware. But something, and I don't know what that something is, has me texting her back.

ME:

You're welcome. Want to come over to my place tonight for dinner?

I press send and then wonder if I should just tell her I was texting the wrong person. But then it's going to look as if I was texting someone else and that would be very fucking uncool.

VICTORIA:

I was going to have dinner at Buckingham Palace, but my flight got cancelled, so I guess I'm free.

I can't help the laughter that comes out of me.

ME:

Here is my address, come any time after five thirty.

VICTORIA:

I shall Zillow this right now and see where you live.

ME:

I don't even know what that means.

VICTORIA:

Then it's a good thing you have me to guide you. I'll show you tonight.

I don't answer her, instead I put the phone down and then go over the plays we should have executed last night, but fell flat, to see if maybe we can practice another drill.

Ken walks into my office at noon on the nose, as if he set a timer to arrive without a minute to spare. He closes the door behind him, not many staff members are in today. It's mostly the equipment team who is unloading the bags and making sure everything is good for the game tomorrow.

He sits down and pulls out his phone. "How are you doing?" he quickly asks me before Brad picks up the line. My look should tell him how I'm doing. My hands are folded into each other and on top of my desk as I tell myself to remain calm.

"Hey," Brad says, picking up the phone. "I'm here with Scott and Dewey," he mentions the team owners, "and we were going over a couple of things."

"I'm here with Zane," Ken tells him.

"Listen," Brad starts, and I immediately want to tell him to fucking fuck off, but I sit here, my eyes on the phone, watching the time go by. "You need to start rethinking how you are calling plays and changing the lines," he advises, and I lean back in my chair, both hands holding the armrests to

stop from throwing the fucking phone across the room. “I know you’ve said that there is a learning curve coming into a head coaching position.”

“He’s been at it for three months.” Ken takes my side. “It is a learning curve.”

“There is no more room for learning curves,” Brad declares. “We’ve spent the last seven years rebuilding this team. This is one of our only shots to get another Cup. If it’s not now, it won’t happen for another fucking seven years. There are lots of contracts due at the end of the year, and we might not have the cap space to sign them all. I’m not fucking it up on a kid who doesn’t know what he is doing.”

“One,” I snap, “I’m not a fucking kid just because I’m not in my fifties, and two, no one, and I mean no one, wants to win more than me.”

“Then why don’t you do something about it?” Brad raises his voice. “Before we have to make a very hard decision about how to proceed with the rest of the season.”

“What does that mean?” I look at Ken as he looks down at his phone, avoiding looking at me.

“If you don’t think you can handle this team the way it should be handled, it might be better for everyone to part ways,” he clarifies.

“I can handle it,” I say tightly.

“Yeah, I guess we’ll see,” he replies. “We’ll speak more on Monday after the game Saturday.”

“Great,” I reply, and Ken hangs up.

“Listen, Zane,” he starts, getting up, “I’m on your side. But you have to look at the big picture.”

“I am,” I tell him, feeling my stomach roil. “If I didn’t think I could do this, I would gladly walk away. I know I can do it. I know the boys can do it. We just—”

He nods, not letting me finish. “See you tomorrow.”

“Yeah.” I exhale as I get up and head back into the room to watch the game over and over again.

I’m totally mentally drained by the time I get home. I’m walking out of the shower when the groceries I’ve ordered are delivered. I start to marinate the steaks and the whole time I’m bouncing between telling myself that work needs to be a priority and that getting involved with Victoria right now is not a good idea, which puts me in a shittier mood. By the time the doorbell rings, I’m ready to claw at my skin.

I walk to the door and open it, and she stands there. Her hair is exactly the same way it was the first night I met her, to the side with soft curls framing her face and bringing out her blue-gray eyes. Her plump lips are shiny, and I want to kiss the ever-loving shit out of her to see what they taste like. She’s wearing a pair of black pants that are tight on her hips but then are loose going down and stop right at her ankles with a low-cut black top and a light-pink dress jacket and leopard stilettos on her feet. “Hi,” she says with a smile, and I can’t help but smile back at her.

“Come in.” I move away from the door, giving her a chance to walk in.

“Thank you,” she responds, and I can tell she’s a bit nervous. “You have a lovely home.”

“Thank you.” I turn and lead her down the hallway that leads to the kitchen. “I was just starting to make dinner.” I point to the island where all the ingredients are.

“I can help,” she offers as she walks with me. The smell of roses hits me first as she walks over to the round wooden table. She shrugs her jacket off and I see the shirt she has under her jacket is a tank top, showing me her arms and her shoulders. She moves over to the sink and washes her hands. “The view,” she says of the three big windows that take up whole back wall, “I think is the best part.”

“Yeah,” I agree, my eyes never leaving her and something twinges in my chest.

“Do you want something to drink?” I ask her as I walk back into the kitchen.

“What are you having?” she asks, and I motion over to the island where the brown bottle of beer is.

“I’m having a beer,” I tell her.

“I’ll have the same then,” she states as she stands with her hands on the wooden counter. I walk over to the fridge, grabbing a bottle, and twisting off the cap.

“Glass?” I ask her and she shakes her head as I hand her the beer.

“Thanks,” she replies softly and then takes a pull. “So what are we having?”

“Steak and baked potatoes.” I look over at the potatoes I just wrapped in foil. “Wait, do you eat steak?”

“I ate a burger the first night we met,” she reminds me, walking around and grabbing the ingredients for the salad.

“So how are you? I know the last few days must have been hard,” she asks, grabbing the cutting board and the knife.

“I don’t think we should see each other anymore.” I don’t even know how or why the words come out of my mouth. They just do and I don’t even have a chance to stop them.

She looks up at me. “Really?” Her voice is calm as she continues chopping the salad. “Why?”

Yeah, Zane, my head screams, *Why?* “There are a whole slew of reasons,” I start and pick up my own beer, taking a pull. “My job.” I look over at her, itching to fucking kiss her, but stopping myself from taking the one thing I want. After this whole shitty fucking day, the only thing I want is to kiss her, sit down with her, and hear her laugh. “Does our age difference really not bother you?”

She rolls her eyes. “Does age even count these days? George Clooney and his wife Amal are seventeen years difference. Jeffrey Dean Morgan,

who is so freaking hot, and his wife are sixteen years difference and not for anything but I'd do him." She laughs and I lean against the counter behind me, watching her. I've never had a woman in my space before. My relationships have always taken second place to my job, always. Which means I didn't have the time to give the women I dated time, meaning they quickly moved on. Sometimes without telling me.

"I was in high school when you were born." I mention of the fifteen years between us.

"It's not my fault the world wasn't ready for me sooner." I smirk at that answer.

"My main focus should be my job." I leave out for however long I might have it.

"Don't blame me if I'm all you can think about." She again jokes about it and this time I can't help but laugh. I put the beer down and rub my hands over my face.

"Victoria," I say her name and it's like I was made to say it.

"Hold on a second." She puts the knife down on the cutting board. "Did you invite me here to break up with me?" She puts her hands down on the counter beside the cutting board. "Even though we aren't really seeing each other and we've had sex twice?" Her voice that was soft before is now growing louder and her eyes have turned fully gray. I hate she's pissed and upset, and I hate even more that I'm the one that made her pissed and upset.

"I have to go," she states, turning and walking to her jacket, and I bite my tongue to tell her not to. She starts to put her jacket on as she looks at me. "You know, I wasn't coming over here tonight expecting anything from you. I have never once forced you to give me something or anything more than what you're willing to give. But I also know I deserve so much more than whatever this is," she declares, and she walks to me. "I want someone who trusts me, respects me, and communicates with me." She is standing in front of me. "Someone who is kind and has empathy, but is not closed off to

building something with me.” I don’t move because all I want is to grab her by her hips and pull her to me. “If you can’t give that to me, then you have to let me go.” She stares into my eyes. “You don’t have to decide this minute. You’ve had a pretty shitty week. But now that I’ve said all I have to say, I don’t want you playing games with my heart.” She inhales. “Now, I want you to think about what you want. What does Zane want?” She smiles at me and it’s a sad smile. “I hope that you are good to him.” She puts her hand on me, right in the middle of my chest. The heat from her hand seeps through my shirt. “Because he’s really one of the best guys I’ve come to know.” Her hand falls from my chest as she turns away from me. “Goodbye, Zane,” she says softly. I listen to the door slam shut and then hear the start of her car. Only then do I pick up my beer and throw it across the fucking room.

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eighteen

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Victoria

JAXON:

We are eating at noon, even if you aren't here.

I PICK UP THE PHONE IN MY LAP AND TURN IT OVER, SEEING THE TEXT AS I have coffee on my deck. The sun is coming in and out of the clouds as I lift the cup and put it to my lips.

I went to the game last night but opted out of going to the bar with my brother and our friends afterward. The last thing I wanted was to see Zane. I was still pissed at him about the showdown we had at his house over a week ago, when he stood there not giving me anything as I put it all on the table. I couldn't help but be mad at him even though I had no reason to be pissed at him; I only had myself to blame.

I finish my coffee and then head to the bedroom to get ready for lunch. I know my parents are still in town, as is my uncle Nico, who is one of my father's best friends and the owner of the Dallas Oilers hockey team. I slip on a pair of loose-fitting white pants with a brown belt and a tight, gray high-neck sleeveless top that hits right above my waist. I slip on my brown Hermes shoes before heading to the bathroom to do my hair and then apply some mascara and some blush on my cheeks. Might as well look good even if I don't feel it inside.

I spray my perfume on both sides of my neck, and then on my wrists before slipping on a couple of gold bracelets and then my silver-and-gold Rolex watch I got for my graduation. I head to the door and get into the SUV, putting on my sunglasses as I make my way over to Jaxon's.

The driveway is full of cars, and I know I'm going to be told I'm late, even though I look over and see I'm technically one minute early. I get out of my SUV, grabbing my purse in one hand and the phone in the other. I walk up the steps as my hair blows in the soft wind, not bothering to ring the bell.

I step in and the smell of food immediately makes my stomach growl. Even from the doorway, voices can be heard all the way to the front of the house as I start walking toward the family room. "Ladies and gentlemen, the favorite child has arrived," I announce, walking into the room with my hand in the air and stopping when I look over and see Zane standing there. I shake it off and turn to my parents. "Please, don't all rush me at once."

I put down my purse on the side table, hearing my father laugh as he comes to me. "Hello, favorite child." He takes me in his arms.

"It doesn't count after the fact, Dad," I tell him as I hug him.

"Well, she's definitely my favorite," my Uncle Nico says, walking over to me and I give him a side hug. "How are you doing?"

"Well, since I left you yesterday, I hopped on a plane and went to Sunday service with the Pope," I joke with him, feeling eyes on me. "He sends his love."

He throws his head back and laughs. "That's good to know." He drops his hand from around my arm. "Thank you for making me laugh when all I want to do is throttle Phoenix." He mentions his son, who I think plays for Nashville now, but I could be wrong.

"Ohh, what did he do?"

"I'm trying to get him to come play for Dallas and he's rejecting my deal," he hisses, mentioning the team he has owned since his father gifted it

to him as a joke. The Oilers were at the bottom of the standings, and he took over, becoming the youngest owner in the history of the NHL, and he clawed his way to the top.

“Could be worse.” I smirk. “He could have had a one-night stand with your best friend’s daughter and got her pregnant.” I wink at him as he shakes his head.

“I mean, it could be that,” he replies to me as I make it around the room, saying hello to my mother first.

“I guess we know who your favorite is,” I tease her as she stands next to Jaxon.

“I love you all the same,” she assures me, and I roll my eyes.

“Yeah, I’m sure,” I mumble, “but you do more for him.” I say hello to my Aunt Becca, who stands beside my uncle now, his hand around her shoulder; her hand folding up to link their fingers together.

“I was with him the longest,” she snaps, making me and Jaxon burst out laughing, and then he kisses her cheek.

“Where is my nephew?” I ask, looking around and not seeing Ariella, but seeing Zane standing there next to my father. “Hi,” I say, holding up my hand, “nice to see you again.”

“Zane.” He points to his chest, and I stupidly picture him without his shirt on.

“Yeah, I heard.” I try not to smile at his joke. “Good news is, now that I know, there is no need for you to wear a name tag.” I turn to the side as I hear Ariella.

“Is that your Auntie TT?” she says and Zane is momentarily forgotten as Jagger enters the room.

“There’s my man.” I hold out my hands and he runs into them as I swing him up and around.

“He just ate,” Jaxon warns, “so unless you want him to yack all over you—”

“He would never,” I reassure him, kissing his neck. “Would you vomit on me?”

“He loves me a bit more than you, and he threw up in my mouth once,” Jaxon shares and I shake my head.

I feel Zane’s eyes on me and when I look over, I see him staring at me. I quickly look away from him, kissing Jagger’s head. “Do you want to go and play with your toys?” I ask him, moving out of the kitchen because my heart is beating even faster than normal. I try to swallow down the lump and then nervously put Jagger down in the living room next to his toys.

“Let’s eat,” Jaxon urges and I make my way to the table, trying to be as far away from Zane as I can, but everyone pairs up and it leaves me right beside him at the end of the table, next to Ariella.

I focus on the plate in front of me, eating maybe five or six bites before putting my fork down. I put one arm on the table and then hold my chin with the other as I take in the conversation around me. But all I can do is focus on the fact that his arm is practically touching mine.

I push away from the table. “Jagger, want to come with me and play?” I ask, looking at him in his highchair as he tries to escape. I pull him out of it, walking over to the sink to wash his hands and his face. “There, now let’s go play with the ball.”

“Ball,” he says to me, “ball.”

“Yeah, ball,” I say, walking into the living room with him. “Where is the ball?” He walks over to the basket in the corner with his balls as he picks up the red one. “The red ball,” I say, feeling Zane’s presence nearby. “Where is the stick?” I ask him of his little plastic hockey stick. “Bring Auntie TT a stick,” I tell him. He walks back and drags a second stick behind him as he hands it to me when he makes it to me. “Thank you.” I walk to get a ball and use the small stick to hit it to him. He walks behind the ball and swings at it and the ball goes flying to the kitchen, hitting Zane on the leg.

“Good shot.” Zane gets up and picks up the ball before walking it over to Jagger. Squatting down in front of him, Zane’s holding the ball in his hand, his big hand holding the ball. “Here is your ball,” he offers to him and then looks over at me. “You going to hit it again?” he asks Jagger. I’m expecting him to leave and go back to the table, but he just stays there squatting beside him.

He gets up and goes behind Jagger, holding his hand under his as he moves the stick back and then forward, hitting the ball, making Jagger shriek and put his hand in the air. Zane laughs at him as my mother gets up from the table.

“Who wants ice cream?” she asks, her eyes directly on Jagger. He drops the stick like it’s a hot potato before running away from Zane and me. I shake my head and walk over to the basket, putting my stick in it. I avoid looking at him as the gang starts to clean up the table. I have never felt so nervous around anyone before and I hate how off-kilter he makes me feel.

I turn, grab two plates off the table, and walk to the kitchen, putting them on the island, where my Aunt Becca is rinsing them off before placing them in the dishwasher. I go back to the table as I see the guys still sitting around the table. Pulling my chair out and listening to the conversation in front of me.

“When the team is united and on the same page,” Zane says, looking over at Jaxon, “they are almost unstoppable.”

“You’re right,” Nico says. “Been watching the last couple of games and if they take the lead, it’s a sure thing they will win. It’s if they go down a goal, it’s like they are chasing the puck instead of playing the puck.”

“Every single time,” Zane says, shaking his head, “they need to stop playing other people’s hockey and play their own.”

“It’s hard for you to sit back and tell them this and for them to listen,” my father says, “but how hard is it to sit there and watch them fuck up?”

“There are no words. I get more heated than anyone because I know they are better than that.” He and Jaxon share a look.

“I will say,” Jaxon now starts, “in all of my coaches that I’ve had, he’s the only one who makes sure that the guys are okay mentally. Forget that he himself is getting railed in the press.” My eyes go to Zane and all he does is look down. “He makes sure that the guys are okay.”

“There are not many coaches like that in the league,” Nico says. “You’ll get through this rough patch.”

“Rough patch.” Zane laughs. “If only it was a rough patch and not that I’m driving on a gravel road with no tires.”

I push away from the table now and start clearing the plates. The guys leave the table as I walk over to the fridge to fill up my glass with water before turning and smacking straight into Zane. The glass of water spills all over the both of us. He hisses out, his hands going to both my arms to stop me from tumbling farther on him.

“Nice,” Jaxon says, shaking his head, “and you wonder why I’m the favorite of the bunch.”

“Shut up,” I snap, stepping back from Zane and seeing the front of his shirt soaking wet. “I’m so sorry.”

“Not your fault,” he mumbles as Ariella comes over and hands him a cloth.

“That isn’t going to help,” Jaxon notes. “I’ll go and get you a shirt.” He starts to walk away.

“Well, she needs to change.” Ariella points to me as I see my shirt is drenched too. “Go and get one of my shirts, and you can give him one of Jaxon’s.”

“Um,” I start to say, “I’m fine.”

“You’re soaking wet.” My mother laughs. “Go and change.”

“Be careful,” Zane warns, putting his hand on my elbow, “the water is all over the floor.”

“I’m fine,” I mumble and want to shake his hand off me, but all eyes are on us and the last thing I need to do is explain to the crowd what is going on.

“Let’s get you a new shirt.” I push aside the nerves and the lump in my throat as I step around the puddle of water. His hand drops from my elbow as I walk ahead of him. “This way,” I direct, heading up the stairs and away from everyone, just the two of us.

He follows one step behind me as I walk to Jaxon’s walk-in closet and open his drawers to find a T-shirt. “Is a T-shirt fine or would you like something else?”

“A T-shirt is fine,” he answers softly as I grab one and walk over to hand it to him instead of throwing it at his face. “Here you go.”

I hold out the shirt for him as a pit grows in my stomach. “Thank you,” he says softly, my eyes looking down at his hands gripping the shirt.

“I’m sorry.” I look up at him, both of us still holding onto the shirt. “I didn’t see you.” The tension in the closet is enough to suffocate me.

“You’re so beautiful.” The words I think shock even him. My heart feels like it’s about to come out of my chest. “I—” he says as he steps closer to me, “I miss you.” I look down, shaking my head, not wanting to hear the words. “I...” The hand he is holding the T-shirt with comes up as he touches my face. “So fucking beautiful.” His eyes shine in a way I’ve never seen before.

“I can’t do this with you, Zane. I know that I said I was okay with whatever but after getting to know you, I’m not. Unless you are ready to claim me and be with me, you need to let me go,” I state, hoping like fuck he says something that will make me drop the fucking shirt and touch him.

“Victoria.” He’s said my name before in a variety of ways, but this time he sounds broken. His fingertips move over my cheek as his head bends, and I can feel the kiss coming. I know I should push him away, but the pull to him is stronger than I am.

“Zane,” I whisper his name right before I feel his lips about to touch mine.

“I’ll get Jagger his jacket.” I hear my mother’s voice from down the hall and Zane quickly steps away from me, giving me my answer.

I shake my head. “I’ll let you change in here,” I tell him, walking out of the closet, grabbing the first shirt I see of Ariella’s and walking out of the bedroom.

I come face-to-face with my mother, who is holding Jagger’s jacket in her hand. “Are you okay?” she asks me, taking in my face.

“Yeah, I’m fine.” I clear my throat. “I was just—” I try to think of something. “So embarrassing.” I shake my head, putting on a fake smile. “I’m going to get out of this shirt,” I tell her.

She nods, walking to the stairs as I make my way to Jagger’s bedroom. “We’ll be in the backyard when you are done,” she says as she starts to walk down the steps.

“I’ll meet you guys there.” I look over my shoulder, seeing Zane coming out of Jaxon’s bedroom. I stare at him one more minute before I close the door and my head falls forward on the wood. “It’ll pass,” I tell myself.

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Zane

“OKAY, EVERYONE.” JILL, THE TEAM’S PUBLIC RELATIONS SPECIALIST, comes into the locker room. “The bus is here.” She looks at the guys. “I want everyone on their best behavior.” She points to the guys. “The press is coming out to snap a couple pictures, and I’ll be capturing some video for social media.”

I watch her walk out of the room and the guys follow her, as we head to the garage where the bus is waiting. “Why are we doing this again?” Cam mumbles to me as we walk out to the bus.

“We’re giving back to the community.” I refrain from calling him a fucking idiot. “Who knows? Maybe it will make you feel better. Plus the team needs some positive attention right now and to be seen as a united front.” I step onto the bus and sit in the front seat like I always do.

This time he sits beside me instead of going to the back, where he usually sits with Owen and a couple of the guys. “We should be focusing on practicing the plays on the ice and not this bullshit.”

“All work and no play,” I fold my arms on my stomach, “makes for a crabby bunch.”

“After the way they played yesterday,” he pffts out, “I’d have them skating until they throw up.”

“Well, then I guess it’s a good thing I’m the man in charge,” I say, and his jaw gets tight. “For now, anyway.”

I grab my phone and pull up the latest sports news. There are a couple of teams in the East that are doing really well, but then I see the latest article from Timothy.

“LA Warriors Looking to Replace New Head Coach Before Christmas.”

I scan the article, looking at a couple of lines. *Sources close to the situation are telling me that things are in motion to make sure the hand-off goes smoothly.* I want to ask what source, and it takes everything in me not to turn to Cam and ask him if it’s him.

The bus comes to a stop and the hiss of the brakes makes me turn off my phone and look out the window at the old church. Then I look over to the side where a group of people are gathering and I look to the other side and see Victoria.

Fuck, every single time I look at her I think it’s not going to affect me, but every single time it does. She’s got her hair in a ponytail and she’s wearing jeans and a black T-shirt with the Warriors logo down the front and Jaxon’s name on the back. I put my head down as I walk off the bus. I step to the side and wait for Jaxon, Kirby, and Knox to lead the way since they’re the reason that we’re here.

“Hi,” Lexi says. “Thank you guys for coming.” I look to the side, seeing her looking at Lexi talking with a huge smile on her face. My chest gets even tighter as I look at her, wishing our conversation the other day had gone differently.

“Our main goal today is to have the swing set up. The new sandbox is done and then we would need to have that section”—she points over to the

side, where it looks like fallen debris and old wood is piled up—“cleared off. We’re going to be giving them a splash pad for the summer.”

“The shovels are over there,” Kylie directs, pointing to the side where there is a pile of shovels, “along with gloves on that table.” She points to the table on the side. “Shauna...” She points to the woman who stands beside Victoria, and I glance at Shauna but I quickly move my eyes back to her.

It’s been a week since she took me upstairs to find a shirt at Jaxon’s, and I thought as the week went by, it would get easier. But all it’s made clear is I’m pretty sure I made a mistake in telling her we can’t see each other anymore. All I do is think of her, fucking hourly at this point. As soon as I stop thinking about her, I turn around to do something or see something that reminds me of her and she quickly fills my mind.

“Welcome, we are so thankful you guys have taken the time out of your day to come and help,” Shauna says as the guy next to her with glasses leans over and says something to Victoria, making her laugh, and I put my head down so I don’t have to see it.

I look back at Shauna as I follow the guys over to the side that is farthest away from Victoria. Grabbing a pair of gloves, I start to clean the pile of debris. Every single chance I get, I look for her in the crowd. Happy with just a glimpse of her from afar.

I work beside Aaron, both of us dripping with sweat after an hour. I lift my hand up and wipe my forehead with my shirt. “Cam is wrong,” Aaron states. “This is worse than making us skate on the ice until we throw up.”

I chuckle. “Is it?”

“I’m going to be more sore tomorrow,” he complains, picking up two cement blocks that have somehow ended up here, “than I would be doing a full workout with my trainer.”

I laugh at him. “Let’s just say, it’s going to be a very early night for everyone,” I tell him. I look over to the side, seeing Jill with Victoria, the

two of them pointing the other way as they take pictures. She snaps a couple on her phone then puts it in her back pocket before bending and grabbing the gloves and shovel, as she works with the rest of the girls bringing sand from the sand pile into the sandbox.

“Coach.” I hear Jaxon call my name and then look over at him. “We need help lifting one of the play structures.”

I nod at him as I walk across the yard, then look across, seeing the asphalt truck arriving at the same time. No doubt getting ready to redo the basketball court. I get to the guys as we pick up the top of the play structure, walking over with it to the play area.

“You know what this park is missing?” I huff out when we load the structure onto the crane that will hoist it up. “A hockey rink.”

“That’s a great fucking idea!” Jaxon exclaims. “Tori,” he calls her over and she looks up and he holds up his hand and motions for her.

She tosses the shovel beside her, walking over. “You rang, Your Highness?” she says to him, pretending I’m not standing next to him.

“Zane had a great idea,” he says and now she has no choice but to look over.

“I thought I smelled wood burning,” she deadpans, folding her arms under her chest. “What is this great idea that couldn’t wait for after?”

“Why isn’t there a rink for hockey?” he asks and she looks over at Shauna.

“Hey, Shauna,” Victoria calls and she steps away from the guys, who are going to be paving the basketball court. “Shauna, this is my brother, Jaxon,” she points to Jaxon, “and his coach, Zane.” I nod at her. “They were wondering why there isn’t a hockey rink.”

“I wasn’t,” Jaxon deflects, pointing to himself as if the idea wasn’t good.

“I would say it probably isn’t in the budget.” Shauna shrugs.

“How much would something like that cost?” I ask her.

“I would think anywhere from thirty to fifty thousand, depending,” she replies.

“I’ll give you my number before I leave,” I tell her, “and we can talk a bit more and I’ll see what I can do.”

“I’ll help too,” Jaxon adds, and I look over at Victoria, who is looking at me with her mouth open.

“If I’m still around as a coach next year,” I start, avoiding looking at her, seeing the pity in her eyes is just too much to bear right now, “I’d like to bring the guys out here to play with some of the kids. Maybe even set up a clinic in the off season.”

“That would be amazing,” Shauna says. “Thank you guys so, so much.”

“Are we having a meeting I didn’t know about?” Lexi asks, coming to us, followed by Kirby.

“Mr. Moneybags over here,” Victoria points to both of us, “is going to donate money to make an outdoor hockey rink.”

“Oh,” Kirby pipes up, “I’d be down to donate something.”

“Great,” I roll my eyes, “I have the idea, and everyone steals it.”

“Okay, Coach,” Kirby says, slapping me on the shoulder and then squeezing, “you can pay for drinks later.”

“Great.” I look back over at Victoria, who is looking at me in awe with a smile on her face.

“I’m going to go get back to work,” I announce, walking away from her look before I walk over to her, hold her chin in my hand, and kiss the ever-loving shit out of her, in front of everyone. That is all I need, more fucking attention on me.

“If we can get a picture of you,” Jill says, coming over to me, “with the girls from the foundation and the captain and the assistants.” I nod at her and I’m going with her as she gathers up Kirby, Jaxon, and Knox before heading to the girls. Kirby stands right next to Lexi, Knox puts his arm around Kylie, and then I stand to the side.

“Don’t touch me,” Victoria warns. I think she’s talking to me but she’s pushing Jaxon away from her. She stands next to Kylie, and I move to stand behind her and Jaxon comes to her side.

“Perfect,” Jill says, taking the picture, and I see a couple of the press guys come over, so I make sure not to stand too close to her. As soon as they are done, I make a beeline back to the pile of debris that has been fully cleared.

I’m looking around, seeing the guys scattered as some of them joke with the others and when I look over, I’m surprised to see Victoria walking toward me. I stand here taking her all in as she does the same. “Hi,” she says softly, “I brought you something to drink.” She holds up the bottle of water for me. “It’s closed so I won’t spill it on you,” she jokes.

I lift my hand to take the bottle from her. “Thank you,” I tell her and we share a look. A look that I hope she can see how much I miss her. “You have...” My hand comes up and my thumb brushes off the bit of sand that was on her cheek. “Some sand,” I say and I see her chest rising and falling, and I wonder if she’s still as affected by me as I am by her.

“Victoria,” someone calls her name, and she looks to the side, seeing the guy who was standing next to her when we got here. “Come and meet my parents.” Wow, I thought seeing her out on a date killed me, but hearing a man tell her to come and meet his parents feels like someone just kicked me in the balls.

“Excuse me,” she says as she looks away and heads to the man. She smiles at him and then she extends her hand and shakes the woman’s hand first and then the man’s hand, as they talk like if they are long-lost friends.

You fucking want her, my head screams to me. *You had her and you gave her away.* I shake my head, pushing away the words before moving back to the side and doing something else with the guys. What, I have no idea, all I know is that I need a distraction. I continue working around the playground as time passes, doing whatever odd jobs need to be done.

When our time is almost over, I pose for a couple of pictures, and every time I look over she's busy with someone else. She's the only thing that has made me happy these past few months and there is nothing I can do about it. Or is there?

The bus gets here as we take a huge group picture of the whole team with all the volunteers. I look over my shoulder at her when I get on the bus, and she's giving Jaxon a hug, followed by Kirby and then Knox. I sit on the bus as the guys get on it, my heart heavy in my chest.

As soon as the bus starts moving, I get up. "I want to thank you guys for all your hard work today," I tell them. "It means a lot to the community."

The guys look at me as Jaxon speaks up. "If you guys aren't busy later this evening, we are going to surprise the girls with a celebration dinner. You are all invited to join."

I sit back down, and I get off the bus first, Cam heads straight to his car and Eric just watches him. "He's never happy."

"That's not true," I reply. "He's happy when things go wrong." He laughs as he walks inside the arena.

"Coach," Jaxon calls, "you're going to join us, right?"

Absofuckinglutely not, my head screams. "Wouldn't miss it," my mouth says. "The girls deserve the recognition." I turn and head inside, knowing—at least for tonight—I'll get to be in her orbit.

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Victoria

“I CAN’T BELIEVE WE DID THIS,” I SAY, SNAPPING PICTURES OF THE NEW playground that has been transformed from one that looked abandoned and haunted to one with a huge splash pad, a massive jungle gym, a newly paved basketball court, and now—according to Shauna—will also have room for an outdoor hockey rink.

“Your social media skills sure did help,” Lexi praises. “Who would have thought to reach out to vendors and ask them to donate in return for free promotion on our page.”

“Well, it did help that we had the LA Warriors coming to help us.” I look over at them and smirk. “I may have name-dropped a bit.” I see them look at me. “What? If I can’t use my brother’s name to get me things that aren’t even for me but for the community, what’s the point?”

“I agree,” Kylie says, with her hands on her hips. “If it makes you feel better, I would totally pimp out Knox.”

“Okay, as much as I want to sit here and pat myself on the back,” Lexi adds, “I need a shower and, apparently, the guys have set up a celebration dinner for us.”

“Fun.” I hold up my phone. “Okay, girls, selfie time,” I announce, making sure the three of us are all in it and the playground is in the background before I take the picture. “That will be going into our social

media as well as the newsletter I'm going to be sending out on Monday," I tell them.

I get into my car and head home, taking a nice long shower. My body feels like I just did the biggest boot camp of my life, along with a triathlon. I take my time blow-drying my hair and applying my makeup, telling myself it's just for me, but secretly knowing it's just in case Zane's there. Seeing him today dressed down and working side by side with his team had me fanning myself a couple of times, and it had nothing to do with the heat.

I grab the white tank bodysuit, putting it on before slipping on a pair of tight blue jeans. I turn around, making sure it looks good from the back before I grab the dressy white jacket with shoulder pads. Pushing the sleeves up to my elbows, I then slip my feet into my nude sky-high stilettos.

I'm parking my SUV when I see the parking lot full and wonder how many people are actually here. I grab my purse and walk into the restaurant, and I'm shocked when I see the whole fucking hockey team here, along with all our volunteers from today.

The whole restaurant is filled and I look over at Lexi, who comes over to me. "Surprise!" she exclaims to me, and I just shake my head. This is a lot more than who I thought would be here. I thought it was going to be just us.

"It wasn't even my idea," she admits to me. "I was just as shocked as you were."

"So much for a quiet night out," I mumble as Kirby and Kylie come up to me.

I kiss Kirby on the cheek as we crowd the front door and then look over to the side. I see more of the team, but also see Shauna and Seth are at the side talking, when he notices me. "Hey." He comes over. "How great is this?" he says, looking around at the packed bar. "The team came out to celebrate with us." Kylie and Kirby walk to the side to talk to Shauna and her husband.

“Oh, wow,” I say, looking around. “I thought it would just be a couple of the guys,” I tell him, but I’m looking for one person in particular—the one person who I shouldn’t care whether he’s here or not.

I feel him before I see him when the door opens behind me and he steps in. His frame fills the doorway, and when I look over my shoulder, I find his eyes directly on me. He’s wearing black pants with a black shirt. The army-green color jacket is pushed up at the sleeves, a silver watch on one wrist, while the other has a black beaded bracelet. “Hey.” His gruff voice sends shivers down my spine. His hair is perfect and my hands itch to run my fingers through it.

“Hi,” I say, looking down and trying to not make it more uncomfortable than it feels. I’m about to say something else, but it would seem my mouth has forgotten how to do anything but drool when his scent finally makes it to me.

“This is fantastic,” Seth states from beside me. “Thank you guys so much for all your help today.”

Zane nods at him. “It was a pleasure.” He looks at me one more time. “But all praise has to be given to Victoria. She’s the one who got in touch with Jill to get the team set up.”

“Someone gave me the idea,” I remind him, and he grins and looks down. My hands are gripping my purse tighter than needs to be.

Jaxon and Ariella come our way. “She’s here,” Ariella announces, coming to me and kissing my cheek. “Surprise!” she says. “I know you weren’t expecting anyone but us and a couple of friends but—”

“Zane,” Jaxon cuts in, “thought it would be nice to celebrate.” My head whips to Zane.

His eyes are on me as he puts his hands in his pockets. “It was the least we could do.” He looks around. “Now if you guys will excuse me, I’m going to go and show my face so they don’t think I forced them to come here and then bailed on them.”

He walks past me but not before his hand touches the bottom of my back as he passes by. I watch him walk away from me. “Ariella, have you met Seth?” I hear Jaxon speaking, and even though he’s in front of me, it sounds like he’s far away. The only sound present in my ears right now is the beating of my fucking heart.

I see him walk up to a couple of the guys and shake their hands. “Are you hungry?” Seth asks me and I nod my head.

“Starving.” I smile at him, and he motions with his head to the side, where there are tables. “You guys joining us?” I ask Ariella and share a look with her that says she’s joining us.

“Oh yeah,” she answers, getting the look, “I’m starving.”

“We just ate,” Jaxon reminds her, and she looks over at him with a tight smile.

“And I want a snack,” she snaps between clenched teeth. “Now, let’s join your sister.”

We sit at a table and are joined by Shauna and her husband. Ten minutes later, everyone is sitting down, and then I hear a glass clinking. I look over and see Lexi standing up, Kirby beside her. Knox is next to him and Zane is sitting at their table. His eyes meet mine for a brief moment before he looks back at Lexi. “I wanted to take a minute to thank you all for coming tonight,” she starts, “and for all the help today. There was no way we could have done this without you.” She puts her hand on Kirby’s shoulder. “So on behalf of the Make The Choice Foundation, we thank you.” She holds up her glass of wine and I grab my glass of water. “Also, keep an eye open for our newsletter coming on Monday,” she points to me, “for some pictures from today, and it’ll be your chance to score tickets to our first ever holiday fundraiser.”

My eyes are on Lexi, but I feel the heat from his stare, making it hard for me to swallow. I smile at the group, ignoring the need to look over at him and when I take a sip of my water, it has trouble going down. Lexi sits

down. "I don't know how you do it all," Seth says from beside me. The two of us have been working closely for the last week to make sure everything went smoothly today.

I think there were four meetings during the week that we had together, as we took pictures of the different stages that were going on before today. I was even there a couple of nights and volunteered during the dinner session, where he told me that many of the kids who stayed in the after-school program are fed there in the evening. It was something that wasn't really offered before he came on board, but he decided to do when he started. It heavily relied on donations from the community as well as the local grocery store.

"It takes a village." I use the words he told me this week and he smiles at me. I wait for it to happen. Wait for that little flutter in my stomach. Wait for my palms to get damp. Wait for me to feel anything for him, but all I feel is a platonic friendship.

"It really does," he agrees as Shauna calls his attention over to her. I don't know why, but I let out a little sigh of relief when that happens.

We get our food, and he gets up to go over with Shauna and Jill to take a couple of pictures with some of the team. I fold my arms in front of me as I see the crowd start to dwindle. "You did good." I hear from the side and look over at Jaxon, who has taken Ariella's chair when she got up to go to the bathroom.

"Why do you sound surprised by that?" I sit up straight in my chair. "I don't know why you don't know this by now, but I'm fucking fantastic." I hold up both my hands in front of me. "It's a gift."

He rolls his eyes at me. "Oh fuck, I forgot to tell you. There is a Family Day thing," I watch him, "at the arena next week. Zane is the one who started it. Wants to build unity with the team." My eyes go to the table where Zane is sitting, as I see him with Aaron talking about something.

“Okay,” I say, not sure why he’s telling me, “do you need me to babysit?”

“We have a game Friday, the thing is on Saturday,” he clarifies. “So we are going to be picking you up.”

“What?” I ask, shocked. “Why do I have to go?”

“It’s Family Day and you are part of my family,” he deadpans.

“What if I have plans with my boyfriend?” I ask him.

“You have a boyfriend?” He pushes away from the table. “You don’t have a boyfriend,” he quickly adds, snort-laughing and shaking his head.

“You don’t know my life, Jaxon,” I snap at him. “I could have a boyfriend. I could have ten if I wanted to.” He glares at me. “I could even be a sister wife, and you would never know.”

“There is no way in fuck you would be able to be a sister wife.” He laughs. “You have trouble sharing your fries with me, you think you’ll be able to share a man?”

I look up at the ceiling. “Good point,” I mumble. “I could have a reverse harem. Or the opposite of sister wives is brother husbands.”

“What are you guys talking about?” Ariella comes back and sits beside Jaxon.

“Do you know Tori is dating?” He looks at her and she looks at me. “She has a boyfriend.”

“I don’t have a boyfriend,” I quickly refute. “I’m just saying I could have a boyfriend.”

“But do you have a boyfriend?” Ariella leans in and quietly asks me. “Are you and Seth a thing?”

I make a grimace. “No, we are just friends.” I shake my head.

“So who are you dating?” Jaxon gasps out.

I push away from the table. “Okay, I’m leaving,” I look at both of them, “and for your information, I am dating.”

He nods his head like “I’m sure you are.”

“You are so lucky you need both feet to do your job, or else your toe would be wearing my heel,” I warn, turning now and stepping away from my chair.

“You aren’t leaving, are you?” Seth asks me and I nod my head.

“It’s been a long day. Stick a fork in me, I’m done.” I smile at him.

“Well, at least let me walk you to your car,” he offers. I nod at him as he puts his hand at the base of my back, very much like Zane did before, but again, no romantic feelings surface.

“I think I’m good,” I reply before we walk out the door, “lots of people outside.” I point at some of the guys outside shooting the shit. “But thank you.”

He leans in and kisses my cheek. “Thank you for everything,” he says, and I just nod at him as I walk out of the restaurant and see a couple of the players there with Zane. His eyes are now trained on me, and I don’t think they’ve left me all night. “Night, boys,” I say, avoiding looking at him. “Thanks for today.” I head to my SUV, put it in reverse, and drive away from him and his eyes.

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twenty-one

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Zane

I PULL INTO THE PARKING GARAGE AND SEE CLIVE POINTING AT ONE OF HIS guys coming from the side. I stop my car right next to him. “Hey, Coach,” he says once I open the door and step out.

“Hey, Clive,” I reply to him, “you’re going to be joining us, right?”

He nods his head. “Sure thing.”

“Good. I can’t wait to meet your wife,” I tell him, and he smiles big as he gets into my SUV and goes to park it.

I walk into the arena and there are people everywhere. “Hey,” I say, making sure I stop and say hello to everyone. “Thanks for coming,” I tell them. When I had this idea of doing a Family Day to build community within the team, I had no idea what went into the planning of it. But Jill took off with my idea and now everyone who is associated with the team has been invited with their family. Everyone from the kitchen staff to the players are here with their families. From the last head count, it was three hundred and forty-seven people.

“Hey, Coach,” Eric says from behind me, and I turn to look at him. He walks in with his wife and daughter.

“Hi,” I reply and smile at his daughter, then nod at his wife. “Thank you for coming in on a Saturday night.” She smiles. “I know it’s not often we have Saturday off, and now he still has to come to work.”

“It’s not work,” she counters. “He’s been looking forward to this for a couple of weeks.”

“Good.” I put my hand on his shoulder. “He’s my left hand and sometimes part of my right hand.” He nods his head at me. “I’m going to go and see if Jill needs anything from me.”

“She did mention a weekend at the Four Seasons including spa treatments.” Eric chuckles and I turn to walk out to the back of the arena and out to the tent-covered area. We were going to do it inside, but there were too many things coming in that it was easier to just do it behind the building, where there is an empty football practice field and we do off-ice drills out there when we can.

I look around to see long picnic tables everywhere. The one thing we did was make sure there were at least enough chairs for everyone, even though we didn’t think everyone would be sitting at the same time.

On the side there are six food trucks all set up to feed us, everything from burgers to tacos to funnel cakes and churros.

There are bouncy houses for the kids and then, I don’t know how Jill did it, but she found some adult bouncy houses too. There is a pit that has two poles you stand up on and you try to knock the other person off with a stick with foam at both ends.

The area is half full as I make it across to the crowd, stopping to thank everyone I see for coming. I look over to see if Cam is here yet, but I don’t see him. I see Brad and Ken, who are standing side by side. “Gentlemen,” I say, holding out my hand. Ken smirks at me, grabbing my hand and Brad does it just because there could be people looking over at us, and the last thing he wants is negative press. It’s okay for me to get it, which I’ve been getting on the daily, but not the big man in charge. “Quite a turnout,” I say, observing everyone.

“Lots of time and energy went into this,” Brad states. “Let’s hope it transfers to the ice.”

“One can hope,” I say, putting my hands in my pockets. “I’m going to go and make sure I see all the guys.”

I don’t bother waiting for him to answer before walking over to some of the rookies who have arrived. “Hey, guys,” I say and shake hands with each of them. “Spread out, yeah, and get to know each other and their families.”

“It’s almost like speed dating,” one of them mentions, and I look down at my shoes to not laugh at him. “You have five minutes to get to know the other person and then, at the end, if you guys have a connection, you write the name on a paper.”

“No,” I immediately shake my head, “this is not like that at all.” The other guys try not to laugh at him. “Everyone here is a part of the team in one way or another. It’s about meeting who is important to them. It’s who you guys play for.”

I look over and my heart stops in my chest. Or maybe it fucking starts, I don’t know, all I know is it’s becoming harder to breathe when she’s around, even if she isn’t right next to me. My heart knows when she’s even in the fucking room. It’s like my body has Victoria radar built into it, and it comes alive when she’s around.

I take her in, her hair flipped to the side reminding me of the mark I left on her, and I see her eyes light up as she points to the side talking to Jagger, who is in Jaxon’s arms. “I’ll be back,” I say to the guys. “Mingle.” I point to the people.

I zigzag my way through the crowd toward Jaxon, and I’m telling myself it’s the polite thing to do to greet my captain, but the reality is I want to see her. It’s been two weeks since I last saw her, and every single day for the past two weeks I’ve had the intense desire to text her. Every fucking night, without fail, no matter where I was, if I was home or on the road. I would settle down and my heart would feel like it was being crushed when I thought of her about how I wished she was next to me so we could end our day together.

“Hey,” I say once I get to them, and she turns and looks at me. Her blue-gray eyes are flickering. “Thank you for coming.”

“This is great,” Ariella compliments.

“I heard some of the planning,” Jaxon says, looking around, “but this is—”

“It’s all Jill.” I motion to Jill, who is going around taking pictures. “I gave her an idea and she ran with it.”

“Ball,” Jagger says, pointing over to the ball pit.

“Well, that is where we will live for the next hour,” Ariella deadpans.

“I’ll take him,” Victoria volunteers. “You guys do your thing.” She holds her hands out for Jagger. “You want to come with Auntie TT to see the balls?” she asks and he lunges into her arms. “Yeah, who’s your favorite?” She smiles at him.

“TT,” Jagger babbles.

“You all heard him say it,” she jokes with us before she turns and walks away. I watch her for longer than I should, then Kirby and Knox arrive with Lexi and Kylie.

I spend the next forty-five minutes making sure I see all the guys who are there. Looking her way every single chance I get to make sure she is still around. I still don’t see Cam anywhere. Then I see her walking across the field by herself, going inside. My feet are moving before I can stop them. At this point, I’m just torturing myself but it’s a torture, apparently, I can’t stay away from.

I step into the hallway a couple of seconds after her. The halls are quiet compared to outside, where it is filled with yelling and laughing. Kids are chasing other kids, while the picnic tables are filled with people mingling with each other. It’s exactly what I had in my mind when I brought it up. No one is talking the game, no one is concentrating on the stress of the press. It’s just a company party, families mingling.

I'm walking past my office when she turns around, hearing my steps probably. "Jaxon said I could use the bathroom inside," she explains, pointing over her shoulder. "I just can't find it."

"You can use mine." I point to my office, and she looks at me and then at the door. "It's right in there."

"I could use the public one," she offers nervously, her head moves side to side as her eyes try to find a sign.

"It's not that big of a deal," I assure her and hold out my hand for her to walk into my office. "It's the door on the right."

"How many doors are in one office?" she jokes over her shoulder, looking at me as she walks into the bathroom and closes the door behind her. I stand in my office and look up at the ceiling.

"Leave," I tell myself. "Just walk out and leave her be."

I put my hands on my hips, waiting for my feet to follow my head's advice. The door opens and she steps out. "You didn't have to wait for me," she says, looking around. "I wasn't going to defile your office," she jokes as she looks around. "Though it could use some defiling, it looks very"—she turns her face back to me—"sterile."

I put my hands in my pockets and look down, chuckling. "It is." I shrug. "I don't know if it's on purpose, or if I think it'll be easier to clean up if they fire me." My eyes stay fixated on her as she looks around.

She laughs. "I mean, talk about a glass half empty." Her laugh stops when she looks back at me. "I didn't mean—"

"It's not that," I say, shaking my head. "It's your laugh."

"What about it?" she asks me.

"It's just..." I look down exhaling, my heart rate kicking up a million notches because I'm standing in front of her, and for the first time in I don't know how long, all I want to do is jump off this fucking cliff with her. For the first time in my life, work isn't enough for me anymore. For the first time in my life, all that matters is this fucking moment and what I do with

it. I lick my lips, fighting it until I can't anymore. "Fuck this," I swear and then my hands are in her hair and I'm gripping her head. "I can't stay away anymore." That's the last thing I say before my mouth crashes down on hers. Her breath hitches, giving me the perfect opportunity for my tongue to slide into her mouth. My other hand comes up to hold the other side of her face. I feel her fingers at the side of my neck. I kiss her like it's the last time I'll ever kiss her. I kiss her like I've wanted to kiss her each and every single time I've seen her and not been able to. I kiss her as if my fucking life depends on it. The hand on the side of her face moves to wrap around her waist and I pull her to me.

The sound of voices coming toward us makes the kiss stop. I don't let her go though; I hold her close to me but step into the corner of the office. "Zane," she whispers my name and I smile, feeling it all the way through my dick. "Let me go."

I lean in, my lips going to her ear. "No," I whisper in her ear. "Text Jaxon that you are leaving," I tell her as I step away from her. "Now." She tilts her head to the side, "or don't, I don't care."

"You can't leave the party, it's your event." She chuckles.

"I don't care," I finally say. "We need to talk."

"We can talk, but we can do it after the event. The last thing you need is to Irish goodbye."

"I don't even—"

She rolls her eyes at me. "I'm not explaining it to you," she huffs out as I lift my hand to touch my thumb to her cheek. "You have to go out there. I have to go out there, and then later on—"

"No," I shake my head, "I'm not letting you out of my sight."

"You know where I live," she snaps at me. "Even if I wanted to run away, how far do you think I'm going to get?"

"Thirty minutes," I agree. "Thirty minutes and I'm out of here and you are going with me."

“Thirty minutes,” she agrees, and I kiss her lips gently before letting her go. “I’m going to go out there first,” she starts, “and then in thirty minutes, you come and say goodbye to us and I’ll ask you for a ride.”

I nod at her as she moves away from me and my hand slides into hers as she walks by me, pulling her back to me. “Thirty minutes, Victoria.” The hand holding her hand comes up to hold her jaw. “Not a minute longer.” I give her one more kiss before she walks out of my office. I look down at my feet, giving it a few minutes before I step out of my own office, the last thing I want is her being in the center of gossip.

I walk back out and see the crowd has dwindled and after twenty minutes, I’m done. I walk over to Jaxon, who is by the ball pit with Ariella and Victoria. “Hey,” I say, “I’m heading out.”

“I think we’re going to go too,” Jaxon replies. “It’s almost time for this guy to eat.”

I look at Victoria and I was not kidding when I said she’s coming with me. I will throw her over my fucking shoulder if I have to. She stands up. “Maybe I can catch a ride with you,” she says to me, “so they don’t have to go out of their way.”

“Sure,” I agree.

“What if it’s out of his way?” Jaxon now says.

“I have nothing to get home to. I have the time. See you on Monday,” I tell Jaxon. I hold out my hand for Victoria to walk with me before he asks questions or thinks too much about it.

“See you guys tomorrow, I think,” she says, giving Jagger a kiss and then walking side by side with me out of the event.

“That was smooth,” she teases, looking at me, “and you said thirty minutes.”

“You’re lucky I lasted as long as I did,” I tell her as we walk into the garage and head over to my SUV. We don’t say anything the whole ride to my house or as I park in the garage and then get out.

I hold the door that leads into the house open for her as she steps in, placing her purse down by the door. "Okay." She inhales. "Let's do this."

She steps into the house, going to the living room and I follow her. My hands grip her hips, and I pull her to me, needing to taste her again. "Let's do this, Victoria," I declare before I kiss her. This time she pushes away and stands in front of me. All I want is to touch her, to have my hands on her, so I do it. "Well, talk," I urge, "but I have to touch you while we talk."

"No, Zane." She shakes her head. "If you touch me, I'm going to forget what I have to say and then we'll be back at square one tomorrow."

"Five minutes to get it all out, and then all bets are off."

"You can't put a time limit on a discussion that we are having," she snaps.

"I just did." I take out my phone. "Set timer for five minutes," I say as I pull up my timer.

"You are incredible." Her voice goes louder and louder. "You don't talk to me for what... a month?"

"Twenty-four days," I correct her and her mouth hangs open. "Yeah, I was counting."

She blinks. "Okay, you want to do this like this. Hostile, let's do it. First time was a casual hookup." She folds her arms over her chest, and my jaw gets tight. "Second time we knew each other a bit more. Now it's becoming a pattern." She looks at me, and I want to touch her. "I'm not interested in being a random hookup when you get horny."

The look becomes a glare as I growl out, "Don't ever fucking talk about yourself like that, ever again." My voice is tight, surprising her, and I put my hands on my hips.

"Well, we need to call a spade a spade and this..." she points to me and then herself, "this is a spade."

"I don't even know what the fuck you are talking about," I say, walking to her to take off her jacket and sit her on the couch with me. I reach for her

jacket, but she moves away from my hands, and I groan as I look at the ceiling.

“This is the last time you zigzag”—she points at me, and I grab her finger, kissing it—“or pivot.”

“Pivot?” I ask, confused.

“Yeah, no more pivoting,” she snaps. “You’ve walked away from me four times.” She holds up her hand.

“How do you count four times?” I ask her.

“One was the day after the one-night stand.”

“How does that count? You left me, so you technically walked away from me.” I slip my hand into hers.

“The second time you saw me at the bar and got all jealous and showed up at my door.” She holds up another finger.

“I had to go to work, so no one walked away from anyone. So that is still zero for me and one for you.”

“Then I came here and you broke up with me.”

“I didn’t break up with you. You walked away from me.” Her eyes go into slits. “So it’s zero me and two for you.” I lean and kiss her jaw. “You walked away from me the last time,” I point out to her.

“Yeah, and why did I do that?” she asks, but doesn’t wait for me to answer, “because I said I was done with this casual thing.”

“Victoria, nothing between us has been casual, not once.”

“Whatever, Zane.” She rolls her eyes. “I’m here,” she says breathlessly, “and I told myself I wouldn’t be here unless you finally admit this thing isn’t just a hookup.”

“I already admitted it.”

“Really, when did you admit this?” she asks me. “I have been here for less than five minutes and I have not heard the words come out of your mouth. I’ve heard nonsense come out of your mouth, but not that. You have to say the fucking words, Zane.”

“I want you,” I declare. “I want you so much, you have no idea.” Her face goes soft. “For the past twenty-four fucking days, I’ve talked myself out of calling you over a thousand times.”

“Let’s not go to extremes.” She rolls her eyes.

“Whatever the fucking number is, it was every single day. I have no fucking idea what the hell I’m doing,” I admit to her. “I’ve never done this before. Never. Not with anyone but you, Victoria. My main focus was always my work, but with you... With you it’s just foreign. You make me smile after all I want to do is fucking frown. You lift me up when I get so down it’ll be hard to fucking stand. You make me feel that all of this is going to be okay and if it’s not, then that is okay also. All I know is I’m done fighting this thing between us. I’m fucking done not being able to touch you, call you. Talk to you, kiss you. I’m fucking done with it all.”

“Obviously, I’m unforgettable,” she retorts, flipping her hair behind her shoulder, and she makes me laugh. “We’ve established you aren’t going to find better than me.”

“Isn’t that the truth,” I mumble.

“So, does this mean we are doing this? Me and you.” I nod my head. “And we keep it to ourselves for now,” she clarifies. “We need time to figure shit out, and the last thing we need is everyone in our business. I don’t really need more opinions on this relationship when I’m still trying to convince you that we’re good together.”

I grin at her. “My job is a mess.” I pull her to me and wrap the arm that is holding her hand behind her. “I’m being dragged through it in the press,” I swallow, “and I don’t want you caught up in it.” I think about the scandal it could be if the press got wind of this. How they would spin it and might even blame her for us losing. There is no way in fuck I’m going to allow that to happen to her.

“We keep it between us, and we stay under the radar,” she confirms softly, “but I swear to everything, if you change your mind tomorrow—”

Her look turns into a glare and I close the distance between us. “Things on you are going to hurt more than they’ve ever hurt before.”

“These past weeks have been torture for me,” I admit to her, as she puts her hands on my chest. “Fucking torture.”

“Well, you have no one else to blame but yourself.” She doesn’t even try to let me off easy. “This could have all been avoided if you took your head out of your ass”—her finger taps my chest—“and taken what you wanted.”

“You are one-hundred percent right.”

“I know,” she says, smiling up at me. “I’m usually always right.” I throw my head back and bark out a laugh. “This bodes well for our relationship if you admit I’m always right.”

“You are always right, Victoria,” I agree softly. “You’re beautiful, so fucking beautiful.” I kiss her lips gently and the kiss goes from zero to a hundred, and there—in the same room I’ve sat in for the last weeks thinking of only her—my thoughts become a reality.

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Victoria

“I’M GOING TO NEED YOU TO DO SOMETHING FOR ME.” MY EYES FLUTTER open after he stops kissing me.

“If you are going to say I’m going to need you to forget about this moment,” I hiss at him and his eyes shine even brighter than they have been during his whole speech. His cheeks go up and a smile fills his face. I remind myself to make him smile more often because he’s got one of the best smiles I’ve ever seen.

“No.” He shakes his head, and his hand comes to hold my neck. “I’m going to need you to take my car, go to your house, and pack a bag.”

I bite my lower lip. “I’m fine with sleeping naked,” I tell him, even though I hate sleeping naked, but I don’t imagine we’ll be sleeping much tonight anyway.

“It’s not that,” he says, and my hand moves to touch his beard. “It’s Saturday night,” he inhales, “and I don’t have Saturdays off very often, so I want to cook for you.”

“Okay, why do I have to leave?” I ask him. He grabs my hand and brings it to his lips.

“Because I want to cook for you and I have a couple of things to get to make it more romantic.” My eyebrows raise.

“You know how to be romantic?” I ask. He laughs and the hand touching his beard goes up and my thumb goes to his lower lip.

“Not even a bit,” he admits to me, “but I’m going to google the shit out of it.”

“What if I tell you I’m happy with just you trying?” I ask, not wanting to leave him just yet. I’ve been waiting for this moment for what feels like my whole life.

“Victoria,” he says my name.

“Why do you do that?” I ask him and confusion fills his face. “Everyone calls me Tori or at least after a couple of times they call me Tori.”

“I’m not everyone,” he retorts, and I can’t help but roll my eyes and smile at the same time. “Now get your things and come back in about an hour.”

“An hour.” I gasp, and he turns and walks me back down the hallway to the garage. “Go home, rest, pack a bag.” He kisses my lips. “You’re going to need it.”

“Hmm,” I snort, “I’m not putting out on the first date, Zane.”

“We slept together the first night we met.” He kisses my lips.

“And I learned from that mistake.” His eyes glare at me.

“It was not a mistake,” he growls. “The only mistake was you walking away from me.” He puts his hands to his chest. “You broke my heart.”

“Hey.” I point at him. “There is only room for one funny person in this relationship and it’s not you.”

He throws his head back and laughs. “Good to know.” He walks with me to the SUV and opens his door for me to get in. “One hour.”

“I might not come back.” I reach for the handle of the door to close it on him.

“I’ll find you,” he assures me, kissing me and then stepping out of the way for me to close the door. “One hour!” he shouts before walking back to

the garage door opener, pressing the button, and I wait for the garage door to roll up and back out of his driveway.

I make it home in fifteen minutes when my phone rings. I look down to see Jaxon is FaceTiming me. I swipe across the screen as I walk to my bedroom. “Well, hello, brother,” I say. “It’s such a long time since I’ve seen your ugly face.”

His face comes into the screen, and he laughs. “Just making sure you made it home.”

“Why the hell wouldn’t I have made it home?” I ask him. My stomach flips, thinking if he had called me and I was at Zane’s, there is no way I would have been able to answer.

“Well, you’re you, and Coach doesn’t really get your type of humor.” I roll my eyes.

“Everyone gets my type of humor but you,” I tell him. “But I’m fine. I’m home.” I turn the phone around for him to see my room. “I’m going to take a nice long bubble bath, and I have a date.”

“With who?” he asks.

“It’s a threesome, really,” I say and he groans.

“See? You say that and people might believe you.”

“I can have a threesome, Jaxon. People love having polyamorous relationships.” His eyebrows go up. “Yeah, you’re right,” I admit to him. “There are just too many parts to make everyone happy.”

“I’m hanging up, and I never want to discuss threesomes with you again.”

“Then don’t call me back because the threesome is about to start,” I tell him and he groans. “Also, I am going on a hike tomorrow.” I make an excuse now, in case he calls me tomorrow and I’m with Zane, and I won’t answer. “I legit have a date tomorrow.”

“With who?”

“Not your business. That is his first, middle, and last name.” I smile at him. “Bye.” I wave at the screen and then hang up on him. I start the bath and drop a scoop of bubble bath in there and then snap a picture to Zane.

ME:

I’m making sure all parts of me are relaxed.

I send the picture to Zane, not sure if he’ll answer and I’m shocked when he does.

ZANE:

Good. You’ll probably have to take an ice bath after I’m finished with you.

ME:

Don’t make promises you can’t keep.

ZANE:

Challenge accepted.

ME:

You aren’t funny.

ZANE:

Nothing funny about me fucking your brains out. Hurry back.

ME:

If I come back.

I put the phone to the side and undress, stepping into the bath, but I’m so nervous nothing about it is relaxing. I get out and dry myself off before making my way to my drawer, deciding to wear some sexy underwear. I grab the pair of black lace crotchless panties and slip them on. I bought them as a joke when I was with my mother to give her a heart attack, and now they are going to come in handy. I take out the matching bra that covers my underboob but not my nipples. Walking over, I pull off a sweater dress and slip it on, and it hits me mid-thigh. I push the sleeves up before

grabbing my black sling-back high heels. A strap goes around the top of my foot with the toes open and then one strap in the back.

I turn in the mirror before going back to my bathroom and touching up my makeup, then I text him.

ME:

Should I bring my own condoms or do you have any?

He doesn't answer me, instead the phone rings in my hand and I answer it, "Good day, sir." I walk to the bedside table and take out the condoms, just in case.

"Hey," his voice is soft and breathy, "I don't have condoms."

"Wow," I say, not shocked, as I tuck the box in my purse. "I'm going to need you to up your game. I'm literally bringing everything to this relationship." I smile only when I hear him chuckle.

"Are you on your way?" he asks me.

"No." I walk out of my door. "You said one hour, and I'm obviously going to be fashionably late," I tell him, getting into the car. "I'll see you when I see you."

"Okay." He just gives in.

"Wow, you just giving in like that. You don't even care," I goad, and he laughs.

"Well, I want you to come over, but if you have to get ready, I'm not going to rush you."

"You're annoying," I state. "Good day, sir." I hang up. "I'll show you," I tell the phone on the passenger side. I stop at the grocery store picking up strawberries and some chocolate syrup. I pass on the caramel because no one needs to be that sticky.

I pull into his driveway, taking the bag off the passenger seat then I walk over to his door and ring the doorbell.

The door opens and his face goes from a smile to heated all in the blink of an eye. "Hi," I say, holding up the bag in my hand, "I brought dessert."

“What are you wearing?” He snatches my hand and drags me in, slamming the door behind me. “Where are your pants?”

“It’s called a sweater dress, Zane,” I explain as he presses my back to the door. “Oof,” I say when he puts both of his hands by my head at the door. “If you think this is good, wait until you see what I have under this sweater dress.”

His mouth crashes onto mine, and my purse and the bag with the strawberries fall to the floor as my hand goes into his hair. His hands go under my arms as I wrap my legs around his waist, and I lose myself into the kiss. Fuck, this man can kiss. My lips tingle from the roughness of his beard, and I can’t wait to feel it in other places. He lets go of my lips, but still pins me to the door, looking into my eyes with a heated expression. “Have I ever told you that you are a good kisser?” I brush the side of his hair with my nails. “I mean, I also help you be a good kisser because you do need to have a good partner. So I’m thinking together we make a pretty good team.”

He smiles as he wraps his arms around my waist and buries his face in my neck. “It’s all you, baby,” he counters, and I smile.

“Damn right,” I gloat, his chest on mine as he laughs. “Now are you going to feed me or fuck me and then feed me?”

“Feed you first,” he replies, putting me down on my feet, “but you’re definitely keeping those shoes on.”

“Good to know you are a fan of the shoes,” I mention as he bends to grab the bag.

“Did you really go out in public like that?” I cock my hip.

“I’m going to give you a minute to rephrase that sentence.”

“I don’t need a minute. Did you go out in public like that?” His finger comes up and then goes down. “Dressed like sex on a stick.”

“Don’t try to lure me with compliments.” I look at him. “I had to bring the condoms.” I pick up my purse. “So I decided to pick up dessert too.” I

fold my arms under my tits, pushing them up. “You’re welcome.”

He slides his hand into mine. “I was planning on eating you for dessert.” He winks at me and my mouth goes dry. “You’re welcome.”

“No,” I shake my head, “you can’t turn my words against me.”

“Fine,” he says, bending and kissing my neck softly. “Come, let’s eat.”

“And here I was going to drop to my knees and eat your cock,” I deadpan, and I can see the way his cock twitches in his blue pants. “Yeah, you’re welcome.” I get on my tippy-toes to kiss his neck. “I’m very curious as to what you cooked in an hour,” I wonder as I walk down the hall and into the kitchen and stop. The lights are off and all around the room illuminating the space are soft candles, some in vases filled with water and floating. There are five vases of red roses, two vases of white roses, one of pink, and another one of peach. Every inch of his counter is filled with roses. “Okay, I didn’t really cook, but I did order food.”

“What is all this?” I go around in a circle as I take it in.

“This is a long over-fucking-due first date,” he explains as he grabs the side of my neck and pulls me to him to kiss me.

“Okay, fine, I’ll give it to you now,” I tease as his forehead hits mine. “You win this round.”

“Baby,” he says, and my stomach feels like it’s a wave crashing onto the sand, “if it means you’re with me here in my house, I win every single time.” I can’t help the smile that fills my face. “Now let’s eat before I forget about my promise to eat and then fuck.”

“I’m okay with that,” I reply as he leads me to the table where he has two place settings set. He pulls out my chair as I sit down. “Do you want something to drink?”

“Yes, but you’ll give me that later.” I wink at him now and he groans. “It’s all fun and games until the roles are reversed.”

“Two can play that game,” he retorts, going over to the oven and taking out two plates and he comes back.

“A burger and fries,” I say and he smirks.

“Figured we can have a redo of the first meal we had together.”

“Did we actually have a meal together?” I ask as he sits in front of me.

“The way I remember it, it was me just talking.”

“I spoke back,” he reminds me, picking up his burger.

“I think you said maybe five sentences,” I point out as I pick up my own warm burger.

“Your voice was that of an angel.” I glare at him. “I was nervous,” he admits, “and pissed about my house.”

“Have you dated anyone?” I don’t know why I ask it, but I do. “You know, in between?”

“No.” He shakes his head. “Now I think you’re asking that so you can tell me you dated someone.”

“Yeah, that’s why I’m asking it.” I nod my head, and he just looks down. “I dated the shit out of my vibrator.” He looks up. “I wanted to date someone, but that someone didn’t want to date me.”

“I’m never going to live that down,” he groans, a grin on his face.

“No, I don’t believe you will. I mean, things might change depending on what else you do. The ball is in your court.”

“Did anyone ask you out on a date?” he asks me.

“Yes,” I reply, not wanting to lie to him, “but apart from the guy from the coffee shop that you met no one else.”

“Why?” he asks me.

“Because I wanted to date you, you big oaf.” I glare at him, and he smiles, nodding his head. “I’m rethinking that.”

“Nothing to rethink on that. We leave on Monday afternoon,” he tells me, “and then I’m gone until Friday. We go to Utah first, and then come back and go to Colorado.” He leans back in his chair. “I want you to stay with me until I leave,” he says softly. “Do you think you can?”

I try not to smile. “Yeah,” I nod my head, “I think I can make that happen. Can you drive me home on Monday morning?”

“Yeah, I think I can make that happen.” I push away from the table and get up, walking around the table.

“We have a lot to talk about,” I say as his hands come up and he rubs the backs of my legs, going higher and higher, “but for now I just want to —” I move away from him, holding out my hand and he takes it. I slip my fingers in his as I walk over to the couch in the other room.

He grips my hips in his hands, pulling me into him and letting me feel his cock. His head bends as he kisses my neck and my hand comes up to hold his face. I turn my head and his mouth comes to mine. He slides his tongue into my mouth as I turn in his arms, and he moves to the couch. Letting my mouth go long enough for him to sit down, I put one knee on the couch beside him and the other on the other side, straddling him.

“I missed kissing you,” he confesses, kissing my neck. “I missed hearing your voice.” He moves the kiss to the other side of my neck. “I missed your smart mouth,” he adds as my hands come up to touch his face, and I bend to kiss his lips. His hands go from my hips to push the hair away from my face before I turn my head to the side, deepening the kiss. He palms my ass as he pulls up the dress, gripping tightly as I put my hands on the back of his couch and grind down on his cock. “Fucking missed you, Victoria,” he declares before his tongue slides back into my mouth.

I let go of his mouth, moving my hips on his covered cock. His eyes stare into mine. “I’m going to need you to show me how much you missed me,” I urge as his hand comes up and his fingertips touch my jaw then trail down my neck and chest to grip my tit in his hand. He sits up on the couch to bite my nipple through the dress. “Yes,” I pant out as everywhere begins to tingle. I arch my back as his mouth moves up to lick my neck before he sucks it into his mouth. My entire body feels like it’s going to combust from his touch. “More.” I grip the back of his head and bend to kiss him as his

hands move down and pull my dress up and over my head, tossing it to the side. A growl escapes him. "I thought this was fitting," I say of the bra that hides literally nothing. My nipples are tight, pebbled, and available for him to feast on. His arms wrap around my waist as he bends to take one nipple into his mouth and then moves frantically to the next. I grind down, rotating my hips on his cock hard and fast, so close to coming apart and he hasn't even fucking touched me yet.

His mouth comes up to kiss me as he pinches my nipple and leans back in the sofa. "Going to have to go and get the condoms," he mutters, and I move off him as I turn and strut my stuff to the kitchen where he dropped my purse. I hear him moving behind me as I hurriedly get my purse. Turning around, I see him sitting back on the couch, his pants beside my dress. His cock is in his hand as he moves up and down, watching me, his eyes on my tits and then roaming down to my panties.

I open the purse and toss him the condoms. "Cover him up so I can ride," I urge as I watch him bring the wrapper to his mouth and tear it open, his hand not moving from his cock and his eyes not moving from mine. I bend my arm behind me, unclipping the bra and tossing it to the side.

He lets go of his cock to sheathe himself. "Climb on," he invites, and I don't make him tell me twice. "Move your panties to the side," he demands as I get into the same position I was in before.

I smirk at him. "No need." I get onto my knees and grip his cock in my hand before rubbing it through my folds. "Crotchless panties for the win," I joke, sinking down on his cock.

"Are you saying you were wearing these, right in front of me, this whole time?" His words are a hiss as I sink all the way down him and then stop for a minute, adjusting to his size. "Next time," he grips my hips, "you wear a toy inside of you, and I'll have the remote."

"You're turning me on," I share, moving my hips, "and I'm already so full of your cock." He leans deeper into the couch, and I put my hands on

the back, holding onto it as I slowly work up and down.

My tongue slides into his mouth as I ride him, not rushing anything and taking my sweet time. "Lean back and put your hands on my knees," he tells me. "Let me play with your clit while you ride my cock." I put my hands back and move my hips, the angle making his cock rub over my G-spot and I gasp. He moves his thumb for me to wet it before his eyes zero in on my clit. "Love the panties, but next time I want to see that pussy bare," he states and then he uses both hands to rip them apart. "Don't hide my pussy from me," he scolds, his thumb going to my clit. The minute he touches me there, my pussy squeezes. "You like that?" I don't answer him, I just nod my head. "Going to have fun with this pussy. Going to fuck it. Going to eat it. Going to play with it." His eyes never leave his hand, watching as his thumb moves faster and so do my hips. "Going to fucking play with it until you beg me to either stop or fuck you senseless." I close my eyes. "Which one do you think it's going to be?"

"I'll never stop telling you to play with it." My stomach gets tighter.

"That's right, because you're mine," he growls. "From now on, I'm the one who makes you come." His hands go to my hips, and he pulls me off his cock right when I'm about to come, and I don't have time to say anything before he pushes me on the couch, my ass facing up as he gets down on his knees and slides his tongue into me. He positions my leg on the armrest and then his mouth is on me. "Fuck my tongue," he instructs, "like you would my cock." I arch my back, pushing back onto him. I can't help the moans that come out of me when he bites my ass so hard, I know I'm going to be marked by him. The thought alone makes me push back harder. He gets up. "Going to fuck you now." He rubs his cock through my slit to my clit from behind and lines himself back up before he slides his cock into me. I look over my shoulder as he pounds into me, his shirt is gone and I didn't even notice. His mouth hovers over mine. "This pussy is mine." He wraps his arm around my chest, pinching my nipple.

“Then fuck it like it’s yours,” I pant, and he grips my hips in his hands and slams me back on him. Gripping my hair in his hand, he pounds into me over and over again. I can’t help the orgasm that rips through me. “I’m—”

His hand buries in between my legs as he plays with my clit to push the orgasm even longer. “Pussy juice is running down my leg,” he notes between clenched teeth. “Soak me, baby,” he eggs me on, and one orgasm leads into another one and just when I’m at the end of the second one, he pulls out of me and throws me on my back. My head goes to the armrest as he spreads my legs. “Time for dessert.”

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Zane

I PUSH HER LEGS OPEN, THE SLICKNESS FROM HER ORGASM MAKING HER pussy glisten and my mouth waters to taste her properly. “Time for dessert,” I declare, pushing her leg over the back of the couch and then my mouth sucks her clit. Her nails dig into the back of my head as I feast, my finger now sliding in with my tongue. “Just fucked you with everything I have, and your pussy is still tight.” I slide my finger into her, the tip of my tongue now flicking. “When I play with your clit and finger fuck you, you get even tighter.” My finger rubs her G-spot and her hips move. “Do you like my fingers or my cock more?” I ask her as she watches me devour her pussy.

“Your cock fills me up more,” she pants out, “but your fingers...your fingers are a close second.”

“That’s because with my fingers,” I rub over her G-spot, “I can touch this right here.” I curl my fingers up and she bucks her hips. “Yeah, baby.” I suck in her clit. “I want you to come on my fingers and then I’m going to fuck you until I come.” Her pussy tightens. “By the end of this weekend, I’m going to know every single inch of you.” I move my fingers even faster. “I’m going to know where to touch.” I bite her clit. “How to touch and when to touch it to drive you crazy.” Her hips are moving so fast, I don’t think she realizes it. “You are so close,” I coax, watching her come apart on my fingers. “That’s it,” I say as she tries to squeeze her knees to stop it from

happening. "Open those legs and let me see you soak my fingers. Watch," I tell her. "You see how wet my fingers are?" I move them faster and she moans, her eyes closing. "Watch your pussy swallow my fingers," I demand and she opens her eyes. "That's it, baby," I praise as her pussy gets wetter. "There we go."

"It's too much." She gasps, gripping my wrist and I bite her hand, her legs shaking as she gushes all over my hands.

"Don't tell me what to do with my pussy," I growl at her. My fingers slam into her so hard for a final time then I withdraw them from her and suck my fingers, her eyes going wide at the action. "Is this pussy ready for my cock?" I put one knee on the couch, taking my cock and slapping it on her clit. She holds onto the armrest of the couch. I move back the tip of my cock, finally sinking into her wet pussy. "Going to fuck you slow for a few thrusts, let your pussy get used to me again, and then I'm going to fuck you the way I've been dreaming of fucking you."

"Yes," she says as I pull out to the tip and then give her half my cock. "More."

When my balls hit her ass, I pull out and then slam into her. Her pussy swallows me, as I pull out and put one leg over my shoulder and then the other. "I'm going deep, baby," I tell her as I sink into her, and she groans out. "Is it too much?"

"More," she pleads, "more."

I fuck her as hard as I can and as fast as I can, my balls getting tight. "Don't you come in that condom," she warns, her statement making my cock get even bigger.

"Don't worry, baby. I'm going to feed you my cum." I pull out of her, and she sits up as I rip the condom off and her mouth covers me, my hand with hers at the base of my cock as I come down her throat. "Swallow it," I demand as she takes it all. "Every fucking last drop." I hit the back of her

throat. “Open that throat up for me, baby.” I grip the side of her head, and she takes everything I have to give her.

My hand drops from the base of my cock, but her mouth doesn’t stop until my cock is at half-mast. She gets up, standing beside the couch, as I try to control my breathing. “I’m not saying this was the best sex I’ve ever had.” She wraps her arm around the top of my chest. “But I’m not *not* saying that.” I bend to slide my tongue into her mouth. “I also think you could have done better.” She winks.

“Baby, look down at my couch,” I say of the beige couch that now has a big wet spot. “That right there says I did the best I could.”

“I see you aren’t up for the challenge then.”

“And what challenge is that?” I grip her ass in my hand.

“Fuck me so hard that I can’t talk after.” She bites my jaw.

“Challenge accepted,” I say, lifting her up and putting her over my shoulder with a swat to her ass. “Time to show you my bed,” I tell her as I grab the box of condoms and head down the hallway.

I PULL into Victoria’s driveway and look over at her. “We leave after the game.”

“I know,” she replies, leaning over to kiss my neck. We spent the better part of Saturday and Sunday naked in my bed. And in the kitchen, and the living room, and the bathroom too. But my most favorite part of the weekend was just lying with her in my bed, with her head on my chest as we talked softly to each other. “And you come back Friday.”

“I’ll text you later and call you tomorrow.” I put my hand on her face and kiss her.

“Okay.” She reaches for the handle. “I would invite you in, but then you’d probably want to do me again since I’m a goddess and you can’t get

enough of me.”

“I’ve been hard ever since you sat down in the seat, and I remembered you have no panties on.”

“Well, if you were any better at this relationship thing, you would have asked me to give you road head.”

“Baby,” I say softly, and I love the way her eyes flicker when I call her that, “I can barely focus on anything when you have your mouth on me. I don’t think it’s safe for me to be on the road.”

“Good fucking answer.” She points at me. “And again, you’ve proved my point that I’m amazing.”

“You’re beautiful,” I tell her, and she just smiles at me, and that smile is fucking everything. Fucking. Everything. “Close the door before I’m tempted to forget all about what I need to do and just bury myself in you.”

“Well, that isn’t going to persuade me to close the door, Zane,” she huffs. “You have to make it so I want to do it. Me not doing it means you get to do me again, and I would like that very much.”

“Okay, close the door before I put you over my knee and play with you until you collapse.” She gasps.

“You did that yesterday, and that isn’t how this works,” she counters. “It’s ‘Close the door, my beautiful Victoria, divine goddess and ray of sunshine,’” she smiles at that, “‘or when I come home on Friday, you won’t get my dick.’”

“Is that what I’m supposed to say?” I ask her.

“Yes,” she huffs out and nods her head.

“Fine, Victoria, my beautiful goddess divine and the ray to my sunshine, close the door or else when I come home on Friday, I won’t give you a drop of my cum.”

She rolls her eyes. “So close. You really can’t teach an old dog new tricks.” I glare. “Bye,” she sings as she closes the door and gives me a finger wave as she turns and walks into her house.

I get to the plane at the same time as Cam is getting out and look over at him. “Hey,” I say and he just nods, “I didn’t see you at the Family Day thing.”

“Yeah,” he replies, “wife made other plans and booked a weekend away for us.” I just look at him.

“A lot of people had plans also, but they changed them to show a united front.”

“Oh well.” He shrugs, avoiding looking at me as he presses the lock button on his key fob. “Next time I guess.”

I ignore the need to tell him that he’s a fucking idiot, instead I walk onto the plane and take my seat, taking my phone out and looking down to see I already have a text from Victoria. I go into my contact and change her name to Beautiful Goddess before answering her.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Have a safe flight. I put on panties.

I chuckle and message her back.

ME:

Then all is right with the world.

I LOOK out at the ice when the whistle blows and then look up at the Jumbotron, where it shows there’s another four minutes to go in the third period, and we are tied.

I put my foot on the bench and look down as the puck drops in the neutral zone. Jaxon and Kirby, side by side, bring the puck up to make the play and the puck is intercepted.

The forward on the other team pushes the puck over the blue line and he has a bit more juice in his legs than Kirby and Jaxon do because he speeds

past them, going on a breakaway. “Motherfucker,” I swear, watching him go with Kirby and Jaxon both behind him, when Jaxon does something I never thought he would do. He literally lunges off of his skates and sticks out his stick to slash at his legs, making him trip up. The whistle blows right away and the referee points to the middle of the ice, calling a penalty shot.

“What the fuck?” I shout, throwing the papers in my hands. Jaxon looks up at the Jumbotron and then shakes his head, coming back to the bench.

“What the fuck was that?” I roar at him, walking down the bench toward the defense side. “That fucking play was for novice players.”

Jaxon comes onto the bench, slamming the door shut. “You better fucking hope he saves that shot.”

“Who knows if he would have had a chance had I not tried to stop him!” Jaxon shouts back at me. “Don’t fucking tell me how to do my job!”

Eric comes over to me and pushes me in the chest. “Step away, yeah,” he mumbles.

“I’ll tell you how to do your fucking job because that is my fucking job!” I shout back at Jaxon, and then I hear the referee on the ice calling the penalty.

“Just play the fucking puck,” I tell the referee, and he looks back over at me. “You’ve been fucking us all night fucking long with these fucking calls and you know it.”

He looks right at me and forms a T in the middle of his chest. “Coach Gilmore, two minutes penalty for misconduct.”

“Fuck you,” I call to him, and he holds both hands in the air.

“Game misconduct.”

“I’m not fucking going anywhere!” I shout back to him when he points to the locker room. “Fuck you, I’m not leaving.” My hands are shaking with rage.

The referee is pointing to the dressing room. “I’m not going!”

“All eyes are on you right now,” Eric warns.

“No fucking kidding,” I retort.

“Don’t give them more,” he mumbles, and I look over to see Cam looking at me with a smirk as he leans against the back of the bench. His eyebrows shoot up, as I shake my head and walk out toward the tunnel. The arena erupts in cheers, and no one makes eye contact with me as I stand here watching the monitor as the opposing team takes the penalty shot and scores.

I look over to the wall of sticks and think about lifting one and beating the shit out of the television with it. The four minutes are over in ten, and I stand here waiting for the players to come back. Jaxon avoids me and walks past me. I shake my head and close my eyes.

“That stunt is going to cost you twenty-five thousand dollars.” Cam shakes his head. “Idiot mistake.”

“Fuck you, Cam,” I snap, and his eyebrows shoot up. He smirks when he looks behind me and sees the press there.

I don’t say anything else. I don’t have a chance to, my phone rings and I look down to see Ken calling me. “What?” I say, putting my phone to my ear.

“Let Cam handle the press, or Eric. Do not go in front of one fucking reporter,” he instructs, and I hang up on him before I tell him to also go fuck himself.

“Eric,” I say when I get into the makeshift coaches’ room, “you’re taking press.” He and Cam both turn back to me.

“I’m taking press,” Cam says, and I shake my head.

“I’m in charge and he’s taking fucking press.” I point to Eric.

“It’s a fucking joke,” Cam retorts. “You are going to run this team into the ground.”

“Is that what you’re waiting for?” I ask him and he doesn’t say anything; he just walks out of the room.

“Listen, I get you’re heated,” Eric tells me, “but you need to relax for a bit. Why don’t you sit in here until we head back to the hotel?” I nod my head at him.

The bus ride back to the hotel is so quiet you could hear a fucking pin drop. I walk into the room, and I collapse on my bed. I can’t believe tonight went the way it did. Knowing I need a distraction and to hear her voice, I call Victoria.

“Well, that was fun,” she says, answering the phone after half a ring. “How are you doing?”

“I’m so pissed,” I confess, my voice sounding as defeated as I feel. “I just don’t know what the fuck is happening.”

“I know you’re frustrated, but freaking out behind the bench—”

I close my eyes. “I know, Victoria.”

“But losing sure does suck,” she notes, and I smile looking over at the dark sky.

“It sucks so bad,” I sigh out, “and I can’t even coach the next game.”

“How does that make you feel?” she asks softly, and I wish she was here.

“Aside from wanting to take all the furniture in my room and throw it out the window?” I close my eyes. “Like I let them down,” I admit

“Well, I think it’s a two-way street,” she explains. “You let them down, but they are also letting you down. I mean, that play by Jaxon was ridiculous.”

“It was and he knew it. It didn’t help that I got on his ass.” I fold my arm under my head. “They can play better than they are playing,” I hiss out.

“I know.”

“They also fucking know,” I say, getting heated. “I just don’t know what else to fucking do,” I admit. “I just don’t. I should let you go. We take off tomorrow and head to Colorado,” I tell her.

“What hotel are you guys staying at?” she asks me.

“I think the Marriott.” I open my travel schedule and send her the information. “Now you have it.”

“Go to sleep,” she urges softly. “Tomorrow is a new day.”

“Yeah,” I say. “Sleep tight.” I hang up the phone and get undressed.

The flight the next day is the same thing as the bus. No one is saying anything to anyone. Everyone is on fucking edge, and it just gets worse when I see the headlines.

“Coach Gilmore Loses It Behind the Bench. Is He Right for the Job?”

“Warriors Start to Crumble and It Starts with the Coach.”

“Should Warriors Coach Gilmore Step Down?”

“The Pressure Is Mounting for Coach Gilmore as He’s Fined \$25,000.”

Two text messages come in at the same time one from my father and one from my sister Ashley.

DAD:

Keep your head up.

ASHLEY:

Remind me never to piss you off.

I answer my father first.

ME:

Will do.

Then answer Ashley.

ME:

I learnt that from you.

I put the phone in my pocket and when I arrive at the hotel, I pull up Beautiful Goddess on my phone and call her.

“Hey,” she answers right away, “how are we doing today?”

“I don’t know,” I admit to her.

“What room are you in?” she asks me. “I’m going to send you a Bundt cake; that makes everyone feel better.”

I laugh at her. “I’m in room four twelve, but I don’t need a Bundt cake.”

“Really?” she asks. “What do you think would make you feel better?” I hear her moving on her end and I wonder if she’s working from home today.

“You,” I reply. “You make me feel better.”

“I was hoping you would say that,” she says at the same time there is a knock at my door.

“Did you already send the cake?” I laugh, walking over to the door and pulling it open, and my mouth hangs open when I see her there.

“I did better, I brought me.”

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twenty-four

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Victoria

I SIT ON THE BED AND WAIT FOR HIM TO CALL. TRYING TO TELL MYSELF THIS is a good idea and not that I shouldn't have booked a fucking flight to surprise him on the road.

I literally had no one to ask if this was a good idea or not, since our relationship is on the down low. "What do you think would make you feel better?" I ask him as I take off toward his room. He tells me his room number and I walk out of my hotel room, looking right and left as I put the hoodie on and head toward the stairs. I've been here for four hours so I had a chance to do a dry run before he called, even though I didn't have his room number. I open the door and step into the stairwell as I walk down to the fourth floor. I peek into the hallway through the little window, my pulse picking up like crazy. I open the door and listen for a second before I rush past the rooms to his room.

"You," he says right when I get to his room. "You make me feel better."

"I was hoping you would say that." I put the phone on mute and knock on his door softly, hoping like fuck no one comes out of their rooms, especially my brother. That would be an awkward conversation, especially after last night.

"Did you already send the cake?" He laughs as he pulls open the door and I see his mouth open and his eyes widen.

“I did better, I brought me.”

“What are you doing here?” he asks, and I look around.

“Can I answer that in your room so no one catches me?” I suggest as he lunges for me and drags me inside.

His arms wrap around me as he buries his face in my neck and picks me up off my feet. My legs circle his waist as he walks over to the king-size bed in his room. His bag is pushed to the side and still packed up. “What are you doing here?” he asks me again as he sits on the edge of the bed, and he takes his face out of my neck, only to hold my face in his hands, kissing my lips softly.

“After the game, or maybe during your whole Hulk episode behind the bench...” I run my fingers through his beard and take in his tired eyes, and I want nothing more than to make this right for him. “I booked the earliest flight I could get on, which was at the ass crack of fucking dawn. Then I had to book a hotel room here, and I called and asked for early check-in, but the girl was not having it. So I booked the room last night and had to download the app to check-in so they wouldn’t give my room away,” I ramble and see his eyes get lighter with each word. “Then I got here and hid upstairs until you called.”

“I can’t believe you’re here.” He kisses every single part of my face, and I silently laugh.

“What choice did I have?” I question him. “You were all, they kicked my dog sad.”

He chuckles as he turns with me in his arms, lying down on top of me. “I can’t believe you are really really here.” He buries his face in my neck, hugging me so tight it’s hard to breathe. “This is so much better than just hearing your voice. Also, I didn’t know that I needed this. Needed you here until I saw you standing there.” He looks at me, his eyes lighting up, giving me a soft kiss “Did you bring condoms?” he asks me.

“I swear, it’s like I’m the man in the relationship and I have to think of everything,” I huff out.

“You should be happy I’m not walking around with condoms,” he tosses out as he sits me up and pulls the sweater over my head and tosses it to the side. “Means I won’t sleep with anyone.”

“No, that just means if you do, you will either get her to bring them”—he takes off one of my sneakers and throws it to the side—“or catch an STI.” He throws the other shoe to the other side as he pulls the jeans off me and tosses them over his shoulder. He’s about to pull my panties down when there is a knock at the door.

“Did you send me a Bundt cake?” he whispers to me.

“Yeah,” I hiss at him with a glare, my pulse speeding up as I get off the bed and grab my things in my hands, trying not to make any noise.

“Go in the bathroom.” He points to the bathroom and then halts when he pulls me back, and I try not to make a sound. “Wait, no, what if they want to use it?” He pulls me out as the knock comes again.

“Why would they be coming in here to use your bathroom?” I whisper frantically as I back up in the corner of the room. “Go answer the door.” I push him away as I hold my jeans and shoes to my chest. I look over and see my chest rising and falling with the way my heart is beating under it.

“Coming,” he calls. “Stay there,” he tells me.

“No.” I roll my eyes. “I was going to scale the building like Spiderman.”

He glares at me as he turns and walks away from me, pulling open the door. “Hey,” he says and I hear Knox’s voice. I don’t know why but I close my eyes and say a little prayer that he isn’t with Jaxon.

“Hey, Coach,” he replies, “was wondering if you had some time we could talk.”

“Um, yeah,” he hesitates. “How about I meet you in the lobby in five?”

“I was hoping it could be private.”

“Oh yeah, I’m just getting on a call,” he says, “but if you want, I can meet you in your room.”

I look up at the ceiling and then look out the window, seeing my reflection, so I slowly squat down to the floor. I close my eyes as Knox agrees to meet him in his room in five minutes. Only when the door is closed do I collapse on the floor and roll to my back. “What are you doing on the floor?” Zane whispers.

“I was pretending to be dead if he came in here.” I don’t move from the floor, waiting for the pounding of my heart to calm down. I extend my arms to the sides and my shoes and jeans now fall out of them and onto the floor beside me.

“Because that would have been easier to explain.” He chuckles and holds out a hand for me to take to get up. “You half naked in my room, dead.”

“I saw my reflection in the window, and I panicked.” I slip my hand in his as he pulls me up, “Now I can’t even leave this room since the guys are going to be going out soon and shit.” I look around. “This is where I live now.”

He laughs at me. “I’m going to go meet with Knox.” He holds my face in his hands. “When I come back up, we can sneak you out of here and I can come and spend the night in your room.”

“You can’t do that; don’t you guys have like curfew and shit?” He leans forward to kiss my lips.

“I’m in charge of curfew,” he states, and I push him away. “I’m going to need you to stay here, and not answer the door.”

“You don’t say.” I shake my head as he laughs and kisses me with a smile. “So me running up and down the hallway in my panties, announcing I’m here is out of the question?”

“I haven’t read all the rules in the handbook,” he deadpans, “but I think you being here in my room, that’s against the rules.”

“You would be wrong,” I inform him. “They have girls in their rooms all the time. They just don’t get caught.”

“Out of sight, out of mind,” he says, and I nod.

“Sweep that shit right under the rug,” I mumble as he kisses me one last time and walks out of the room. “You definitely didn’t think this through, at fucking all,” I scold myself as I put my jeans back on and then lie on the bed.

Turning the television on and finding something to watch, it’s about an hour and a half later when he comes back into the room. “Finally. It’s been eighty-four fucking years,” I hiss at him. “You know when you kidnap a person, it’s common decency to go and check on them occasionally. Call them, text them. Anything. Silence isn’t golden.” He tosses his key card on the long dresser that sits under the television, coming over to the other side of the bed and plopping down.

“How is it kidnapping when you came to my room of your own free will?” He rolls to me and pulls me in his arms. “Sorry it took so long,” he says softly, and I can tell from looking at his face that it didn’t go well.

My hand comes up to run through his hair, as I cock a leg over his hip. “Everything okay?” I ask him softly and he shakes his head.

“No,” he replies, pushing the hair back away from my face. “If I thought there was a divide before, there is one even bigger now. Knox is thinking that maybe some of the players are throwing these games and these plays so I can get fired.” His arm brings me closer to him.

“Do you think that maybe that’s true?” I ask him, putting my hand on his cheek.

“I don’t know. I wouldn’t think so. It’s one thing to lose to get me fired, but then again, they are being blamed for it also. It’s like a catch twenty-two. Maybe they don’t care.” He takes a deep inhale. “Maybe it’s just too fucking much,” he admits, sounding defeated.

“It’s not too much,” I counter him. “So you fucked up.” His green eyes look almost brown. “You fucked up and you own it. It shows you’re human and that you love the game. You love your team.”

“Sadly, they aren’t thinking like that.” He sighs. “Maybe it’s not meant to be. Maybe it’s my coaching they don’t want.”

“Zane,” I say his name, “do you think you can do this job?”

“No,” he says, “I don’t, but I think that these guys have it in them to win and play a lot better than they are playing.”

“There, right there,” I put my hand on his cheek, “shows you believe in them. That you want them to win. Anyone else would be pointing fingers at the players and not at themselves. You can do this.”

He rolls me to my back now. “Thank you for showing up here and listening to me.” He smiles as he softly kisses my lips, the sting of his beard always a good feeling. He kisses my jaw. “How did I get so lucky?”

“I have no idea, but you struck the lottery with me,” I tease and he barks out with laughter and I put my hand on his mouth. “They’ll hear you.”

“I think this is a challenge for both of us. You have to keep quiet when I fuck you.” He tilts his head to the side and I smile.

“Challenge accepted,” I declare right before his tongue slides into my mouth. It really is a challenge but one I am absolutely up to.

ZANE SLIDES his jacket on and I watch him, sitting up in bed, lying against the pillows at my back, the sheet covering my naked body. “What are you going to do while I’m at the game?” he asks, pulling his cuffs out of the sleeves of his jacket.

“I was going to go to the hotel bar and pick up a stranger,” I retort, and his eyes go into slits as I try not to burst out laughing. “What? It worked

before, didn't it?" I hold up my hand, and he comes to sit at the side of the bed.

He puts his hand on top of me and leans in. "Seriously."

"Well, when you leave here, text me when the bus is away from the hotel. I'll sneak out of here and head to my room," I tell him. "I have a flight tonight at seven." He frowns. "You'll be home tomorrow, and I'll see you then."

"Yeah, but you won't be here tonight," he pouts in a low voice.

"I think you can be a big boy and be brave." I put my hand on his cheek and there is a knock at the door. "I'm also never, ever doing this again." He smiles. "In my whole life," I whisper, and he bends to give me a soft kiss.

"I'll see you tomorrow," he says, whispering, "but I'll call you tonight." The knock comes again.

"Go." I push him away from me. "And play nice with others." He shakes his head and opens the door.

I hear the mumbling of voices as the door closes behind him with a click. I wait for a full two minutes before I get out of bed and get dressed. I'm sitting on the bed dressed when he sends me the text.

ZANE:

Coast is clear, we are all on the bus.

ME:

Perfect, talk later.

I'M GOING over a couple of emails, when the door opens and Knox steps in followed by Jaxon. I know they both just landed since I got a text from Zane not too long ago telling me this. "Well, well, well," I say, leaning back in my chair, "if it isn't the guy who lost his shit on the ice and his sidekick."

"Okay, one," Knox refutes, "that would be Kirby."

“And two, I didn’t lose my shit on the ice,” Jaxon snaps. “I was trying to—”

“Get a penalty.” I put my elbows on the desk and look at him. “Yeah, I know, heard all about it.”

“Yeah,” Jaxon says, “from who?”

I scoff, “It’s all over the family chat.” I smile big. “I started it.”

“I’m going to see Kylie and then we can go.”

“This is the last time I carpool,” Jaxon mumbles to Knox as he walks to Kylie’s office, who squeals when she sees him.

My eyes look to her office and I’m smiling as the door opens again, and I look over to see a man come in with a vase of roses. “Delivery for a Ms. Stevenson.” I get up, avoiding looking at Jaxon.

“Thank you.” I hold out my hand to grab the roses and see the card on top. I put the vase down and quickly grab the card, in case Jaxon grabs it before me.

“Well, well, well,” Jaxon says from behind me as I pretend I’m smelling the flowers, but I’m trying to hide the card. “What do we have here?”

“We have a beautiful bouquet of roses,” I state, pointing to them. “Something you probably didn’t send your wife and mother of your child.” I raise my eyebrows as I pretend my heart isn’t going crazy in my chest. “Someone is a winner here,” I point to the floor, “and it’s not you.”

“Who are they from?” He narrows his eyes at me.

“The same guy I went hiking with,” I tell him and smile big. “You remember his name, it’s None of Your Business.” I sit down. “Or it could be the threesome I’m in. The list is endless.”

“Yeah, right,” he scoffs at me.

“You don’t know my life, Jaxon.” He rolls his eyes at that.

“So you are actually seeing someone?”

“Maybe, or maybe I just made someone’s day by smiling at them and they sent me flowers. There could be a million reasons.”

“Okay, I’m good to go,” Knox declares, coming out of the office, wiping his lips that are full of lip gloss, followed by Kylie, who now has no lip gloss left on her. “Oh cool, flowers.”

“Yes, they are for me.” I point to myself. “And you need to leave and take this oaf with you.”

Jaxon glares at me as he and Knox leave. I look over at Kylie, who has her eyes big as she looks at me and the flowers. “I’m not talking about it,” I tell her, and she whistles.

“Is this the reason you called in sick?” She tries not to laugh at me as she uses her fingers around the word sick.

“I didn’t call in sick,” I counter to her smirking face. “I was owed days off, so I took them.”

“If you want to talk about what you did on your sick days,” she uses her fingers to air quote sick days, “I’ll be in my office.”

“Good to know,” I reply, and she walks away to her office. Only when I hear her typing on her keyboard do I take the white envelope out and turn it over, pulling out the card.

V,

Thanks for scaling the walls for me.

Z.

I smile, putting the card in my purse and then texting him.

ME:

You know what’s nice? Getting flowers. You know what isn’t nice? Getting flowers when your brother is here and having to be Houdini, making the card disappear before he sees it.

ZANE:

I knew you had many talents.

ME:

Don't try to butter me up.

ZANE:

You coming over after work?

ME:

Depends.

ZANE:

On?

ME:

Well, what is in it for me?

ZANE:

My sunny disposition and winning personality.

ME:

Ehhh, pass. That describes me.

ZANE:

My mouth, my fingers, and my dick.

ME:

Sold.

“Well, whoever it is, is making you blush,” Kylie teases from the side, and I turn my phone over. “You need a minute?”

“Yes, I can't work in these deplorable conditions.” She bursts out laughing. “Also, I want lunch.”

The rest of the afternoon goes by at what feels like a snail's pace, Kylie leaves right after lunch to go and pick up the kids with Knox. Finally, at three thirty I pack up my things and head out.

I call him as soon as I pull out of the garage. “Hey, beautiful,” he croaks, and his voice is deep and it sounds like he was sleeping.

“I just left work,” I tell him. “Should I come over now or later?”

“Now,” he replies. “Call me when you are close and I'll open the garage door for you so you can park inside.”

“Should I bring anything?” I ask him. “Pick up anything?”

“Just you, baby,” he says, his voice a grumble, and I can’t help but smile.

“See you soon,” I say, putting the phone down. Pulling up to his house, he’s standing in the open garage door. He waits for me to turn off the car before pressing the button for the door.

I am barely out of the SUV when he wraps his arms around me and gives me the biggest hug I’ve ever had in my whole life. It’s not a hug that says “Hey, glad you’re here.” No, it’s a hug that says, ‘Now that you’re here, I’m okay.’

“Someone missed me,” I note, looking up at him and seeing his eyes look tired.

“Best thing that happened to me today,” he replies, and I reach up to touch his face.

“I thought the best thing would have been the team winning.” I try to make a joke out of it.

“Seeing them win was good.” He wraps his arm around my waist as we make it inside. “Reading the headlines today, not so much.”

“Don’t you know the rules?” I ask him. “Never, ever read the headlines.” I smile up at him as he walks us into the kitchen. “It’s like a rule in our house that we weren’t allowed to read the headlines or talk about the headlines. Sort of like Fight Club.”

He picks me up and places me on the counter, and my legs open for him as he steps in between them. “No one told me that rule,” he admits as I lay my arms on his shoulders. “I should probably listen to that one.”

“You should,” I tell him. “Follow me for more of my TED talks.” I make a joke and when he bends his head, his mouth swallows our laughter. His tongue slides into my mouth and the kiss softens, and then it’s as if we haven’t seen each other in weeks or months. He pulls me closer to him and

my legs wrap around his waist. His hands go from my back to my breasts, and he's about to peel the shirt off me when the doorbell rings.

He steps away as he looks at me as if I'm the one ringing the doorbell. "Yeah, right, it's me," I say, pushing him and then I look around. "Who is it?" I ask him.

He walks over to the side of the fridge, checking his monitor and his hands go to his head. "It's your brother."

"What?" I hop off the counter. "Why?" I ask him, looking around and then heading for the stairs. "I'll be in your room. Do not tell him I'm here."

"Yeah," he hisses at me as he runs his hands through his hair, "that's exactly what I'm going to tell him." I make it downstairs as he opens the door.

"Hey," I hear him say as I hide at the entrance of his room, looking up, "this is a surprise." He clears his throat. "Come in." I put my hands on my mouth when I remember I left my purse right near the garage door.

"I think we should talk," Jaxon says, and I lean in more to make sure I can hear him, "especially after what happened on the road."

"Yeah," Zane agrees, "we should. I'm sorry for snapping at you. There was a time and a place for it and the bench wasn't one of them."

"I deserved it," Jaxon admits, and I smile, but then the smile fades. "Listen, I want you to know I think you're a great guy." My stomach tightens and my mouth dries. "I just don't know if you are the guy to lead the team." I close my eyes, the burning at the back of my neck makes my eyes go dry and start to sting. "I think that a couple of years down the line with more experience under your belt, you would be fantastic."

"So you came over here to tell me that I suck at my job?" Zane's voice sounds as if he's both pissed and sad at the same time.

"No, I came over here to tell you I think you should really think about things moving forward. Change things up a bit. Go back to what Martin was

doing, since it was working. Maybe this group of guys is too much for you. They're veteran players and most of them don't really take well to change."

"Are you one of them?" The question is valid. I close my eyes as I wait for the answer.

"No, I'm not one of them," he replies. I want to smile but his next words take it all back. "But I'm also going to say that I've started to change my mind." I put my hands on my head and all I want to do is charge out there and tell him that he's wrong. He's so, so wrong.

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. . .

Zane

I SIT ACROSS FROM JAXON ON THE COUCH, WATCHING HIM TRY NOT TO MAKE eye contact with me. The whole conversation guts me, to be honest. It's one thing for the headlines to tell you that you aren't fit for the job. It's one thing for your boss to shit on you and tell you that maybe you aren't up to his standards. It's a whole different thing when one of the players, who is supposed to be standing with you, tells you that you might not be right for the job.

"Are you one of them?" I ask him the question and wait for his answer.

"No, I'm not one of them," he answers as he shakes his head and looks down and then he looks back up—man-to-man, eye to eye. "But I'm also going to say that I've started to change my mind."

"You think it was easy sitting up in the press box watching my team on the ice, knowing I couldn't do anything?" I let that linger in the air for a minute. "Because let me fucking tell you, it was fucking hard to watch. It's the same feeling you must get when you are in the box and not able to help your team." I stick him, knowing that is going to bug him. "You think because you guys won one game when I wasn't behind the bench that it means I'm not good for the job?" I ask him.

"It's more than that and you know it."

“Is it?” I ask him, getting pissed now. Hurt still lingers there under the surface because I thought we were friends. “What does it say about you?” I ask him. “You’re captain of this team,” I point out. “You are supposed to lead the team.” His jaw gets tight. “I don’t see that happening. You see cracks in the foundation just as me.”

“Now, wait just a minute.”

“Not such a good feeling, having something like that thrown in your face.” He doesn’t say anything. “I’ve had people telling me from day one that I shouldn’t be in this position. That I shouldn’t have gotten the job. I started this fucking job with two strikes already on my back. One, that I was the youngest one out there and two, people didn’t think I could do the job.” The statement shocks him. “Yeah, so I’ve been dealing with trying to prove them all wrong, while trying to guide a group of men to play to their best ability. What have you done? These guys”—I put my elbows on my knees—“some of the best guys I’ve seen on the ice. Best rookies I’ve ever seen play. I can only help steer them, but you—” I point to him. “You need to lead them on that ice. You want to point the finger at me and blame me?” I shrug. “Maybe you’re right, maybe I’m not good for the job. Maybe there are other people out there more qualified. But I’m here and I’m going to fucking fight to stay here. What are you going to do? Tell me, what are you going to do?” I wait a second to see if he will answer me, but he doesn’t. “Or better yet, if you were me, what would you do? Would you just bow your head and walk away, or would you stay and fight?” He opens his mouth. “If you tell me you would bow your head and walk away, that’s a fucking lie.”

“I was going to say I would stay and fight,” he admits.

“But you want me to pack it up and move on.” I point to myself and shake my head. “Well, I’m not going to do it. I might not be the right man for the job,” my voice gets tight, “but it’s my job for however long they let me have it. I’m asking you to fucking work with me.” He doesn’t say

anything. "Something is going on in that locker room, and I don't know what it is."

"You." He points to me. "You are what's going on."

"No." I shake my head. "It's not me. It might be about me, but it's not me. There is a divide and one side is working with me and one side is working against me. I don't know who is on either side." He raises his eyebrows. "What side are you on?"

"I'm on the team's side," he snaps.

"Then find out what the fuck is going on and lead the fucking team." He gets up, his eyes in slits as he turns to walk out of the room. "And try not to fuck it up by taking penalties." I try to hide the smirk. "I need you on the ice and not in the box."

"I'll see you tomorrow, Coach," he says and I nod at him.

"Unless I get fired tonight," I sigh and he walks out of the house, and the sound of the front door slamming has me exhaling in relief.

I wait a full two minutes before I get up and walk to the front door, locking it and then looking outside. "He's gone," I call loud enough that she can hear me and come out of her hiding spot.

I walk over to the kitchen and open the top cabinet, grabbing the whiskey out of it and then pouring myself a glass. I take the shot as she walks into the kitchen, putting the glass down on the island and then extending my hands to the sides, hanging my head. "Well, that was something," she says, walking over to me and standing beside me. "Are you okay?"

"No," I admit. I look over at her and see her eyes are red. "But I'm going to be, I guess." I raise a hand to cup her cheek. "How much of that did you hear?"

"I wasn't locked in a soundproof room." She tries to make me smile. "Pretty much all of it. I'm sorry."

"For what?" I ask her, turning and leaning my hip into the counter.

“For my part in it,” she says, looking down, and I put my finger under her chin and lift it up so she’s looking at me.

“What the fuck are you talking about, Victoria?” I ask her, my heart hammering in my chest for a whole different reason.

“This is one of the reasons why you didn’t want to get involved, and I sort of pushed you.” She grabs the glass of whiskey that I poured for myself and swallows down a gulp and then hisses. “That’s disgusting,” she says, coughing. “Why would you drink that?” She walks over to get a glass and then fills it with water. She takes two full sips before she turns to me. “You said you had to focus on work and your head had to be in the game.”

“I did.” I nod, waiting for her to get whatever it is she needs to get off her chest.

“And instead of just stepping back and letting you do what you needed to do, I was full of my awesomeness and I forced you into this.”

“Your awesomeness?” I try not to make a joke, but the grin comes out.

“Well, I pushed you too far and you snapped,” she says softly, “and maybe you were right.” My eyebrows pinch together.

“Are you breaking up with me?” I say, trying to remain calm.

“No, I’m just giving you an out,” she offers.

“You’re giving me an out.” I fold my arms over my chest. “What if I don’t want an out, Victoria?” I turn it around and ask her the question. “What if you are the best fucking thing that has happened to me in the clusterfuck that has been the last couple of months?” She just stares at me. “What if you’re the one I’ve been waiting on my whole life, and you just walk out the door and I let you?” Her eyes go big. “What would that say about me?”

“That you’re stupid,” she retorts. “I was trying to help.”

“By breaking up with me?” I shake my head and reach for the glass. “Wow.”

“Don’t you fucking wow me, Zane Lincoln Gilmore,” she barks, and I try to hide the smirk with the glass in front of me. “I’m trying not to put more pressure on you.”

“Then stop trying to break up with me. You are always walking away from me.”

“I’m going to walk away from you in less than a second if you don’t quit it,” she snaps at me.

I grip her hips and put her on the counter, where she was before her brother came in. She opens her legs, letting me in, and I push her hair off her shoulder so I can have access to her neck. “You,” I say, kissing her neck gently and she moves her shoulder up and her body shivers under my kiss, “are the only light in all of this. There is so much shit going on in the rest of my life that you are my saving grace.” I push the other side of her hair behind her as I kiss the other side of her neck. “I’m sorry it’s not going to be all roses,” I tell her as she drapes her arms over my shoulders. “I wish it was. I wish I wasn’t butting heads with your brother. Wish my team was riding high the way they should be, and I really wish you weren’t here for that conversation.”

Her hands move from my shoulder to my chest. “He was out of line,” she states softly. “If he wanted to say what he did, he should not have come to your house to do it.”

“It’s the only place where he felt comfortable doing it, without anyone listening,” I explain. “Well, there wasn’t anyone who was supposed to be listening.”

“I was this close,” she picks up her hand and holds her thumb and forefinger together, “to coming out swinging.” I tilt my head and kiss her, stopping her from speaking.

“Whatever happens with us, the last thing I want is for you to be in the middle.” I look at her and raise my hand to touch her cheek before palming it in my hand. “I will protect you at all costs.”

“My knight in shining armor.” She smiles big and I see the sadness that was in her eyes is now gone. I know I did my part in putting it there, and then made sure I took it away. I know it probably wasn’t easy for her to hear that conversation, and I wish she hadn’t, but now she knows where we all stand, I guess.

“You bet your ass,” I confirm, trying to shift the mood. “Now, what are we going to do tonight?”

“Well.” She sighs. “I was thinking we could maybe order some pizza. Then we could take a bath.”

“Is that what you want?” I ask her and she nods her head. “Do you want to do the bath before or after we eat?”

“Are you going to fuck me before or after we eat?” she counters my question with her own question.

“I was planning on doing both.” I pull her to me, my cock hard for her. “Maybe order the pizza, fuck you on the counter.”

“Yes.” She giggles. “I like the sound of that.”

“Then fuck you before we take a bath or fuck you after the bath.”

“I mean”—she looks up to the ceiling as if she’s thinking about it—“if you are really up for the challenge, you could probably do all three. Before, during, and after.” I throw my head back and for the first time in what feels like forever, I laugh, like hardcore belly laugh. “I mean, if you think your heart can handle it.” She kisses under my jaw. “I wouldn’t want to push you too far at your age. I think we should be fitting you for a Life Alert alarm.” She is fighting to not laugh. “You know, ‘I’ve fallen and I can’t get up, please help.’”

“I WASN’T the one who couldn’t keep up the last time,” I remind her.

“THAT’S because I had to bury my face in a pillow so no one would hear me. I almost suffocated myself.” She quickly defends herself. “I told you it was too much.”

“NO, YOU DIDN’T.” I chuckle. “I believe you said, ‘give me more, Zane,’” I repeat her exact words. “I want more,” I try to mimic her voice.

“WE OBVIOUSLY AREN’T EVEN GOING to have sex once with that attitude,” she sasses and bites her lower lip to stop herself from talking.

“I’M GOING to need you to stop talking and save your breath.” I pull her shirt off her, leaving her in her white lace bra. “Better than that,” I pick her up off the counter, “I have something to fill your mouth.”

SHE GASPS and I’m expecting her to push me away, but what I’m not expecting is for her to drop to her knees. “I hope your heart can handle it,” she teases, unbuckling my pants, pushing them over my hips. I watch her pull my cock out of my pants and take it to the back of her throat, the conversation now tabled.

WE END up ordering pizza twenty minutes later, and eating it with her wearing my shirt, I wouldn’t trade it for all the wins in the world.

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twenty-six

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Victoria

I PICK UP THE PHONE BESIDE MY BED AND SEE IT'S JAXON CALLING ME. "You've reached Victoria," I start to say, "she's either unavailable or doesn't want to speak to you."

He barks out a laugh. "Very funny," he says. "I'm going to be at your place in ten minutes."

"I can't wait." I get up and walk to the bathroom where I put in my diamond stud earrings. "Are you going to stop the SUV, or am I going to have to jump in when you drive by?"

"Take your time," Ariella interjects. "I have to come in anyway. I need to use the bathroom."

"Again?" Jaxon says and I can feel the look she is giving him. "Yeah, take your time," he tells me.

"See you soon." I hang up the phone and then go into my closet to slip on the pair of black satin shoes with a crystal hoop on the toe. I turn as I check out the whole outfit, the black dress hits me mid-thigh, tight around my waist and then flares off just a touch. The whole dress has black flowers embroidered on it with see-through sleeves covered in stitched on flowers. I love that the V in the front gives off a hint of boob. My hair is swept back in soft little curls on the sides of my face. My makeup is smoky but with a hint of silver around the corners, making my blue eyes even brighter. I put on a

bit more blush than I normally do and make sure my lips are lined with a soft pink, almost purple, lipstick, and I apply a clear gloss on them, knowing it drives Zane crazy. I smirk when I think of him as the front door opens and I hear heels on the floor. “Hello,” I call to the doorway, seeing Ariella run by as she waves her hand.

“How much water does she drink?” I mumble as I walk out of the room and see Jaxon sitting on my couch, looking at the vase of flowers I had delivered yesterday.

“Is this new?” he asks me of the yellow roses that sit in the middle of the table.

“Well, considering the last flowers were red and these are yellow”—I walk over and slide my lip gloss in my black handbag—“I’m going to say yes.”

“He sent you flowers again?”

“What can I say?” I smile at him and raise one shoulder. “He really likes me or maybe it’s certain parts of me he can’t forget.” He groans as Ariella comes out of the bathroom.

“This dress is too tight for me,” she complains of the dress she has on. “Literally feels like I’m going to pop out of it.” Her black dress is off the shoulder and is tight all the way down to her mid-calf. Her black heels are satin like mine, but sling-backs with crystals crisscrossing the front.

“You look amazing,” I assure her, “and it fits you fine.”

“Okay, let’s go so we can get there and then leave,” she says. “Casino nights to raise fund for the Warriors Foundation is always a good time, but I’m exhausted.” I look over at her. “Jagger is breaking in his molars and is determined to do it not sleeping.”

“Let’s go get this over with.” Jaxon gets up and I see he’s wearing a blue suit with a baby-blue shirt, which makes his blue eyes pop even more.

I walk out with them, following them to the SUV as I take out my phone and send Zane a text.

ME:

On my way.

ZANE:

Already here. See you soon.

I put my phone back in my purse and look out the window as the three of us talk about nothing. We get to the arena and Clive is dressed in a black suit for tonight. “Hey there,” he says, opening Ariella’s door and then mine. “Look at how beautiful you two look.”

I smile at him as I get out, the sound of our heels clicking on the cement. We walk over to the door the players and staff usually go into. I’ve been in there a handful of times for the family skate day, as well as the barbecue, and now for the casino night.

I swallow down the lump in my throat as we walk down the hallway. We pass the locker room that is closed and locked and then Zane’s office. The door is slightly ajar and the light on his desk is turned on. I can hear music playing and as we get closer and closer there are more voices.

The whole arena has been transformed. A black floor is now down over the ice. On one side of the rink are casino tables, from blackjack to roulette to craps tables. Nearby, a lounge area is filled with black couches and are paired off for people to sit on and chat. On the other side are some round tables for eating and men and women dressed in white shirts and black pants are passing around cocktails.

My eyes scan the room to search for Zane and when I see him, I swear I take a second to get my breathing under control. He’s standing, talking to a man I’ve never seen before. He’s wearing a black suit with a white button-down shirt and no tie. The two buttons of his shirt are open. He must sense my gaze, or maybe he’s searching for me when he looks over and we lock eyes.

“There are Knox and Kirby,” Jaxon points out, and I give Zane a small smile before I turn and follow Jaxon, instead of going to Zane and kissing

him. It's been over two weeks since we've had that talk at his house. I want to say things have settled down, but that would be wishful thinking. The team is pretty much divided. At this point, someone is going to either snap and get with the program, or I hate to say it—let alone think it—but Zane will be out of a job.

The press is its own beast. There isn't one day, whether they win or lose, that Zane's not dragged through the mud. It's come to the point that I'm blocking them out for my mental health. I can't imagine what he's going through. I know it bothers him, but I also know there is no space for that to seep into our relationship, so it's not talked about. We speak about the game and how he's feeling, but the whole tabloids shit is the very big elephant in the room.

"Hey." I hear Lexi and smile at her as I kiss her cheek, and then do the same thing to Kylie, as if we didn't go shopping less than twenty-four hours ago to buy these dresses.

"Hey." Zane's voice appears behind me, and I turn to see him approaching us. He stands next to me, bending to kiss Ariella's cheek and then doing the same to Lexi and Kylie. "Hi, Victoria," he says, as if we didn't wake up together, as he kisses my cheek.

"Hi, Zane," I reply, sounding a bit more peppy than I should. "How are you?"

"Doing good, thanks," he says as he looks at the guys.

"How is everyone doing?" he asks them, and I look over at Jaxon to see if he's going to give him attitude, and I get ready to bite my tongue if he does.

"Good." Knox is the first to answer him then looks over at me. "I thought you were going to bring a date tonight."

"You were going to bring the guy you are seeing tonight," adds Jaxon.

"I was," I say, right before I roll my eyes, "but then he found out you were going to be here, and well, he thinks you're a tool, so he said hard

pass.”

Ariella is the first to snort-laugh as Jaxon glares. “He thinks I’m a tool?” He points to himself.

“Oh, please.” I hold my purse in both hands before I forget that we are supposed to keep our relationship quiet and hold his hand. “You give yourself too much credit.”

“So you told him about me?” Jaxon puts his arm around Ariella.

“You think if I told him about you, he’d still want to date me?” I laugh. “Please, he would run for the hills.”

“Because he’s scared of me?”

“No, because you suck on the ice.” I point at Jaxon, who glares. “Now that we’ve gotten that taken care of—”

“You know this guy sends her flowers like twice a week.” Jaxon looks over at Knox and Kirby like it’s foreign.

“You should take notes,” I urge him. “Ariella was saying that she felt like you are dismissive of her feelings.”

Ariella gasps. “I did not say that.” She shakes her head. “She’s fucking with you because it’s so easy.”

Jaxon glares at me. “I’m hungry,” I say. “Anyone else?”

“I could eat.” Knox nods. “I have to take my turn at the roulette table in thirty minutes.”

“Oh, there you are,” Jill says, rushing over to us and heading to Zane. “I was looking for you. There are a group of single ladies who would like to meet you.” I swallow down the lump that forms in my throat and try not to snap. “They want to meet the big burly bearded coach.”

“I’m not interested,” he quickly says.

“Okay, well, can you pretend?” she suggests. “It’s for the Warriors Foundation that benefits the children’s hospital.”

“I’m going to go eat,” I say, avoiding looking at him so he doesn’t see how much this bothers me. I smile at everyone as I walk to the buffet and

grab a plate. I'm sitting down when Ariella sits next to me while the phone buzzes in my purse.

I take it out, seeing it's a text.

ZANE:

Meet me in my office.

I look around, not seeing him anywhere. "I have to go to the restroom," I say, looking at the table that is now filled with everyone. I hope Lexi or Kylie say they don't want to go also as I quickly slip away.

I walk with my head down as I sneak back to where we walked in. I see a couple of the guys from the team, so I smile at them as I walk, hoping none of them hang around. I'm in the hallway with a couple other people, stopping right outside his office door that is more open than before. But I know I can't just walk in, so instead I look at the mural wall of my brother, trying to pretend I'm interested in it until the coast is clear. It feels like forever until it clears and as soon as I see no one around, I slip into his office.

The door is shut behind me and locked when I feel him push me against it. "Zane," I say his name as I feel him bend to take my mouth. My purse drops to the floor when I lift my hand to hold his face as he slides his tongue inside. His hands go to my ass, lifting me off my feet so my pussy is right over his cock. "Zane," I repeat his name when he rips his mouth away from me.

"Do you know how torturous this is?" he whispers in my ear as he puts me back down on my feet, his hands going to the hem of my dress as he grips it in his hands, pushing it up. "Do you know how hard it is?"

I look up at him as my hand comes out to rub his cock over his pants. "Is it this hard?"

He kicks one foot to the side, making me open my legs as he rubs his finger down the lace of my panties. "I'm going to show you what I wanted to do to you the minute I saw you walk in wearing this dress." He kisses my

mouth; his hand moves my panties to the side, and he slides a finger in me. His mouth swallows my moan. “Shh,” he warns, while he lets go of my mouth as he adds another finger in me. His mouth goes to my ear as he whispers, “I saw you walk in and saw your legs, and I wanted them wrapped around my neck.” His fingers work magic on my G-spot and within seconds I’m drenched for him. “Does my girl want me to lick her pussy?” he asks and I nod my head. “Or does she want me to fuck her pussy?” I move my hips to meet his fingers. “Bend you over right now and fuck you?” The sound of both of our heavy breathing fills his office. “Or would you like me to fuck you against the door?” His thumb swipes my clit and I’m over the fucking cliff.

“Zane,” I say his name and I hear him chuckle before his mouth crashes on mine and he finger fucks another orgasm out of me.

“Tonight, when we get home, I want you to ride my face.” He nips my ear. “I want to lie down, and I want you to ride my face like you ride my cock.” His fingers don’t slip out of me, no, not with Zane. He wants another orgasm out of me and he’s fighting to get it. “I’m so hard for you,” he growls, and my hand comes up and undoes his belt, which shouldn’t take me long, but with his fingers in me, I can hardly focus. I spring his cock loose and grip the base of it in my hand.

“After I ride your face,” I close my eyes, “am I going to get to ride this cock?” He groans now. “Have you lie on the bed and straddle you with my ass facing you as I ride.” His finger scrapes over my G-spot and I can feel my legs shaking. “Ride you until I soak the bed.”

“Fuck,” he growls, “I’m going to—” He barely has the word out before I drop to my knees and take him to the back of my throat. One of his hands goes flat on the door, the other in my hair as he shoots his cum down my throat. I take everything he has to give me, waiting for him to go half-mast before I let him pop out of my mouth. I stand back up and he devours my mouth. I’m almost tempted to turn around, lift my dress up, and have him

fuck me, but I know, in a matter of minutes, someone will be coming to look for us.

“I have to get back,” I say when he lets me go. “I should check my face.”

“You’re beautiful,” he whispers, and I walk past him to his private bathroom. I turn the lights on and see my lipstick smudged, so I grab a Kleenex and fix it. I apply more of my gloss and then look at myself in the mirror.

I back up as I slip my panties off and then ball them in my hand, walking out, finding Zane waiting for me. “I’m going to go out first,” I tell him. “Then, well, good luck to you.”

I slip my hand into his pocket, leaving my panties, as he bends to kiss my lips softly. “Clean your lips before you come out,” I whisper, walking out of the door and coming face-to-face with Jaxon.

The back of my neck feels like I’m being branded. “Hey,” I say nervously and loudly so Zane can hear me.

“What the fuck are you doing in Zane’s office?” he questions.

“I saw him when I was going to the bathroom.” I try not to stutter. “He said I could use his office if I wanted to.” I shrug. “Then I got a call from my guy, so I shut the door for privacy,” I tell him as he looks at me. “Are you trying to spy on me?” I shake my head and step as far as I can from Zane’s office. “I’m telling Mom on you, and Ariella,” I add, moving away from the door and hoping he follows me. “It’s creepy.”

“I was not spying on you,” he hisses. “I was going to the bathroom and then I saw you.”

“Jaxon,” Kirby shouts from down the hall, “it’s your turn!”

“Hurry, hurry,” I say to him as he looks up and we head back out together. I look over my shoulder, hoping no one catches Zane, and thanking God we dodged another bullet.

twenty-seven

. . .

Zane

HER VOICE PITCHES HIGH, AND I KNOW SHE'S BUMPED INTO SOMEONE. I slowly advance to the door and hear Jaxon's voice. I turn around in a circle, taking in the office and wondering if I should hide in the bathroom, but then that's fucking creepy. I try not to move too much, in case I bump into something. My heart hammers in my chest and I want to kick myself for putting her in this position, but I couldn't take being around her and not being able to touch her. It was fucking torture, and I hated every second of it. So what did I do? I texted her and told her to meet me in my office. I planned to just take a moment alone with her to tell her how beautiful she was, but just like always with her, we went skyrocketing to the fucking moon. What started out as a sweet innocent kiss ended with her on her knees.

Now she was outside my office door with her brother arguing, and I was thinking about hiding under my fucking desk.

"I was going to the bathroom and then I saw you," Jaxon argues with her and then I hear Kirby shouting for him. I look up to the ceiling and breathe a sigh of relief when the voices move away from my office.

The phone buzzes from my pocket and I take it out to see it's a text message from her.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Coast is clear. I think...

ME:

You think...

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Well, at least from my brother and anyone who would have seen me come out of your office.

ME:

I aged ten years.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Great, so now you're a grandfather. I'm not sure I'm down to date a grandfather. A Zaddy sure, but a Grandzaddy doesn't sound appealing to me.

I shake my head and go over to the door and walk out without showing any guilt. I think it works, especially since my head is down and I'm pretending I'm texting.

I head back into the room and look around to see if I can find Victoria. She's standing with Eric and his wife as they laugh at something. My feet are moving toward her and the minute I can clearly hear her laugh, my cock gets hard again. "Hey," I say, and she looks over at me. Her beautiful face takes my breath away. Her smile goes just a touch bigger when she sees me. Her lips are glistening and all I want to do is grab the back of her head and kiss the shine away.

"Hi," she replies, and I can see her chest rising and falling a bit faster than normal, and I can't help the grin that fills my face.

"Is everyone enjoying tonight?"

"No," Eric's wife, Shelly, says, and I look over at her and see her laughing. "My feet hurt, and I'd rather be sitting on a beach doing anything but this."

I chuckle at her. "You and me both."

“It’s always fun to get out and dress up a bit,” Victoria shares and I feel a bit guilty because I’ve never taken her out on a proper date. It’s usually the two of us either at my house or at hers. Mainly my house and it consists of watching television, fucking, or walking on the beach. “Not always but sometimes. As someone who wears heels to work, sometimes twice a year is good enough.” She holds her purse in front of her.

“Oh, there you are,” Jill says, rushing to my side. “It’s your turn at the blackjack table.”

“Why?” I ask her. “This is more for the players.”

“Please?” She rolls her eyes at me. “The chairs are already filled with the ladies.”

I groan as Eric and Shelly laugh at me. “It would be good for you to date someone,” Shelly says. “You must be lonely.”

“I’m fine,” I assure her, and I avoid looking over at Victoria.

“Is anyone coming to my table to save me?” I finally look at her and she smiles.

“No.” She shakes her head. “But good luck with that.” Her smile is very deceiving because her eyes look like they could kill me.

I stare at her probably longer than I should before I nod my head at Jill, who is not going to leave my side until I follow her. I make my way over to the table and see she was not fucking kidding when she said the chairs were full.

“How long do I have to do this?” I ask Jill as we get close and I see one of the women smile my way.

“It’s thirty minutes,” she replies, and I take out my phone from my pocket and start a timer. “You must be joking.”

“I’m not,” I say gruffly as I look over to see Victoria is now with Lexi and Kylie sitting on one of the couches.

“Can you pretend to be nice?” She looks at me and asks. “Maybe smile.”

“No,” I reply as we get to the table.

“Ladies,” Jill calls to the table and the group of five women look up at me. Three blondes and two brunettes. “Your dealer has arrived.”

“Under protest,” I put in and Jill nudges me, “but it’s for a good cause.”

“It sure is,” one of the blondes agrees. “I’m Debbie.”

I don’t say anything to her, I just nod my head. “We should start,” I suggest and look over at the real dealer, who is watching to make sure I don’t fuck up.

“Place your bets,” he tells the girls, and they all stick some chips in the circle. “Now you deal them each one card,” he instructs me, “with a card to you, but it has to be face down.” I do what I’m told and then look down at the two that are flipped over.

“What do you want to do?” I ask the first girl who has a sixteen flipped over.

“Stay.” She smiles at me, and I move onto the next one until I get to the last woman, who has a twenty.

“How about we up the stakes a bit?” she urges. “If one of us wins this hand, you drop a number, your phone number.”

“Sure,” I agree.

“Then I stay,” she says, and I bust with twenty-four.

“So what’s the number?” She puts her elbow on the table and lays it under her chin.

“Nine,” I say, knowing full well there is no nine in my phone number.

They all share a look as if they have me. The next round they try again and this time I win, so I don’t have to make up a number. When the thirty minutes is over, I nod at them. “Have fun,” I say, turning around when I feel a hand on my arm.

“Thank you,” one of the blondes tells me, and I know she told me her name, but I didn’t care enough to register it.

“That was really fun,” she adds, her hand still on my forearm. “I’m sorry, I don’t usually do this.” She acts coy and there is nothing coy about what she is doing. “But I was wondering if maybe I can give you my number.”

I’m about to tell her no when the photographer comes by. “Can we pose?” he asks me.

“No,” I snap at him and he must think I’m joking because he laughs and puts the camera to one eye, as she pushes herself up against me and I lean to the other side.

The phone in my pocket buzzes and I pull it out.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

You look like you are having a great time.

I look up and see her turned away from me then she looks back at her phone, and I see her fingers moving.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

I left you a surprise in your jacket pocket.

I look up at her and see her staring at me as the girl next to me is still close to me. My hand reaches into my pocket, and I feel lace and my mouth opens. My eyes go back to look at her as she smirks and holds up her champagne glass to me.

“Oh good, you have your phone out,” the blonde says once the photographer steps away, “you can take my number down.”

I’m still speechless from feeling her panties in my pocket when the text comes in again.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Thought you could hold onto them for me.

“So what do you say?” She looks up at me.

“No.” I shake my head, and I turn to walk away from her, leaving her with her mouth hanging open.

“Hey.” I feel another hand on me, and I look over to see Shelly. “Come here,” she says, taking my hand and pulling me with her to the side. “I want you to meet someone.”

“I don’t want to meet anyone,” I mutter quickly, but then I’m in front of the woman who has long, curly red hair. “Zane,” she says my name as she lets my hand go, “this is Miriam.” I make a tight smile as I nod at her. “She works for the hospital.”

“Nice to meet you.” I’m more polite than I want to be since Shelly is there.

She holds her glass in her hand. “It’s a pleasure to meet you,” she says softly. “This is a great turnout.”

My phone beeps in my hand and I look down.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

I wore them for you tonight so it’s fitting that you have them.

ME:

I’m going to turn your ass red later.

I turn the phone around so no one can see.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Is that before or after I sit on your face?

I swear my mouth goes dry as I look up at Shelly and Miriam, who are now talking to each other.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Before or after you fuck me with your cock? Either way, I approve.

My eyes go to her, and she’s smirking as she looks away from me.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

I'm wet just thinking about it.

My cock goes rock solid and I have to take a deep inhale. I grip my phone in my hand so hard I think it might bend. "Excuse me," I say to Shelly and Miriam. Shelly gives me big eyes, while Miriam just smiles at me. "It was nice to meet you." I try to be polite as my phone vibrates in my hand. "Have a great evening."

I move to walk around them when my phone again vibrates in my hand. My mouth waters when I see she's sent me a picture of her legs, but her dress is higher than it should be and showing a lot of inner thigh.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Can you see the wetness?

My stomach feels like it's going to squeeze together as I look up and see that she isn't in the chair.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

I'm off. Have a lovely evening.

ME:

What do you mean you're off? Off where?

I look around frantically, seeing if she's fucking with me.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Jaxon said it's time to go so, we go.

I look around and then I'm about to take a step forward when Jill stops me again.

"Jill," I grit with clenched teeth, "I did my turn at the blackjack table. I posed for a picture." Her eyes go big. "Which you will not use ever. I want it deleted." I point at her. "Now I'm leaving." I pull up the text thread with the driver I hired for tonight to meet me now.

“I was just going to see if I can get a picture with you and the assistant coaches and Ken,” she explains.

“Then I’m leaving,” I practically hiss at her as she tries not to laugh in my face.

“Then you can go,” she says, shaking her head. “Jeez, someone is grouchy after having all those women fawn all over him.” She looks over her shoulder. “I have ten phone numbers that have been slipped to me.” She laughs. “I’m assuming you don’t want them.” Her side glare says it all.

I get to where Eric and Ken are chatting it up with the photographer. “Where is Cam?” Jill asks.

“Left,” Ken states.

My eyebrows go up as I share a look with Eric, who mumbles, “Shocking.”

“Okay, can we all face here?” the photographer asks as we pose for the picture.

“I’m out,” I announce, “my car is here waiting.” I shake their hands. “See you guys Monday.”

I turn and head out of the arena and my driver is there waiting, exactly where he left me. I get in. “Change of address,” I tell him as I give him her address.

He pulls up to the house, and twenty minutes later I’m getting out in front of her house. “Thanks for the ride,” I tell the driver, who nods at me and drives off as I walk to the door.

The lights are all off as I hold my hand up and press the doorbell. I reach in my pocket and pull out the small ball of lace she left in my pocket.

I hear the door lock open as she pushes through the door and I see the soft light all around her, but my mouth hangs open at what she is wearing, or better yet, what she is not wearing. The black see-through robe opens all the way down, showing me the little lace panties and nothing else. “Can I help you?” she asks wickedly.

I hold up her panties on the tip of my finger. “I came to return these,” I say, stepping in and gripping her around the waist with one hand and then using the other hand to slap her ass, “and to turn your ass red.”

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twenty-eight

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Victoria

I FEEL HIS FINGERS RUB OVER MY BACK AND THEN DOWN ON THE CURVE OF my ass. My legs automatically open for him, even when I'm half asleep. "That's my girl," he praises as he slides a finger in me. My back arches, giving him even more access to me. "Hmm," he groans out. My eyes open and look over my shoulder at him, his cock already with a condom on it as he lifts my hips off the bed.

"Zane," I say, leaning on my arms as he rubs the tip of his cock up and down my slit before sliding into me. He bends forward to kiss my shoulder before his hands move my hips away from him and then brings me back slowly. "Hmm," I murmur as he bites my shoulder, this time slamming into me. His hands move from my hips to my tits as he pinches my nipples. "Yes," I hiss as my ass pushes back into his cock.

"Take it, baby," he grits out as I move forward and then push back.

"Stop fucking around, Zane, and fuck me the way you want to fuck me. The way I need you to fuck me," I snap, frustrated I can't go as fast as I want to. He chuckles and then stops when my pussy contracts on his cock. He grips my hips in his hands, and I barely have time to grasp the sheets in front of me as he pounds into me, my back arching to make him go deeper. One of my hands snakes in between my legs to play with my clit. "I'm so close," I groan and he hisses as I feel his cock swell inside of me. You

would think, after all this time, I would be used to his size, but I'm not. "I'm so close," I repeat, feeling the buildup of the orgasm and trying to push it away, just a little more, so it can be even better, but I can't hold it this morning. "I'm—" I don't say anything else because Zane hisses, grunting out and thrusting, and I know right behind me.

His thrusts slow as he slips out of me and I collapse on the bed, turning to my side and seeing him fall on his back. "Well, good morning to you." I put my hand on his stomach as he tries to catch his breath.

"Figured since you woke me up with your mouth on my cock yesterday, I owed you this." He puts his hand on mine, bringing it to his mouth and kissing me.

"Well, I guess there are pros and cons to falling asleep naked." I look down at our naked bodies.

"You didn't fall asleep naked," he counters, laughing. "I think you passed out."

"It's the same thing." I chuckle as he moves out of the bed and looks down at me.

"That's what you get when you answer the door naked." He winks at me, and I look at his retreating ass as he goes to the bathroom to dispose of the condom.

"I wasn't naked!" I shout back at him. "I had a robe on!" I roll my lips when I look over at the see-through robe that he ripped off as soon as we got into the bedroom. His clothes are also scattered all over my room.

"Is that what you're calling it?" he questions, walking out of the bathroom, his cock at half-mast as he searches through the clothes for his boxers. "You want me to make you coffee?" he asks me, coming to my side of the bed and kissing my neck.

"Yeah." I stretch. "I'll meet you in the kitchen," I tell him, getting up and walking to the bathroom.

I walk out wearing a pair of shorts and a tank top, my hair piled on my head. He takes one look at me and picks me up, placing my ass on my island. “You do that often,” I tell him, laughing as he hands me my coffee.

“That’s because I like to stand between your legs.” He kisses my neck. “I like doing a lot of things between your legs.” He turns his head to the side and starts to kiss me when we both hear a car door shut. He looks at me and he’s about to say something when the doorbell rings, and then the knocking starts.

“Wake up, sleepyhead,” Jaxon crows and my eyes go big as he moves away from me, gripping my hips and putting me on my feet.

“Go and hide in my room,” I hiss-whisper at him. “I’ll get rid of him.”

“You’re naked.” He points to me, looking at me and then the door.

“Wakey, wakey,” Jaxon calls out.

“I’m not naked,” I deny, pushing him out of the kitchen and toward my bedroom.

“Your nipples are on display.”

“They’re just nipples,” I hiss at him but grab my terry cloth robe. “There, now hide.” I urge him as I walk to the door. My heart is hammering as I look up and try to act calm when I open the door. “This is almost criminal,” I say, trying to pretend I’m rubbing sleep away from my eyes.

“It’s the ass crack of dawn,” I point out as he comes in holding a bag in his hand.

“It’s almost ten and I’ve actually been up since the ass crack of dawn.” He walks into the kitchen.

“And you’ve already been up since your coffee is made,” he remarks, pointing to the cup that Zane was handing to me before he knocked. I look over at the coffee maker seeing Zane’s cup there.

“What are you doing here?” I walk into the kitchen, picking up the cup of coffee before turning and giving him my back. I try to make a plan to

move the cup without him knowing, but it will draw even more attention to it.

“I’m here because Ariella was craving those cinnamon buns, and I thought I would be a great brother and bring you one.” He holds up his hand. “But if you don’t change that attitude, you’ll get nothing.”

“Thank you.” I grab the bag from him. “That was very kind of you.”

“You okay?” he asks me. “You look flushed.” He tilts his head to the side. “You aren’t coming down with something, are you?” He puts his hand in front of his face. “I can’t get sick.”

“I think”—I fake cough—“I can’t come over.” I cough again, this time in his direction. “I’m sick.”

“Why are you so evil?” he asks, edging his way to the door.

“Because I’m the middle child,” I sass, making him laugh.

“We’re having dinner tonight since I leave on Tuesday,” he says. “Jagger misses you. You haven’t been over in a month.”

“Six days is now a month? I visit when you aren’t there,” I tell him, “so I can avoid you.”

He laughs. “I’ll tell Ariella you’re coming for dinner,” he states, opening the door. “I have to go!” he shouts back as he slams the door. I hold out my hand on the island and hang my head, breathing out a sigh of relief.

His car door slams shut and then starts before he drives off. “He’s gone,” I call toward my bedroom and then look up when Zane comes back into the kitchen.

“That was not fucking fun,” Zane declares, running his hand through his hair.

“I don’t know about you”—I grab my coffee—“but I had a great time.” He glares at me.

“Do you know how small your closet is?” He puts his hands on his hips. “It’s small.”

“It’s not that small.”

“It is when you are six foot six,” he hisses at me, “and as wide as your closet.”

I try not to laugh at him, but I can’t help it. “And your closet is like packed to the fucking gills, so I had to literally stop breathing so I wouldn’t move and make a sound.”

“Well, if it’s any consolation,” I put my foot on top of the other, “you did a great job.” His glare makes me burst out in laughter. “I’ll give you a gold sticker.”

“Let’s go have breakfast,” he suggests, and I tilt my head to the side.

“I thought we just had breakfast.” I point to my bedroom.

“We’ll go to my house first, so I can change.”

“I mean, we can go with you in that suit. That would scream I just had sex,” I singsong, holding my hands up in the air.

“No,” he says, and I silently laugh as I follow him back into my bedroom, where I put on a pair of yoga pants with a matching bra and a sweater.

“I really like these pants,” he growls when he steps behind me while I’m brushing my teeth, his hands rubbing my ass. “I’m going to like them even more when they are on the floor of my bedroom.” I shake my head as he kisses my neck.

We walk out of my house with him wearing his suit from last night. Well, half the suit, his jacket is in his hand. I get into the passenger side as he makes his way home to his house. It takes him ten minutes to change into a pair of blue pants and a sweater.

After breakfast, we decide to hit up the farmers market. He parks in the parking lot and when I walk around to the back, he’s there waiting for me. He slides his hand in mine as we walk around. “We should get some flowers for your house.” I point to the arrangement of flowers they have.

“I’m leaving for three days,” he mentions as I stop beside him, and he smiles down at me. “But if you want to get them, Victoria”—he bends to

kiss my lips—"get them."

"Tori." I hear my name being called from behind me and he slides his hand out of mine, as if someone poured cold water on him. I look back at him, seeing him duck his head and move five steps ahead of me. "I thought that was you," Nicole, one of the girls from my workout class, says. "You missed boot camp this morning," she notes and I smile at her.

"It was my Sunday lazy day," I reply to her, and a couple of minutes later she's on her way and I look over to see Zane at the end of the row of vendors. I suddenly hate this hiding and sneaking around.

I bend my head as I walk to him. "Hey." I suddenly feel off. "I'm ready to go," I murmur, and he looks at me.

"Aren't you going to get your flowers?" he asks me, pointing, and I just shake my head.

"You're leaving anyway," I say and he just nods his head and turns around, and we head back to his SUV. I get in, looking out the window, my head going around and around, and when I get to his house and walk into the kitchen, he is the first one to say something.

"What's going on with you?" He looks at me. "You became quiet all of a sudden."

"I know you've said you wanted to keep our relationship on the down low," I start to say nervously, "but maybe we could, I don't know, let it out of the bag?" I look at him. "Open the top just a bit, let some people in, or spill the bag on the counter and show everyone?"

He puts his hands on the side of the counter. "There is so much going on right now," he starts to say. "I'm in the press every single day. They literally destroy me." I swallow down the lump. "I just don't want that to affect you."

I try to hide the hurt from my face. "I understand." I force a smile on my face. "Yeah, you are probably right," I tell him. "I think I'm going to head out." I point over my shoulder. "Go and visit with Jagger."

“Victoria,” he says my name and just the way he says it, it gets me in the middle of my chest.

“It’s fine, Zane,” I reply. “I’ll talk to you later.”

I’m starting to walk out when he grabs my hand. “Victoria, can we talk about it?” he says softly, and I close my eyes for a second.

“There is nothing to talk about, Zane.” I look over at him. “You’re right, it’s not a good time.” His hand falls from mine. “I’ll talk to you later,” I repeat and walk out the door.

I get into my SUV and pull out of his driveway. The tears escape as soon as his house is in my rearview mirror. My phone rings and I see it’s him. I want so much to send it to voicemail, but my finger hits accept. “Hey,” I answer, trying not to sound upset.

“Victoria,” he says my name softly, “we need to talk about this.”

“There is nothing to talk about, Zane. We’ll keep it to ourselves. Everything stays status quo.”

“But you’re upset.”

“I am,” I admit to him, “but it’s fine. We’ll talk when you come back from the road.” He doesn’t say anything. “I’m at Jaxon’s,” I say, pulling into the driveway. “I’ll call you later.”

“Okay,” he replies, and I hit disconnect. I get out and head up to the door, ringing the doorbell before walking into the house.

“Hello, hello,” I call out, my voice trying to sound chipper as I walk into the living room and see Jaxon on the couch with Jagger playing by his feet. “There he is, the love of my life.” I hold out my hands and he runs to them. I bend to kiss his head before sitting on the floor.

I watch Jagger play, not saying a word, my eyes in a trance. “What’s up with you?” Jaxon asks. “You look sad.” I shrug. “Did you and your guy have a fight?”

“Sort of. I don’t think it’s going to work out with him.”

“Is that why you didn’t introduce him to us?” he asks me, the worry on his face now.

“I wanted to get to know him a bit before I just introduced him to my family,” I defend myself.

“You should get Ariella to fix you up with someone,” Jaxon suggests, and I shake my head.

“I think I’m sort of in love with the guy,” I confess, and he gasps. I’m even shocked I’m admitting this to him. “I’m just trying to figure things out.”

“If he hurts you,” Jaxon declares, “I’m going to find out who he is.” I chuckle.

“Thanks for having my back,” I tell him and take a deep inhale.

“Always,” he assures me. “I’ll always have your back.” I don’t say anything else to him. We spend the day at the park, and that night when I get home, there is the bouquet of flowers we were going to buy at the market.

A note on top.

Wanted you to have these.

Z.

I walk into the house and put the flowers in water and, for the first time in a month, I go to bed without calling him.

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twenty-nine

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Zane

THE PLANE LANDS AND I TURN AIRPLANE MODE OFF AND WAIT FOR THE messages to come through.

I see emails start to come in and then some texts, names pop up and I hope like fuck one is Victoria. But she hasn't sent me anything. I texted her yesterday, but she told me she was going home with a massive migraine, so I didn't want to bother her.

This morning, I sent her a text, asking her how she was feeling, and she didn't answer me. I look down at the phone and pull up the text thread anyway, pushing away the worry starting to unspool in my chest.

ME:

Just landed.

I then go over to see my emails as the plane is starting to slow down. I see two from Ken, one of them that is marked Urgent.

I open it up and read it right away. Seeing that he's cc'd Brad, Cam, and Eric.

To: ZG@LAWarriors.com

Subject: Owen, Hutson, Arber, Brady, Markus.

Gentlemen,

It's come to my attention that five players on the team have requested a trade. The requests were made official through their agent.

I am going to get on a call with their agent this afternoon to see if there is something I can do to try and get them to stay.

I'll let you know.

I look over and see the five guys in question all hanging together.

Brad responds within seconds.

Ken,

I'm going to need to be on the call. I'm assuming I know why they are asking for a trade.

I shut the phone down, not bothering to answer the emails. I get up, grabbing my backpack and look over to see Cam with the guys. He turns his phone and shows them the email, and I want to walk over to him and snatch his phone from him.

"Is he showing them the email?" Eric says. "What an idiot."

"He's not worth it," I say, walking off the plane and heading straight to the bus. I look over at Cam when he walks in.

"I'm guessing you got the email." His face goes a little white when he sees my expression, but he quickly recovers.

"Yeah, I was asking them what it was about."

"Save the bullshit," Eric snaps, "I can't deal with it. Eyes notice you always with them, I have to wonder if you're the little bird in their ear?"

"Whatever," Cam replies, sitting in the seat across from us.

We get to the hotel; everyone has a key waiting for them. I get into my room and my phone rings. I look down seeing it's Ken calling.

"Hello," I answer, putting the phone to my ear.

"Hey," he says, breathing heavily, "I thought I would call you." I swallow, thinking this must be it. "Just got off the phone with Steph," he says of the agent that represents them all, "they are requesting either a trade or that we get rid of you."

I sit on the bed. "Well, I don't know what to say."

“I will tell you I told him to fuck off, no one tells me what to do with my team, but that’s just because he pissed me off. I do have to tell you; Brad is already making the plans to replace you.”

“He’s been making the plans to replace me before I even started,” I tell him, putting my elbows on my knees, “so that doesn’t surprise me.”

“You have a big game ahead of you,” he says. “Why don’t you get through the game and we can figure things out when you get back?”

“Ken, is it worth it?” I ask him. “All of this. Is it even worth it?”

“The team is playing like shit and I’m sorry, but it has nothing to do with you. We know that at least those five are going to do what they need to do to make sure we lose the game.”

“I can’t bench them,” I tell him.

“No, you can’t,” he agrees, “but that doesn’t mean they need to have their full ice time minutes.” His voice goes low. “You pull off a win against Florida and there is nothing they can say about it.”

“If this works,” I tell him, “I’m going to want to sit down with you when I get back to go over a couple of things. If I’m going to stay, I’m going to need more support than Eric.”

“You have Cam,” he points out.

“I don’t,” I admit to him. “I don’t know what’s going on, but I can’t depend on him.”

“He’s been with the organization a long time, Zane,” Ken reminds me. “So before you bring this further, think about it.”

“I will.” I take a deep inhale. “Can I mention to the guys that I know about this, or is it supposed to be confidential?”

“Don’t give a shit. If they took this to their agent, confidentiality went out the window. I’m going to have to do what I need to do, and I needed you to know.”

“Thanks.” I put the phone down beside me and want nothing more than to call Victoria and talk to her about this. Just even to hear her voice.

That night, I pick up the phone and call her, and it rings twice and then goes to voicemail. I wait for it to beep and finally talk.

“Hey,” I say softly and close my eyes, “just calling to see how you are feeling.” I wait for a full five seconds before I say, “I miss you.” Then I hang up the phone.

I send her a text also.

ME:

Just called you. Checking in.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Hey, sorry, on a conference call. Talk later or tomorrow since there is a time difference.

ME:

Okay, hope you are feeling better.

I put the phone down and stare out the window. The next day I get up and I’m the first one in the bus as the team heads over to the rink for practice. I wait to be the only one in the dressing room with Jaxon before I say something. “Just wanted you to know, five players are asking to either be traded or have me replaced.”

The shock fills his face. “I knew there was tension for sure but to ask to be traded?” he snaps. “Who?”

“I’m not naming names, but just wanted you to be aware of it.” I look over to see Kirby walking in. “The two of you, I’m going to be giving you extra ice time tonight, but I’m not announcing it.” Kirby and Jaxon share a look. “Let’s get on the ice,” I urge, walking past them, knowing that Jaxon will fill him in. The practice is light since we play tonight and when we head back to the hotel, I look over at Eric. “I want to go over something with you.”

We walk into my hotel room, review the lines and I finally make my play. “They get less ice time,” I finally share. “I hate cutting the bench, but

I'm not fucking around. You can't be a team player; you don't get to play on the team."

"About fucking time," Eric declares. "I'll handle the lines."

"Let's do this." I slap him on the back and that night when I get to the arena, I can feel a difference in the room.

Jaxon and Kirby are quiet as they look around and take in everything. Knox just scowls at everyone, and I can't help but chuckle. "Gentlemen," I say before we take the ice, "not only are we playing the reigning Stanley Cup champions"—I look at the room—"we need these two points more than you know. Let's go out there and fuck things up," I say, clapping my hands and heading out.

The crowd boos us as soon as the players skate on the ice, and I look up at the board with a deep sigh. Eric and I decided we are going to play the lines like normal and slowly take time away.

Every fucking minute I feel like I'm holding my breath and when we finally score first, I can't explain how exciting that feels. This team is the best of the best. They didn't change anyone from last season. It doesn't take them long to respond, and we end the first period tied.

When we start the second period, I look over to see Cam huddling with the five players, but who really knows what he's saying. Things between us have still been tense and I'm not so sure he's being helpful. The first shift they get on, they fuck up the play and lose the puck, lucky for us, Jaxon blocks the shot.

When he comes back to the bench, he leans over Kirby. "You guys think you cannot fuck up like that again?" he asks them, and they just look over at him, giving him the stink eye. The second period has a lucky shot that bounces and there is nothing our goalie can do to stop it.

We start the third period trailing by one. "We can still tie this game," I state to the bench as Cam stands there with his hands behind him, rocking on his feet. Eric is giving the five players less and less ice time, and they are

glancing at each other, sharing a look, and then looking at Cam, who continues to side-eye me, the tension growing between us.

“Three minutes to go, we pull Sammy,” I instruct Cam, who shakes his head. “I’m not asking you; I’m telling you, at three minutes to go, we pull him out of the goal.”

“Big mistake,” he replies and then smirks, “but you’re the boss.”

I look over at Eric, who just shakes his head when Sammy comes to the bench, giving us an extra attacker on the ice. We have no choice but to put in Owen, who skates into the zone and then does the stupidest play known to mankind when he ices the fucking puck.

I shake my head, looking down, seeing we have twenty-nine seconds to go. “Another loss.” Cam shakes his head. “Ridiculous.”

Knox, Aaron, and Lane are on the ice with Kirby and Jaxon playing defense. The puck drops and the goalie comes over skating, giving us a chance to get an extra attacker on there. Josh jumps over the bench as Jaxon brings the puck into the zone and almost loses it when they poke check it away from him, and he saves it from going over the blue line.

“Shoot the fucking puck!” I yell and he shoots it at the opposing team’s goalie, but it looks like it’s going off to the side when Knox comes to stop it, and it flies into the back of the net with eight seconds to go. I swear you would think we won the Stanley Cup the way we all get up and celebrate. I shake my head and look over to see Knox coming to the bench to get high-fives. Eric comes over to me and shoves my shoulder as I look up and see the replay. The period ends, sending us to overtime.

I put Knox, Kirby, and Jaxon on and look down at Cam, who wanted to put Owen in there. I immediately took that away from him. There’s something going on with him and Owen. I just can’t prove it. The puck drops and Jaxon wins it, slapping it back to Kirby, who skates the puck into the zone. Cutting down the middle and then turning to come back to the blue line, he skates to the other side. Then Knox skates to him, taking the

pass from him. He moves to the right, going all the way across. The goalie goes to the right, sliding to protect the corner from his shot, and Knox just speeds up, wrapping it around the net and putting it in.

The red light goes on behind the net, the referee points to the net, telling us it's in and the bench erupts. They are flying off the bench as they go to celebrate with Knox. I walk down to the entrance of the tunnel, looking at the guys celebrate, and I chuckle, shaking my head.

I wait there for the guys to skate back to the changing room, congratulating them as they go by. Owen just glares at me when he passes me, not even caring that he's being disrespectful. I know he wants a scene, but I'm not going to give it to him.

Knox is the third from last player to come into the room, and I hold out my hand. "Now that deserves a gold star," I tell him, and he laughs.

The press conference after is grim, even though we just won against the best team in the league. There have been rumbles of the trades with a couple of the players, I play dumb and pretend I know nothing about it.

The bus ride back to the hotel is a little bit more cheerful than it's been in a while. When we get there, a couple of the guys go to the bar to eat. I join them and sit next to Jaxon and Kirby. "What's up with you?" Kirby asks. "We just beat the best team in the league, and you look miserable."

"He needs to get laid," Knox mumbles and I shake my head. "When was the last time you had a relationship?"

I think about lying, but she deserves a bit more respect than that, besides I'm not naming her. "I'm sort of seeing someone," I share. "It's just a bit complicated."

"She married?" Knox asks right away, ever since he walked in to his wife banging his brother-in-law, that's his first question when someone's seeing someone new.

"She's not married. It's not like that."

“I mean, she’s not married; you’re not married,” Knox observes. “You two are already winning.”

“Yeah,” I reply, “I guess so. It’s a bit more than that.”

“Was she at the casino night?” Kirby asks and I nod.

“She was there.” His mouth hangs open. “But like I said before, it’s complicated.” I can feel eyes looking at me and I look over at Jaxon, who picks up his water bottle as he watches me with a weird look on his face. “I’m going to head up.” I push away. “Good game, boys,” I praise then look at Knox. “You the man.”

I put my hands in my pockets as I head to the elevator. Looking at my watch, I see it’s just after eight back home. I walk into my room and toss my jacket on the long cabinet under the television. I’m about to kick off my shoes when there is a knock at the door.

My heart speeds up when I think it might be her. I pull it open to see Jaxon standing there. “Hey,” I say and he gives me a chin up before he walks into my room.

“Let me ask you something,” he starts, and his voice is tight, “and I want you to be completely fucking honest with me.” I stare at him, wondering what he is going to ask, not expecting the words that actually come out of his mouth. “Are you dating my sister?” The question makes all the air in the room stand still.

I swallow down the lump in my throat. “Yes.” I don’t even try to hide it. “I am.” I don’t even want to fucking hide it anymore. “I was, I think I still am.” I exhale, my chest so tight breathing is hard.

“What the fuck does that mean?” His voice is raised and I see his hands beside him flexing into fists. I know one of them is going to fly up and knock me out, and I’m going to let him because I deserve it.

“It means that I’m fucking in love with her,” I say the words out loud and I think I’m having a heart attack. “But I can’t let her get caught up in this media bullshit,” I tell him, shaking my head. “I won’t do it. Not to her.”

I can't stop shaking my head. "The press eats me alive every fucking day. You think I'm going to put the spotlight on her so they can blame her?" My voice gets tight. "No fucking way. No fucking how. She doesn't get touched by this shit because of me."

"So you fucked my sister," he says the words and all the blood in my veins feels like it turns to ice.

I take a step to him, toe to toe, chest to chest. "Watch your fucking mouth." My own hands ball into fists beside me.

The room feels like electricity is zapping in. "I have to watch my mouth when you are dating my sister and hiding her like she's some dirty fucking secret?"

"I'm fucking protecting her," I clarify, getting even more into his face.

"Protecting her," he says sarcastically, "by keeping her a dirty secret."

I grip his jacket in my hands. "I'm warning you, Jaxon, I will..." I trail off.

"You'll what?" he eggs me on, pushing me off him. "What the fuck are you going to do? How long?" he hisses out. "How long have you been hiding this bullshit?"

"None of your fucking business," I retort, refusing to give him anything. "You want to talk about this calmly, I'll talk, but you come at me or at her, and we're going to have bigger fucking problems than we already have."

"We got big fucking problems, the first is you dating my fucking sister." His voice gets louder and I glare at him. "When did it fucking happen?"

"The night they announced I was taking over for Martin," I reply, shocking him. "I didn't know who she was. We met at the hotel bar."

"That's a fucking lie," he hisses.

"Her flight got delayed and then cancelled. She stayed at the hotel next to the airport, the same hotel I stayed in when my house was flooded." His mouth opens. "I didn't know who she was until I came over to your house and saw her in your pictures."

“Holy—” His hand goes on top of his head.

“She’s the best thing to ever happen to me,” I admit to him. “I’ve never wanted anyone more than I want her. But I won’t let her get eaten by the media for me.”

“Then you’re a bigger fucking idiot than I thought you were”—he shakes his head—“and you don’t fucking deserve her.”

“Fuck you,” I hiss at him. “What would you do,” I ask him, “if you knew the press was waiting for any reason to tear me apart? Tear her apart? What the fuck would you do?”

“I’ll tell you what I wouldn’t fucking do.” He puts his hands on his hips. “I wouldn’t walk away from her. I would never walk away from her...” His voice trails off. “Until my last dying breath, I would never let her go.” He walks away from me, headed to the door. “You don’t love her enough.” He pulls open the door and I see Knox and Kirby there, shocked expressions on their faces. “Stay away from my sister.”

“Fuck you!” I shout and Knox’s and Kirby’s eyes go big.

“You hurt my sister, and you’ll have more to worry about than keeping your job,” he hisses as he walks out of the door and slams it shut.

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thirty

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Victoria

I GET OUT OF THE SUV AND WALK TO THE TRUNK TO GRAB THE TWO FABRIC bags that have wine in one and everything to make margaritas in the other. My heels click on the cement driveway as I walk up the steps to the front door and juggle the bags in my hands to open it. “I’m here,” I shout, “and I brought reinforcements!”

I walk down the hallway past the staircase and to the family room, seeing Jagger on the couch hiding behind Lexi. “I told him to hide so you don’t take him from me.”

I laugh and shake my head. “Traitor,” I tease him, leaning over the back of the couch and tickling his belly, making him laugh.

“Hey,” Ariella says, coming into the room. “You didn’t go home after work?” she asks me and I shake my head.

“You said ‘my house, four o’clock,’” I remind her, walking to the kitchen and putting my bags on the counter. “So I figured since it was already six, I was late.” I look over at Lexi. “Some of us have to work. My boss, she’s—” I don’t say the word.

“She’s needy,” Lexi fills in, laughing as she cuddles with Jagger. “I tell Kylie all the time to lay off, but she’s such a bitch.”

I snort-laugh at her and look around. “Where is Kylie?”

“She went home to change,” Ariella says, taking the bottles of wine out of the one bag and the tequila out of the other. “Go upstairs and change into comfy clothes and then we can watch the game.”

“Wait, you guys haven’t started watching?” I groan out.

“It’s a watch party, Tori,” Lexi explains. “We are recording it and we’ll start it from the beginning when Kylie gets here and so does the food.”

“Or we can fast forward and just see if they won.” I hold up my hands when they both look at me. “I’ll go change.” I point to myself. “You two start making me a margarita.” I turn to walk toward the stairs. “Not spicy like last time, I had heartburn for four days.”

“No one told you to drink that much!” Ariella shouts from the kitchen. “You were like ‘it’s sweet and spicy.’” I laugh as I kick off my heels at the door and jog up the stairs, going to the bedroom to change out of my work clothes.

I grab a pair of yoga pants and a Warriors T-shirt before heading back downstairs. “I’ve come to be supportive.” I sway, walking into the room with my arms outstretched, showing off my shirt.

Lexi laughs at me and the front door opens and then shuts. “I’m here.” We hear Kylie say as she comes into the family room where we are all standing. “Oh good, you didn’t start the game yet.”

“Do we really have to?” I ask, not really wanting to spend the night looking at the screen while my eyes try to find Zane.

“Yes,” Kylie replies, “it’s a big game.”

“Every game is a big game.” I roll my eyes, walking into the kitchen where Ariella is putting everything she needs for the margaritas in a pitcher and then stirring it while the other girls turn the television on and the announcers start talking.

“Who wants a margarita? Who wants wine?” I ask over my shoulder, going to get the glasses. Kylie and Lexi both vote for margaritas. I pour them each a glass before walking over and handing it to them. “You’re

welcome,” I tell them before walking back to the kitchen, grabbing mine, and heading for the living room.

I roll up in the corner of the L-shaped couch, curling my feet under me as I look at the screen. The guys are taking the ice and skating in their zone, and my eyes automatically go behind the bench. My heart feels like it’s going to explode when I see him walking out, wearing one of his blue suits with a darker blue tie. I take a sip of my margarita, ignoring the way the back of my neck starts to tingle. “I really hope they win,” Kylie says.

“They need to win,” Ariella states and instead of saying anything, I just drink my margarita. “Look,” Ariella says to Jagger, pointing to the television screen, “Daddy.”

“Dadadada,” Jagger babbles, pointing to the screen and then slapping Lexi’s leg to show her that his father is on TV.

The anthem starts playing and the camera pans to the benches and I catch sight of Zane. His eyes are looking ahead. “Fuck, he’s hot,” I say the words out loud instead of in my head, and my eyes go big. Three sets of eyes turn back to look at me. “What?”

“Did you just call Zane hot?” Kylie giggles.

I exhale. “Yeah,” I admit, draining the rest of my drink, “I did.” I get up, avoiding them looking at me, but I can feel the three of them staring at me and then at each other.

I pour myself another glass and bring the pitcher with me to the family room. “You missed your hottie on the screen again.” Lexi rolls her lips to try not to laugh, as Ariella snickers with her glass in front of her mouth.

“I’m sure I’ll see plenty of shots of him,” I mumble.

The doorbell saves me from them saying anything else. Ariella comes back into the room with two boxes of pizza and then takes out two trays of sushi she had in her fridge.

I get up to help her, carrying in the plates and a roll of paper towels so we don’t have to get up. The middle of the table looks like it’s going to

explode with food when Kylie shouts, “Goal!”

“You know, I think the game is over, we could find out now if they won or not,” I tell her and she gasps at me.

“Do you know the score?” She sits up straight. “Did you check? Did they win?” She puts her hands on her face. “Did they lose?”

“You need to calm down.” I point at her. “I literally went to the kitchen and came back.” I shake my head. “And my phone is right there.” I point to the place on the couch where I was sitting.

I grab a piece of sushi before sitting down in the corner again and looking at the screen to see the other team score. “That’s not good,” I say. Instead of the camera zooming in on the other player, it goes straight to Zane, who is looking up at the Jumbotron at the replay of the game.

“I guess he’s hot,” Ariella mentions, “in like a burly type of way.” I snort out when she says that. “The beard is a lot.”

“I love the beard,” I mumble, thinking they aren’t paying attention to me, but I would be wrong. “What? You can’t sit there and say he’s not hot,” I defend. “The beard is hot. The way his biceps bulge in his suit jacket.” I shrug. “Hot.” They turn back to watch television, leaving me with my own thoughts. Four glasses of margaritas later and half a tray of sushi, and my feet are stretched out in front of me. Ariella is on the other side of the couch with Jagger beside her drinking his bottle. Lexi and Kylie are sitting on the floor, their backs against the couch. “I think I’m in love with him.” I sigh.

“With who?” Ariella laughs and looks at me.

“With Zane,” I admit, pointing to the screen that is showing the guys playing hockey.

“Zane, Zane?” Lexi turns to look at me.

“The coach, Zane?” Kylie then does the same motion that Lexi just did, turning to look at me.

“Yup,” I confirm, drinking from the empty glass, getting maybe half a sip.

“No.” Ariella shakes her head. “No-no-no-no-no.”

“Yes,” I say, nodding my head.

“You just think he’s hot,” Lexi puts forth, nervously laughing and turning back to look at the game. “I think he’s hot and I’m in love with him are two different things.”

“Yeah,” Kylie scoffs. “To be in love with him, you would have to know him and shit.”

“Well, I...” I avoid looking at them as I trail off.

“No-no-no-no-no-no,” Ariella chants and she sits up.

Jagger sits up with her, shaking his head and then holding out his index finger. “Nonononono,”

“Hold on a second.” Kylie turns fully to face me. “Are you saying that you”—she points to me—“and Zane”—she points to the television—“*know each other?*” she emphasizes the words know each other and puts her two forefingers together at the tip.

“Yes,” I say, trying not to smile, but the buzz from the margaritas is making it very fucking difficult for me.

“Wait,” Lexi interjects while she stares into my eyes, reading whatever expression is on my face. I nod my head. “You had sex!” she shrieks out the word and then turns to look at Jagger, putting her hand in front of her mouth, as if he understands what she’s saying, before turning back and whispering, “You had sex with him?”

“Guilty,” I hold up my hand, “as charged.” The giggle escapes me.

“Oh my God. Oh my God. Oh my God,” Ariella chants and puts her hand on her head. Jagger thinks this is a joke and copies her actions.

“Shut up!” Kylie slaps the floor beside her. “You and the coach of the hockey team your brother plays on,” her voice goes higher, “got it on?”

“Correct.” I nod at her. “Very much got it on. Often too.” I smile big as if I just told them we have the winning lottery numbers. The fact that it’s not a secret is somewhat freeing in a way.

“I don’t want to know.” Ariella puts her hands on her ears and Jagger snorts, laughing as he puts his hands on his ears also.

“Oh my,” Lexi starts, looking at me and then at Ariella, “often, often?”

“Often enough,” I confirm. “We sort of—kind of.”

“If you say you had—” Ariella stops herself from saying the word sex, “in this house, I’m going to vomit.”

“We didn’t have it in this house.” I roll my eyes. “We almost did in his office.”

“The first time I banged Knox was in his SUV,” Kylie tosses out. “Then the second time when he came to return my panties I accidentally left in his SUV.”

“Accidently, my ass,” Lexi retorts.

“Zane returned mine too.” I hold up my hand for her to give me a high-five. “But I took them off and put them in his suit pocket to drive him crazy.” I giggle.

“So how is it?” Lexi asks and then holds up her hand. “Wait, stop, don’t say anything because I don’t know if I want to know for real.”

“I’m not going into detail.” I smile. “But he can do things with his fingers that make me think he’s a magician.” Ariella hides her face. “And his—” I whistle and hold out my hand. Ariella now peeks through her fingers. “Yup.”

“I have so many questions,” Kylie states.

“How?” Lexi gasps. “Like I’ve seen you guys together in places and you barely talk to each other.”

“We decided to keep it a secret,” I share and then my stomach gets tight. “But well, now I’m sort of tired of keeping it a secret”—I swallow the lump—“and he’s not.”

She’s about to ask me another question when the announcer goes crazy and we look up to see the game is now tied with eight seconds to go. Kylie jumps on her feet as she sees that it’s Knox who scored the goal.

Jagger now turns on his belly to get off the couch and jump with her. The camera shows the replay over again and then the reaction of the bench. “There’s your daddy,” Kylie jokes to me and I howl out in laughter.

“I think we call him Zaddy. Zaddy Zane.” Lexi laughs and drinks more of her drink.

“We are not calling him that!” Ariella exclaims. “Oh my God.” She shakes her head as the game finishes and Kylie turns.

“Should we?” she asks the group, and I look at her confused. “Should we cheat and check the score?”

“Yes!” I nod my head as the other two yell, “No!”

“There are five minutes and then if anything shoot outs,” Ariella says.

The guys get back on the ice. “Oh look,” I declare, pointing to the screen, “all three of your men.”

Their eyes are glued to the screen as the Warriors win the face-off. Lexi is on her feet with Ariella, and it happens so fast I don’t even know it’s happening until the three of them are jumping up and down. “We won! We won! We won!”

“He’s going to get so lucky when he gets home,” Kylie says of Knox, who scored the overtime goal. “So fucking lucky.”

“Eeew.” I shake my head, looking up at the screen as the three of them jump around in a circle together. Jagger is beside her holding onto Ariella’s hand. My eyes go to the screen where they show Zane smirking, then shaking his head and walking back, and I take back what I said. I don’t think I’m in love with him. I know I’m in love with him.

“COFFEE,” I mumble as I walk into the kitchen the next morning. One eye opens to see where I’m going, the other closed from the pounding of my head.

“Look who is awake,” Ariella says to Jagger, who is in his highchair, “Auntie TT.”

“TT,” he repeats, shoving scrambled eggs into his mouth as Ariella sits on the chair in front of him having her own coffee.

Her feet are up on the chair. “How is TT doing this morning?”

“I would feel better if we hadn’t chugged more margaritas after the game ended,” I mutter as I wait for the coffee to start and pour into my mug. I put my arm down on the counter and rest my head there.

I add some milk to my coffee, going to the table and sliding into the chair beside Jagger, who holds out a piece of egg for me. “Thank you, my angel, but Auntie TT isn’t hungry.”

I finish half my coffee when the front door opens and then shuts. I hear the thud of a bag fall before he comes into the kitchen. Jagger strains to get out of his chair to go to Jaxon. “Hello, my boy.” He smiles big, kissing Ariella first and then Jagger. His smile fades when he looks at me. “Oh, you’re here.”

My eyebrows pinch together as I pick up my coffee and bring it to my lips. “Hi,” I mumble, “I guess.”

He kisses Jagger on his cheek, walking to the kitchen to grab a facecloth and wipe his face. “So,” Jaxon starts and both Ariella and I look at him, “how long were you and Zane dating before you broke up with him?” The minute he finishes his question, I feel my heart both sinking to my stomach and feel like it’s going to come out of my mouth.

My eyes go immediately to Ariella, who is looking at me with her eyes big like saucers. “You told him,” I accuse, shocked she would tell him. “I’m pretty sure I said, ‘don’t say anything.’”

“I didn’t say a word.” She sits up straight.

“She didn’t tell me,” Jaxon defends her. “He did.”

I blink my eyes a couple of times. “I’m sorry, what?” I ask, both shocked and pissed at the same time. “Why?”

“I put two and two together.” He puts Jagger down and then glares at me. “You came over here and were moping, and then he was also mopey, said he was seeing someone,” he explains, “but it was complicated.”

“It’s a private matter,” I tell him.

“Then Knox asked him if the woman was at the casino night.” I try to remain calm. “And then it all clicked into place. You coming out of his office. Him being him.”

“What did you say to him?” I put my hand on the table to help me get up.

“I said what I had to say to him, and he said what he had to say.” My stomach gets tight as I stand up.

“What does that mean?” I bite down hard, the words coming out in a hiss.

“That means nothing.” He folds his arms over his chest. “It also means I told him to never go near you again.”

“You did what?” Ariella and I both shout at the same time.

“You did not!” Ariella shrieks and Jaxon pffts.

“I sure as fuck did,” he assures me, “and I mean it. Whatever shit you had with him is over.”

I ignore the last part of his sentence. “What did he say to that?”

“Doesn’t matter, it’s over between you guys anyway.” I glare at him. “Don’t you fucking glare at me, Tori. You’re lucky it’s me who found out and not Dad.”

I shake my head, walking into the family room and grabbing my phone. “No, you’re lucky,” I point to him, “that I’m not kicking you in the balls right now.”

“You had no right to do that,” Ariella scolds softly, “no right. She’s a grown-ass woman and she is allowed to date who she wants.”

“Yeah,” I agree, “what she said.” I shake my head. “I’m leaving.”

“Tori,” he snaps out my name and I look at him, “let it fucking go.”

“No,” I snap, my eyes going into slits. “You let it fucking go,” I fire back to him before turning and walking out of the house, slamming the door behind me.

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thirty-one

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Zane

I PUT MY BAGS DOWN AT THE DOOR AND WALK UP TO THE KITCHEN. THE stack of mail in my hands is tossed on the counter before pulling off my jacket and tossing it on one of the stools. I look down at the mail and start sifting through the letters when a car door slamming has me looking up.

I don't have to wait long before the doorbell rings, followed by knocking. I walk down the hall and pull open the door, thinking it's Jaxon who has come to finish what we started last night. "Victoria," I say her name in a whisper. She's standing in front of me wearing a pair of yoga pants and a wrinkled Warriors shirt. The feeling of dread that I had is now gone with her standing there in front of me.

"You told my brother we were dating." Her hands fly up in the air and then back down again.

"Hi," I say calmly. "Would you like to come in?" I move away from the door and when she walks in, it takes everything, and I mean everything, in me not to grab her and kiss the ever-loving shit out of her.

I close the door and follow her down the hallway to the kitchen when she twirls on her feet to look at me. "Why would you tell him?"

"In my defense," I put my hand to my chest, "I didn't exactly tell him; he guessed."

"You didn't have to give it up just because he guessed." Her voice rises.

“Why not?” My voice, trying to remain calm, goes up a notch or two.

“For one, I thought it was a secret,” she hisses at me.

I don’t know if it’s the fact that I’m exhausted, or the fact she’s here or just the fact I’m over all of this. “Well, maybe I didn’t want it to be a secret anymore.” Her eyes go soft, the lightness in her eyes makes them crystal blue. “Maybe I want people to know we were together.” The past tense word is making it harder to breathe. “Are together.”

“But I thought you said it was too risky.” The voice that was just shouting at me is now almost a whisper.

“It is,” I admit to her, “it’s more fucking risky now than it was before.” Her eyes stare into mine. “Five players on my team want to either be traded or have me fired,” I say the words and she gasps, her eyes asking the question. “Not your brother.” She sighs out in relief. “Well, at least before he found out about us.” I run my hand through my hair. “So, yeah, it’ll be harder than before,” I reiterate my previous statement, “but maybe you’re worth the risk.” Her chest rises and falls breathlessly. “You’re so beautiful, Victoria.”

“What are you saying right now?” she asks me.

“What are you saying right now?” I ask her the question back. “You didn’t call me back.”

“You deserved it.” She quickly fights back. “You let me leave again.”

“You walked out on me again.” My fingers twitch to feel her face. “You need to stop doing that.”

“You need to stop doing shit to make me walk out on you.” She points to me.

“Are you going to get your ass over here so I can kiss you?” I ask her and she doesn’t move.

“I told the girls about you.” She shrugs. “I was drinking, and you were on the screen in your suit and you looked hot.” My eyebrows go up. “They were all ‘he’s not hot’ and I had to defend your honor.” I roll my lips. “Then

I told them we were together.” She claps her hands in front of her. “Often.” I try not to laugh. “And Ariella thought it was at her house but then I said no, but it did almost happen in your office.” I watch her ramble in front of me. “They called you Zaddy.”

“No.” I shake my head. “Absolutely not.”

“It’s a compliment.” She defends her girls. “It means like Daddy,” she winks at me, “but Zaddy because of Zane.”

“I don’t give a shit why they call me that, they just never need to call me that again,” I hiss and she gives me a giggle. “So are you going to get your ass over here?”

“I also told them I thought I loved you.” She doesn’t move.

“You thought you loved me,” I repeat the words, making sure I emphasize the past tense of her words.

“Well, I’m pretty sure I love you,” she restates, and they’re the best fucking words I’ve heard in my whole life.

“I said the same to your brother,” I admit to her. “I think I said it while I had his jacket in my hands.” Her eyes go big. “It got heated.”

“I got the gist of it from what he told me,” she shares. “So you love me?”

I nod at her. “So you love me?” I can’t help the smile that fills my face when she nods. “Then get your ass over here.” I don’t even finish the words before she’s running to me and throwing herself in my arms.

I catch her as she wraps one arm around my shoulders, the other hand holding my face. “I did tell them how much I liked the beard,” she says, giggling.

“Did you keep anything to yourself?” I turn and head toward the stairs and my bedroom.

“Well, I think, if I remember correctly, I said you were a magician with your fingers.” I gasp. “I had margaritas, and I was in my feelings about you breaking up with me.”

“Baby, if anyone broke up with anyone, you broke up with me”—I walk down the stairs—“and then you avoided all contact with me.”

“Well, you brought that on yourself.” She puts her forehead on mine. “You should do better.”

“What am I going to do with you, Victoria?” I ask her as I stand in front of my bed.

“Love me,” she answers softly, “and never stop.”

“You going to stop walking away from me?” I ask her.

“You going to stop doing stupid shit so I don’t walk away from you?” she asks me, rubbing her nose with mine.

“I’ll try my fucking hardest,” I assure her, and she smiles.

“Same,” she replies before she tilts her head to the side. “Now kiss me.” She smiles at me and her mouth comes down on mine, her tongue slipping into my mouth as she kisses me.

I put her down on her feet and our clothes fly left, right, and center. I kick one shoe off to the right, the other to the left. She stands in front of me naked, her hand going to my chest. “Get on the bed,” she urges me, and I walk around the side of the bed and climb on, lying in the middle. I hold myself up on my elbows as she gets on the bed, crawling to me. Her hand goes to my chin as I smile at her, and she bites my lower lip before she’s kissing me again. I hold her cheek as her hand goes to rub my cock, my boxers still on me. “I need these off,” she pants out as her fingers go into the waistband of my boxers. She grips the side of them and I lift up, so she can peel them down my legs.

Holding my cock in her hand, she licks her lips before looking into my eyes and licking right up the shaft. My head goes back into the pillow as she takes the tip in her mouth and then swallows half of it. “Victoria,” I groan out her name as she slips her mouth off me and then twirls her tongue around the head of my cock. My hips reflectively move up to fuck her mouth. “That’s my girl.” I grip the back of her head and push my cock

deeper into her throat. Her watery eyes gaze into mine as she tries to take more into the back of her throat. "Open that throat up," I urge her when she gags a little. "Let me see you open for my cock." Her fist grips the base as she moves it with her mouth, working me. "I don't want to come down your throat yet," I tell her as I release her head. "That's later." She moves up my chest and throws her leg over my hips as she sits down on my cock.

My cock nestles in between her lips. "I didn't bring condoms with me." She moves her hips back and forth over my cock, her hands behind her on my thighs. My hand comes up to pinch her nipple. "And we used the last one the last time."

"I've never been without," I say through clenched teeth, feeling her heat on my cock, both hands playing with her tits as she moves her hips. "I'm clean."

"I'm on the pill," she states as she puts her hands, palms down, behind her on the bed, between my legs, placing her feet by my hips, "and I've never been without one."

One hand grips my cock while the other rubs her clit. "Never?" I ask her, my cock getting even harder.

"Never," she repeats.

"My cum will be the only cum to be inside you." I rub my cock through her slit up to her clit before moving it into her. "Fuck you and come in you." I rub her clit as she moves her hips up and down. The wet heat from her pussy on my bare cock makes me bite down and grind my teeth, it's so fucking good. Like fucking touching heaven. "You want my cum in your pussy?" I ask her as my hips move up and my finger works her clit. Her head falls back. "Tighter and tighter," I hiss as I slip out of her and she groans. I hold my cock up as it fucks her slit. "Painted your throat," I gloat as I slide back into her. "Painted your tits." She moves slowly now. "Only place left to paint is that pussy."

I thrust up and her tits bounce and she holds both sides of my neck in her hands as she wraps her legs around my back as I sit up. Her eyes stare into mine, her mouth open as she pants. “Your pussy is going to suck the cum right out of me.” She yells out my name as I slam inside her, her pussy clamping down on my cock, her juices dripping down my balls. I try to fight it away, try to make it last, but I can’t fight it. I lift up one more time and shoot my cum into her. Giving small, short thrusts as her pussy takes everything I have to give her, my cock slips out of her and she collapses on her back, and I look down to see my cum seeping out of her.

“Never, ever,” I say, my hand comes up, shoving my cum back in her, “have I been this feral about a woman before.” She opens her legs for me and gets on her elbows. “Never have I wanted to claim someone like I do you.” And it’s true. I’ve never had feelings like this for anyone before. Only for Victoria. Only for her. She moves her legs back, giving me full access.

“Take what you want, Zane,” she pants. “It’s all yours.”

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thirty-two

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Victoria

I STEP OUT OF THE SHOWER, LEAVING HIM IN THERE, SITTING DOWN ON THE bench, catching his breath. “If I thought sex with you before was amazing,” I toss over my shoulder, “now that we’ve ditched condoms, it feels like a whole different experience.”

“Yeah.” He grips his cock that was just in my mouth in his hand. “I was just thinking that.” I wrap my hair in a towel before heading to his walk-in closet and grabbing a T-shirt. “I’m going to go and get something to eat.”

I walk up the steps to the kitchen, going straight to the fridge and pulling it open. I grab two of the prepared meals, putting them in the oven and starting it.

I feel him before I see him, his face in my neck, his hands gripping my tits, rolling my nipples. “Zane,” I say his name as my ass pushes back into his cock.

“I need food,” I tell him, but I’m frantic for him, “you need food.”

“But I haven’t tasted your pussy yet today.” His hand lifts the shirt in his hand then two fingers run through my slit and inside me. “You’ve had my cock down your throat twice,” he mumbles, “and I haven’t even had a taste of you.”

“That’s because while I was riding your cock in the shower you told me you wanted me to swallow your cum,” I remind him. “And since I’m the

best girlfriend ever”—my eyes close as my legs open a bit—“I had no choice but to get on my knees and take care of my man.”

“Now it’s time for me to take care of you.” He slips his fingers out of me, grabs me by my waist, and puts me down on the counter. “Lift your shirt so I can play with your tits while I eat your pussy.” His tongue slides into my mouth as he becomes impatient and lifts the shirt himself. Both hands go to my nipples and roll them at the same time followed by a pinch before he bends his head to suck a nipple into his mouth. “Put your feet on the counter, baby, and open that pussy for me,” he instructs, pulling the T-shirt over my head, then stepping back to look at me. “Look at you,” he mumbles as he reaches up and rolls my nipples. “Nipples tight.” He pinches them and I moan. “Then this perfect pink pussy.” He uses one hand to rub the front of my pussy. “My perfect pussy,” he mumbles as I watch him slide a finger in me. “Isn’t it perfect?” I’ve never been so turned on in my life, and he slides another finger in me. “Tell me this is mine.” He bends to suck my clit into his mouth. “To play with”—he bites down now—“to eat.” He curls his fingers against my G-spot. “To fuck.”

“Only yours,” I pant out.

“Only mine”—he pulls his fingers out—“from now on.” His tongue slides into my pussy with his fingers. “You want to play with this pussy—” His fingers move faster; one hand comes up to play with my nipple. “You’re going to have to ask me.” I moan again and he stops what he’s doing when I close my eyes. “Open your eyes and watch me,” he directs, his voice tight, as my eyes drop to look between my legs. “If you need to come and I’m not here”—he moves his fingers in me—“you call me, and I’ll make you come with my words.”

“What if I can’t—” I can’t even talk, my breath comes in pants.

“Then you wait until I can talk and then you make yourself come.” His fingers move faster. “Tell me you understand me,” he says, licking my clit with the tip of his tongue and then burying his face in my pussy. The way

his beard feels against my inner thighs makes my hips move up. “Is my pussy needy?” He sucks my lips into his mouth. “She needs to come.”

“Yes,” I pant, “please.” I reach between my legs to grip his wrist. “I’m right there.”

“I know, baby. I know this pussy better than you.” I hold onto his hand and he ruthlessly finger fucks me on his counter, and I scream out my orgasm. “That’s it, baby,” he praises as his fingers come out of my pussy and he rubs my clit side to side before slipping them back in. “Ride it out.” I don’t even know how long it lasts but when I’m done, I lie back on the island, and he laughs. His thumb rubs my clit, and I slap it away. “Sensitive?” he asks me and I nod my head. “I think the food is ready.”

I sit up. “You plate it,” I tell him. “I’m going to go and get cleaned up and we should talk about things.”

He takes me off the counter and places me on my feet as I pull his shirt over my head. I’m about to walk away from him when he grabs my hand and pulls me back. “Give me a kiss when you leave the room.”

“Someone is very needy in this relationship, and it’s not me,” I tease, making him laugh as I get on my tippy-toes, kissing under his chin. I run out of the room on my tippy-toes, going back downstairs to the bedroom, where I snatch up my panties and put them on. I clean up, walking back upstairs and seeing the plates on the table.

“I put on panties,” I inform him, sitting down in the chair in front of him, “as a barrier.”

He barks out with laughter. “Victoria, if I want in your pussy, I’ll get in your pussy.”

I roll my eyes. “We need to discuss that.”

“You said it’s mine,” he reminds me, cutting a piece of chicken and popping it into his mouth, smiling at me and winking.

“I don’t think what we say during sex is allowed to be used against us.”

“Well, we differ then. I told you, you agreed.” He shrugs his shoulders. “Not my fault.”

“So are we really doing this?” I ask him and I don’t know why, but I hold my breath.

“You are going to have to be a bit more clear with that question.” He laughs. “Are we really doing sex every night I’m home? Yes.” He nods. “Are we going to get a little ass play into that?” He winks at me. “Also yes.”

“I meant me and you and dating. Going public and no longer keeping this a secret.” I shake my head. “Stop thinking about me and my ass.”

“Never.” He reaches under the table to rub my leg. “But as for that question, we are really fucking doing this.”

“So do we soft launch this?” I ask him and his eyebrows pinch together.

“Victoria,” he says my name, “I have no idea what the fuck you are talking about.”

“It’s because you’re old.” I pat his hand on top of the table. “It’s okay, I’ll explain it to you.”

“A soft launch is me posting a picture of you and me holding hands on my social media,” I explain to him, “or it could be my legs over yours with your hand on my legs.”

“Why are we even posting this on social media?” he asks, and I gasp, putting my hand on my chest.

“Are we not going to be social media boyfriend and girlfriend?” He laughs at me.

“How about you come to the game on Saturday night, and then we go out with the team and then leave together?”

“That isn’t a soft launch,” I tell him, grabbing a piece of asparagus. “That’s a hard fucking launch.”

“So we hard launch it.” He shrugs his shoulder.

“My brother,” I mumble.

“I’ll handle your brother,” he assures me, and I look up from my plate.

“Excuse me?” I ask him and he looks up at me.

“I said, I’ll handle him.”

“What does that even mean?” I ask him.

“After we eat, we’re going to go and get dressed, and we’ll go and see your brother.” I stare at him in shock. “We’re going to do this once and for all. Lay our cards on the table.”

“Rip it off like a Band-Aid,” I tell him and he smirks.

“Sure,” he says, finishing what he’s eating. We get up and I put back on the clothes I was wearing when I got here, and he puts on a pair of joggers as we head to Jaxon’s house.

We get out of the car and my nerves start to fly through me. “Maybe we don’t do this?” I put my hand on his stomach, and he bends to kiss me.

“It’ll be fine,” he reassures me as he reaches out and rings the bell.

“I don’t ring. I usually just walk in,” I mumble.

“With me you ring, without me you do what you want.”

“Wow, there are rules for everything with you,” I grumble as the door opens and Jaxon stands there looking at us.

“What are you two doing here?” His eyes go from me to Zane’s and then back to mine.

“We came to talk.” I walk in and look over my shoulder. “You come in with me.”

He follows me in as I follow Jaxon to the living room, where Ariella is sitting with Jagger reading a book. “You came back,” she says and then looks over my shoulder at Zane and her eyes widen as she gets up.

“Zane and I—” I start to say.

“There is no Zane and you.” Jaxon’s voice gets tight.

I ignore him and what he just said, slipping my hand in Zane’s. “We’re dating.”

“Oh my,” Ariella mumbles.

“Interesting,” Jaxon says. “Are you going to tell Mom and Dad?”

“Did you tell Mom and Dad when you knocked up Ariella?” I glare at him.

“Oh,” Ariella notes, “that’s a good one.”

“Ari,” Jaxon grits her name with his teeth clenched.

“What? It was a good comeback.” She throws up her hands. “If you say something I like, I’ll say, ‘Ohh good one, Jaxon.’” She smiles at him. “I’m Switzerland.”

“You aren’t Switzerland,” Jaxon points at her, “you’re on my side.”

“I don’t know how I feel about that,” she mumbles, “especially for this.” She points to him and then to Zane and me.

“Listen.” I hold up my hand to stop them from getting into a fight because of me. “We are together and we are going to figure shit out,” I explain. “I’m going to tell Mom and Dad. I just want to figure things out before I do.”

“What if I forbid it?” Jaxon puts his hands on his hips.

“Forbid it?” I repeat the words.

“Forbid it?” Ariella repeats the words. “Jaxon Stevenson.”

“Forbid it or not,” Zane speaks up, “it’s happening. I love her.” He drapes his arm around my shoulders. “She loves me.” I smile up at him. “There is a lot of shit that will probably come our way.”

“And we’ll deal with it.” I wrap my arm around his waist. “I mean, we’ll figure it out.”

“Is this a soft launch?” he asks me, and I snort.

“This is a hard launch since you just told everyone in this room you love me.” He leans down to kiss me.

“What about the press?” Jaxon asks, his arms folded over his chest.

“We’ll fucking play it by ear, I guess,” Zane replies. “You play hockey and have a wife and kid.” He points to Ariella and Jagger. “It’s not their fault you suck on the ice.”

Ariella laughs at that. “This is true.” She nods. “It’s not my fault you suck on the ice. That would be your own damn fault.”

“Ari,” he hisses her name, and she walks over to him.

“Jaxon,” she says his name and his face goes soft, “your sister is with a guy who respects her and loves her.” She puts her hand on his chest. “It could be so much worse.”

“Yeah,” Jaxon mumbles, “how?”

“She could have had a one-night stand with him and then showed up at his house to tell him she was pregnant, six weeks later, and was chased out by his girlfriend.” I roll my lips and Zane laughs for a split second but then coughs.

“I mean, technically, we had a one-night stand,” I mumble, “but we didn’t know each other.” Zane squeezes my hip to tell me to shut up.

“She was my ex-girlfriend,” Jaxon deflects then looks at Zane. “If you hurt her—”

“She’s literally left me fifteen times.” Zane’s voice goes up. “If anyone hurts anyone—”

“I didn’t leave him fifteen times.” I roll my eyes when Jaxon turns his glare to me. “It was once.” I hold up a finger. “Maybe twice.” I look at Zane, who is side-eyeing me. “What difference does it make? I’m here now.”

“Yeah,” Zane confirms, “you are here now, and you aren’t going anywhere.”

“Well, now that we have that settled,” Ariella says, “would you like to stay for dinner?”

I look up at Zane. “Whatever you want to do,” he says softly.

“Fine, we’ll stay for dinner, but you better watch yourself”—I point to Jaxon—“and be on your best behavior.”

“Me?” He points to himself. “I’m not the one who was sneaking around behind my family’s back.”

“Yes, you were,” Ariella counters. “We snuck around everyone’s back.”

“Ari,” he huffs out, “for once, can you just let me—”

“Okay,” She taps his chest. “Do your thing, big man.”

“We’re leaving,” I groan, fake vomiting. “I’m not sitting at the table after you called him big man.” Zane just laughs.

“I don’t know what you’re laughing at,” Ariella retorts, “Mr. Magician.”

“Okay, well, this family get-together is great,” Zane interrupts. “Rain check.” Everyone nods and we walk out of the house. “See? Told you I’d handle it,” he gloats, getting into the SUV and I can’t help but laugh. “Now, let’s go get some clothes for you and get back to my house. There are a couple more places I need to mark.”

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Zane

“WHAT TIME DO YOU GO FOR A NAP?” VICTORIA ASKS ME AS SHE TAKES A sip of her coffee. The two of us are sitting outside of my bedroom on the balcony. She’s wearing my big white terry cloth robe with nothing under it. Her legs are draped on mine as I sit in a pair of black boxers.

“What time do I nap?” I ask her, confused about the question. “I don’t know what you mean by that.” I smile. “Is that like a young person thing again?”

She smiles and it just takes my breath away that this woman is mine, all mine. “It’s game day.” I nod my head as I take a sip of my own coffee. My hand rubs up and down her bare leg, pushing her legs off me. “Don’t you nap before the game?”

I chuckle. “If I was on the ice I would, but I’m not, so I don’t nap. But I have to do pregame stuff.”

“Ohh.” She puts her elbow on the back of the outdoor couch and rests her forehead on her hand. “Pregame stuff, is that old guy code?” She makes fun of my joke, and I roll my eyes.

“Smart-ass.” I lean over and kiss her lips. “You’re lucky it’s daylight outside and there are people on the beach, or I’d shove my cock in your mouth for that.”

“Oh no,” she deadpans, “I’m devastated. I literally had your cock in my mouth less than an hour ago.”

It’s my turn to smirk and then grin. “That was a good wake-up.” I wink at her. “Feel free to wake me up like that whenever you want.”

She returns my smirk, which makes me turn to the side, put my coffee cup down, and then grip her and bring her over to me. She yelps, holding her cup high so it doesn’t spill as she straddles me. The front of her robe opens and shows me the side of her nipple. “Hmm,” I hum, pushing the robe to the side. “You know, I could take my cock out and you could ride me, and no one would know.”

“Everyone would know.” She leans over to place her cup right next to mine and then places her hands on my chest. “I can’t keep quiet when you fuck me.”

“That should be like a challenge.” I lean forward and kiss the middle of her chest, right over her beating heart.

“So how do you pregame?” she asks me, and I put my hands on her hips.

“I go over the plays from the last game,” I explain to her, “make notes about where we can tighten up. Then I watch the other team’s last game to see if there is something they do that we can use to our advantage.”

“That sounds like a lot more work than napping,” she jokes, and I wrap my arms around her and pull her to me. She lays her head on my shoulder, and I watch the water in total contentment, just holding her close to me.

After we head inside, I spend the afternoon in my office and she leaves me to it. I can hear her around my house when she sticks her head in. “I think I’m going to head out and go home.”

I lean back in my chair. “Why?”

“You’re working.” She points to me, and I see she’s changed from wearing the robe to her black yoga pants. “And I have to get a change of clothes for tonight.”

“How are you getting to the game?” I ask her, as she walks into my office and leans at the side of my desk.

“Ariella said she’s going to come and pick me up,” she tells me.

“Okay, good, and pack a bag.”

“So needy.” She pushes off from the desk and comes over to hold my cheek in her palm. “Okay, I’ll see you later.” She kisses my lips. “I won’t tell you have a great game since you aren’t actually on the ice”—she smiles—“but help them have a great game.”

I chuckle at her and get up, following her out of my office. “Where are you going?”

“I’m going to walk you out,” I tell her as she stops in the kitchen, grabbing her purse and keys, and then walking to the door. I hug her one last time, giving her a kiss before she gets in her car.

I hold up my hand as she drives out of the driveway and walk back inside, heading back to my office. I pick up my phone and call her. “Literally just left.”

“Come back,” I plead softly, “I miss you.” The sound of her bursting out laughing rips right through me. “I’m needy.”

“You’ll survive. I have faith in you. You’re a brave boy. A big brave boy.”

“Yeah, I am.” I smirk.

“I didn’t mean like that,” she groans. “Go do coach things.”

“I’ll see you tonight.”

“You betcha, I’ll be there,” she assures me.

“I love you, Victoria,” I say the words softly and with all the meaning I can behind them.

“I love you too, Zane,” she replies, just as soft. “Now get back to it and stop enticing me with the sweet talk to turn around.”

“Okay, baby, see you later.” She hangs up the phone and I spend the next two hours making notes and going over a couple of things when my

phone rings.

I look down, seeing it's Ken calling me. "If this is you calling to fire me before a game—" I chuckle at the joke while at the same time holding my breath.

"I wouldn't do it on a game day," he assures me, his voice tight, "but I do have news for you."

"This sounds like it's fun news." I lean back in my chair.

"Well, the fab five," he refers to the five guys, "went above my head and straight to Brad with their demands to have you fired." His voice, if you can even imagine, gets even tighter. "Which, I'm going to go on the record to say, it fucking pissed me the fuck off." I don't say anything when he trails off. "It's one thing to come to me with your demands, but then to think you are going to strong-arm me into doing something, well now you've done pissed off the wrong person."

"I don't know if I should tell you this," I start, "but as of the last game, I've started cutting the bench."

"No shit, Sherlock. You don't think I see the time sheet? I know how much less each are playing. It's not enough to get them talking, but I know it's enough for them to notice."

"I don't trust them to not go on the ice and fuck up the game for everyone," I admit to him.

"You have my support," he assures me. "Now you'd have it a lot more if you can win the next couple of games."

"I'll try. Thank you, by the way."

"Yeah, now it's not even about you," he growls. "Now it's about me, and him thinking I can't do my job," he snaps and then hangs up the phone.

When I walk into my office two hours later, I toss my keys on the desk as I make my way into the coaches' room. I walk over to the whiteboard, making the change to the lines. Cam arrives as soon as I'm done.

“We changing the lines again?” he asks me, putting his hands on his hips. “How do you expect us to win games when you keep changing the lines?”

“I’m assuming that everyone on the ice knows how to play the game, so what does it matter who they play with?”

“Then why don’t you separate Kirby and Jaxon?”

“Because Jaxon is the top defenseman in the league, and Kirby is the second, so that means they play the first line.” I look over at him, seeing him with his jaw tight. “That’s what I thought,” I say and he doesn’t say anything back to me.

We start the game with the lines I wrote down, Vancouver scoring first. “Still two and a half more periods to go,” I say, walking down the bench. “You got this.” The guys nod their heads. “But you’d have more chances if you shoot the fucking puck,” I remind them. “If you have the shot, I want you guys to take it.”

The second period has the puck coming into our zone. Taking the shot, our goalie goes to cover it up, losing it right before but then their forward blocks him from moving in his crease, letting the puck go into the back of the net. I get on the bench as soon as they say the puck is in the net.

“Goalie interference!” I shout to the referee. He nods at me as he tells the crowd I’m challenging the goal. I look down at the iPad Eric is holding, showing me the play over and over.

“His knee is out of the crease,” Cam says. “You’ll fuck us for this and then we’ll have to put someone in the box.” He shakes his head and walks to the end of the bench.

The referee comes to the middle of the ice. “After the coaches’ challenge, it was determined that there was goaltender interference, therefore there’s no goal on the play.”

The crowd goes crazy as I call the next line, without Owen, and instead putting Aaron with Knox. Owen looks back at me and I can tell he’s pissed.

I ignore him as I watch the game, seeing them in our zone again. There is a shot on our goalie and it's blocked, with Aaron taking the rebound and then moving the puck up the ice. He skates down the center ice and then passes it to Knox as soon as he skates over the blue line. Knox has two men on him, and he looks like he's going to pass it back to Aaron but instead goes around the two men and then winds up his shot, with no one in front of him. The puck slides in between the pads, the horn starts and then the crowd flies to their feet.

"I guess switching up the lines helps." I lean to Cam, who just nods at me, but it's not a friendly look either. Four minutes later, Kirby takes the puck down the ice and finds Aaron all by himself on the side, and it hits the back of the net.

We win the game, and the locker room is buzzing with two wins in a row. I look over at Jaxon after the game, and he walks over to me. "You giving me a lift to the bar?"

"I don't know, am I?" I ask him, and it's not unusual that I do this, but now I'm dating his sister.

"Yeah." He turns and forty-five minutes later, we're walking to my SUV.

"Should I come for like backup?" Knox asks, looking to Kirby, who is looking around and avoiding looking our way.

"We'll be fine," Jaxon assures him and gets into the car.

"If you guys aren't at the bar in twenty, I'm going to be pissed," Knox warns. "We don't have the kids tonight, and the last thing I want is to drag out the night fixing other people's shit."

"It'll be fine," I state, getting in and turning my key into the ignition. "Are we good?"

"I promised Ariella I would be on my best behavior," Jaxon says, "and I don't break my promises to my girl." I nod, waiting for a but and then he starts it. "You better be fucking sure of this."

“Only thing I’m actually sure of,” I admit, pulling out of the parking garage, “is how I feel about Victoria.” He nods. “She’s one of a kind.” I grin, thinking of her smile. “There is no one else on this earth I would protect more than her. Not even myself.”

We pull into the parking lot of the bar and I get out, followed by Jaxon. Kirby and Knox park next to me. “Good, no blood was shed,” Knox reports, making us all laugh. “I’m literally going in there, getting Kylie, and taking her home where I’m going to do lots of—”

“If you finish that sentence,” Kirby warns, “I’m going to throat punch you and you won’t be able to do anything.”

I pull open the door and step in, seeing most of the players are here. Aaron is at the bar leaned in, talking to Eric. I do a sweep of the room and see my girl standing to the side talking to the others. She must sense I’m here because her eyes fly up and meet mine.

She gives me a smile and then holds up her hand, not coming to me. My eyes are trained on hers as I zigzag through people, giving a couple of them chin lifts. “Hey, Coach,” Aaron calls from the bar, “come over here.”

“In a second,” I reply, not stopping in my tracks as I make it to her. “Hey, baby,” I greet her and then it’s as if everything in the bar goes silent. Or maybe the only thing I can hear is the beating of my heart. My arm wraps around her waist and I pull her to me. “You look beautiful,” I say before my lips softly touch hers.

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Victoria

I HOLD THE GLASS OF WINE IN MY HANDS NERVOUSLY, WAITING FOR ZANE TO walk in the door, not sure what is going to happen. Then he's standing there, wearing his blue suit with a white shirt. I hold up my hand, not sure how to play this. If maybe he's changed his mind. I don't want to force him to do something he doesn't want to do. At this point, I love him, he loves me, and who knows or doesn't know is of no importance to me.

My eyes go to the buttons of his shirt, the tie he was wearing during the game is gone. I see him giving a couple of the guys a nod, and then Aaron calls him over, but his eyes never leave mine. He makes his way to me. "Hey, baby." His voice is low and sounds like a growl. Everything is stuck in my throat when he wraps one of his arms around my waist, pulling me to him. "You look beautiful," he compliments and then his lips touch mine.

I swear I hear a couple of people say, "Holy shit." Meanwhile, a couple more say, "Fuck me."

His lips let go of mine. "Good game," I say, lifting my free hand and wiping the gloss off his lips. "You hungry?"

"Yeah," his eyes twinkle, "but not for food." I shake my head, hoping my cheeks aren't beet red, feeling them light up.

"Well, then," Eric says, coming to stand next to us, "this is a surprise."

“To everyone,” I reply as Zane steps beside me and his hand slips into mine, “including me.” I look up at him.

“You just going to let him date your sister”—Eric looks over at Jaxon —“and not say anything about it?”

“Oh, there were words all right,” Knox declares, making the circle of us laugh. “Some were even the F-word.” His arm hangs around Kylie, who wraps her own arms around his waist. “This was fun. I guess now that the cat is out of the bag and there isn’t a brawl,” he looks at Kylie, “we’re leaving.”

“Bye, everyone.” The smile on her face goes from ear to ear. “Congratulations to the happy couple.”

“We’re dating, not getting married,” I mumble, making Eric chuckle.

I sit at the table with Ariella and Jaxon for a bit before they get up and get home to the sitter. “Lunch tomorrow.” He points at me, and I nod my head. “You bringing that guy?” He points over to Zane, who is talking to Aaron and Eric at the bar.

“Why would you ask her that?” Ariella snaps out. “If she invited me to her house and said don’t bring Jaxon, what would you say?”

“I wouldn’t say anything,” he retorts. “It’s my sister’s house, I’m going.”

“Exactly.” She pushes him out of the door. I sit back in my chair, looking around and seeing that most of the players have left. I get up and make my way to Zane, who catches me walking to him and looks over at the table, seeing that no one is left. “Hey,” I say when I get close enough.

“I’m sorry,” he apologizes. “We were—”

“Talking business,” I fill in, looking at Aaron, who leans on the bar, and Eric, who smiles at me.

“Are you ready to head out?” Zane asks me and I nod my head.

“Unless you want to stay,” I quickly add, “to finish business. I don’t want to interrupt.”

“You aren’t interrupting,” Zane assures me. “I’ll see you guys on Monday,” he says and then he slaps Aaron’s shoulder. “Good game tonight.”

“Thanks.” He nods his head at us. Zane slips his hand in mine, and we leave together. There are a couple of the guys who I hear whispering as we walk out.

“Well, that was uneventful,” I state as he brings our hands to his lips and kisses my fingers. “There was not even a drop of blood shed.” I make a joke as Zane laughs at me. “It’s almost as if no one cared.” He stops by the passenger side door, pushing me against it before he kisses me. “This is when you tell me I was right.” I slide my arms up his chest and around his neck.

“Victoria,” he says my name, “you were right.” He kisses me softly. “You are always right.” He pulls open the door. “Now get in before I forget where we are and fuck you against the car.”

“Don’t tease me with a good time, Zane.” I tap my hand on his cheek before getting in. He shakes his head and walks around the front of the SUV, getting in. He leans over, grabbing my hand, and lets it rest on his thigh as we make our way to his house.

I’m on my stomach in the middle of his bed when the phone rings. I groan as I turn my head to the side. “Hello,” he grumbles, “yeah.” I close my eyes, hoping I fall right back to sleep. “What?” His tone changes and the sleep I was hoping to get back to slips out of my grasp. “Where?” I get up on my elbows and look over at him as he sits up. “Fuck,” he swears, looking over at me. “There is no fucking comment, Ken,” he hisses. “Give me twenty minutes and I’ll call you back.” He hangs up. “Where is your phone?”

“I don’t know.” I turn on my side. “Probably in my purse.” I bring the covers to my neck. “Is everything okay?” I ask him as he looks down at his phone.

“The press posted a story about us,” he says and I get up.

“What do you mean the press posted a story about us?” I throw the covers off me, grabbing the white shirt he took off last night when we finally made it into the bedroom. I run up the stairs to the entrance of the garage where my purse fell out of my hands after he fucked me against the door. It’s right next to the pair of jeans that was left there. I pull the phone out of my purse and see the dreaded missed calls; five from my father, fifteen from my mother, and two from Jaxon.

“Oh shit,” I mumble before pulling up the story on my phone. I don’t have to even search far, it’s the first thing on my social media.

Hockey coach Zane Gilmore dating much younger woman, who just happens to be his captain’s sister. Sources close to the pair have been speculating for months that he has been grooming her.

“That’s a little extreme,” I say, walking down the stairs and seeing him standing at the bottom. He’s wearing a pair of boxers, and his face is ashen white. “Are you okay?”

“They said I’ve been grooming you.” His voice is a whisper. “Do you know what that means?”

“I’m twenty-five,” I remind him, “not a child.” I shake my head and his head hangs. “It’s a fake article, obviously filled with shit since I didn’t even know you months ago.”

“They found a picture of us at the community garden,” he says, turning his phone to let me see. It’s a picture from when I went to bring him a water bottle. “We weren’t even together.”

“You look like you’re either in love with me and it hurts, or I kicked your dog.” I try not to make a big deal out of it. But my phone in my hand feels like a bomb ready to explode. “My parents called,” I tell him, and he puts his head back.

“We should have called them. We should have covered all our bases before this happened.” He hits his head with the phone in his hand. “Fuck. Fuck. Fuck,” he repeats again before he takes his phone and whips it across the room. It smashes as soon as it falls to the floor.

“I don’t know why you would do that.” I shake my head. “It’s just adding one more thing to the list of things we have to do now. Get Zane a new phone.” I walk past him to his phone and look at the screen. “Well, it’s not that bad,” I say, seeing two cracks in the screen. “Screen protector saved it.”

“Victoria,” he hisses out my name, “I’m going to need you to start freaking out just a little bit. Or at least show that you are as bothered about this as I am.”

“Why?” I ask, walking into his bedroom. “You seem to be freaking out enough for the both of us.” He stands there. “What I’m going to do is take a shower,” I tell him, “get dressed, and head over to Jaxon’s house.” I walk to him and put my hands on his hips. “Once we are there, we will call my parents and discuss things.”

“I have to call Ken back.” He runs his hand through his hair. “He’s going to want to put out a statement.”

“Okay.” I shrug. “You do what you need to do.” I try not to show him that I’m going to be freaking out just a bit, but it’ll be okay.

“Just like that?” he hisses.

“I didn’t want to say this,” I smile at him, “but I’d be more worried about my father than the press.” I tap my hand on his chest. “You deal with Ken. I’ll deal with my father. See? Divide and conquer.”

He glares at me as I walk away. Ten minutes later, he's in the bathroom. "How are we feeling?" I look over at him as I turn off the water and step out. "You look like you're getting your color back." I grab a towel. "What did you and Ken decide to say?"

He rubs his hand over his face. "It's a private matter and we don't discuss our team's private life off the ice."

"I approve. Now, you need to get into the shower if you are going to come with me to Jaxon's house."

"It's not even nine," he tells me.

"I've had five missed calls from my father, fifteen from my mother, and two from Jaxon." Whatever color had come back on his face is now gone. "So I'm not going to say this is an urgent matter," I roll my lips, "but I'm not *not* saying it. I will say you were right about one thing. We definitely should have told my parents."

He puts his hand on his chest. "I think I'm having a heart attack," he groans, rubbing his chest. "Like there is a pain in my chest."

"Okay, that's being a bit dramatic." I roll my eyes. "But if you really are, that would maybe help a little." I laugh. "Zane," I say his name, "it's going to be fine."

"How can you say that?" he asks me, his hand moving up to touch my face.

"Because it can't get worse." I tap his chest. "Get in the shower."

Forty minutes later, we are walking out of his house and headed toward Jaxon's. His phone rings as soon as we sit in the car and I look at the center where it displays just the word dad.

"I think someone is in trouble." I sing out and he shoots me a look before he presses answer.

"Hey," he says, "I'm in the car and you are on speaker phone." He warns him.

“Zane,” he says his name and I smile because he sounds so much like him just older, “what the ever loving F is going on.”

“I can explain.” He says, “it’s not what it seems.”

“I’m listening.”

“Oh shit you wanted me to explain now.” He laughs, “okay well I’m dating this woman.” He grabs my hand to kiss my fingers, “and she’s younger than me.”

“What is this hogwash about you grooming her?” He snaps out and I speak up to defend my man.

“No,” I snap out and then put my hands to my lips, “hi,” I say to the screen, “I’m Tori, it’s nice to meet you or meet your voice.”

“It’s good to meet you.” He says.

“Dad, I promise you that it’s all lies and when the season is over, I’m going to bring her down to you and you can meet her.”

“I would like that very much.” He says, “now I can hear your busy so how about you call me later.”

“Will do.” He says, “love you dad.”

“Love you more.” He says disconnecting.

“Wasn’t that nice? He sounds like you, or you sound like he does. We should stop and pick up some sweet treats,” I suggest to him as the phone rings in my hand and I see it’s Ariella. “Or not,” I remark, putting the phone to my ear. “We’re about twenty minutes from you,” I answer instead of saying hello.

“Oh, look who has risen and is not fucking shining,” Jaxon growls, making me laugh.

“Should I get some cinnamon rolls before coming to the house, or just show up?” I ask him.

“Tori,” he grits between clenched teeth, “we’ve been up since six and on the phone with Dad since six oh five.”

“I have to call him back.” I look out the window. “I’m going to call him when I get to your house.”

“Great,” he retorts, “just great, so I’m an accessory.”

“Everyone is being a bit dramatic today.” I roll my eyes. “I’m dating a man. It’s not that big of a deal, people do it every day. It’s actually a very common thing.”

“Just get your ass over here,” he grumps, hanging up.

“He says no to the cinnamon rolls.” I look over at Zane, who looks like he’s turning green now.

“Good news is that in an hour it’ll be over,” I spin it as he pulls up to Jaxon’s house.

His phone is going crazy with notifications and mine is too, but the last thing he needs is to know this. I slip my hand in his as we walk up the steps. Jaxon opens the door as soon as we hit the first step. “Oh good, they’re here,” he tosses over his shoulder, “alert the presses.” He then looks at Zane. “You look like you’re going to yack.”

“I might,” he mumbles as I step into the house and head straight to the kitchen. Ariella is there with her lips rolled together to stop from laughing.

“Hi,” I say, going to kiss her and then Jagger. “Hi, buddy.”

Zane and Jaxon get into the kitchen and he’s about to say something when we hear a car door shutting. I close my eyes and look down. “Is that —” I look at Ariella.

“He said I couldn’t tell you.” She points to Jaxon.

“Couldn’t tell you what?” Zane asks, his voice tight. I hear the front door opening and then I walk to him.

“Remember when I said it couldn’t get worse?” He nods. “I was wrong. My parents are here.” He looks over to the hallway.

thirty-five

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Victoria

“YOUR FATHER—” ZANE HAS ENOUGH TIME TO SAY BEFORE I HEAR MY name being rumbled from behind him.

“Victoria Stevenson.” I look over at my father, who is standing there wearing a track suit, looking like he literally just woke up.

“Manning.” I hear my mother, who is coming in beside him. “Did we or did we not talk about this on the plane?” she questions and his jaw gets tight.

“You—” He points to Zane.

“If you say outside,” Jaxon interrupts, “I’m going to die.” He puts his hand to his stomach and silently laughs.

“No one”—I hold out my hands to stop my father, in case he charges forward—“is going anywhere.” I look at him then at Zane, who is standing with his shoulders back.

“Everyone needs to just take a step back,” my Uncle Nico instructs, walking into the room and coming to me. “Hi, sweetheart.” He kisses my cheek. “And we’ll discuss things.”

“Fuck that.” My father’s usual calm demeanor is out the window. “You’ve been grooming her?”

“Oh, Manning,” my mother huffs at the same time I snort out.

“Dad, two months ago I was still living at home,” I remind him. “How was he grooming me when I didn’t even know him?”

“How the fuck should I know? I didn’t even know what the fuck that word was until I looked it up,” he hisses at me. “This is a fucking nightmare, Victoria!” he roars.

“With all due respect,” Zane warns, “but you’re going to have to bring that tone down when you are talking to her.”

“Oh snap,” Jaxon mumbles as his eyes look like saucers.

“With all due respect,” my father snaps back at Zane, “look at what you’ve done. People are saying that she’s dating someone old enough to be her father.”

“No one is saying that,” my mother snorts. “He’s forty,” my mother points to Zane, “you are not.” My father just glares at her.

“Okay.” I hold up my hands. “Why don’t we sit down,” I look around at everyone, “and we can discuss this like adults. Calmly,” I look at my father and then at Zane, “with inside voices.”

“Yes, let’s sit,” my mother urges. “First thing we are going to do, Manning,” she says his name so he can look at her, “is say hello to our grandson because you made him scared with your booming voice.”

“He’s heard that voice before,” Jaxon explains. “Oh wait, sorry, that was your father”—he points to Ariella—“who lost his shit when we told him we were pregnant.”

“This isn’t about you, Jaxon,” Ariella mutters between clenched teeth.

“Oh my God,” my father says, his hand going to his mouth, “are you pregnant?”

I roll my eyes. “I’m not pregnant. It’s like herding cats,” I mumble and then slip my hand into Zane’s. “How are you doing?” I whisper to him and he looks down at me as my parents go to Jagger, who smiles at them.

“I feel like my hair is on fire,” Zane confides to me, his thumb rubbing mine.

“It’s going to be okay,” Nico says, slapping his shoulder. “He had three hours to calm down.” He smirks. “Also, nice game last night.”

“Thanks,” Zane mumbles as my mother holds Jagger, with my father kissing his neck and making raspberries.

He then turns to look at Zane and me. “What the fuck are you two thinking?” he asks with a forced smile on his face, because Jagger is holding his hand as he moves it up and down. “Like, what the actual fuck?”

“Dad,” Jaxon scolds, “can we tone down the F-word?”

“Yes, because he said the s-h-i-t- word yesterday because of *your* son.” Ariella glares at my father.

“Wow!” I exclaim. “You’re both just winning at the father of the year club.” I look at my dad.

“You’re pushing it,” my mother warns me.

“Okay, you guys go and talk,” Jaxon urges. “I’m going to take Jagger out to the park, even though it’s not even noon yet.”

“I don’t know if I should come with you or stay here to play referee,” Nico states, looking at my father with a grimace. “I’m going to stay,” he tells my brother.

“Can we do this calmly and rationally?” I ask my father when the front door opens and then closes. “Or are we just not going to do it?”

“We are going to do this calmly,” my mother states, looking at my father. “Right, Manning?” I pull Zane into the living room and sit down then pull him down next to me.

“It’s fine,” I mumble to him as my mother pulls my father in, much like I did with Zane, and sits down on the couch in front of me. Nico comes over and sits in the lone armchair in the middle, folding one leg over the other.

“Okay, so how should we start this?” Nico questions. “It’s safe to say we were all surprised with the article that dropped this morning at 4:00 a.m.”

“That’s how you guys got here so fast.” I slap my knee with my hand. “I thought for sure I had like a six-hour window.”

“You knew this was going to happen?” Zane asks me.

“Well, I knew that it was a high probability.” His mouth hangs open in shock. “But you were already going through the freak-out moment, so I didn’t think it was a good time to say that my father was on his way here to maim you.” I hold up my hands. “I figured he might, but I couldn’t say for sure.”

“Victoria,” he hisses my name.

“It’s fine.” I throw my hand up and roll my eyes, trying to get him to calm down, or at least get some color into his face.

“I’m going to need you to stop saying that it’s fine,” my father snaps, “because it’s not.” He looks at me and then at Zane. “I just don’t understand.”

“There really isn’t much to understand,” I start to explain. “I met a guy. We hooked up.”

“Victoria,” Zane hisses when my father puts his hands to his hips and looks up at the ceiling.

“What?” I extend my hand. “I’m twenty-five years old. I’m old enough to be hooking up with guys.”

“Okay,” my father snaps, “I’m not discussing that.”

“Sounds good,” I reply, winking at Zane. “See. Already won round one.”

He can’t help the smirk on his face, and I lean into him and look up at him to kiss me. “He already knows we slept together.” I don’t know if Zane kisses my lips because he wants to or to shut me up.

“When did this all start?” Nico asks, trying not to be amused by this whole thing.

“Seven months ago,” I answer and everyone gasps. “We met one night. I had no idea who he was; he had no idea who I was.”

“That’s what he’s telling you?” my father hisses. “But he knew who you were.”

“Yeah,” I snort, “because getting involved with me is making his life better.”

“I can assure you I had no idea who she was,” Zane counters. “Not a clue until I came here one night for dinner, five months later, and saw her picture.”

“What is up with our kids and one-night stands?” my mother mutters to my father.

“I think it’s the apple and the tree.” Nico chuckles, earning a glare from my parents. “Anyway, you met; you did what grown-ups do.” He motions with his hand in a circle to move it along.

“We did,” I confirm, and Zane just looks up at the ceiling.

“Then I got his number and asked him for—” Zane holds up his hand to stop me from talking.

“We can fast forward that,” Zane suggests. “Mr. and Mrs. Stevenson,” he looks at my parents, “I didn’t want any of this to happen. I knew the press was ripping me to shreds—”

“I was the one who wouldn’t take no for an answer,” I interrupt him.

“She’s exactly like her father, and she isn’t even married.” My mother looks at Zane. “I told him no so many times, and he just kept showing up at my door.”

“For the record, you let me in.” My father glares at her. “Don’t even try it...”

“For the record, her press was nothing compared to your press.” She points to my father. “But what does it matter that he’s dating her? They are two single adults who started dating.”

“Our team put out a statement today,” Zane says, “that we won’t be commenting on anything.”

“Yeah, that’s not good enough,” Nico chuckles, “and Ken knows it.”

The front door opens and then shuts. "Oh good, there is no bloodshed," Jaxon says. "Jagger wanted to come home."

"Wow, using your own son to lie," Ariella accuses as Jagger comes into the room and runs to my father.

"Hey, buddy." He picks him up and puts him on his lap.

"So are we all over the fact she's dating someone who is almost Dad's age?" my brother jokes knowing full well he's not close to my father's age, sitting next to me.

"There have been four more articles," Nico reports and Zane gasps, "that are not spinning anything in a good light."

"So, you put out your own story," Ariella suggests. "Get something drafted, do a formal statement, which if you ask me is dumb. No one cared that he got me knocked up." She points to Jaxon. "It wasn't even news."

"It's because the organization is trying to get him fired," Nico explains, and now I'm the one who is gasping out. "These stories." He uses his fingers to do quotation marks, "are just an added bonus for them. To not make them look like the bad guys when Zane's relationship with the team goes south."

"What?" I say in a whisper.

"I don't give a shit about the fucking job," Zane hisses. "They can say whatever the fuck they want to say about me, but now they are fucking with her and I'm not going to take it."

"They want you fired?"

"Tori," Jaxon says, "where the fuck have you been?"

"She's been in her love bubble," my mother states with a smile.

"You love her?" my father snaps out and it makes Jagger jump. "I'm sorry, buddy."

"What the hell do you think we are here for?" Nico spouts. "You think he would show up at an ambush if he didn't love her?"

"Technically, he didn't know he was being ambushed," I counter.

“He knew shit hit the fan,” Nico retorts. “He knew that it was not good. He still walked into this house.”

“How do you think we should do this?” Zane looks at Nico.

“If this was my team”—he smirks—“I would have the two of you put out some statement on social media. Maybe even do a one-on-one with someone in the press. Then I would,” he looks at Jaxon, “and this is all just a suggestion, I would have a couple of the guys from the team put out their own statements counteracting what the press is saying.”

“On it,” Jaxon declares, “I’ll call Kirby and Knox who, for sure, will say something. Then we have Aaron and at least the five players who think you walk on water.” He rolls his eyes. “We only have to worry about the five who want to be traded and then Cam.”

“If Cam comes out and says anything about her,” Zane seethes, “I’m going to break every single fucking tooth in his mouth and feed them to him.”

“I guess that answers that question.” My mother looks at my father. “Anyone who is going to knock someone’s teeth out isn’t going to do it for fun. He’s not going to do it if it’s just a fling and doesn’t mean anything.”

“I’m sorry you guys found out about us the way you did,” he apologizes to them. “It was never my intention for it to happen like this. I respect you both very much.” He then turns to me. “And I respect your daughter more than this.”

“You’re a good man, Zane Gilmore,” I kiss his lips, “and I’m lucky to have you.”

“Aww,” Ariella and my mother both sigh at the same time.

“When this whole situation is over,” my father warns, “we’re going to have more to say about this.”

Zane nods at him. “I’ll look forward to the opportunity,” he replies and then looks at me.

“See?” I smirk at him. “Told you it would all be over in an hour.” Then I look at my dad. “Tell me I’m your favorite without telling me I’m your favorite.” I stand up. “You didn’t even try to rough him up.” Only when I see Zane chuckle do I really feel like everything is going to be okay. I run my hand through his hair, bending to whisper in his ear, “I love you,” before leaning to kiss his lips. “I don’t know about you guys, but I’m starving.”

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Zane

“OKAY, SO THE GUYS HAVE ALL SENT OVER THEIR STATEMENTS TO KEN,” Jaxon announces. “The only ones we didn’t reach out to were the five in question.” I nod my head at him as he comes back to the table and sits down. “Ken said the team just released their statements.”

Everyone reaches for their phones. As I open mine, I see a picture of me and Ken on the day he announced I was going to be head coach.

“We care about what happens on the ice, not off the ice. Timothy’s piece was misleading, and he should be ashamed of his words.”

“I can’t wait for the next time I see Timothy,” Jaxon says, and I look up at him.

I put my phone down and look up at Manning. “If you have a minute, Manning.” I take the napkin off my lap, placing it on the other side of my phone.

“What?” Victoria’s head snaps to me. “Why would you want to do that?” She looks up at me as I stand. “You literally just came out of the battle unscathed, so why would you rush back in there?”

“It’s fine,” I assure her, and she glares at me. “Oh, when I say it, it’s not okay, but you saying it fifty million times is okay.”

“I don’t make the rules, Zane.” She throws up her hands. “You will be on your best behavior.”

She points to her father.

“Are you going to give me the code for the lock on your bedroom door?” He smiles big at her, knowing she probably will not. “That is your answer.”

“Fine, I’ll give it to you,” she concedes, “but only after you guys finish talking—”

“Don’t fall for that,” Evelyn advises, “get the code before anything.”

“Mom,” she snaps out and I bend to kiss her lips.

“You don’t need that room,” I remind her softly, “give up the code.”

“That’s my room.” She points to herself. “It’s my property.”

“In their house,” I tell her.

“I thought you were on my side.” She shakes her head and I kiss her through my smile. “I guess I was wrong.”

I walk to the living room, following Manning, and when he takes a seat, I sit in the seat in front of him. “I wanted to sincerely apologize to you,” I start to say. “When we met the first time, I had every intention of not pursuing anything with Victoria.” I put my elbows on my knees and intertwine my hands together. “I just couldn’t stay away from her. It was a force bigger than even I knew.”

“Why now?” he asks me. “What makes now different that you are willing to give up your bachelorhood for her?”

“She’s everything you could want in a woman. She’s kind, she’s funny, she’s beautiful, and she makes me laugh like no one else has ever made me laugh. My main focus in my life has been hockey. Getting to this point in my career. I didn’t have time nor did I want to make the time for it. But with her—” I look down. “I’d give it all up to have her.”

“If you hurt her,” he warns me.

“For the record, she’s left me more times than I have left her.”

“Good.” He nods. “Keeps you on your toes.”

“That she does,” I agree with him. “I promise to keep her safe.” His eyebrows go up at this. “I mean from now on.” I shake my head. “We should have expected it.”

“I have to agree with Nico, someone is out to get you. You have my daughter now in the crossfire.”

“She shouldn’t even be there,” I admit and for the first time today, I sound defeated. I know I should be holding strong but the articles that have come up since this morning are horrible.

“I know that and you know that.” He points to himself and then me. “Now it’s time for you to tell them that.”

“If I see Timothy,” I mention the veteran reporter who leaked the story, “I’m going to throat punch him.”

Manning laughs. “That’s what he wants. They want you to fuck up. The best thing you can do is put out a statement and then you say nothing.”

“I’ll take your advice on that.” I nod to him and Victoria comes into the room.

“Uncle Nico says the wheels have to be up in thirty minutes,” Victoria reports, walking into the room. “Which means you have to go.” She makes a sad face. “It was nice to see you.” She makes her way over to him, hugging him. “Next time, maybe you can stay a few days.”

“Next time?” He exhales. “There will not be a next time, Tori, because you will be telling us if you are dating anyone new.”

“There is not going to be a next time.” The words come out of my mouth before I can stop them, and Manning smirks when he looks over at me while Victoria chuckles.

“Yes,” she agrees, “my current boyfriend is saying no to whatever future boyfriends want in.”

“Current boyfriend,” I hiss then say her name, “Victoria.” Making everyone laugh, except me.

We leave at the same time as her parents and Nico, going straight to her house so she can pack a bag and then head back to mine.

“Are you ready”—she walks into the kitchen with her phone in her hand—“for us to draft up a statement?”

“I’ll post whatever you want me to post,” I tell her. “I want you to draft it because it matters to you.”

“I honestly don’t even want to put out a statement,” she states. “The only people who really matter are the people who know us.”

“We have to put out something.” She cocks her hip. “Everyone we know has been dropping statements on social media defending us.” Ken was not wrong, every fucking hour on the hour he was posting a comment from one of the guys on the team. I’m sure there were a few people who were pissed off by this, but I couldn’t care less at this point. My main focus was to make sure Victoria was okay.

“I know.” She comes to me and puts her head together with mine. She smiles at the camera; I don’t. “This is perfect. I’m going to caption it. “Put a finger down if you read that misleading article about my dating life.”

“I don’t even know what that means,” he says to me. “How about, drowning out the noise?”

“I guess we could use that also. Would that make you feel better?”

“It would,” I tell her as I grab her hips. “Now hurry up, time for me to get inside of you.”

She gets on her tippy-toes, wiggling her ass in my direction. “That sounds like a good time,” she throws over her shoulder. She posts something on her phone and then reaches for mine, doing the same thing on mine.

“Okay, now that this is taken care of”—she turns in my hands—“time for you to get inside of me.” She winks. “My throat feels a little dry.”

I HEAD into my office the next morning, my head down as I look up and see Eric standing outside my door. “Well, that was an eventful day off.” He snickers at me, and I shake my head.

“Press is coming in today,” I inform him, “to film the practice, apparently.”

“Yup, Ken sent the email out this morning.”

“That should be interesting.” I walk into my office and toss my phone on the desk.

“It should be.” Eric sits in the chair in front of me with a smirk on his face. “Seems to me half the team or better yet the whole team, including a couple who are not happy with you are not happy with Timothy.”

“No shit.” I pull out my chair and sit down. “I dare him to fuck with me today.”

He doesn’t say anything because Ken walks into my office. “Good morning.”

“Why is everyone here so fucking early?” I lean back in my chair.

“Got shit to do,” Ken replies. “You and Jaxon have a press conference after practice.” I put my hands down on my desk. “And we just got word that if we win the next game and get the two points we need, we will officially be in playoff contention. Chasing that wild card spot.”

“I take it that is good news.”

“Haven’t been in this spot in the last four years, so yeah, good news.”

“Great, it might be nice to go a week without my job being threatened,” I mumble, making Ken laugh.

“It’s only Monday, still a lot of week left,” he jokes and I can’t help but laugh.

When the guys come out, we head to practice. Cam comes in right before Eric and I are about to walk out to the ice. “Nice of you to join us,” I tell him, putting on my gloves. “It might be a good idea to get on the ice before the players.”

“Why?” Cam asks, going to sit down at his spot. “It’s not like I’m the one who needs the practice.”

“You lead by example.” I shake my head as he rolls his eyes.

The practice is good, and the boys push hard. I grab my phone from the desk as I head out to the press room, bumping into Jaxon. “We have press,” he reminds me and I nod my head.

We walk into the room and head over to the stairs that lead to the elevated desk in the middle of the room. Some of the reporters are there as I sit down in the chair, and I look around to see Timothy in the back, leaning back with his pad on his knees.

“Let’s start this,” Jaxon urges. “Who is going first?”

“Jaxon,” one of the reporters in the front starts, “this year has been challenging for everyone.”

“That’s putting it mildly,” he jokes.

“Your line has been the constant the whole time,” he continues, “but the other lines are always being switched up. Has that been helping you guys?”

“I think that changing things up is good for the team,” Jaxon replies. “We started off the year in a slump and you have to make those changes in order to find out what is working for us.” He looks up at Timothy. “We’re in a good spot for the next couple of games. We’ll see what happens.”

“Coach Gilmore.” Timothy puts his hand up. “You’ve been in the press a lot these last couple of months. Both good and bad.”

“You don’t say?” I lean back.

“Do you think that maybe your focus has shifted in light of the recent events?”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about.” I play dumb. “My focus has always been on the team. I’m sure no one would come to you and ask you if your focus was on your job if you have one article that is bad.” I raise my eyebrows. “We all have good and bad days. As much as I want to win every

single game, it's just not possible. But I have faith in the guys who are on the ice."

"So you aren't playing favorites with the guys?" he asks me.

"I'm giving ice time to the guys who want to be on the ice." I look him dead in the eyes. "You come at me right now and tell me who on that ice doesn't merit being there?" I wait a second for him to answer. "That's what I thought."

We walk out of the press conference and Jaxon looks over at Timothy, the two of them sharing a look. I push him out of the room, and he looks back over. "What a fucking tool," he mumbles as we make it back to the locker room and get ready for the big game the next night.

I GET to the rink the next day at the same time as the guys. The press is there snapping pictures. My head is down as I walk into the rink, going to the coaches' room. The lines are going to stay the same as the last game.

My phone rings an hour before the game and I look down to see it's Victoria. "Hey," I say, putting the phone to my ear.

"Hi," she replies breathlessly, "I was hoping to catch you before you left." I smile. "Good luck tonight."

"Thank you." I lean back in my chair. "I'll see you after the game?"

"Yes, sir," she confirms, "and I asked for the day off tomorrow so I can spend time with you before you leave." I smile big. "I know how needy you can get."

I look around, making sure I'm all alone. "Well then, I'm just going to have to fuck you hard enough to make sure you don't forget about me for the three days." She laughs and it makes my dick stir in my pants.

"Challenge accepted. Go make them skate hard, my love."

"I'll try," I reply. "See you later, yeah?"

“Only if you win.” I can hear the teasing in her voice. “No one wants to go out after they lose a game. It’s all like mopey and shit. Ruins it for everyone.”

“Goodbye.” I disconnect the phone on a laugh.

I get behind the bench when it’s time and look up to the suite. I know she’s there, seeing movement but not seeing her. My heart beats in my chest hard. “I’m so fucking nervous,” I confess to the guys, “and I’m not even the one on the ice.” The whole bench chuckles. “I can’t even imagine how you guys must feel. Your hearts must be ready to come out of your asses.” I walk up and down behind the bench. “Three periods. No pressure, but this could make or break us.”

“No pressure.” Eric chuckles as the puck drops. The guys are playing as if their lives depend on it. They are the first ones on the puck; they are winning the battles in the corners. They are shooting the puck and hitting the net, but the goaltender is having the game of his life tonight.

The game is tied and it’s four minutes left in the third period. I look up and down, going to Cam. “Calling a time-out,” I tell him. “Show them the play we worked out in the second period.” He nods at me, going to the side to get the whiteboard.

I noticed the other team is playing the box with four of the players and using a forward to chase the puck, leaving the middle open. If we get a guy to go into the middle, it will leave the sides open for our guys to try and take the shot.

I hold up my hand in the air for a time-out as the referee blows the whistle and the guys come over to the bench. Standing next to Eric, I mumble, “If this doesn’t work,” and then I hear Cam giving the instructions to the play. He’s fucking it all up, basically saying to give the puck to the guy in the middle of the box, who will have no chance to get it to the net with all the bodies in front of him.

“Hold on,” I snap and walk out, grabbing the whiteboard and seeing he fucked it up on purpose. “That is not what we are doing.” I look at Cam. “Get the fuck out of here.” Finally confirming my suspicions that he’s the whole reason that half the plays are not working.

“What?” he says defensively. “I’m doing it how you called it.”

I look at the guys in front of me, erasing the board. “This is how they are playing.” I mark the opponents in X’s. “I want Kirby and Jaxon here.” I point to the blue line. “Aaron, I want you in the middle with them, the three of you passing the puck. I want you skating into the middle but passing it back to Jaxon, who one times it to Knox.” I then do two circles. “Knox,” I look at him, “I want you here.” I do the circle right next to the goalie. “Lane,” I do the other circle, “you jump on the rebound.”

The whistle blows, telling us that it’s time to get back on the ice. “You are not to touch another fucking play.” I lean over to Cam. “That’s the last time I’ll coach with you behind the bench.” He leers at me.

I’m not even watching the ice when the roar of the crowd makes me turn my head and I see Knox skating to the side, pointing over at the bench. “You fucking did it!” Eric cheers. “You fucking did it!”

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Zane

ERIC COMES OVER TO ME AND SLAPS MY SHOULDER AND THEN SQUEEZES IT. My eyes are on Cam as he looks up at the Jumbotron. I walk to him and whisper in his ear, “Get the fuck off my bench.”

“Fuck you,” he hisses at me, “you don’t tell me how to do my job.”

The horn blares, telling us the game is done, and the guys are jumping over the bench, heading to the ice to celebrate with Sammy. I look over my shoulder at them, skating over to the middle of the ice, holding up their sticks to the crowd who are on their feet. I stand in the tunnel as Cam walks out. “Dressing room. No press,” I snap. He looks over at me and if I didn’t know he was gunning for me before this, the look on his face solidifies it.

I look at Eric. “I need you to find Ken,” I tell him. “Get him to the dressing room.” He nods at me and looks back at Cam. “This ends tonight. I just hope it ends in my favor.”

“I have your back.” He slaps my shoulder as he starts to walk off to find Ken.

The first couple of guys come off the ice, my fist is closed to hit theirs. “Way to fucking play, boys,” I praise as they trickle off. I’m not expecting Owen to fist bump me, but he does.

“Nice play there,” he says, nodding before pushing off his helmet and heading to the locker room.

“I want no press in the room!” I shout down the hallway as the crowd roars, and I look up to see they announced Knox as the third star. He does a circle by the bench and then comes back down the tunnel, holding up his hand.

“The comeback king.” He smirks at me. “Who would have thought you had it in you?” he jokes with me, hitting my shoulder with his.

“Shit is going down,” I tell him quickly. “I need you to make sure no one leaves the dressing room until I get there.”

“You got it, Coach,” he assures me, taking off his glove and walking down the hallway as Kirby skates off the ice.

“Not going to say that was one of the best moments of my life,” he declares to me, “considering I found the love of my life, but that comes in the top five.”

“Top five?” I ask him.

“I’m going to have kids, that’s going to come above this. But if it makes you feel better, it’s number one on the job front.” I chuckle as he walks past me and toward the locker room.

I hear Jaxon’s voice as he takes an interview on the ice. “Yeah, it was a play Coach came up with,” he explains, “and to make it come to fruition was pretty great.” He looks up at the crowd. “I don’t know about you guys,” he says, “but who else is looking forward to lighting this place up for the playoffs?” The question makes the crowd roar even more. “It’ll be a fun ride, no matter what.”

He comes out of the tunnel and toward me. “Aww, are you waiting for me?” He takes off his gloves and unsnaps his helmet. “Aren’t you sweet?”

“Good game out there, Captain.” I slap his shoulder. “It’s been an honor.”

“Why are you talking to me like you’re about to break up with me?” he questions as he turns and the two of us walk to the locker room. I look

down the hallway and see Eric coming down with Ken beside him. Ken's face is tight, and Eric looks down.

I look at the press surrounding the locker room. "No press in the room," I issue to them, looking over at Timothy. "I don't even want you guys next to the door." I look at them. "Clear them out," I tell security, who nods at me as he ushers them to the media room as I look up at Ken.

"What the fuck is all this about?" Ken asks between clenched teeth as I walk into the locker room. Half the guys are celebrating, the other half know shit is about to go down. Cam is standing on the side, his back to the wall, one of his legs cocked up and his foot pressed to the wall.

I walk in and go to the other end to get as far away from him as I can, or else I'm afraid I'm going to throttle him. The door closes behind Ken and Eric. "Gentlemen," I start and everyone looks my way as they start to get undressed, "that game was incredible." I put my hands in my pockets. "And it was all because of the leadership on and off the ice." Ken just eyes me. "With that being said, I have to also apologize to you all." The looks the guys give me are of confusion. "I put my trust in someone who I thought had the team's back, and he didn't." I look over to Cam. "I don't even want to think about the times we were in this situation and instead of helping his team win, he sabotaged us every step of the way. He was looking out for him and only him." I turn to look at Cam. "You fucked up for the last time. You went out there and gave them the wrong play on purpose." I wait for him to say something, but he just rolls his eyes. "We went over the play three times in the room between the second and third period, and yet when it was time to play it, you were going to lead the team out there with the wrong instructions."

"I wrote it down wrong," he starts to say as if it's no big deal.

"It's him or me." I look at Ken. "I refuse to coach with someone who doesn't have the team's best interest." Ken's face gets tight. "Actually, scratch that. I quit," I declare and gasps fill the room. I see Kirby and Jaxon

share a look and then Jaxon looks back at me. "If this is the way the organization wants to lead," I point to Cam, "it's not for me."

Ken looks at Cam. "Is what he's saying true?" he asks him and Cam scoffs at him.

"I'm not going to dignify that with a response." He stands, his shoulders square. "He's the problem here." He points to me. "He can't lead the team. I made one mistake."

"That we know of," Owen throws out and all heads turn to him. "I have to wonder how many times you made a mistake with the plays that ended in us fucking up." He stands up. "Which then led to us losing. Which ended with some of us being crucified in the press." He shakes his head. "Which ended in some of us doing things we shouldn't have done."

"I'm going to go out on a limb and say that it wasn't his first time." Jaxon stands up. "I'm not playing for anyone else but Coach Gilmore," he declares, and Kirby stands up.

"Same here," he adds. The guys all stand up, even the ones who have threatened to not play for me.

"This is bullshit," Cam spits out. "You can't fire me." His smile is more of a sneer. "You have no proof I did any of this."

"Clean out your office," Ken orders and the color drains from Cam's face. He turns to storm out of the locker room.

"We'll see what Brad has to say about this." He grips the door handle in his hand before pulling it open and stepping out.

"I don't know," Ken's voice stops him. "I'm pretty sure the only thing Brad likes is winning." Cam storms out and I close my eyes and look down at my feet.

"Okay," Eric says to the guys, trying to not let the whole scene with Cam get to him, "tonight was a big win. Two points and we clinched the spot in the playoffs."

"Yeah." The guys clap their hands.

“The fight isn’t over,” I announce. “It’s just starting. There is hockey”—I look at the guys in the room—“and then there is playoff hockey.” Ken nods his head. “It’s a different breed.”

“We wouldn’t know,” Jaxon says, chuckling, “but we’re about to fucking find out.”

“Okay.” I clap my hands. “We need to do press, and then we have a celebration to get to.”

The guys start getting up and getting undressed as I walk out of the room and head to my office. “Well, that was something,” Eric says, walking in followed by Ken.

“Is the shit going to hit the fan?” I ask Ken, who just shrugs.

“Wouldn’t be us if we weren’t ruffling feathers,” he states and the phone rings in his hand. He looks down and then up. “Time to go see the boss.” He holds up the phone and puts it to his ear. “I’m on my way,” he says, walking out of my office and then stopping. “We going to have to have a debrief tomorrow morning?” I nod at him, and only when he walks out of the room do I let out the breath I’ve been holding.

“That was intense,” Eric remarks, and I put my hands that are balled into fists on the desk. “I don’t know how we didn’t see it before.”

“He fucked us so many times.” I think back to all the times the plays were fucked up on the ice. “And I thought it was just the plays on the ice.” I shake my head.

“Tonight we celebrate,” he says and the phone beeps on my desk.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

Proud of you.

BEAUTIFUL GODDESS:

I love you.

“Yeah,” I agree.

“Tomorrow we fuck things up again.” He laughs. “Now, let’s go and take some questions from the press.” He motions with his head, and I pick

up my phone and put it in my pocket.

“Let’s do this.” Walking out of the room, knowing that sooner rather than later I’ll be with my girl, and for once it won’t feel like I have the weight of the world on my shoulders.

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thirty-eight

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Victoria

“IT’S BEEN OVER AN HOUR,” LEXI NOTES, HOLDING HER WINE IN HER HAND and looking over to the door of the bar. “They are never this late.”

The knots in my stomach that were there the entire game are not gone, even after the big win. Something was happening and I couldn’t put my finger on it. I pick up my phone and turn it over to see if Zane texted me. My last text to him was right after the game. Actually, two texts, both three words.

ME:

Proud of you.

ME:

I love you.

Both of them said they were read, both of them still unanswered. “It shouldn’t be much longer,” Ariella reasons. “If it is, I’m going to have to go and one of you will have to drive him home.”

“I can drive him,” I offer her, “but I’m sure he’ll want to see you more than he wants to see me.” Ariella smiles at me. “I called him today to wish him luck,” I inform her. “He told me to never call his phone again with that message since I’ve never once in my life cared until I started dating his coach.” She laughs. “He hung up on me and then sent me a text to tell me to fuck off.”

“He didn’t mean it.” Ariella leans across the table and puts her hand on mine.

“I hope he did because I then told him to go fuck himself, and I was taking back the luck.”

“You know what that means now,” Kylie says, taking a sip of her water, “every single game you have to repeat that same thing.” The whole table nods their heads. “Knox and I had sex once before the game and they won, and he thought every single game thereafter I had to have sex with him before the game.”

“They travel.” I gasp.

“Yeah, he thought I would go with him. Sneak in his room.”

“I did that.” The girls stare at me with their eyes looking like they are going to pop out of their sockets. “It was in the beginning.”

“When?” Kylie asks me.

“It doesn’t matter. What does matter is I didn’t get caught. But Knox did show up at the door and I had to hide.” I laugh and then the laugh stops midway when the door opens and two guys walk in. The whole table holds our breath to see if it’s our guys and it’s not.

“This is getting to be ridiculous,” Lexi pouts. “It’s like doomsday and we are seeing who is returning home unscathed.”

“Okay, well, for one, no one died,” Ariella states, “so there is that to celebrate.”

The door opens and more players come in, all of them acknowledging us with a chin lift, and I’m so nervous that my leg is bouncing up and down. “I’m giving them five more minutes,” I mumble, “and then I’m going back.”

I pick up my phone and I’m about to call him when the door opens, Knox and Kirby come in first, both in their suits minus the ties. They look around the room, coming to us. Lexi and Kylie both get up to greet them. “They’re coming,” Knox says, his voice monotone.

I know something is wrong; I can feel it in my bones. I look over at Ariella, who gives me a smile, and I don't know if she's trying to comfort herself or me. The door opens and I'm on my feet before I can even think about it. Jaxon comes in first, looking around and then seeing me and Ariella. He nods at me then goes to Ariella. I don't even care, my feet make it to the door when Zane walks in. His head is down, and I feel like my heart is going to either come out of my chest or my throat. His eyes find mine and I can see so much turmoil in them, it's making it hard for me to breathe.

I don't stop until my arms are around his waist and my ear is to his chest, listening to his heart beating. "Hey, baby." He wraps his arms around me and the heat from his body should make me feel warm, but I'm shivering inside.

"Hi," I say, looking up at him. "Are you okay?"

"No," he replies, "but I'll explain later. Right now, I want to show my face so we can get the fuck out of here as soon as possible."

"But it's a celebration." I rub his back.

"I want to be celebrating another way." His voice is low, and I look over my shoulder.

"We should leave now then," I tease, and he laughs for the first time since he walked in. He lets go of me but his hand slides into mine as we head to the other side of the bar, saying hello to the guys who came in before. "Good game out there." He slaps them on the shoulder with his free hand, never once letting my hand go.

When we finally make it to Jaxon and the other boys, the door opens behind us, and I can tell by Jaxon's face he's shocked. "What the fuck," he swears, and I look over my shoulder at the guy in a suit coming in. He's followed by another guy I've met before, but I don't remember his name.

The first guy looks around the room, his scowl then turns to a smile when he takes it all in. His eyes find Zane's, and I can feel his body tense as

his hand squeezes mine a bit before the two men make it over to us. “Zane,” the guy says with a smile on his face, “I was hoping to catch you here.”

“Brad,” he says his name, “it’s a surprise to see you here tonight.”

“Thought it was fitting to come by and congratulate the guys on a well-fought win.” He looks at me. “You must be Victoria.” He holds out his hand and I have to let Zane’s hand go to shake his. “I’m Brad, the VP of Operations,” he mentions his name and his title.

“It’s nice to meet you, Brad.” He grips my hand to shake it.

“Victoria,” the guy beside him says, “I’m Ken. We met at the end of last season.”

“It’s nice to see you again.” I nod at him.

“Impressive game tonight,” Brad praises Zane. “I’ve been briefed on what went on, and I’m here to give you my full support.”

I slip my hand back into his and lean into his side. “Thank you.” He nods at Brad, who looks over his shoulder at the guys as he moves away from Zane.

“It’s going to be a busy day tomorrow,” Ken shares. “You should get out of here.”

“We were just leaving,” Zane says, looking at me and I nod my head.

I turn to grab my purse and my phone, giving them all a little finger wave as we walk out of the bar into the coolish night. “That was intense,” I say to him as he picks up our joined hands and kisses my fingers.

“Well, considering I quit after the game, I guess so.” I stop in my tracks and gasp.

“You what?” His hand slips out of mine and he stops mid-step. “You quit?”

“Yeah,” he confirms, looking at me and then coming back to stand in front of me. “It was either me or Cam.”

“What the fuck happened?”

“What happened is, I found out why we’ve been fucking up so much on the ice,” he explains, telling me everything that happened with Cam. “The guys stepped up and confirmed everything I was saying. He was then terminated from his position.”

“That rat bastard,” I hiss out.

“You know what this means, right?” he asks me, pushing the hair that is flying around my face back, as he cups my cheek. “The next couple weeks and months are going to be crazy.” I hold onto his jacket. “I’m going to be either tied to my desk or my head will be in an iPad.”

“Okay,” I reply, not sure where he is going with this.

“So, I promise when all this is over and done with, I’ve got a vacation for just the two of us planned. Sun, sand, and no interruptions.” He kisses my lips.

“Are you going to come home to me every night that you are in town and sleep by my side?” I ask him.

“Try to stop me.” He puts his forehead on mine.

“Then I’ll be by your side every step of the way, cheering you on or listening to you rant.” My hands go from his sides to his chest. “Through all of that, you never mentioned sex,” I point out and he smiles big. “Is sex in any of that? If it’s not, I think tonight is going to be a very long night if I’m going to have to store it up.”

“Then I suggest we get home.” He kisses my lips softly, turning and gripping my hand as he moves toward his SUV. I have to jog to keep up with his big strides, the sound of my laughter filling the night. The night ends with us celebrating the big win just the two of us.

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thirty-nine

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Zane

Four months later

A BEEP SOUNDS ON MY PHONE, TELLING ME I HAVE FIFTEEN MINUTES BEFORE I have to head down to the bus.

“On a scale of one to ten,” Victoria says, sitting in the middle of the hotel bed while wrapped in the hotel robe, her legs crossed in front of her, “how nervous are you for today?”

I grab the jacket from the hanger, looking over at her. “A million,” I reply as I shrug the jacket on, pulling down the sleeves as she rolls her eyes at me.

“It’s not that big of a deal.” She tries to make light of the situation. “Just game seven for the Stanley Cup.” I glare at her, my stomach getting tight.

“This time tomorrow, this will all be over.” She gets on her knees and comes to the edge of the bed as I walk toward her. “And no matter what, I will still love you.” She takes my tie and plays with it in between her fingers. “I mean, I might love you a bit more with the win, but I’ll still love you.”

I can’t help but chuckle at her saying that. “Thank you, I guess. You know the bus is going to be here in an hour and a half to get you guys to take you over to the arena.”

“I know,” she replies. “Your parents and sister are going to be here fifteen minutes before and if they are not I’ll go and get them.” I smile seeing how happy he was that his family took the trip down for him. “And I’ve already gotten five texts from my father and then my uncle Nico, who just landed, by the way.”

“He’s coming to the game?” I ask, shocked.

“You think he’s going to miss Jaxon winning the Cup?” she questions, and I gasp.

“We don’t say those words out loud,” I remind her through clenched teeth. “It’s bad luck.”

My phone beeps again at the same time I hear the players’ doors being opened and then closed, and knocks up and down the hallway. “You go,” she urges, getting up off the bed to stand in front of me. “I’m proud of you,” she whispers softly. “The fact that you guys made it this far is incredible. It’s just one more game.” Her voice is soft and even though I know she’s trying to make me feel better, I know she’s lying. This means fucking everything.

“I love you.” I kiss her nose before kissing her lips. “See you later.”

“You bet your ass, Coach Gilmore.” She smiles up at me big, and I know that no matter what, having her to come home to is a win for me.

I nod at her, turning to walk out of the room and hit Jaxon, who is walking with a bottle of water in one hand and a cup of coffee in the other. “Really?”

“This has been my thing since we started the playoffs.” He holds up both. “It helped us beat Vegas in six, and then St. Louis in five.” He presses the button for the elevator. “Now here we are in Florida, and it’s game seven. I’m not going to fuck things up now by not doing it.”

“Let’s not tempt fate,” I mumble to him. “Maybe you should have ditched it when we went down three to one.” He rolls his eyes as the elevator gets there.

We get in and head down to the bus. A crowd of people are outside waiting for us to leave as I go straight for the bus and Jaxon holds up a hand waving to the crowd then following me on the bus. I sit down and wait for the rest of the team to join us. We're usually the first on the bus and even if we aren't, no one gets on the bus before us.

No one would have thought we would be here. Everyone had Florida winning in five, but in game five we tied the game in the last minute of play. Then we got lucky when we flew back home for the next game and in overtime, there was a turnover in their zone and Kirby scored the game-winning goal. Then we flew back to Florida and now here we are, game fucking seven.

"You nervous?" I look over at Jaxon, who glares at me and puts his AirPods in. "That would be a no, I'm assuming." I chuckle as I look out and see Kirby and Knox both walking out of the lobby and onto the bus.

"If we lose tonight," Knox says, "I'm not talking to any of you motherfuckers until next season."

I chuckle as the bus fills up and we head over to the arena. Fans are already pregaming as they line up outside. There are games and music blasting through the parking lot and the sea of red jerseys fills the entrance, with a couple of the white and purple ones that we will be wearing tonight.

The bus pulls up in the underground parking, and you can hear the camera shutters going off as we get ready to walk inside and pass the press waiting to snap our pictures. "I'm also going to look forward to shaving," Kirby gripes, scratching his neck. "I don't know how Coach does it all year-round."

"He looks like a mountain lumberjack," Jaxon jokes, making me laugh. I followed the guys and stopped trimming my beard when the playoffs started and even though it was long before, it's becoming too much. I can't wait to trim this fucker.

The walk down the hallway, everyone is quiet and in their own thoughts. Even before the game, it's the quietest they've ever been. "There really isn't much left to say," I tell the room before we take the ice. "I've used up all my speeches in the last games." That earns me a chuckle. "Go out there and do what you guys do best." I smirk. "Hopefully, it's win and not a loss."

I look over at Eric, who shakes his head. "Nice speech," he deadpans when we walk out after the guys. We get out there and I look up to the suite, just like I have done each game. I see Victoria right away. Our eyes meet, and she gives me the smile I've grown to search for in every room. Right next to her stands her father, wearing Jaxon's jersey. Ariella is on the other side of her with Jagger on her hip as she points to the bench. The team has flown everyone's family down and rented out five suites to make sure we are all here. The lights go down as they play the pregame video. I look up, watching the Jumbotron as they show how Florida got here and the last three games we won, and I can't help but smile.

The anthem is sung and the crowd is deafening as the puck drops. After we win the face off, I swear I hold my breath every single time the puck is in our zone. When Kirby intercepts the pass and starts to skate up the ice with Jaxon, he passes the puck to Knox, who skates it into the zone and then shoots it on the net, but it's deflected as the defenseman grabs the puck and tries to clear the puck out of their zone. Except Jaxon intercepts it and he winds his arm back and aims at the net and it goes in. The horn blares behind the net and our bench gets on their feet. The rest of the crowd puts their heads back as Jaxon skates over to the bench, giving everyone a high-five as they replay it on the Jumbotron.

It doesn't take them much to get even with us, the puck bouncing over Sammy's pad. The crowds roars out and we feel the floor move under our feet. "Even score, guys. We aren't out of it yet," I snap.

We start the second period and when Knox gets a shot at the goal, we are all watching as their goalie saves it. Five minutes later, he gets the puck again, skating it into the zone and around the defensemen, snapping it back and it flies into the net. The bench erupts as he's congratulated on the ice. We end the second period leading by one.

The guys get on the ice at the start of the third period, and Florida is out for blood. They push hard and it pays off for them when they score two minutes into the third period. For the rest of the period, it's back and forth, each of us having a chance but being shut out. "Figures," I say right before we get on the ice for overtime, "that you guys would not only force a game seven, but you would take it into overtime." I shake my head. "I don't know about you guys, but I'd really like to shut this team up and tell everyone who doubted us to go fuck themselves."

We get back out there and I look up, seeing Victoria hasn't moved once since the game started. With her all-black outfit and custom jacket with my name in purple on the back, one hand is across her stomach, the other is folded up and covering her mouth.

Everyone is on their feet, not one person is sitting down as the puck drops. Two minutes into overtime, the puck flies over Jaxon's stick and they get a breakaway of sorts. I close my eyes, not willing to watch, and when I don't hear the crowd go crazy, I open them and see Sammy getting up, tossing the puck in his glove. I sigh, the lump in my throat getting bigger. I watch the replay on the Jumbotron.

The face-off starts off in our zone which immediately leads to a shot on the net, where Sammy blocks it with his blocker. One of the Florida players tries to catch it midair, but it falls in front of Knox, who takes it and starts to move out of the zone, Owen and Aaron skating up with him. It's three on two by the time they enter the zone. I get up on the bench to see the play. Knox passes it to Owen, who skates it in and passes it to Aaron, who shoots

it on the net but it's blocked. However, Knox is right there in front, waiting for the rebound and he puts it in.

I don't even hear the horn going off, all I see is Knox and Aaron jumping in the air. Helmets, gloves, everything flies. The bench is cleared off and all I can do is put my hands on top of my head. "We fucking did it." I look up to the suite, seeing Victoria with tears in her eyes as she holds her hands in the air, yelling.

Our eyes meet for just a second as she points to me, and I point back at her. Everything feels like it's going around in a circle, and I'm just standing in the eye of the hurricane.

Ken is beside me going nuts, giving me a hug as he's handed a baseball hat that says "Stanley Cup Champions." "I knew you could do it!" he cheers and I laugh.

"No, you didn't." I laugh as I'm handed my own hat.

"No, I didn't," he concedes as I look over and see the carpet coming out.

I finally get on the ice as I walk to the team and Jaxon spots me. "Guess you think you're big shit now that you got a Stanley Cup."

"Knew I was big shit the minute your sister gave me the time of day." I wink at him, and he pushes my shoulder as we line up to shake hands with the other team. When I get to the coach, he smirks at me.

"Good fucking game," he says. "Look forward to getting it back next year."

"Who knows; we might go back-to-back." I slap him on the shoulder as I see the players with their families now. Jaxon is hugging Ariella, who is smiling and crying at the same time. Lexi holds Kirby around the waist, looking up at him. Knox is with his kids and Kylie. My eyes roam for Victoria and I see her standing there behind the bench. My father and mother beside her both with tears in their eyes. My sister with her hip

cocked to the side trying to show she isn't happy but you can see the twinkle in her eye.

I walk over to her, our eyes on each other as she steps toward the bench and leans over to hug me. "I'm so proud." She barely gets it out before the sob joins her words. "More proud now that you won." She holds my face in her hands.

"Good to know." I kiss her lips. "Good to know."

I walk over to my father who slaps my chest and then hugs me and then to my mother who beams, "you were so good doing your thing." She puts her hand to my face.

I see my sister, "I mean it wasn't you who scored the goal but I guess congratulations." I throw my head back and laugh at her. Moving back over to Victoria kissing her lips.

Manning comes over and shakes my hand. "Well done, Coach," he praises.

"Thank you." I shake his hand as he moves to Jaxon, the two of them hugging it out.

"So what are you going to do now that you won?" Victoria asks me.

"Try to get you to agree to marry me." I wink at her, and she laughs.

"Just because you get one ring, you think I'm just going to agree to yours?" she jokes as I walk to the side and make my way behind the bench, reaching inside my jacket pocket.

"Wasn't sure I would be able to give you this tonight," I tell her, getting down on one knee. "Definitely wasn't going to do it if we lost." She laughs as she puts her hands over her mouth. "Today is the second-best day of my life, after the day I met you, but," I look over her head to see everyone watching us, "want to make it take the number one spot?"

"So needy," she teases, and I get up, grabbing her around the waist and kissing her. "I love you," she declares.

I kiss her once more. "Spend the rest of my life telling me that."

“I guess so,” she says, making me laugh, and here in the middle of the biggest night of my life, she gets a ring before I do.

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epilogue one

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Victoria

Three months later

THE PHONE RINGS BY MY DESK AND I LEAN BACK IN MY CHAIR, SEEING IT'S Seth calling me. "Hello." It's been a while since our project at the church, so I'm surprised to be hearing from him.

"Hey, Tori," he says my name, "it's Seth."

"Hey, Seth." I look over to the two offices, hearing clicking coming from Kylie as she types on her keyboard. "What's up?"

"I was wondering if you are at your office." His tone is tight, and he has never asked this before.

"I am." I sit up now. "Is everything okay?" I ask him.

"Not sure," he replies, "but I can be at your office in about five minutes."

"I'll be here." I disconnect the phone, putting it down and getting up to walk over to Lexi's office. "Seth just called; he's going to be here in five." She looks over at me and her eyebrows pinch together. "Yeah, that was my reaction too."

"Is this a meeting and I didn't know?" Kylie asks when she sticks her head out of her office and walks into Lexi's.

“Seth is coming here,” I inform Kylie, who gives me the same look that Lexi gave me.

The door to the office opens and I turn to walk out, followed by the two of them. I stop dead in my tracks when I see Seth, who is standing beside a woman we’ve met at the church during our first visit, holding a child on her hip that is about as old as Jagger and also holding the hand of a little girl. “Hey,” I say, smiling, trying not to give off anything, “this is a nice surprise.”

“Hi,” Seth returns. “Good, you are all here.” He looks at Lexi and Kylie behind me. “This saves me a phone call.”

“Please sit,” Lexi speaks up and points to the couch beside my desk. “Can I get you guys anything to drink?” She looks at the woman. “Water, juice, coffee?”

“No.” The woman’s voice is soft.

Seth puts his arm on her lower back and ushers her to the couch. “Thank you for seeing me on such short notice.”

“Of course,” I reply, sitting on the couch, facing the woman who is softly shaking, and I have to wonder if she even realizes she’s shaking. She moves the baby on her lap and she sits with her legs over hers while she puts the little girl to sit between her and Seth.

“I don’t know if you remember.” He smiles at us. “This is Kennedy,” Seth introduces the woman. “This is Serafina and this is baby JJ. She has been helping out in the kitchen at the church the last couple of months.”

“It’s nice to see you again,” Kylie says, sitting on the armrest of the couch I’m sitting on. “What can we do to help?”

“Kennedy is best friends with my sister,” Seth starts to say, “and she just let us know about some things that are happening at home.”

“Which is?” Lexi asks softly.

“My husband,” she starts to say and then her voice trembles so she stops, and I can feel my stomach drop. “He’s...” She shakes her head. “No

one is going to believe me.” She looks at her daughter, who looks up at her. “He’s...” Her lower lip quivers. “He’s not right with me.” She doesn’t need to spell it out, you can see the fear all over her body.

“How about I take the kids out of the room?” Seth says, holding out his hand for Seraphina and then grabbing JJ.

We all wait for him to walk into the other room when Lexi starts, “What about with the children?” She shakes her head no.

“It’s just me,” she shares, “but I’m afraid as time goes on, it’ll be—”

“That he’ll turn on your children,” Lexi fills in her thought and she nods her head.

“I’m ready to leave him but—” She looks at all of us. “I have nothing. He has control of everything.” I swallow the lump. “And he’s got a good job.”

“Of course he does,” Kylie says and looks at Lexi.

“He’s going to fight me for custody.” The fear is written all over her face, the bottom of her eyes filling with tears as she fights them back.

“Do you have anything documented?” Lexi is asking all the questions as I just sit here feeling helpless.

“I do,” she confirms. “I have medical records that support my claim.” Seth comes back in the room and stands by the door so he can watch the kids.

“I also have—” She looks at her hands trying to decide if she’s going to tell us what she needs to tell us, “I have hours and hours of recordings. Some while he was beating me.”

My hand goes to grip Kylie’s leg, and she puts her hand on top of mine. “I’m afraid he’s going to hurt me and then my babies will have no one.”

“We thought you would be able to help. Give her somewhere to go and help us make plans for the future,” Seth declares.

“We have a safe house,” Lexi says, and I look up at her, knowing we do not have a safe house, “but it’s in the process of being renovated.” She

looks at Kennedy. “We can talk to our in-house counsel,” I look up at her, “and we can put you up in a hotel until then.”

She pulls out her phone. “We can have you talk to her privately, if you like.” Kennedy nods her head.

“I’ll call her now,” Lexi says as she walks into her office. Serafina runs back into the room with panic on her face looking for her mother. Who bends to take her in her arms.

“Have you guys eaten today?” Kylie asks and Kennedy looks at her daughter.

“This morning we had breakfast and then when he left, we left.”

“Where does he think you are now?” Kylie asks her.

“A playgroup,” she whispers, “at the church.”

Lexi comes out of her office. “Riley is on the phone,” she says of her cousin, who practices family law. “She can speak with you.”

Kennedy gets up and puts JJ on her hip and then holds out her hand for Serafina. “Thank you.” She looks at Seth. “Will you come with me?” He gets up and walks with her into Lexi’s office and they shut the door.

“Okay, what the fuck are you doing?” I look over at Lexi. “Where is this safe house we have?”

“One that we are going to buy as soon as she leaves,” she confides, and Kylie nods her head. “We are going to put her up in a hotel until we close.”

“I don’t know about this,” I say honestly. “I think we need to plan more. There has to be steps taken to make sure that it’s all handled without any backlash on all sides.”

“You see that fear in her eyes?” Lexi says in a whisper. “I had that fear but hers is down to her bones. I was lucky, I had a family who had my back. I had myself to worry about; she has two children. I can’t even imagine.”

“We will help in any way,” Kylie states, “but I have to agree with Tori. This has to be done—”

Lexi cuts her off. “So we just send her back to him? Send them back to him?”

Neither of us know what to say and when Kennedy comes out of the office, we make plans to speak to her in a couple of days. She agrees that we have things set up before she leaves him.

I get up out of my chair as Lexi and Kylie go to her office and they call the realtor. I pick up my phone, calling the one person I know who can make everything better. “Hey,” Zane says, answering the phone after one ring, “how did you know this was perfect timing?”

“I have you chipped,” I joke with him and smile when he bursts out laughing. “It’s like an AirTag, just had the doctor insert it into you at your last physical.” I quip. “Where are you?”

“At the office. Why?”

“I,” I look toward the door, “I just had a really bad meeting and I—”

“I can be there in fifteen or I can be home in twenty,” he offers, and I hear him moving on his side of the phone. “Where do you want to meet?” He doesn’t even give me a chance to speak. “I’ll pick you up in fifteen. Don’t drive.”

He disconnects the phone, not giving me a chance to say anything. My eyes fixate on the screen of the computer as I replay the meeting over and over in my head. I get up and walk over to Lexi’s office. “I’m going to head out.”

“That was a lot for you,” Lexi says, leaning back in her chair. “Are you going to be okay?”

“That was the most insane thing, I think, that has ever happened in my life. I’ve been pretty lucky to be sheltered from things like this,” I state honestly. “I come from a family has protected me and cared for me in ways not many people get. I don’t think I know anyone who has been in that situation.”

“That’s the scary part,” Kylie says, “you probably do, but they hide it so well you have no idea.”

“That is what has me so thrown. We met her while we were renovating the playground, and we had no idea.” I look down. “How many other people are in dire need and haven’t gotten help?”

“You can only help the people who ask for it,” Lexi comforts softly as the door to the office opens. I look over to see Zane, his eyes going wild as he looks at my desk and then finds me. His chest is heaving as if he ran here from the rink.

“Are you okay?” I ask him as he walks to me.

“Took the stairs, the elevator was taking too long,” he explains.

“Aww,” I hear Lexi from behind me, “he sounds like he would run into a burning building.”

“Obviously, he’s not going to get any better than me.”

“Tell me you love yourself without telling me you love yourself.” Kylie laughs. “I’ll go first.”

“You okay?” I feel his hands on my hips and look up to see the front of his hair fall onto his forehead.

“I am now.” I wrap my arms around him. “Will you take me home?”

“Which home?” Lexi asks, knowing she’s going to be starting something. It’s been three months since he’s proposed to me. Three months that I have been dragging my feet to move in with him. Why? I have no idea. I think it’s just my way of not giving into him. Even though I haven’t slept in that house in over four months.

“Our home,” Zane says, “the one where all her stuff is at.”

“Not all my stuff.” I roll my eyes. “I do have a couple of things still left at the other house.”

“Mail doesn’t count,” Kylie teases, laughing. “Just give in already. I did and look at me now,” she says, putting her hand on her belly where her little baby bump is barely visible.

“We should be going.” I slide my hand into Zane’s. “I need a bottle of wine and a bath.”

We walk out of the office and I don’t even think about my car, knowing I’ll come and get it tomorrow. We walk into the house, and I head straight for the stairs. “Want to talk about it?” Zane asks me when I start the bath.

“I love you,” I tell him, “like with my whole heart.” He leans against the bathroom door. “And I want to have children with you.”

“That’s good to know.” He gives me one of his smirks that makes my heart flutter.

“I also want you to know how lucky you are to have me.” I give him my own smirk.

“You don’t have to remind me,” he replies as I pull my shirt off me and toss it to the side.

“After walking out on me all those times.” I point at him and his eyebrows shoot up.

“You walked away from me each time,” he reminds me like he always does.

“Yeah, but you never chased me, so technically you made me walk away.” I pull off my pants. “But anyway, today I sat there and listened to someone tell their story and the only thing I could think of was that I was so lucky I had you to come home to.”

“For the rest of your life.” He pulls his shirt off and I see the new ink he added to his chest. It’s the words “I Love You” written in my handwriting, with the date we got engaged under it, the same day he won the Cup.

“We should make it official,” I tell him, getting naked and then slipping into the bath. “Like I should officially move in with you.”

“Baby,” he says, getting into the tub with me, something he doesn’t do often but he’s done a few times, “you already officially live with me.” He reaches out and grabs me so I can straddle him as he wraps his arms around me. “You are in our bed every night,” he reminds me. “Your clothes hang in

our closet.” I turn my head to lay it on his shoulder. “I don’t care where your mail is delivered,” I laugh, “but it would be nice to have it here.”

“Fine,” I sigh, “I’ll move in with you.”

An hour later, I’m on the phone with my father. “I’m calling to give you news,” I tell him as I pluck a chip from the bag Zane is eating.

“If you are calling me to tell me you are pregnant,” he hisses, “I’m going to be pissed.” I can’t help but laugh.

“No,” I say, sighing deeply, “but I’m moving in with Zane.”

He barks out in laughter. “Good. I’m going to need his address to send your things to.”

I gasp, “Wow, tell me I’m not your favorite without telling me I’m not your favorite. You are just tossing me out of my own home.”

“You live in California,” he reminds me, “this house is in Dallas. It’s safe to say you moved out.”

“Well, it’s good to know I can never come back.”

I see Zane roll his eyes. “Dramatic much?”

“Well, I just changed my mind. I’m not moving in with Zane after all.” I look at Zane, who picks up his can of beer and takes a pull. “I have to go now.”

I hang up on him and toss my phone to the side. “You are lucky I love you, Zane, and I know how good the sex is, or else you would not be worth it.”

“You better hurry up and choose a date before I choose one for us,” is all he says.

“So needy.” I try to hide my smile by biting down on my lip.

“Damn fucking straight,” he retorts and that night when I slip into bed, he takes me in his arms, and I fall asleep with his heartbeat under my ear.

The next morning, I kiss him goodbye as he drops me off at the office before going to the rink. The tray of coffee is in one hand and the box of cinnamon rolls is in the other. I juggle them both when I push open the door

and see Lexi and Kylie there sitting down. They look like something drastic just happened. “Who died?” I ask jokingly.

“Kennedy shot her husband last night,” Kylie says, and the coffee slips out of my hands. “He didn’t make it.”

Want more Zane & Victoria? Click [here](#) for a bonus epilogue!

Kennedy

They say the devil has three faces. To me, he only has one.

Until that night.

It was me or him. I chose me.

But only because of them.

Now I’m a single mom picking up the pieces.

I don’t have time for anything else.

But fate had other plans for me.

Phoenix

I was living under the shadow of my family name.

My father owned the Dallas Oilers.

It was a given I would only play for Dallas.

Except I didn’t want to play with the cloud that I was only on the team
because of my father.

Until I asked to be traded.

I needed to make it on my own.

Now I was in a new town.

We met by accident.

We became friends.

Then I wanted her to be more.

I wanted them to be mine.

Pre-Order Only For Them [Here](#) releasing March 23, 2027!

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acknowledgments

To **my Husband and Kids:** Thank you for loving me through the ups and the downs. Through takeout meals and then repetitive menu's when I'm in a rush. I'm so proud to be part of your world.

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about the author



When Wall Street Journal and USA Today Bestselling author Natasha Madison's nose isn't buried in a book, or her fingers flying across a keyboard writing, she's in the kitchen creating gourmet meals. You can find her, in four-inch heels no less, in the car chauffeuring kids, or possibly with her husband scheduling his business trips. It's a good thing her characters do what she says because even her Labrador doesn't listen to her...



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